

KINGDOM OF
DESTINY :
SOLOMON'S
HERITAGE

M.V. BALDUR

THE SECOND EDITION

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M. V. BALDUR

THANK YOU!

I owe a debt of gratitude to my first editor, my friend, my brother, who read over and over again for three years without getting tired of it in the process of writing my novel, and who honestly criticized it.

Without your support, this book would always be incomplete, wouldn't be in its best shape. Thank you for always being there for me always.

M. V. BALDUR

CHAPTER ZERO

Rehoboam was galloping his horse swiftly through the streets of the kingdom. When he arrived at the palace's garden, he dismounted his horse and one of the nearest guards took hold of the reins, leading the prince's horse to the stable while the others opened the door for Rehoboam. This time, Rehoboam was dashing through the corridors of the palace.

“Father!” he exclaimed anxiously as he entered the throne room. “A portion of the army... They have rebelled believing that you are the one who has kept all the magical power to yourself! What should I do? Shall I have them killed before the rebellion grows even stronger?”

Elder Solomon, watching outside through the window, turned to his son. He brought his hand to his beard and began stroking it. “Dark magic has had a worse effect than I anticipated. Their desires may seem simple, but their demands will be endless. No matter how much power they possess, they will always crave more! However, we still haven't been able to cleanse the other realm. That's

why, even with a slight chance, they might regain their senses. We will give them some time. Gather the people in the palace garden. Ensure their safety. And I want a wall from the soldiers. Let our loyal ones protect our people.”

“As you command,” Rehoboam said, then swiftly exited the throne room. Solomon took a deep breath and made his way towards his throne

CHAPTER ONE

The sunlight slowly entered through the window, illuminating the house. The woman with her brown hair scattered all over the pillow opened her eyes. She sat up slowly and got out of bed. She opened the partially drawn curtains all the way and looked outside. The man mowing the grass behind the fence saw the woman looking out the window. He furrowed his brows and cursed at her. With a sigh, the woman closed the curtains. She quickly changed her pajamas to sportswear and tied her hair back. She left her room and hurriedly descended the stairs. Then she went out through the door on the lower floor.

After closing the door of her house, she picked up the package lying on the ground at the height of the doorbell and descended the two steps of the veranda. She emptied the contents of the package roughly in front of the small shed in front of the fence. She bent down and looked inside the shed. It was empty. She folded the top of the package and placed it next to the shed. then jogged slowly towards the sidewalk and crossed to the other side, continuing her path through the trail in the forest.

Apart from the sound of the dried leaves crushed under her feet, there was no other sound. Green trees stretched from both sides as if trying to cover the blue sky. After running for a while, she looked at her watch. It was approaching eight o'clock. She changed her direction and plunged into the midst of the trees.

Suddenly, she heard a rustling sound and looked toward the source of the sound. The sound came from behind the bushes. She advanced towards the bushes with heavy steps, bringing her right hand to the level of her waist. Breathing rapidly, she leaped behind the bushes and pointed the knife in her hand. But there was nothing there. She slowly put the knife back in its sheath and wiped the sweat off her forehead with her other hand. She turned back in the direction she came from and resumed running at the same pace.

As she approached her house, she heard shouts and accelerated her pace because she recognized the voice.

“You damn dog! Stay away from my garden!”

The woman went to the man who was shouting at the black dog in front of her house.

“Is there a problem, Mr. Sapkon?” the woman asked and caressed her dog's head.

“A problem? The same problem I've been dealing with for the past six months! Your dog, Mss. Anton, is ruining my garden!”

Ms. Anton leaned forward and looked at Sapkon's garden.

“I don't see any problem.”

“But if I hadn't intervened, it would have trampled everything!”

“I really don't have time for this. Come, my dear, let's go home,” Mss. Anton said as she stroked her dog's head and stood up, walking towards the door of her house. Halfway there, the dog left its

owner to eat and dashed towards its bowl. The woman picked up the newspaper in front of the door and entered her house.

After placing the newspaper on the countertop, she retrieved the vegetables from the refrigerator and placed them inside the blender. While the machine whirled, transforming the contents into a smooth puree, her attention was caught by a newspaper article with a striking black headline. With one hand operating the blender, she picked up the newspaper and unfolded it. The headline "MR. DORSON ELECTED MAYOR" prominently adorned the front page.

Pouring the vegetable juice into a glass, she made her way to the sitting room. She went directly to the shelf, walking between the sofas. Her hand ran through the books and chose one. With her breakfast in hand, she settled onto the couch, engrossed in her reading while occasionally taking sips of her drink.

Just as she finished her last sip, the doorbell rang. The doorbell rang again which made Mss. Anton sigh. She placed her book facedown on the couch and headed towards the door.

As she opened the door, the ringing ceased, revealing a plump man with thinning hair standing before her. He held files tightly under one arm and carried a white box in his other hand.

"Why are you here?" she inquired.

"Aren't you going to let your father in, Rose?" the plump man replied, Rose stepped back and gestured inside.

The man took a seat on the first chair at the table behind the couch in the living room. He placed the file on the table and handed it to Rose.

"As always, you're here for duty," Rose remarked, attempting to hide her nerves, as she accepted the file. Meanwhile, her father opened the box.

“This morning, Martin Hugo was found dead a few kilometers from your house. Jason retrieved the footage from the crime scene after the forensic report,” the man stated, retrieving a pink sugar-coated donut from the box and patiently waiting for Rose to find the pictures. Once she had them in her hand, he took a bite of the donut and continued, “He had over ten visible cut marks on his body. The killer made his face unrecognizable. According to Jason, there have been a few similar deaths recently. All the victims were in their forties to fifties. We seem to have a creature that preys on the elderly. Interestingly, some individuals have gone missing in the same forest.” Another bite of the donut. “What do you think?”

“Jason may be right. After all, it's his area of expertise. It should be reliable, shouldn't it?”

“No. You're the expert, not Jason.”

“The distinct scars were clearly inflicted to drain the victims' blood. Some tribes sacrifice not only souls but also blood,” Rose remarked, glancing at her father, who had just taken the last piece of the donut. His gaze lingered on the box, which he then turned towards Rose.

“Would you like some?”

“You never listen, do you? You know what, forget it. I'll take care of the investigation as soon as possible.”

“That's my girl! It was pleasant chatting with you, but I have important matters to attend to at the library.”

“Then I won't keep you any longer. Send someone for the body tomorrow,” Rose said, as her father rose from the chair and made his way towards the door. Once Rose closed the door behind him, she let out a sigh. She ascended the staircase at the corridor's end and reached the upper floor. Adorning herself in sleek black trousers and a deep crimson shirt, she proceeded to the house's garage. A motorcycle adorned with a bright metallic finish stood prominently in the center of the garage.

Rose picked up her black leather jacket hanging on a hook near the garage entrance. After getting on her motorcycle, she put on her jacket and zipped it up to her collar. She secured her helmet on the handlebars and used the remote control from her jacket pocket to open the garage door. As the door slid open, she straightened her jacket with a quick movement. With determination, she maneuvered her motorcycle out of the garage and into the outside world.

Traffic was busy. For some reason, everyone was trying to speed east of the city, but the cars were moving slowly. Rose had no such problem. The speedometer was steadily increasing and the engine was passing between cars in sharp movements.

Gradually, the motorcycle's rumble faded until it finally fell silent. Rose parked her bike and got down on the sidewalk. When she looked up, there was a three or four-story building. On the bottom floor was a café. Rose entered the café.

As the door swung open, a bell chimed overhead, drawing the attention of an elderly woman who had gathered her silver hair into a neat bun behind the counter. She glanced towards the entrance, spotting Rose, and warmly extended her arms.

"Darling, welcome!" she exclaimed, embracing Rose affectionately.

"Hello, mom," Rose replied, reciprocating the embrace.

"Would you like something to drink?"

"Actually, I need your help."

"Is that so? Then come with me," Rose's mother responded, unlocking the door labeled "staff only." She led her daughter inside, gently guiding her through.

Once inside, Rose's mother locked the door and turned to look at the stack of boxes behind her. They were blanketed in dust,

veiled by intricate spider webs. Rose handed her mother the file, and Mrs. Anton gingerly opened it, inspecting its contents.

"I assume we have a Barghest problem. Isn't it?" Rose remarked.

"Darling, without a doubt, this is a Barghest. Just examine these claw imprints. However, I haven't heard anything about the age range. Maybe it's something about the guy being cursed."

"I was thinking the same."

"In that case, why did you come here?"

"Because I have nothing that can kill the creature entirely. But I am sure that you do."

Rose's mother pulled one of the closed boxes from the warehouse in front of her. She opened it, and dust flew and spread everywhere. She rummaged inside. The sound of metal clashing against each other came from inside the box. Then her mother moved on to the second dusty box. When she couldn't find what she was looking for in that one either, she opened the third one and rummaged through it. After a short while, she turned to Rosa with a satisfied voice. She was holding a gold chain with a globe on the end, surrounded by various shapes and symbols.

"It has been years since I've used this stuff. But you are lucky. I found one."

"It's only enough for two or three bullets but still thank you, Mom." Rose said as she smiled and picked up the orb with the chain, unfastened the chain, and put it around her neck.

"Don't use the potion for bullets, honey, unless you're good at aiming. Do you know where to find the Barghest?"

"They were found dead in the woods near my house. So Barghest's lair is probably there somewhere. According to Jason, there's an old

house. A house that was abandoned a few years ago. It's the perfect place for the Barghest we're looking for."

"Who are you going on the mission with?"

"I will go alone."

"Alone? Have you lost your mind, Rose? In the past, you had Nathaniel as your partner, someone to watch your back, but now..." She seemed worried after she heard the word. Looking her daughter's face with the eyes which are filled with fear.

"Don't worry mom. The creature will be surprised." Said Rose to make her mother relax a little bit. But of course, wasn't enough.

Rose got off her bike, took off her helmet, and entered the house. She threw her jacket on the couch, hurried upstairs, and went to her room. She opened the large wardrobe opposite the bed and shoved the clothes on the hangers to one side. A dark green bag appeared among the clinging clothes. Rose took the bag and put it on her bed. unzipped the zipper. At the top, there was a short sword in its sheath. She picked it up and unsheathed it. twirled it around and inspected the sword. She ran her fingers over the silver rose engraving under the hilt and put it back in its scabbard and tossed it next to the bag. After briefly glancing at the weapons, she picked up a silver pistol and attached it to the waistband of her trousers. Rose closed the zipper back and put the bag back. That was enough for her. She distributed the clothes on the coat rack.

Holding the sword in its scabbard, she went downstairs, adjusted her belt, and slung it over her shoulder. She went outside and got on her motorcycle parked in front of the door. Just as she was about to put on her helmet, she saw her black dog running out of her neighbor's yard into her own. Right after that, she saw Mr. Sapkon chasing her dog, cursing at it.

"Ms. Rose, I can't take it anymore! Your dog..."

"How old are you, Mr. Sapkon?" Rose inquired, raising an eyebrow quizzically. She didn't care what did her dog did to the yard.

Mr. Sapkon raised his eyebrows, trying to understand the reason. "I...me? Forty-seven. Why do you ask?" Mr. Sapkon didn't notice the fist coming at his face. Even if he did, he didn't seem to be able to do anything about it.

Rose quickly drove her motorcycle deeper into the forest. She was traveling fast along an open path. Straight ahead, old Sapkon, his hands and arms bound, was slowly waking up. By the time Rose stopped her motorcycle, he was already awake. She lowered him down, grabbed the rope and pulled him along. They started to move through the trees on the narrowing road. Mr. Sapkon was trying to say something, but the piece of cloth stuffed in his mouth prevented him from being understood.

It was a few hours before dark. Rose kept noticing that time was running out. She pinned Mr. Sapkon's back against the tree and tied him to it with the thick rope she had taken from the box on the back of her bike. When she was sure it was tight, she removed the piece of cloth from the teary-eyed man's mouth. And as soon as she removed it, he asked, "Why... Why are you doing this?" asked Mr. Sapkon. This time he could not hold back his tears.

"There are things I cannot tell you. I apologize. See you soon." Rose took the piece of paper out of her jacket pocket and started walking. As she walked, she unfolded it. Suddenly, she heard Mr. Sapkon screaming for help.

After a while the screaming stopped. Rose knew the creature had taken Sapkon. She had to find the house before the creature did. She quickened her steps. And fast steps turned into running. She tried to go as fast as she could. She ran through the trees, jumping to avoid tripping over the roots of the trees sticking out of the ground.

She was out of breath. She put her hands on her knees and saw the sky turning red. She straightened her back. When she looked across, she could see the wooden structure, albeit in patches, between large tree trunks. She took a deep breath and started running towards the trees.

She was standing in front of an old house with broken windows and a broken door with pieces of wood falling from the walls. To her right was a well with a few pieces knocked over. On the other side, a swing made of creaking chain and wood swung slowly. And from inside came a momentary scream. It was gone as quickly as it had come. Rose started walking towards the door of the house. She gripped the gun at her waist and brought it close to her face. With her other hand she held the gold chain around her neck and lifted the glass orb. The transparent orb changed color as Rose took a step, as if blood was dripping into it.

She left the orb dangling around her neck and pushed the door with her hand. The door creaked open louder than a swing and the hinges broke. Rose cursed silently as the door crashed to the floor with a loud thud and shattered into several pieces. It was worse inside than it looked from the outside. Spiders had invaded and crawled all over the rotten wood. There was a stench of carrion inside that didn't come out. It seemed to envelop the whole house. It was a disgusting smell. Rose entered the house, taking careful steps with her gun.

She pointed her gun at what she thought was speeding behind her. There was nothing. She turned toward the door opposite her. She stopped and stared at the closet a few feet away. She changed her direction and headed for the table. She saw the photo, dusty and cobwebbed, tied to the table and the bookcase behind it. As much as she hated spiders, she cleaned the web with her hand. The picture showed a man, a woman and two girls. She slowly put the photo back.

Rose was unlikely to launch a sneak attack as the worn, rotting wooden floor squeaked. Rose tried to move as slowly as possible, but every step were making an annoying sound.

In another room, a large white triangle was drawn on the floor. There were circles at the three ends. Inside each was a different symbol. In the center of the triangle, old Sapkon, stiff with fear, was curled up on his side, crying.

“Mr. Sapkon. Let's get you out of here.” Rose said, pulling out her knife with her free hand. She quickly cut the ropes from Old Sapkon's hands and feet. Taking him by the arm, she helped him up. Mr. Sapkon looked at Rose as if he didn't understand anything. Rose just led him with quick steps to the exit. As soon as Sapkon was out of the door, he started running. “Wrong way!” Rose shouted and gestured in the right direction. At a loss for what to do, the man did as he was told and quickly changed direction. The moonlight in the darkening sky illuminated Rose's face as the old man disappeared from sight. “Now we begin,” Rose said and went back to the log cabin.

There was nothing but light seeping into the house through the broken wood. Rose took a lantern from her jacket pocket. Shining it around, she made her way to where she had found Sapkon.

She could hear her heart beating rapidly. Even though she had come into the room without any trouble. She shone the flashlight on the symbols drawn on the floor. In the center of the triangle, in the space occupied by Sapkon, was another symbol. Rose shone the light on the symbol first. Then she got closer. She ran her hand over the symbol drawn in a dark color. She felt the stickiness on her hand and when she lifted it, she smelled the faint smell of iron. The symbol was covered in blood. She shone the flashlight into the circles in turn. They were also covered in blood. The only difference was that the white symbols were drawn over the dried blood.

He stood up and ran the flashlight along the walls. Quickly she turned it to the creaking floor. There was no one in sight. She continued on her way, shining the flashlight around. The wooden floor went dark for a short time and the light came back on. A second time the lantern's light went out and illuminated. Then it was completely dark. Rose tapped the dying lantern several times, but it

was useless. Cursing, she put the lantern back in the pocket she had taken it from.

She slowed her steps and stopped. She listened. The creature was wheezing and breathing rapidly. The sound from all around of her was getting louder and louder. It was coming closer. Rose quickly turned around and began firing at the source of the sound. As the source of the sound moved around Rose, she twisted her body in fear and fired the gun.

First the growling stopped. Then the sound of bullets. And Rose sighed. It occurred to her that normal bullets don't kill the creature, they only slow it down.

Rose quickly turned around. About a meter and a half high, she saw two blood-red eyes staring angrily at her.

"Don't move!" Rose said, hoping the creature still understood the words.

The red eyes rose slowly, creaking the floor. Light filtered in through the broken glass and splintered wood on the left wall, illuminating the black fur of the creature on its feet. The two-and-a-half-meter creature's molars, two extending upwards and two downwards at the end of its lion's mouth, did not fit in its mouth. Behind its long pointed ears, fluffy black fur fell halfway down its back. The tips of its long fingers were covered with nails as sharp as knives.

Rose saw the creature in full view and pulled the trigger. At the sound of the trigger, she realized she had completely used up her bullets. The creature must have realized it too, for it let out a sound somewhere between a howl and a roar. It was a sound that awakened Rose, who felt like she had seen a ghost. She quickly grabbed the chain around her neck and pulled with all her might. As pieces of the shattered chain flew everywhere, she grabbed the remaining chain and hurled the orb at the creature. The creature who smelled the danger, stopped its noise. It snarled angrily, baring its fangs in a

threatening gesture. The horrible face faded into darkness along with the sound as the moon was obscured by a curtain of clouds.

The creature seemed to be gone. But even if Rose was sure of that, she couldn't leave the creature unhunted. She had to finish her mission. She reached for the magazine in the inside pocket of her jacket and stopped. The bullets weren't doing anything to the creature. She had to use the thing inside the sphere to do it. She tried to look with the orb at the point where the broken chain was connected. She couldn't see much. But finally she found the spot by touch and removed the part of the orb with the chain.

She must have realized she didn't have time to put it in the bullets, so she reached behind her back and unsheathed her sword. She began to pour the blood-red liquid onto her sword. She swirled it around, turning the sword until she was sure it was coated all over. When the sword was completely coated, Rose lifted it up and tried to see, just barely.

Little by little, the sound of wood from far away filled the moldy house. It was coming from the entrance of the house. "You can't escape me!" Rose said in a low voice and realized how ridiculous it sounded when she said it out loud. She crossed her sword and moved towards the door.

She scanned the area with her eyes. As much as she could see. Gradually she could hear the creaking sounds better and better. A second creak followed behind her. Rose froze. There were two source of the squeaking sound.

"Idiot Nate! Where are you when I need you?" she said in a voice only she could hear and decided to be the defender instead of the attacker. They were getting close from both ways.

She turned sideways in the room she was in and started walking backwards. She could secure her back. They were approaching from left and right. As she backed up she bumped her back against the wood which is opened after it creaked. She stepped

inside and kept walking backwards. Until she tripped and fell backwards.

Her back was very sore. Groaning in pain, she got up from the steps where she had hit her back. For a few seconds the silence of death surrounded her. And then it was broken again by a loud creaking. Rose climbed the steps quickly. She seemed unconscious. She was stunned. The railing swayed so much that Rose was sure it would break off at the root and she would fall, but it didn't.

The upstairs was smaller than the downstairs. The ceiling got shorter from the middle to the ends. There was nowhere to hide in the attic.

The railing swayed. She climbed slowly. This gave Rose an advantage. As she slowly backed up, she thrust her sword forward. She wanted to be ready when the creature came out. As she stepped back, she heard the boards creak with tension. That made her stop. It didn't move, but it sounded. The boards splintered and the claw grabbed her foot. The creature pulled Rose down with all its might. Rose hit her head on the broken floor and then crashed to the ground.

Rose could feel her throbbing head bleeding as the creature growled in rage. The creature looked at Rose with its red eyes and raised its claw. Rose dodged the claw coming at her, rolling to the side at the last moment. She stood up, supported by the table in front of her. She put one hand behind her head. Her hand was red and sticky wet by her blood. Her only chance was to attack. And then she realized. She didn't know where her sword is.

Now running away was the most logical idea she could think of. She spun around quickly and found her way out. But the creature had no intention of letting her. It swung its claw swiftly. Rose ran her hand over the table beneath her, grabbed the first thing that came to hand and tried to swing the claws that came at her like knives. It broke into two pieces in her hand, but she managed to dodge it.

Rose noticed the bulge in her pocket and threw the glass orb at the creature. The creature recoiled and then realized that the orb was empty. By this time Rose had run as far as she could. She was standing in front of the closed door of the house. Before she could even take a step, the creature pounced on her.

Rose hit the ground, screaming curses and trying to attack the creature standing over her. But the creature grabbed both of her hands with its sharp claws. It snarled, baring its teeth. Angrily, it tilted its head to the side and opened its foul-smelling mouth wide. Slowly it bent down to take a bite out of Rose's face. Rose turned her head to the side in disgust as drool dripped down Rose's face. She struggled, trying to shake the creature off her. She could do nothing.

She felt the warmth in her stomach that followed the disgusting sound. And the creature collapsed on top of Rose.

"I was mistaken about the age. I guess it was just a coincidence," Said the man in the suit standing. In his hand he held Rose's sword, washed in the creature's blood. "But... I was right about other things. I even found the lair of the creature. You are welcome Mss. Anton."

"I was just about to handle it by myself, Jason." Rose said breathlessly as she threw the creature off her.

Jason held out his hand to Rose, but she was already standing up. Jason handed the sword to its owner.

"I found this upstairs. I guess its belongs to you." Said Jason with his annoying smile.

"It was you all along."

"I don't understand."

"Why did you come, Jason? New mission? Was Dad too lazy to come this time. Or did he think I wouldn't be up to the task?" She immediately changed the topic.

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"I know you like hard missions, after all, you are Mr. Anton's daughter. The honored des..."

"Get to the point, Jason!" She interrupted him. "Cut the showoff."

After he exhale deeply "The Parchment revealed itself." Said with a little smile.

"Oh, my God!" Rose exclaimed excitedly. "Why didn't you say so in the first place? ? I'll start right away! No file this time?"

"Slow down, Rose. Be at the library tomorrow morning. I'll go and call the other members."

"Other members? Who are they?"

"You don't want to spoil the surprise, Rose."

"All right, first, let's get this corpse to your car and take it to the library."

"I'd love to, Rose, but you were about to handle it." Jason made one of his fake laugh. "Leave the body here. Mr. Anton will probably send someone to pick it up." His pointy finger rose. "Also who knows what kind of torture he would do to me if I put that bloody corpse in his car! I have to go. Everyone has to be back in time for tomorrow morning." Said Jason and opened the door and went out. A seventy-two Chevrolet Corvette was waiting for Jason in front of the house. He got into the car.

"Is it..."

"Yeah, Rose, Nate's car." Said man with a great joy.

As Jason's car sped away, Rose sheathed her sword and slid her gun into her waistband. Slowly she made her way through the trees. She felt like she was going to collapse and fall asleep at any moment from exhaustion. Sometimes she held on to the trees and tried not to fall.

And here was her bike right in front of her. Her legs were relieved of a great burden when she got on her bike. She gunned the throttle. The motorcycle roared while getting away from the forest.

As she opened the door to her house, her dog came in and started licking her shoes. When the door unlocked, Rose opened it wide and went inside. The dog went in with her. Rose put the gun on the counter and unbuckled the scabbard of her sword and threw it over her back. Too lazy to go upstairs, she flung herself down on the couch. She put her hand to the back of her head. The blood had dried. Her fluffy dog climbed up and settled on Rose's legs.

When Rose opened her eyes, the sun was already up. Her dog jumped down. Rose stood up and took off her jacket. She threw it on the sofa and went upstairs. She went into the bathroom opposite her room.

Rose felt better after a hot shower. Her wound wasn't really visible through her hair and there was no more blood. She opened the drawer next to her bed, took the white cloth, unsheathed her sword and gave it a good wipe. She changed the magazine in her gun and went down to her garage. She quickly lifted the blanket next to the table. Underneath was a shiny black basket like her motorcycle. She mounted the basket with the leather seat on the right side of her motorcycle. She opened the garage door and pushed her bike out while whistling. Hearing the whistle, the dog barked and came to Rose and immediately took her place. She jumped on the leather seat in the basket. Rose got on her bike and started the engine.

After half an hour of traveling, she stopped her motorcycle at the corner and got off. Her dog jumped down and came to her owner. Rose opened the door with the bell and her dog rushed inside. She ran to the cash register.

"I didn't expect to see you so soon." Said the smiling old woman, "I thought you wouldn't show up for at least a few weeks." She hugged her daughter tightly.

"I'm glad to see you too, Mom. "

"So how can I help this time?"

"I'm going on a mission and I need someone to look after my dog." Mrs. Anton bent down and petted the Rose's dog's head.

"Of course I will. But what's this mission? You don't get out of town much."

"Things are different this time. I'm going after the scroll!" said Rose with sparkling eyes. Still try to hide her excitement.

"Is that...? you know, the scroll...? Solomon's..."

"Yes!"

"That's great news!" And where is it?" Mrs. Anton asked with the same excitement of her daughter.

"I don't know anything about the mission. I'll go to the library and find out."

"Then we'll be waiting for you here after your mission is over." She said while she was looking to the dog. After that she hugged Rose. "I love you. You know that, right?"

"I love you too, Mom." Rose said and she got out of her mother's arms and patted her dog's head as it sat on the floor. She tugged at the lapels of her jacket, straightened it, and set off.

She stopped in front of the building that stretched into the sky and parked her bike. She looked up at the golden "C". It was the symbol of the company. Then she looked across the street. There was a three-story building. She crossed to the other side. One by one she climbed the stairs leading to the entrance. She looked at the big man standing by the glass door. The man buttoned up his black suit.

"Hello, Vex."

“Welcome, Mss. Anton. Would you like me to escort you to your destination?”

“Of course.”

Vex opened the door and said, “After you.” He said. Rose walked through the door and went inside.

She saw people going about their business among the silent shelves. Some of them were people who had no idea about magic and lived an ordinary life. The other part was an employee of the library. One of them was reading a newspaper and occasionally glancing up to check who was coming in. The young people sitting at the table in the corner were doing his research and some were working. No one knew anything about each other. Rose walked through the shelves and saw the elevator. She pressed the button and the doors opened. She went inside. Vex was right behind her.

When the doors closed, Vex took his key out of his pocket. He opened the box under the buttons. There were keys with numbers from zero to nine. He glanced at Rose with a fake cough and she looked away. After six keystrokes, Vex pressed the button marked three and the elevator began to descend.

“I’m the daughter of the Boss here and you’re still hiding the password from me, Vex.”

“Ms. Rose, it’s my duty and I can’t take even the slightest risk. Besides, Mr. Anton doesn’t know the password either.”

“And do you know anything about the scroll?”

“I’m just the caretaker of the library, Mss. Anton. Jason takes care of that.” Said Vex and the elevator doors opened. “I think you can take it from here.”

“Yes, Vex. Thank you.” Said Rose and got off the elevator. As the doors closed, Rose walked down the long, wide corridor.

KINGDOM OF DESTINY: SOLOMON'S HERITAGE

She opened the door. There was no one inside. She must have been early. She sat in the chair next to the round table and started to wait.

CHAPTER TWO

The taxi stopped in front of the blue wooden house. Scatt, seated in the backseat, handed the driver his payment and got out of the car. His long coat had the right sleeve tied at shoulder height. He had lost his right arm. He opened the trunk of the taxi, took out a black rectangular bag, closed the trunk, bid the driver farewell, and proceeded towards the house.

He held the bag between his legs and opened the door with the key he took out of his pocket. He picked up her bag for the second time and went inside. Closed the door with his foot. He put his key on the table with his bag. Then walked down the hallway and entered a room. Without waiting he jumped on the big bed in the center of the room. He picked up the picture on the small drawer beside him. In picture, Scatt was hugging a short-haired woman with his both arms. He sighed and put the photos back. Just as he was about to go to bed, his phone rang. He picked up the phone.

“Hello, Mr. Steven... What kind of items?.. Belonging to Solomon?.. Of course, Mr. Steven, I'm eager to see your collection... I

will come as soon as possible.” Scatt said. He ended the call and lay back on the bed.

Scatt opened his eyes. He looked around, finding himself not in his bed. He was walking between stone walls. His mind was empty, just moving forward. Unfamiliar voices echoed throughout the cave, some were a woman's laughter, others were sweet words. Scatt continued to walk within the cave, fear enveloping him. At the end of the cave, he saw a bright light. He walked towards the light, and as he approached, it gleamed even brighter. Finally, it surrounded him entirely. For a while, he could see nothing but white light. Suddenly, the light vanished. Scatt found himself inside a house. He had no idea how he ended up there. He furrowed his brows, scanning his surroundings. Then his gaze landed on a box he held with both hands.

“Scatt, We have lots of work! Don't just stand there!” a graceful voice exclaimed. The voice didn't sound too far away.

“I'm coming, my love!” Scatt replied with a smile. He proceeded towards the direction of the voice, which came from the bedroom. He entered the room and placed the box on the table. With his short hair and black eyes, he smiled at the woman who gazed back at him.

“As beautiful as ever,” Scatt said, his smile lighting up his face, as he slowly approached his wife. He embraced her, closing his eyes tightly. It felt like the first time in a long while that he held her in his arms. Slowly, he noticed that his left hand was becoming wet. And his chest too. When he opened his eyes, he was no longer at home. He was inside the cave. His wife lay beside him. He was holding her with a single arm, blood flowing from her abdomen also his shoulder where there must be the arm but of course his body and pain was nothing to him. His life was lying with slow breath which were slowly turning into the silence. He attempted to lift her with his remaining arm, but he couldn't. “No... No...” Scatt clung to her once again, his clothes drenched in blood. He placed his hand on her cheek. His forehead rested against hers. “Don't leave me... My love... You must endure.”

"I love you, Scatt..." the woman said, attempting to caress Scatt's face. Slowly, her arm fell. Scatt held onto her lifeless body, tears streaming from his eyes. His hand leaned against the cave wall, and he placed his cheek against hers once more. Her body had turned ice cold. Scatt couldn't hold back his tears any longer.

He jolted awake in his bed, gasping for breath. His heart raced rapidly. He wiped away a tear that rolled down his cheek. Then he just sat on his bed for a while. His hand was on his face. Trying to calm himself. After a while he stood up. He leaved his home with the bag he brought.

After walking a few blocks, he came to a stop and shifted his gaze to the right. Crossing the street to the right side, he entered the church. Inside, there were many people, most dressed in black. An elderly priest in a long robe attempted to console someone crying behind a brown casket. Scatt turned around and exited the church.

He continued walking on the sidewalk. The people trying to make sales, the musicians strumming their guitars on the side of the road... He didn't see any of them. His gaze was fixed on the ground as he walked, filled with sorrow. Until he noticed a shop filled with flowers. He quickly entered and bought a few roses. Holding the handle of the bag with his remaining hand, he held the flowers.

As the night grew darker, the moon rose in the sky, casting its light onto the green grass that had pushed through the concrete. He walked through the patterned stones extending from the ground and stopped in front of one. The stone had "Emily Flag" written on it. When he reached the grave, his knees were knocked. He sat on the ground for a while, placing the flowers on the grave and setting the bag beside him. With his hand, he unlocked the two locks on each side, one after the other. As he lifted the lid of the bag, he found a necklace adorned with crystals inside.

He looked at the necklace, tears streaming down his face. "This necklace is priceless to me. Because if I hadn't been chasing after this necklace, I would never have met you." He said, his voice

choked with emotion. He loudly blew his nose, attempting to smile awkwardly. "Lady Shaviana's necklace." He wiped away the tears streaming down his cheeks with his hand and took the necklace. Standing up, he placed it around the tombstone. "I wish I could have placed this necklace around your neck."

After a moment of silence Scatt felt a hand on his shoulder, and then he heard the owner of the hand say, "May she rest in peace." Scatt recognized the voice and turned his back.

"Thank you, Jason."

"Scatt, you haven't been around for a long time." Jason said, embracing Scatt tightly. "I've missed you, my friend." He let go and placed his hand on Scatt's left shoulder. "I'll be frank. I need you."

Scatt wiped away his tears and sniffed. "A mission?"

"Yes." Jason answered with straight face.

"I'm sorry, Jason, but I'm a bit exhausted. I know you can find someone else to take my place. Someone even better than me..." He said and his gaze focused on his lost arm.

"We know where the parchment is. And we want you to be part of the team that retrieves it."

Scatt stood for a moment like a statue. Little smile appeared on his face. "No one can no to that. Our real purpose. It would be a great end for my adventures."

His answer made Jason have a big smile.

"Go home and rest. Come to the library tomorrow morning. The meeting room. I'll tell you everything. See you tomorrow," Jason said, turning away. But just as he was about to leave, Scatt caught him by the arm.

"I don't know how I can thank you to make me a participate of it." Scatt expressed, offering a grateful smile.

Jason smiled softly in response.

"Don't mention it," he replied, and continued on his way. Scatt glanced at the gravestone and the necklace atop it. Then, he bent down and placed his hand on the soil in front of the tombstone.

"I love you, Emily. You will be in my heart. Always." he murmured, standing upright. He picked up the bag lying on the ground and retrieved his phone.

"Mr. Steven, I apologize for disturbing you in the evening, but an urgent matter has come up. Could we possibly postpone the meeting for a while?... Wonderful! Thank you very much... Have a good evening," Scatt said, ending the call and returning the phone to his pocket.

He had arrived home. Sleep eluded him. He had only mentioned his tiredness to Jason as an excuse to stop. But the parchment would change everything. He lay down on his bed, reminding himself of the need to rest. Tomorrow would be a momentous day.

When he opened his eyes, drowsiness still lingered. He stretched his arm upwards and yawned, getting out of bed. His gaze fell upon the photograph standing beside the bed. With a sigh, he placed the photo back in its position. He headed to the kitchen and opened the refrigerator. It was devoid of any food. He had forgotten to buy something to eat the day before. He picked up his green bag resting near the door. Slipping the bag's strap over his head, he slung it onto his left shoulder. Locking the door behind him, he left the house and embarked on his walk.

After walking for nearly half an hour, he entered a restaurant. He savored his well-done pastrami omelet and sipped his coffee. Settling the bill, he resumed his stroll until he found a taxi on the street. Raising his hand, the taxi halted before Scatt. He stepped into the cab.

“To the city library, please,” he requested, and the vehicle set off.

As he continued for a few more blocks, Scatt noticed that not much had changed in the surroundings. Especially the skyscraper bearing a “C.” The city’s grandest and most splendid skyscraper stood opposite the three-story city library. When the taxi came to a stop, Scatt snapped out of his reverie and handed the money to the driver.

“Good day, sir,” the taxi driver greeted.

“Good day,” Scatt replied, disembarking from the taxi. With the vehicle departing, Scatt ascended the steps of the library at a leisurely pace.

Ascending the steps, Scatt lifted his gaze. His eyes widened in astonishment. He walked toward the library’s entrance, taking a deep breath as the man swung open the doors and stepped outside.

“Vex!”

“Am I mistaken, or is it Mr. Flag gracing the library?” Vex exclaimed, sporting a smile.

“Yes, Vex, it’s me. I haven’t been around for a while, but I returned yesterday morning. And Jason informed me that they’ve located the Parchment! This might be the best news I’ve heard.”

“Until you actually retrieve the parchment, that is,” Vex remarked.

“You’re absolutely right.” Said Scatt with great happiness.

“Mr. Scatt, may I accompany you until you reach your destination?” Vex offered, holding the door open.

“Of course, Vex. As always, thank you,” Scatt accepted, entering through the doorway. He glanced around as he made his way toward the elevator. “Nothing has changed, Vex.”

“We don't make many alterations here, Mr. Flag. You know that.”

Vex pressed the elevator button. After a brief moment, the elevator arrived at their floor, and the doors slid open. Young people clutching books exited the elevator. After the last person had left, Scatt and Vex stepped inside. As the doors closed, Vex unlocked the metal plate beneath the buttons without turning his head.

“I know that one day I'll discover this code,” Scatt remarked, smiling.

Vex returned the smile.

“Just as you know about my dreams of settling up north with my family and leading a tranquil life.”

“When I last left, you didn't have a family. Have you gotten married?” Scatt inquired, squinting his eyes at Vex.

“No, it's just a figment of imagination, like yours.” Then Vex had a loud laugh to his own joke while entering the code and pressed the button labeled “3.” The elevator descended.

“Vex, do you possess any information about the Parchment? Such as its whereabouts?” Scatt queried.

“I'm sorry, Mr. Flag. Jason handles those matters. You know how it goes.”

The elevator doors opened, and Scatt stepped out.

“Good day, Mr. Flag.”

“Good day, Vex,” Scatt bid farewell, opening one of the doors in the corridor. He entered the room. Rose was seated inside.

“Rose,” Scatt greeted, nodding his head. And rose did the same. Greeting with nodding

M. V. BALDUR

CHAPTER THREE

He was bothered by the light. Even though his eyes were closed, there was no escape. His eyelids slowly opened. This time, the sun was directly in his eyes. He quickly sat up from his bed. Bottles fell to the ground, shattering with a loud crash as the disheveled man jumped up and cursed.

He looked at his wristwatch. The watch had stopped. He got up from his bed, nearly stumbling forward. But he managed to hold onto the table at the last moment. It was then that he noticed a large stain on the collar of his long trench coat. Ignoring it, he continued on his way. Passing through scattered belongings, he entered an old kitchen. Broken cabinet doors were spread across the floor. He moved forward and opened the refrigerator, finding only an empty milk carton inside. He placed the box on the dusty table, covered in dried dirt. Then, he opened the creaking cabinet door that was about to fall and took out a cereal box. He placed it on the table as well.

He grabbed a bowl from the counter and poured the remaining cereal from the box into it. The only problem was that the box was empty.

The man sighed and tossed the box aside. He picked up the milk carton and held it to his head. It was no different from a cereal box. He threw it away too. Slowly, he exited the old house. There was a lush green area in front of the door, a garden filled with all kinds of trees. Without entering the garden, he turned left and started walking.

The house had disappeared from sight. After passing a few old structures, newer ones appeared. He had arrived in a town. He walked through the town, consisting of one or two-story houses. After walking for a while, he stopped. He slowly opened the door of the bar in front of him and entered. Inside, people were drinking, laughing, and chatting while wiping glasses behind the counter, except for the chubby man.

“Where have you been, you bastard?” the bartender shouted. “If you're late again, I'll kick you out! Do you understand me?”

“Of course, of course, I understand. You know, when you get mad at me, it feels like Bob is standing in front of me. He used to get mad at me just like you,” the man said, taking a few seconds to search for more similarities. “And he was bald and fat, just like you.” The bartender sighed.

“I hate you, Nathaniel. If it weren't for work, I would have thrown you out the door a long time ago.”

Nathaniel furrowed his brows and pointed at the man.

“Yes, Bob used to say the same thing!” Nathaniel said as the bartender sighed, taking the guitar that was next to the counter and moving to the stage. He ran his pick through the strings of the guitar.

After the music Nathaniel played, he did not refrain from giving an exaggerated bow to the applause and cheers. After a few seconds, everyone was back to their old selves. This time there was the sound of glasses clinking on the tables. Nathaniel came in front of the bartender and put the guitar on the counter. The bartender put twenty dollars on the counter and handed it to Nathaniel. Nathaniel took the money and pocketed it.

"A beer, please," Nathaniel requested.

Nathaniel swiftly downed his foamy beer. Once finished, he placed the glass on the counter.

"Bartender, one more!" he said.

"I can't figure you out, kid," the bartender said, sighing, and poured another beer for Nathaniel. Nathaniel downed it too. "This is not the age to play guitar in a bar! You're still young! Go and live your life!"

As the last drops of beer trickled down his beard, Nathaniel looked at the empty glass in his hand. Ignoring the bartender's words, he placed the glass on the counter.

"One more. You know, unlimited beer is part of the deal," Nathaniel said, and the bartender sighed, refilling his beer.

After a few more drinks, Nathaniel slowly got up from the chair in front of the counter. The surroundings were shaking as if an earthquake had occurred. Nathaniel lost his balance and staggered towards the exit. The bright lights hindered his view, but he managed to make it outside. In the dark night, he began walking.

He didn't understand how, but he was back home. He groped the walls, making his way to the bed, and lay down. He closed his eyes.

The sound of an engine woke Nathaniel up. He looked out the window. It was coming from the direction of the sound. There was a vehicle parked in front of his door. He couldn't believe his eyes. He rubbed his eyes. What he saw was real. And the door of the car opened. Jason got out of the car and walked towards Nathaniel's house. Nathaniel's car, to be precise. From Nathaniel's car to Nathaniel's house.

With anger, Nathaniel gritted his teeth and said, "Jason!" He opened the small drawer next to his bed and took out a long-barreled

revolver. Filled with rage, he sprang from his bed. “You son of a bitch!” After a few angry steps, he slowed down. He tried to move as silently and softly as possible. Quickly, he pressed his back against the door of one of the rooms and retreated just in time to disappear from Jason's line of sight. He saw Jason entering one of the rooms. With quick and quiet steps, Nathaniel followed Jason.

Jason was standing directly in front of him, he pointed his gun at the back of Jason's head. He cocked the hammer. Jason slowly raised his hands, surrendering.

“Nate, stop! It's me! Your old friend, Jason!”

Nate shook his head hopelessly. Then, he took a deep breath.

“I didn't point the gun at you because I couldn't remember you, Jason,” Nate said in a cold voice as much as he could. “ My car, Jason! I'm pointing it at you because you stole my car! “ He shouted this.

“I'm sorry. How about we talk about this more calmly?”

Nate sighed and lowered his gun, facing Jason.

“After what happened to my father, I quit my job. And my car too. But that doesn't mean you can use it. Don't you ever touch my car again!”

“Yes. Of course. After all, it's your car.”

“Why did you come, Jason?”

“Isn't seeing an old friend reason enough?”

“Jason, I know you. You're calling me back to the library.”

“A mission...”

“No. I'm off.”

“But Nate...”

"I said no!"

Nate angrily turned his back and left the room, heading towards the exit of the house. He quickly bent down and grabbed the axe leaning against the doorframe. He continued on his way and went to the right side of the house. He knew Jason was following a few steps behind him.

There, on the right side of the house, lay a fallen tree trunk on the ground. A few meters behind it, the remaining part of the tree stood on the ground. There was also a pile of firewood nearby. Nate picked up one of the logs. He was breathing heavily. He placed the log on top of the log stump on the ground. At that moment, Jason arrived.

"Nate, just look at the life you're living! You..."

"Damn it, Jason!" Nathaniel said angrily and swung the axe at the firewood. The split pieces of wood fell in different directions. "You know! My father... I'm grieving." He said, lowering his head.

"So, for how long?" Jason asked, continuing to approach. "Ten years? Maybe twenty! But I must say, from where I stand, it looks like you'll be grieving for the rest of your life."

"Jason, get the fuck out of my house!" Nathaniel cried out with rage.

"I knew Mr. William, and I'm sure he would be disappointed to see you like this!" Jason said raising his voice up.

"Don't..." Nate said, driving the axe into the log. He grabbed Jason by his collar, pressing him against the tree behind him. He took a step forward. "Don't you dare use my father's name to summon me for some pointless mission! If it weren't for that damn library, my father would still be alive!"

"You're mistaken," Jason said. "Your father died because he chose to protect innocent people as the Headknight. He gave his life

doing the same thing he expected from you. Your father chose to die heroically. He didn't choose to die of hunger in a pit like this, nor did he choose to die after turning a hundred with millions of dollars."

"My father may have been the most remarkable man in the world, but I'm not him," Nathaniel said with calmness, releasing Jason's collar. He started walking towards his home. "Don't ever come here again, Jason," he said.

"The Parchment," Jason said while Nathaniel were closing the door. he froze like a statue. He widely opened the creaking door.

"The Parchment?" Nathaniel walked slowly towards Jason.

"Yes, Solomon's Parchment!" said Jason with joy.

"Now," Nathaniel said, with less than a hand's distance between him and Jason. "I accept the mission." He stepped back. "I'll be there in a few hours. You know how long the road is."

"pack your things up and let's go then." Jason said, smiling.

"You know, Jason, you're unnecessarily prolonging everything. If you had shouted something like "We found the parchment!" before entering my house, none of this would have happened. Oh... And you're not coming with me," Nathaniel said, pulling out his hand from his pocket. The car key was attached to his finger. Jason unwillingly checked his pockets.

"But Nate..."

"Jason, no one touches my car without permission. Well, not that anyone touches it with permission either. If I were you, I'd start running south on the main road. The bus to the city passes once a day. You wouldn't want to miss it."

"You're joking, right?"

Nathaniel smiled and shook his head. "No, Jason. I'm not joking."

Jason took a deep breath.

“Fuck!” he said and started walking away.

Nathaniel's spirits were lifted as he watched Jason quickly disappear into the distance.

A few minutes after Jason vanished from sight, Nate entered the house and closed the door. He walked through the corridor and entered one of the rooms. He picked up the shovel lying on the ground, slung it over his shoulder, and left his house. He began heading towards the forest across from his home.

He walked swiftly, looking at the trees, whistling while keeping an eye out. He stopped and looked at a tree in front of him. There was an eye carved into the trunk of the tree. Nathaniel planted the shovel into the ground next to the tree, stepping on the shovel's top with his foot and burying the metal end as deep as he could. Lifting the shovel, he pushed the soil forward with his hands, revealing a metal hatch. He cleared the remaining dirt off it, uncovering a rusted box. He took the box, removing it from the pit, and carried it back to his house.

Just as he was about to enter the door, he paused. He turned his head and looked at his car. With a smile, he walked over to his car, shaking the metal box to remove any remaining soil. He opened the car door with the key from his pocket and got into the car.

“Partner...” Nate said, tossing the metal case onto the passenger seat as he ran his hands over the leather-covered steering wheel. He started the car, gripping the wheel tightly and stepping on the gas pedal.

Nate was pushing the limits of his car on a road where there were no other vehicles. He drove with great excitement, trying to choose the right music but couldn't find what he was looking for. He sped through deserted roads.

Suddenly, he slammed on the brakes, bringing the car to a halt. Nathaniel was pleased to confirm that the brakes were working well. He got out of the car, taking the metal case with him and locking the doors. He looked up, gazing at the towering corporate building. Then he turned his attention to the three-story library across the street. He crossed the road and climbed the steps of the library. Vex was waiting for him at the door.

“Nathaniel Cooper! Come here, my boy!” Vex said, spreading his arms wide. Nathaniel embraced Vex.

“Vex! I haven't seen you in a long time.”

“Welcome home, boy. It's good to see you here...” Vex said, pushing Nathaniel away from him. “But you should take a shower.”

“Vex, I'll be leaving here shortly. I'm only here for the parchment. You know I promised my father.”

Vex took a deep breath. “Son, I can't imagine how great your loss is, but we need the old Nathaniel for this mission.”

“Don't worry I will be.” Nathaniel said, nodding.

“Then let me accompany you to the floor you're going, Nathaniel.”

“Do I have any other choice?”

Nathaniel entered through the door. They were making their way towards the elevator through the shelves.

“This place is like a damn maze!”

“Quiet, Nate. You're in a library now,” Vex said softly. He pressed the button for the elevator. The doors opened, and they stepped inside. Once the doors closed, Vex uncovered the buttons beneath them. He was about to enter the code when he turned around. Nathaniel was focused on the code section. Vex cleared his throat. Nothing changed. He coughed again. Still, nothing happened.

"Nathaniel, for god's sake, turn around so I can enter the code!" Vex said angrily. Nathaniel sighed and turned around. Vex began entering the code. He had typed three digits when he turned around again. Nathaniel was trying to look at the code. As soon as he saw Vex turning, he quickly reverted to his previous position, facing the wall. This time, Vex sighed and entered the code. The elevator started moving downwards.

Nathaniel clasped his hands together, waiting for the elevator to descend.

"Vex, what do you know about the Parchment?"

"Nathaniel, who handles mission affairs in the library?"

"Jason."

"Am I standing like Jason over there?"

"To be honest, no. From here, you look more like Bob," Nate said as the elevator doors opened.

"Just a minute, boy" Vex said, handing Nathaniel a set of keys. Nathaniel understood what the keys were for. He stepped out of the elevator and looked around. After a short while, he stopped and turned around.

"Vex, where was the meeting room?"

Vex shook his head in despair and took a deep breath.

"The fifth room on the right."

"Thank you," Nate said, continuing his path without looking back.

"You're welcome, my child," Vex said with a small smile, and as Nate entered the fifth room on the right, the elevator doors closed.

Nate closed the door behind him and sat around the table, looking at the two people in front of him.

“You must be Nathaniel,” Scatt said, extending his hand. “My name is Scatt Flag. It's a great honor to meet you.”

“Thank you, but I'm not the person you think I am. I want to find that damn parchment and get as far away from here as possible,” Nathaniel said, shaking the hand of the man in front of him.

Rose, standing behind Scatt, stood up.

“We've been waiting for you for half an hour. You haven't changed at all, Nathaniel Cooper,” she said, opening her arms and going towards Nathaniel. She tightly hugged her old friend. “Although you used to take more showers,” Rose said, scrunching her face

CHAPTER FOUR

Jason opened his eyes in horror. He had fallen asleep on the chair again. At first he couldn't grasp where he was. But then he realized he was in the meeting room. He stood up with support from both sides of the chair. He looked around in the stupor of sleep, and the table beside him caught his attention. A few papers and a few files were scattered on the table. He sat back in the chair and straightened his posture. He took the ballpoint pen on the papers and continued his unfinished business.

After underlining a few lines, the phone on the opposite end of the table vibrated. Jason picked up the phone and looked at the message he had received, turning the pen in his hand. He slipped the pen into his jacket pocket and tucked the papers into the files. He put it together and left the room. As he made his way to the end of the corridor, he greeted the man coming from the opposite direction. And he continued on his way. He got on the elevator, pressed the button with the number "zero" on it and he took the elevator up.

The elevator's door opened and Jason made his way through the shelves to the exit. People were sitting reading their books and taking notes. Jason walked out the door, greeted to the woman at the cash register, and walked out the door. Vex was waiting by the door.

"Vex."

"Are you going somewhere, Mr. Jason?"

"I think I have to go to the crime scene." Jason said and started down the stairs.

He was walking between the short buildings, looking around. His files were still under his arm. He looked at the parking lot which was reaching up on his left. He headed to the gate of the parking lot, where there was a sign that said "PRIVATE PROPERTY". A man was standing inside the cabin to the left of the entrance.

"Mr. Jason, I think you need a car."

"As usual, Wilson." Jason said and walked past the man who had stepped aside from the door and entered. He wasn't after a nice car. He opened the door of the first car that came his way and got in. He threw his files on the side seat. He opened the gauntlet box of the car and took the key. He started the car. He saluted Wilson once more as he was on the way out of the parking lot.

He was driving at high speed on the road where the buildings gradually decreased and were replaced by trees. His car was the only vehicle on the road at this time of the morning. There was no sound other than the irritating sound of the car's engine. Until the sirens started to be heard. After a while blue and red flashing lights began to appear, albeit from afar.

Police cars were standing in front of trees. They surrounded a large area in the forest with yellow bands. Jason stopped his vehicle. He opened the car door and slipped his hand into his jacket's pocket. He put on his sunglasses and got out of his car. He closed his

door and locked his car, took a deep breath. He was trying to comfort himself. He straightened his jacket one last time and walked towards the policeman.

Next to one of the police cars with a flashing light on it, a young girl was crying and telling a police officer something. Ten step away from her, several policemen were talking on the radio. Jason went right through their center and reached the area with the yellow band. He put his hand in his pocket. The policeman behind the yellow tape lifted the tape.

"Detective Jason, I think the same murder that took place a few days ago happened here too."

Jason took his hand out of his pocket and slid under the tape.

"I've got your message. Can you show me the way, officer?" he said.

"Of course. Follow me. Hopefully, we'll catch that scumbag who did this soon." As they walked amidst the trees, Jason asked,

"What do you think about this case?"

"Maybe it could be the work of a psychopathic Satanist guy. You know what? You'd better consult the forensics team. These things are beyond me. Here's the body," the officer replied.

"Thank you," said Jason. As the man returned to his previous position, Jason knelt next to the corpse. He uncovered the body, trying not to vomit in disgust. The man's body was covered in numerous inexplicable cuts. He looked at the man in the blue gauntlets, who was approaching from a few meters away, then stood up.

"What do you think happened here?"

"The man's name is Martin Hugo. Like the other victims, he appears to be in his forties. I think he was killed around midnight. The cause of death is clearly massive blood loss, almost as if all his

blood was drained. But he wasn't killed here. He was dragged for a while and then carried."

"By a car or something?"

"I don't think so. There are no tire tracks. Maybe there were a few people involved, who carried him here and then covered their tracks."

"Do you have any idea who might have done this?"

"That's your job, detective. I just examine the scene. But it wouldn't hurt to add a few wild animals to your list."

"Alright, did you manage to find out where he was killed?"

"No. This forest is one of the largest in the state. The police are searching, but as you can imagine, it takes time. Look, I can't prove it, but I'd bet a hundred bucks that the deaths happened in that wooden house further in the forest." The man handed Jason a set of photos in a transparent bag. Jason took the photos of the corpse, scrunching his face.

"Thanks. Then I'll start my investigation there," Jason said and glanced at the body one last time before walking away quickly. He passed beneath the yellow tape and headed towards his car. He got into the car and opened the folder that was on the passenger seat. Running his fingers over the papers, he pulled out a photo from the back. The man he had just seen shared the same fate as the person in the picture. He put the photos from the transparent bag together with the old ones. Taking out another piece of paper, he furrowed his brows and started reading. Closing the folder and putting it back in place, he shifted the gear and stepped on the gas, steering the car.

He returned to the parking lot the way he came and parked the car in the same spot where he had picked it up inside. Put the keys back into the gauntlet compartment, he grabbed the files and stepped out of the car. Passing by a few nice cars, he reached the exit.

“Good day, Mr. Jason.”

“Good day to you too, Wilson.”

Jason climbed the library stairs, and without Vex saying anything, he asked,

“Vex, would you accompany me to the second floor, please?”

Vex nodded, meaning yes, and opened the glass door. Jason entered, and Vex followed right behind him. They got into the elevator, and when the doors closed, Vex entered a code away from Jason's gaze. When he pressed the button with a '2', the elevator started descending.

“Is it a new case, Jason?”

“Yes, I think so. It's a brutally committed murder.”

“Is there any official information yet?”

Jason opened the folder and found the photo between the papers, showed them to Vex. Vex didn't seem affected by it.

“This is a Barghest.” Said Vex then like nothing happened he turned to the door of the elevator.

“Are you sure?”

“One hundred percent.” The elevator doors opened, and Jason stepped out.

“Thank you, Vex,” said Jason, and he began walking among the white walls. After passing a few doors, he stopped in front of one, adjusted his tie, and cleared his throat slightly before knocking. When he heard the voice from inside saying, “Come in!”, he opened the door and walked in.

Mr. Anton was sitting at his desk, trying to fill out some documents with his glasses resting on the tip of his nose. Jason took a seat in one of the chairs opposite the man's desk.

“Sir, there's a new murder case. It appears to be committed by the same entity as the one I was investigating before. Three deaths in the last three days. I've compiled all the information related to the deaths into a file. I'm ready to take on the assignment now. Would you like me to assign it to someone?”

“Leave the file on my desk. I'll assign the task myself.”

“As you wish, sir,” Jason replied. He left the file on the desk and stood up. Just as he was about to leave the old man's office, he asked,

“By the way, what do you think we're dealing with here?”
Mr. Anton asked.

Jason pretended to think for a moment.

“In my opinion, sir, it's definitely a Barghest matter.”

Jason exited the room, closed the door behind him, and started walking down the corridor. He opened one of the doors and entered the dark room. He turned on the lights, revealing a bed parallel to the right wall. Jason lay down on the bed, took a deep breath, sat back up, and removed his tie, then his jacket. Just as he was about to lie back down on the bed, someone knocked on his door. Jason sighed, got up, and opened the door. In front of him stood a middle-aged man in a suit.

“I apologize for disturbing you, Mr. Jason, but it's an important matter. One of my colleagues in Egypt has come across three structures during excavations. Three structures that look like identical temples, about thirty meters apart, with only the upper parts exposed. The exposed parts resemble architectural works from Solomon's kingdom. The symbols, construction style... Everything matches.”

"In Egypt? Structures from Solomon's era?"

"At first, it didn't seem logical to me either, but..."

"Have they detected any energy signals?"

"Yes. All three structures carry traces of magic."

"I want you to go there and investigate for me."

"Alright, sir," the man said, and Jason closed the door.

Taking slow steps, he returned to his bed, threw himself onto it. He placed his hands under the pillow, closed his eyes, but opened them again after a second. Lifting his head from the pillow, he furrowed his brows. Quickly got up, he grabbed his jacket from the collar, exited the room in haste, and headed for the elevator. He caught the door as it was closing and stepped inside.

"I think I need to go to the third floor," said Jason, tying his hands, and waited for the elevator to go up.

When the elevator doors opened, Jason entered the floor filled with shelves. Walked through the narrow gap between the large bookshelves, he scanned the books with his eyes. He turned to the right a little further ahead, he ran his hands over the books on the shelf. He placed his hand on one book and pulled it out, then grabbed another from a different shelf and placed it on top of the first one. Finally, he took the third book. Continuing his journey, he picked up the fourth book as well, and he reached the end of the shelves where there was an open space with tables and chairs. Sat on one of the stiff chairs in front of the window, he laid the books side by side on the table. Opened the second book, it had "The Life of Solomon" written on it. Jason opened the book and started flipping through the pages.

When he found what he was looking for, he eagerly pressed his finger onto the page of the book and slid it aside. Grabbing another book, he opened it and started reading rapidly, skipping through the pages. He proceeded to open the rest of the books, trying to glance through all of them one by one.

As the sky darkened, not much light was illuminating Jason's desk. He felt his eyes getting heavy, but he wouldn't allow himself to fall asleep. He moved his head back and forth, then buried it in the books.

A few minutes later, he forcefully opened his eyes and looked at his books. Flipping a few pages with drowsy eyes, he started reading. Suddenly, his eyes widened. He grabbed all the books in excitement and quickly stood up. Only then he did realize his numb leg and, along with the chair, fell backward. He used the desk for support and got back on his feet, gathering the scattered books from the floor. Clutching the books tightly, he started running, hugging them to his chest. He turned left between the shelves, reaching the front of the elevator. He pressed the button, and when the doors opened, he stepped inside and pressed the button for the ground floor.

When the doors opened, he started running towards the exit. Vex, who had stuck his head inside the glass door, saw Jason running with the books tightly clutched to his chest and quickly opened the door, entering inside.

“Jason, what's happening?” Vex asked.

“Vex, you have to take me to the second floor immediately!” Jason said, breathing heavily.

“Calm down. Take a deep breath.”

“The parchment...” Jason managed to say, taking a deep breath.

Vex also began to move as fast as Jason. He quickly entered the code for the elevator and waited. Before the elevator doors fully opened, Jason jumped out and started running down the corridor with the books.

“Jason, wait for me!” Vex called out, but Jason was too excited to hear what Vex was saying.

Jason entered his room, threw the books onto his bed, and started rummaging through the cabinets in the corner of the room. He took out the files and threw them aside. His hands rapidly searched through the drawers. He pulled the drawers open in haste, looking for something, and slammed them shut when he couldn't find it. Jason took the box standing next to the cabinet, and without hesitation, he threw the lid aside. He emptied the contents of the box on the table, separating the fallen files, and picked up one of them. With a satisfied smile, he placed the file on top of the books and picked them up from the bottom again. He started running swiftly. Vex, who barely managed to catch up, stepped aside just in time to let Jason pass. Jason was running fast.

Quickly turning the doorknob, he barged inside. Mr. Anton was looking at Jason entering his room, trying to figure out what was going on. Jason wanted to adjust his tie for a moment but realized it wasn't around his neck. He swallowed hard.

"I apologize, sir, but this is an urgent situation! The parchment, sir, the parchment has revealed itself!"

"Jason, calm down, and start from the beginning," said Mr. Anton, at the same time Vex entered the room, tapping the edge of the open door.

"Vex, take a seat," Jason said, pointing to the chair with his gaze.

"For centuries, the time has come for the knights! The parchment is revealing itself!"

"Jason, what did I just say? Calm down and sit opposite Vex! Start from the beginning!"

Jason took a deep breath and sat in his chair.

"Alright. Luke's friend mentioned some structures found in Egypt. The structures contain traces of magic and resemble Solomon's kingdom architecturally."

“As far as we know, Solomon never went to Egypt or its vicinity,” Vex added.

“Exactly, Vex. So I started my investigation.”

“And what did you find?”

“First, I made sure Solomon never went to Egypt, then I researched the Egyptian structures.” Jason placed two books he was holding on Mr. Anton's desk. “I didn't find anything resembling Solomon's architecture. So, I started looking into Egyptian legends.” He placed the last remaining book on top of the others. “In one part of the book...” Jason quickly flipped through the pages and found the section he was looking for. “It talks about the legend of the Triple Pyramid. Some tribes claim to have seen three identical structures that suddenly emerged and disappeared into the sands shortly after. Carved onto a rock. Look at these pictures! This star, these decorations... All of them are symbols from King Solomon's time!”

“Luke told me they found three identical structures in Egypt, supposedly bearing the mark of Solomon's era. But if Solomon never went to Egypt, someone else must have gone there on his behalf. To hide the parchment. And it remained buried in the sand until the time came.”

“Well, Jason. It won't hurt to try.”

“Who are you going to assign for the task, sir?”

“Do you have anyone in mind, Jason?”

“As a matter of fact, I do Sir. A three-person team. A file I prepared in my spare time about two years ago...” Jason said and handed over the file.

“Jason, you write everything, important or unimportant, in these files. Just tell me who they are.”

“Scatt Flag.”

"Scatt has been out of town for a long time."

"As far as I know, his plane will land in the city tomorrow."

"Go on."

"Rose Anton."

"Our best soldier. She's currently dealing with the Barghest case."

"And Nathaniel..."

"Please don't tell me that he is Nathaniel Cooper."

"Alright. William Cooper's son."

"Oh damn! I don't like that guy at all. He's the opposite of his father. Arrogant, doing whatever he pleases, not following rules..."

"He's as good warrior as Rose. And he's also a Headknight now."

"Nathaniel can never be a Headknight! Even if he could, he wouldn't accept. You saw him at the funeral. He didn't even come to pick up his father's belongings. He hates this place now."

"Nathaniel is the best leader for this group right now," Vex said.

"And I'm only calling him for this mission, I believe he'll come. He'll fulfill his father's last wish." Jason added.

"Alright. If you can get Nathaniel, they can take on the mission. I will send someone to inform Luke. But be careful. We hope he would not shot you into your head with his revolver."

"Come on, we rely on Nate here. He wouldn't do such a thing," Jason thought silently for a while. He furrowed his brows first, then widened his eyes, asking with fear, "He wouldn't, right?"

Jason was walking towards the parking lot in the darkness of the night. His hands were in his jacket pockets as he walked briskly.

“Welcome back, Mr. Jason.”

“Wilson, where's Nathaniel's car?”

“The Headknight's car?”

“Do you know any other Nathaniel?”

Wilson shook his head, indicating 'no'.

“It's on the first floor, covered up.”

“Thanks, Wilson.”

“Wait, Mr. Jason,” Wilson said and bent down inside the cabin. He opened a few drawers and finally took out a car key. He handed it to Jason through the open window. “The key to Mr. Cooper's car.”

“Thanks again,” Jason said, taking the key and entering the parking lot. He passed through the cars on the first floor. There were different types of cars. Some were private vehicles, and some belonged to the library. As he looked around, he approached a car that looked like a ghostly figure under the dim lights of the parking lot. He pulled the cover aside to take a better look and took a step back.

“Nathaniel, you bastard. You have the most beautiful car I've ever seen,” Jason said and got into the black Chevrolet. He replaced the key that Wilson gave him and started the engine. He stepped on the gas and left the parking lot.

His hands gripped the leather steering wheel. He was accelerating. Curious about Nathaniel's car's limit, he didn't take his foot off the gas. He was driving on the asphalt road with grass sprouting from it. The engine roared as he sped along.

Gradually, the asphalt road ended, and it turned onto a road covered with dirt and rocks. When the car started to shake a bit, he slowed down and continued on. He wasn't going as fast as before, but he was still moving quickly.

He had arrived at the place he was looking for. The wooden house was right in front of the car. He slowed down the car and drove towards the front of the house. Then he parked the car and got out. He reached for his gun at his waist and pulled it out. He advanced towards the door of the house. He looked at the collapsed door on the ground and then stepped over it to enter the house.

He extended his gun towards the direction of the footsteps. His own footsteps, like the approaching ones, were creaking the wooden floor beneath him. He could feel his heart beating rapidly. His breathing quickened. He heard the creaking sound of the door, different from the wooden floor's creak. He continued towards the sound. After a short while, amidst the creaking noise, Jason heard something fall. Or someone. Then came the sound of footsteps. the footsteps rose to beating the wood.

Jason followed the footsteps and saw the staircase behind the door. With one hand gripping the railing, he held his gun and scanned both upstairs and behind him. Halfway up the stairs, he heard a loud crack as the wooden floor gave way, prompting him to hasten his steps. He reached the upper floor and saw a gaping hole in the ground. He didn't want to get too close to the void. From where he stood, he looked down and saw Rose and the creature. Rose seemed defenseless without a weapon.

When he tilted his head slightly, he saw the silver rose. It was on the hilt of the sword, right at the edge of the hole in the ground. He reached for the sword and gripped the hilt tightly before pulling it back. As he brought the sword closer, he noticed that it didn't have its original color, so he sheathed his gun. He turned back and tried to descend quietly from the side close to the wall. Despite some minor creaking sounds, he tried to ignore them and continued on.

Looking from the edge of the door, he saw Rose lying on the ground. The creature was trying to pounce on her and bite her. Jason moved as silently as possible, taking careful steps. One by one, he advanced his feet and forcefully stabbed the creature with the sword. The sword made a disgusting sound as it tore through the creature's abdomen. He withdrew the sword, and the creature fell on top of Rose.

"I was mistaken about the age. I guess it was just a coincidence," Jason said while looking at the sword completely covered in blood. "But... I was right about other things. I even found the lair of the creature. You are welcome Mss. Anton."

"I was just about to handle it by myself, Jason." Rose said, catching her breath as she pushed the creature away.

Jason reached out to help his boss's daughter get up, but Rose had already managed it herself.

"I found this upstairs, I guess it belongs to you." Jason said, extending the sword to Rose. She took the sword.

"It was you all along."

Jason furrowed his brows. "I don't understand."

"Why did you come, Jason? Is it a new mission? Was Dad too lazy to come this time? Or did he think I can't handle this?"

I know you like hard missions, after all, you are Mr. Anton's daughter. The honored des..."

"Get to the point, Jason!" She annoyingly interrupted him. "Cut the showoff."

Jason inhaled.

"The Parchment revealed itself." Said and a smile rose in his face.

“Oh my God!” Rose exclaimed with excitement. Why didn't you say so in the first place? ? I'll start right away! No file this time?”

“Slow down, Rose. Be at the library tomorrow morning. I'll go and call the other members.”

“Other members? Who are they?”

“You don't want to spoil the surprise, Rose.”

“All right, first, let's get this corpse to your car and take it to the library.”

“I'd love to, Rose, but you were about to handle it.” Jason made one of his fake laughs. “Leave the body here. Mr. Anton will probably send someone to pick it up.” His pointy finger rose. “Also, who knows what kind of torture he would do to me if I put that bloody corpse in his car! I have to go. Everyone has to be back in time for tomorrow morning.” Said Jason and opened the door and went out. Nathaniel's car was waiting for Jason in front of the house. He got into the car.

“Is it...”

“Yes, Rose. Nate's car.” Jason said with a malicious smile. He wasn't sure if Rose saw the smile.

“One down, two to go.” He said and stepped on the gas and drove the car quickly down the road behind the house. He didn't have to be quiet anymore.

As he drove towards the city center, he slowed down the car. He passed by the tall buildings and drove carefully around the cars. After a while, he parked the car in front of a wall and got out of the car.

He walked through the large black iron gates in front of him. Jason started walking on the grass inside. The stones were close. Different-sized and different shaped tombstones could be seen from

the entrance. Jason walked a little further and saw Scatt, who was kneeling on the ground, with one arm.

“There you are, my friend.” He said to himself and walked towards Scatt. When Scatt was a few steps away, Scatt took the necklace, which was full of sparkling stones, out of the bag and put it on the tombstone.

“I wish I could put this necklace on your neck.” Scatt said. Then he sighed. Jason bowed his head and put his hand on Scatt’s shoulder. “May she rest in peace.” Jason said. Scatt slowly turned his back.

“Thank you, Jason.”

“Scatt, you haven’t been around for a long time.” Jason said and hugged Scatt tightly. “I’ve missed you, my friend.” He separated his arms and put his hand on Scatt’s left shoulder. “I’ll be frank. I need you.”

“A mission?”

“Yes.” Answered Jason. Didn’t want to smile next to the biggest loss Scatt ever had.

Jason couldn’t take his eyes off the necklace.

“I’m sorry, Jason, but I’m a bit exhausted. I know you can find someone else to take my place. Someone even better than me...” He said and his gaze focused on his lost arm.

“We know where the parchment is. And we want you to be part of the team that retrieves it.”

Scatt stood for a moment like a statue. Little smile appeared on his face. “No one can no to that. Our real purpose. It would be a great end for my adventures.”

His answer made Jason have a big smile.

“Go home and rest. Come to the library tomorrow morning. The meeting room. I'll tell you everything. See you tomorrow,” Jason said, turning away. But just as he was about to leave, Scatt caught him by the arm.

“I don't know how I can thank you to make me a participate of it.” Scatt expressed, offering a grateful smile.

Jason smiled softly in response.

“Don't mention it,” Jason replied, and looked at the crystal necklace one last time and turned around. He walked through the tombstones in the darkness of the night and walked on the grass.

Jason closed the car door and leaned his head back. He took a deep breath. He wanted to have a long sleep but he knew he can't, so he just closed his eyes tightly for a moment. Then opened them. He started the car and started to drive it.

The sun was just starting to rise as the car was driven out of the city. Jason opened the car window all the way and stepped on the gas. The wind was blowing all over the car. Then he found an old song on the car's radio and continued on his way. As he slowly came to himself, he noticed the gas gauge of the vehicle. The vehicle had very little gas left.

After a while, he pulled into a gas station on the deserted land. After filling up his car's tank, he went inside the station. He put money in the coffee machine and got a hot coffee. After the machine filled the cup with coffee, Jason closed his eyes and smelled it first, then took a sip.

“Sir, you're very lucky to have such a car.” The man at the cash register said and Jason was content to thank him. He got out of the store and got into his car and continued on his way.

The sun was slowly rising above the horizon. Jason continued towards the almost dilapidated and abandoned-looking

house, almost as ruined as Barghest's place. He slowed down and stopped his car.

“What kind of man doesn't take care of his father's memories after he dies, but comes to live in his old house?” Jason wondered to himself as he got out of the car. “Nathaniel!” he called, but there was no answer. He went to the door and knocked.

The moment Jason's hand touched the door, the door opened. Jason entered the house, which looked worse than the outside.

“Nathaniel, I need to talk to you! Nathaniel?” said Jason, entering one of the rooms inside the house. He couldn't take the second step into the room when he felt something hard in the back of his head. Then he heard the sound of the rooster pulled. Jason slowly raised his hands, trying not to show his fear.

“Nate, stop! It's me! Your old friend, Jason!”

The man in the back paused briefly and took a deep breath. “I didn't point the gun at you because I couldn't remember you, Jason...” Nate said in his ice-cold voice. “My car, Jason! I'm pointing it at you because you stole my car!” That's what he said, shouting with all his anger.

“I'm sorry. How about we talk about this more calmly?”

Nate sighed and turned to Jasona, his old friend, as he lowered his gun.

“After what happened to my father, I quit my job. And my car too. But that doesn't mean you can use it. Don't you ever touch my car again!”

“Yes. Of course. After all, it's your car.”

“Why did you come, Jason?”

“Isn't seeing an old friend reason enough?”

"Jason, I know you. You're calling me back to the library."

"A mission..."

"No. I'm off."

"But Nate..."

"I said no!"

Nathaniel turned angrily and walked towards the exit of the house. Jason followed after him. As he took a few steps behind Nathaniel, he saw the axe leaning against the wall in the doorway, bended down quickly to pick it up. It slowed down a bit. He swallowed and continued on his way. He followed Nathaniel to the right of the house.

As Jason turned the corner of the house, he saw Nathaniel who was walking past the fallen tree to the root of the fallen tree right behind it. There were piles of wood near the root of the tree. Jason took a deep breath and relaxed as Nathaniel took one of the woods. Anger was visible in his eyes as Nathaniel placed the piece of wood on the root in front of him. Jason Nate came up to him before he could even hit the wood.

"Nate, just look at the life you're living! You..."

"Damn it, Jason!" said Nathaniel angrily and slammed the ax into the wood. Pieces of wood split in two fell on different sides. "You know! My father... I'm grieving." He said and lowered his head.

"So, for how long." Jason asked as he slowly took a step towards Nathaniel. "Ten years? Maybe twenty! But I must say, from where I stand, it looks like you'll be grieving for the rest of your life."

"Jason, get the fuck out of my house!"

"I knew Mr. William, and I'm sure he would be disappointed to see you like this!" Jason said with higher voice to be able to make Nathaniel Heard.

"Don't..." Nate said. He grabbed Jason's collar, slammed it into the tree behind him, and took a step with him. With an inhale Jason gave his pain away. Don't you dare use my father's name to summon me for some pointless mission! If it weren't for that damn library, my father would still be alive!"

"You're mistaken." said Jason. He couldn't remember ever being so scared in his life. "Your father died because he chose to protect innocent people as the Headknight. He gave his life doing the same thing he expected from you. Your father chose to die heroically. He didn't choose to die of hunger in a pit like this, nor did he choose to die after turning a hundred with millions of dollars."

"My father may have been the most remarkable man in the world, but I'm not him," Said Nathaniel and let Jason go. He started walking towards his house. "Don't ever come here again, Jason." He added.

"The Parchment." Jason said as his last card, and Nate froze like a statue.

"The Parchment?" said Nathaniel and turned and walked slowly towards Jason.

"Yes, Solomon's parchment!"

"Now..." said Nathaniel while getting closer to him. less than an inch from Jason. Jason wasn't happy about it. "I accept the mission." After he stepped back he added. "I'll be there in a few hours. You know how long the road is."

"pack your things up and let's go then." said Jason, smiling.

"You know, Jason, you're unnecessarily prolonging everything. If you had shouted something like "We found the

parchment!" before entering my house, none of this would have happened." Nathaniel stood for a second smilingly. "Oh... and you're not coming with me." said Nathaniel, and he took his hand out of his pocket. The car key ring was attached to his finger. Jason reluctantly checked his pockets.

"But Nate..."

"Jason, no one touches my car without permission. Well, not that anyone touches it with permission either. If I were you, I'd start running south on the main road. The bus to the city passes once a day. You wouldn't want to miss it."

"You're kidding, right?" ' Jason asked, trying to laugh.

Nathaniel shook his head, smiling.

"No, Jason. I am not kidding."

Jason took a deep breath. "Fuck!" he said and started walking. He quickened his steps. He quickly left the house. When he came on the asphalt road, he looked both ways. He tried to figure out where to go. Finally, he chose the right side and rushed forward.

He was walking in sweat under the shining sun. With one hand, he unbuttoned the top of his shirt. He slowed his steps. and ran to the gas station. he noticed the bus stop opposite the gas station. then went to the station and waited.

The bus hissed and stopped in front of the stop. Its doors opened and Jason got in. The bus was empty. The only person inside was the bus driver in the hat. Jason handed the driver the money and walked towards the back of the bus. He sat down in one of the armchairs by the window.

He rested his head on the glass and closed his eyes slightly. Despite the shaking of the glass, he fell asleep. He came to his senses in pain as his head slammed into the glass. Looking out the window, he saw the pitted road. He looked around as if cursing inside. The bus

was not as empty as before. It was half full. He looked out the window to see where he was. He realized that the library was only a few blocks away. He took a deep breath.

The bus stop shakingly. With support from the top of the two seats, Jason stood up and walked out through the two open doors. He slowly climbed the steps as he walked down the pavement and reached the library steps. He turned his gaze from the steps he was stepping to Vex.

“Hello Vex. Has anyone come?”

“All of them.” Said Vex, frowning, trying to avoid the brilliance of the rising sun. “Can I escort you to your destination, Mr. Jason.”

CHAPTER FIVE

The sun shining in the sky was bothering the King's eyes. The king straightened his crown and squinted his eyes back at the double door of the palace.

"He's late again." said the king with a sigh.

One of the guards waiting beside him turned to the king.

"He'll be here in a minute, sir."

Before long, the double-winged doors of the palace slowly opened with a loud creak. Sheathing his sword, the prince advanced towards the king. He bent slightly.

"Father."

"Prince Solomon, you are late again!" said the king sternly.

"Apologies for that." said the Prince. His tone said the exact opposite. He quickly mounted the horse standing next to the king.

The king looked once more at his son, who was jumping on his horse. Then he drew the reins of his horse. He turned to his soldiers.

“Lets ride!” said the king. His horse reared up in all its glory and neighed. When his hooves hit the ground again, King began to gallop on his horse.

The prince narrowed his eyes from the sunlight reflecting on his face from his helmet. Then he lifted his helmet putting it on. He followed the king with the soldiers.

They slowed the horses when they came to the seaside. When the guards around the pier saw the arrivals, they started to prepare the ship. The King, the Prince, and the soldiers took turns boarding the ship. They untied the ship's rope, unhooked the sails, and some of the guards moved to the oars. The ship was advancing with the wind which was blowing behind the ship.

Solomon walked slowly to the side of the ship. He put his hands on the side of it. He was watching the sea. While flowingly he was watching fishes that were jumping and trying to race with the ship frowningly, The king saw him. When he got off the ship's dock, he came to Solomon's side. Solomon turned to his father. He saw the pale scar on his cheek.

“What happened to your face father?” asked with his curiosity. He couldn't remember the scar.

The king smiled mischievously. Unconsciously, he brought his hand to the wound on his cheek.

“I'm a warrior, son.” He said and put his hand on Solomon's shoulder. “Why are you so thoughtful?”

“I postponed my wedding for this deal, father.”

“Solomon, you will be a great king in the future. A king who will rule over Judah, Israel, and perhaps much more.” Solomon's father smiled and continued. “And great kings have to make great

decisions. A king gives priority to his people, to his kingdom, no matter what. Treaties with other states are like wars. Only difference is that you don't shed blood. It's like a war on paper. The great part about it, sometimes it can be beneficial for both kingdoms. It's like our covenant.”

“Then I think I'd better learn a little more about the covenant we're making.” said Solomon with a sigh.

“I agree with you on that, King Solomon.” said the King, smiling. Solomon responded to his father's smile. “Follow me. I'll give you the scroll on which the covenant is written.” They were just about to climb the steps of the pier when a guard came up to them. He slammed his fist on his chest and bowed in greeting.

“My king, forgive me for interrupting, but there is a ship from the west.” Said the guard and gestured to the approaching ship in the open sea. The king strode forward and looked at the incoming ship. He frowned.

“Apparently, Solomon, on this journey I will teach not only warfare on paper, but also decapitation of some of their soldiers.” Said the king, putting his hand on the hilt of the sword at his waist. “Do not deviate from the course! But be prepared for war too! If they attack, we will respond; if they do not, we will continue on our way.”

Everyone on board was watching the approaching ship carefully. A tense air surrounded him. The ship continued to glide towards them on the water. Solomon and the king kept their eyes on the incoming ship. One of the men on board quickly released the bow he had been stretching. The king retreated with great agility. The arrow grazed his wound and made him feel the wind of the whispering arrow.

“Grab your swords and let's show these robbers who they're up against!” said the King, and he himself drew his sword. He drew his sword as Solomon's heart beat fast. The guards abandoned their

duties and came to the king, some unsheathed their swords, others grasped the large axes hanging from his belt.

When the ship came close, with the help of a wood piece, the robbers jumped on the ship, one after the other. Swords rang, spears swung as well as the axes did. Solomon took a deep breath and arched his sword in the air. He took up arms and attacked the first looter that came his way. In his first attack, the swords clashed and trembled. Solomon took a step back and stepped forward for the second move. opened a large wound to the man's chest. And with one move, he cut off the man's neck.

Solomon swung his sword at the grubby-clothed looter who had come upon him. The man jumped to the side, evaded the attack and went on the attack. Solomon slipped under his sword and shouldered the man. And he stabbed his sword. The man staggered and fell off the ship. As the raider sank to the bottom of the sea, Solomon saw the large man standing on the opposite ship. The man drew his axe from the chest of the guard he had killed and watched the corpse fall to the ground. Then his sight met Solomon's eyes. A dark smile appeared on his face. He walked towards Solomon with his huge axe.

It was the big raider who landed on the first piece of wood between the ships. With a quick move, he took the head of the guard opposite him. As the corpse tumbled from one side to the other, Solomon faced the man. And he attacked. The man deflected the attack with his huge axe. He was moving fast for his size. Big man raised his axe and slammed it down with a shout. Solomon stepped aside. He lost his balance when his heels reached the end of the plank. He kept his balance with his hands and rushed forward. He backed away again as the man's fist exploded in his face. He had his sword raised when the looter threw his axe. The axe spun out and slammed into the center of Solomon's chest.

Solomon looked around as he staggered forward. The warriors' voices were muted. His body was too numb to even notice that the sword had slipped out of his hand. And he fell to his knees.

The looter stepped forward and grabbed the hilt of the axe. He put his foot on Solomon's torso and pulled the axe out. The piece of wood also began to be getting wet and sticky with Solomon's blood. Solomon lowered his head and looked at his wound. His eyes were blank, as if he didn't understand anything. Solomon's eyes began to darken. And it fell from the plank. The last thing he saw was the dirty smile of the man while he was drowning deeper and deeper. Then darkness came.

M. V. BALDUR

CHAPTER SIX

Jason quickly opened the door of the meeting room. Nathaniel nodded as he saw Jason enter.

“How was the bus ride, Jason?” said Nate, smiling.

“If everyone is ready, we can begin.” Said Jason as he straightened his suit, Nate placed his feet on the table and tapped the bag twice.

“Nate please... just forget about it. As I said when I summoned you, the parchment appeared. And I decided to create this team to get it. Courtesy of Mr. Anton of course. I chose you because you're the best guys we've got. Top three. I wanted the number of people to be three because we don't want to draw attention. You know we're not the only ones looking for the scroll.

“Coming to our main subject, you will enter three structures in the Sahara Desert in Egypt. We think there's a parchment in one of them.”

“I hope you are right.”

“Don't worry, Nate it will be in one of three. Mr. Fred will take you there. He will land you near the structures. And you will scatter.”

“Perhaps I should join the team after the parchment is received.”

“I'm sorry, Nathaniel. You will be the leader of the group.”

“Look, that just made things worse.” Said Nate with a sigh.

“I'm going to call Fred now and tell him to come.” Said Jason while trying to ignore Nathaniel's words which were interrupting him.

“Maybe you should prepare more next time. Why did you call us here? Just for having small chat for ten second?” Nathaniel asked.

“Because I know if I put a thick file on the table, you won't read it.” Jason said,

“You are right.” Nathaniel had already risen from his chair. He grabbed the metal bag by the handle and at that moment the door opened. It was Mr. Anton. Rose and Scatt stood up. Nathaniel slammed his bag on the table.

“Jason, I have to admit, I'm impressed. You got everything done in no time.”

“Thank you sir.”

“Bob, I'm happy to say that we will share the management position here during this tenure.” said Nathaniel with his annoying smile.

“On what grounds?” Mr. Anton asked curiously.

Nathaniel slammed his hands on the metal box.

“We both know that I'm also the Headknight now.”

“Nathaniel, the Headknight is not just a verbal thing. I've never seen you using your power.”

“You know, Bob, I didn't see you use your power either. Um... Wait, you never had to use it because you're sitting in that leather chair doing nothing but sending people on missions And... And while you are sitting and scratching your big fat belly real head of the knights was dying!” the rage exposed with his shout.

“You can't talk to me like that! I am the manager of this place!”

“I'm a Headknight too, Fuck off Bob!” Said Nathaniel and took his bag. He walked between Jason and Bob. Walking through the door “I need half an hour. Let's meet at Vex's place in half an hour.” Said. He turned right and walked to the end of the corridor. He opened the two doors standing in front of him. There was a stair that Nathaniel used to descend.

After descending one floor, he looked down at the steps leading down. He turned his gaze forward and opened the double-winged doors. Another corridor appeared before him. It started to progress. He took the key Vex had given him from his pocket and stopped. He tried to open the door opposite him. The key didn't go all the way in. Nathaniel took a step back. “My room...” He took another step back and started counting from the side of the stairs. He found the seventh door and used the key. The key opened the door. Nate went into his old room.

He turned on the lamps and placed his bag by the frame on the table. Sighing, Cleaning the dust on it with his hand he took the frame in his hand. It was a photo taken with his father. They were both smiling, Nathaniel smiled as he recalled his memories. And put the photo in its place.

He walked through the door beside the closet and turned on the lamps. He looked at himself in the mirror on the dusty cabinet

door above the sink. He opened the cupboard and took out the razor. He began to trim his beard and mustache. After his beard gone, he found a scissors which he used to make his hair shorter.

He placed his hands on either side of the sink and looked at his reflection in the mirror. The sadness on his face was replaced by a fake, cold smile.

“You promised your father, Nathaniel. And you will keep that fucking promise.” He said to himself.

After taking one last look at her face in the mirror, he took off his clothes, threw them on his bed, and took a cold shower. he took one of the towels by the shower stall, wrapped it around his waist, and opened the cupboard beside the bed. The middle of the closet was filled with weapons. They were all in order. They were lined up one by one. After glancing at the guns, Nate opened the bottom drawer of the closet and selected his clean clothes.

Nathaniel put on his new clothes and looked at himself in the mirror in the room. Then he slipped the revolver, wasn't one of the small ones, on his old, dirty clothes into the holster at her waist. On the other side was an empty case. There was a black pistol which Nathaniel stretched his hand to take it but he stopped. He closed the closet back and grabbed the trench coat that he had thrown on the bed. He lifted it up and looked. He saw the big speck on his collar again, but this time with a grimace. He took the metal bag and left the room.

After climbing a flight of stairs, he opened a door. Inside, Bob was talking on his phone.

“I'll call you later.” said Mr. Anton and frowned at Nathaniel. “What now?”

“I want the key to my father's office? After all, it's my office now.”

Mr. Anton sighed and bent down and opened the first drawer. He took out the jingling keys and handed them to Nathaniel. Nathaniel took the keys and left Mr. Anton alone in his room. He opened the door of the room opposite and went inside.

As the lights illuminated, a dusty table, chair, and several large boxes appeared. He hung his trench coat on the chair. Then opened the first of the boxes. He instantly recognized the notebook with the eye mark on it, picked it up and placed it on the table. That notebook was his father's diary. He searched the bottom of the box but found nothing and moved on to the second box. He turned the second box upside down and slowly poured its contents onto the floor. He scattered the books and files that had been piled on the floor and picked up the silver gun under a file. He raised the gun. It flipped before his eyes. He held the gun to his side and stared at the eye engraved on the hilt. He looked at the barrel of the gun. Then he sheathed the pistol on his belt. He stood up and took back the trench coat he had placed on the chair. He took the diary and the metal box, left his Father's office, locked it, and headed for the elevator. He went to the ground floor.

As he walked through the shelves and opened the glass door, Vex, Rose, Scatt, Jason, and a middle-aged man appeared before him. The man's eyes turned from surprise to happiness.

"Mr. Nathaniel, I'm so glad to see you! For a while I thought you were dead. But you are alive!"

"Hello Alfred." said Nathaniel. He took a step and turned to Jason, who was on his right. He held out the trench coat he had slung over his arm. "Jason, can you give this to the dry cleaners?" He said, and Jason sighed and took the trench coat.

"If you're all ready, the car is right over there." said Fred, pointing to the black car parked at the end of the stairs.

"Let's go team." Said Nathaniel and began to descend the stairs.

Fred, Rose, Scatt and Nathaniel got in the car. Fred started the car and they left the library.

When the car arrived at the airport, Nate opened the front door of the car and got out, frowning at the plane taking off above his head. He brought his hand to the left of his chest. And his eyes got bigger.

“Damnit!”

“Nate, what's wrong?” Rose asked as she got out of the car.

“My pocket flask was left in my trench coat.”

“There. Our plane.” said Fred and pointed to the white jet ahead. They came to the side of the plane and entered through the opened door. Nathaniel opened the closets above the armchairs as Scatt and Rose took their seats. He continued to search the closets in plane but couldn't find what he was searching.

“Alfred, where are the drinks? Especially the alcoholic ones?” Nathaniel asked.

“I'm sorry, Mr. Nathaniel, but Mr. Vex has banned alcoholic beverages while on duty.”

“It will be a long journey.” said Nathaniel with a sigh. He put the box in his hand under the seat by the window and sat himself in the one on the aisle side. Nathaniel opened the diary as the plane was moving slowly. And he started to read.

“Nathaniel, when did you started to reading? Last time I checked you were reading only comics.” Rose asked from the backseat.

Little respect for ‘only comics’. Anyway... you know... I'm reading my father's Diary. I'm looking for something to do with that thing.” Said Nathaniel and tapped the metal bag to the side with his foot twice. “Not working.”

“Have you tried just plugging it in?”

“Of course I tried.” Said Nathaniel and returned to the diary. It was waking up some memories which Nathaniel had missed. He wanted to remind them all even Tho those memories gave him an awful feeling and the feeling of what he lost.

“Bingo!” said Nathaniel a few hours later. “Actually, it's pretty simple. It just wants the knight's oath.”

“Nate, do you know the knight oath?”

“I swear to serve the Great Solomon and so on.”

“So you don't know.”

“By the way, since it is written here, I'm going to need some blood.” Nathaniel changed the subject by saying.

After the plane landed, Nathaniel stood up. He held a metal box in one hand and a diary in the other. When he got to the door of the plane, he felt the cold wind blowing on his arms. He looked at the darkened sky. After everyone on the plane had landed, Fred started walking towards the hangar.

“I'm going to get a car.” said Fred and disappeared. Shortly after, Fred arrived in the car.

After a short drive, the car stopped. Nathaniel took a few steps, leaving footprints on the sand with his black boots. He put the metal bag on the sand. crouching on the ground. He lifted his head after unlocking the two locks in front of him. He saw Rose standing in front of him. Rose took the knife from her waist and handed it to Nathaniel.

“You're going to need your blood to run it.”

Nathaniel sighed and took the knife from Rose's hand sharply. He stared at the gauntlet inside the metal box. After a while, he took it and put it on his left hand. He glanced over at the dark gauntlet that

reached up to his elbow. "It was like it was brighter when my father was using it."

Nathaniel came all the way to the back of the hand, running the fingers of the hand on which he was holding the knife, on the carburized and etched patterns on the gauntlet. He had a huge eye on the back of his hand. The closed eye was like the center of all the other decorations.

"I think we should drip the blood on the eye. At least that's what it said in the diary," said Nathaniel, and handed the knife to Rose. "Would you like to bleed me Rose?"

"With great pleasure," Rose said smilingly and took the knife from Nathaniel's hand. He grabbed Nathaniel's wrist with his other hand and made a diagonal cut in his hand. Nathaniel grimaced in pain.

"I realized that deeply inside of you, you really want to cut off my whole hand," said Nathaniel as he stared at the wound on his hand.

Rose carefully placed Nathaniel's bloody hand over the eye on the gauntlet. He waited for a few drops to drip.

"Alfred, do you have bandages on the plane?"

"I'll bring it right away."

"Now, Nathaniel, take your vow of knight and see what happens."

"Sure yes, the knight's oath. Solomon's... Your Great Solomon... No... I'm Nathaniel Cooper..."

"You forgot the oath!"

"In fact, I never learned," Nathaniel told the truth calmly.

"What exactly was written in the diary?"

“Before using the gauntlet, my father cut off his hand and dripped blood into the eye, just like I did. Then he took the oath of knightship. The thing is, Rose, my father's oath of knight can keep him faithful forever. Even without the oath, he would have remained faithful to the end, but I am not like him.” ' said Nathaniel, and he frowned quietly and thought for a moment. “But you know, I think I've found a vow to be faithful.” He closed his eyes and extended his gloved hand forward. “I am Nathaniel Cooper, I swear to follow in the footsteps of my father, who followed my ancestor Coldor, to the end of our lives.” He opened his eyes and looked around, but nothing happened. He sighed and closed his eyes again. “Old Solomon, I swear on my father's soul that I will keep my fucking word!” he shouted out.

“Nathaniel...”

Nathaniel opened his eyes. He couldn't see anything at first, but soon, seeing the light shining from the embroideries at the bottom of the gauntlet, he opened his eyes wide and took a few steps back. The light was rising towards the eye, and it was shining brighter as it went. It finally caught the eye, and the eye gleamed golden. The lid on it opened like a real eye and the lights went out. Nathaniel excitedly raised his gloved hand in the air.

Fred who missed all came to Nathaniel with a bandage in one hand and a small box in the other. Scatt came over as Rose took the bandage and wrapped it around Nathaniel's severed hand.

“Umm... Nathaniel, if you'll excuse me, I'd like to take a look at your gauntlet. To the gauntlet of the Headknight Coldor!”

“Of course.” Said Nathaniel while Rose finished bandaging the wound on his hand. He held out his hand to Scatt. Scatt stared at the gauntlet, fascinated. Sometimes he would lift it up and look under it, and sometimes he would look at the part with the embroideries on it.

Fred opened the box in his hand. He took one of the earphones inside and handed it to Nathaniel. Nate took it and put it in his ear. Scatt left the gauntlet and took his own headphones and put them on. When Rose put it on, Fred extended his hand to the right.

“Go west. It's right behind the hill you see. I'll wait for you in the car.” Said Fred, squinting from the sun, taking one last look around and back on the plane.

“Okay team. Let's get going.” Said Nathaniel and started walking in the direction Fred pointed.

They began to climb the large dune that came before them. After taking a step to get out, their feet slipped slightly over the sand and took the second step. It was the same with every step.

When they finally reached the top, Nathaniel crouched down and his team followed.

“We must go in secret.” Said Nathaniel, spoke in a low voice, even though the nearest tent was hundreds of meters away. “You see all three structures, right? The three of us will split up and go inside the structures. One of us will take the parchment and we'll be out. We'll meet again on this hill. I will go to the middle one. Rose, you on the right, Scatt, you on the left.”

They stood up and began to carefully descend the dune. Their feet slid on the sand and they went all the way down. After walking for a short time, they managed to enter the area where the tents were.

When they reached the first tent, they stuck to the cover of the tent as much as possible and looked around. Nathaniel moved to the far left of the tent and looked around. Seeing no one around, he gestured towards the building on the left. Scatt nodded and began to walk towards the structure, bowing. Then Nathaniel turned to check the right side when Rose was already on her way. He took a deep breath, focused on his own path, and ducked behind the next tent. He looked around and continued.

Nathaniel reached the reputation of the building after he drove past two trucks lined up at the end of the tents. It was a small structure for a pyramid. He began to walk around the almost six-meter structure. He searched for a place to enter but could not find an open place. Using the ledges on the edges of the pieces of stone, he got to the top and tried to push the end of the structure. Nothing happened. "Damn!" he kicked in anger, and his kick came right in the middle of the star symbol on the structure. The pentagonal stone fell into the structure and shattered into pieces. The moonlight entered through the void, illuminating the place where the stone had fallen. "That works too." Said Nathaniel, put his hands on either side of the structure and jumped down.

Nathaniel took out his flashlight and held it inside. Engraved pictures stood on the walls of the building made of stone blocks. Turning the lantern around, Nathaniel looked for a way and noticed the closed door on the floor. He pulled its round dusty handle and lifted the door. As the door opened, it suffocated the surroundings with dust, and as the dust descended to the ground, the wooden staircase underneath was revealed. The moment Nathaniel stepped on the ladder, the step under his feet cracked and broke in the middle. When Nathaniel's foot touched the rotten step one below it, it broke like the first one, and the one after that, and the one after that... Nathaniel cursed bitterly as he fell to the ground.

Nathaniel rose from the ground. He cleaned the dust off as much as possible. He retrieved his lantern, which illuminated part of the wall. It was in a hallway. First, he held the lantern behind the stairs and, seeing that there was no way, continued on the opposite road.

When he got to the end of the corridor, he shone his flashlight on the corridors that stretched to the right and the left. "Damn!" said. He turned to the left as his voice echoed through the entire structure. He began to move forward, glancing at the symbols on the walls. He saw the gauntlet standing next to the man in the long robe. The gauntlet in the engraved image had an eye on the back.

Nathaniel frowned and slowly placed his left hand on the gauntlet picture.

All of a sudden he had a headache. It felt as if they were hitting him on the head with a sledgehammer. He blinked his eyes. He didn't seem to be able to see anything. Everything around him was shifting, merging with the light of the shining lantern. His breathing quickened. He lost his balance and, after two staggered steps, fell to the ground on his knees. Leaning against the wall, he forced himself to get up, but the pain got worse as he got up. He felt every bone in his body aching, and he staggered towards the opposite wall. Supporting the wall with his shoulder, he was holding his head, which was about to crack, with both hands and silently screaming in pain. He left the wall. He was able to take a few steps down the hall and felt his knees buckle. He fell to his knees and then fell on his chest.

Her eyelids didn't want to open, but they had to. He opened his eyes and looked around. Remembering where he was, he straightened up with sawdust and picked up the lantern he had dropped as he stood up. He felt as if his head ached. He staggered and stumbled against the wall, but his hands rose with a reflex before it touching the wall. He hurriedly brought his hand to his earphones. "Do you hear me? rose? scat? Anyone? If you can, hurry up! Because we have a huge problem!" yelled. He turned to either side of the corridor. It wasn't where he last remembered, but he knew where to go. He started to run. He was trying to go back the way he came.

The building began to shake rapidly. Sand seeped through the blocks. Nathaniel swayed back and forth, then regained his balance and began to run. Sand surged up the narrow corridors of the structure.

The sand had risen a few inches when he arrived in front of the wooden staircase with broken steps. He jumped up over the sand. He grabbed either side of the small entrance in the ceiling and pulled himself up. When he came up to the small pyramid part of the structure, he did the same. Pulling himself out of the pentagonal space in the middle of the star. The building was buried underground.

Nathaniel looked at the other two structures as well. Their end was the same, and he heard a familiar voice.

“Damn it!” cried Scatt.

Rose took one last look around and ran her hand over the structure. She wandered around the back of the building and found nothing until he got in front of it. she was about to give up when he realized that the lines of the pentagon, which is the heart of the star symbol, it was slightly fanning and pulling her hair. She placed her knife in the air-flowing space and moved it back and forth. Soon, the pentagonal stone fell into the structure. Rose pointed her flashlight into the structure and, seeing the floor, jumped inside.

It was dark inside. There was no light but Rose's lantern and the moonlight streaming in through the void. Rose swept the lantern's light all over the cobwebbed space, and when the light was reflected on the square wooden door on the floor, Rose bent down, grabbing the rusty handle with slow movements, and carefully opened the door, looked downstairs. She held her flashlight. He could see the ground. Putting her arms on either side of the door, she stepped on the first step of the ladder and held himself up at the last moment as the step cracked. she carefully lowered herself to the floor. As far away from the steps as possible.

She started walking down the corridor before her. After a short time walk, the road split in two. And Rose glanced down both corridors. Not seeing much difference, she chose the left side and started walking.

When she got to the middle of the corridor, she saw that the road split into three. A single door on the left. On the right is a double door, and across a corridor. Thinking that something as valuable as parchment was behind the double door, she opened it. But all she saw was a step and sand filling the two-winged chamber up to the second step.

she opened the door on the left and entered the room. In the center of the room, which had not been touched for centuries, stood a table made of decaying wood. The chair, made of the same material, was surrounded by cobwebs. The room was empty except for cobwebs and the table. Rose looked around and glanced at the doors behind the chairs at either end of the Dining table. The door on the right—near the one Rose had entered—was a double-winged door that looked majestic with a mix of gold and brass. The one on the left was a wooden door fixed to each other with metal in two different places.

She chose the nearby door. A few feet from the door, she looked at the accumulated sand on the floor. Even though she knew it wasn't a good idea, she still opened the door and the sand rushed over her. Rose quickly jumped back and cleared most of the sand, but not the ones that got into her boots. She turned around and walked to the opposite side, running her hand over the wooden chairs, noticing even more the fine workmanship on the chair and table as she moved forward.

She freed her hand from the chairs and opened the single-leaf door. She had come to a crooked corridor. It was straight as a road, but the walls seemed to go in and out. She took her first step towards the double doors, waiting for her at the end of the corridor. She continued walking down the hallway. When she got to the door, she took a deep breath and stepped inside.

At first she noticed the column standing right in the middle of the room she was in. At the top of the column stood a wooden box. She moved forward with heavy steps. Holding her breath, she excitedly opened the box, but the box was empty.

When she was sure that there were no other doors around the room, she left the room and began to walk down the corridor she had entered. Rose felt the jolt from under her feet. The shaking seemed to come from the whole building, not just from one place. Rose began to run as the sand surged through the broken stones on the ground.

Rose kept running without looking around. Every now and then she looked down at the ground, trying to figure out how deep she was buried in the sand. She kept running out of breath. She came to the end of the wooden staircase first. Then she went up. The sand was flowing into the void as if flowing from a waterfall. Rose pulled herself up. When she got outside, she spit out the sand that got into her mouth. She started running towards the hill.

Scatt was looking for a place to enter the pyramid-shaped structure. As he hovered the lantern over the structure, he saw the pentagonal void. He put the lantern in his mouth and, using one hand for support, pulled himself up. He tried to get out by pressing his feet against the curved Wall. After all he succeeded to find a way to go in. When his foot stepped on the pentagon the symbol had fallen in. Scatt, was used to those kind of unexpected ways in so he just continued his way and he picked up the lantern again and jumped down the gap.

Disregarding his aching legs, he stood up on the pentagonal stone he had fallen on and held the lantern around as he jumped over the stone to the floor of the building. In the building dominated by spiders, not much was visible on the walls. Just a few symbols. And he realized that there was no going back. He swept the lantern across the floor and looked down through the pantry door, which was wide open. He went down the wooden ladder that stretched to the floor.

This time the walls were different from the first part. Pictures and writings were engraved on the blocks. Scatt chose one of the blocks and tried to understand the story as much as he could from the pictures. The story seemed half-hearted because he couldn't understand the writing, but he continued on anyway.

When the road split in two, he turned left to see the continuation of the story he had started to read and walked forward, rubbing his hand on the wall.

“So this structure is really to protect the scroll.”

Then he turned his attention to the sizzling earpiece in his ear. Nathaniel was trying to say something.

“Hurry up!” It was all that Scatt could heard, and he frowned away from the wall and quickened his pace. He walked with strides.

He turned right. He was running. It was not easy to navigate the long corridors of the structure. He slowed his pace and stopped somewhere in the middle of the corridor. There were doors on both sides. A two-winged magnificent door on one side, and a single-winged door on the other. Opening the double doors on the right, he saw the sand-drenched steps and realized that the right way was to continue down the corridor. He continued running.

The road parted again. This time it was split in two. Ahead the corridor continued, and to the right was a new corridor. Hold his flashlight forward, Scatt saw nothing but the empty corridor. But when he held it to the left, he saw the ladder leading up.

“Damn it!” said Scatt when he realized he was back where he started. All that was left was running towards the closed door now.

When he opened the door and walked in, he put his hands on his knees and tried to breathe. He froze for a few seconds as he looked up and saw the wooden table. Antique chairs and table... “No.” He said to himself. “I’m not here to deal with them. I have only one mission here. That’s parchment.” He said and tried to find the rest of his way. He looked at the magnificent double-winged door on the right. And the door on the left, which is about to collapse. He turned his head a few times and tried to choose the right one, and finally decided on the door on the left. And he rushed through the door.

When he opened the door, a long corridor appeared before him. The corridor began to move forward. When he reached the winged door, he turned the handles and opened the door.

He walked towards the pillar standing in the middle of the room. A wooden box stood on the column. Unblinkingly, Scatt moved towards the box. He walked with heavy steps. Without taking his eyes off the box, he excitedly extended his hand and stopped. He clenched his fist. He wiped his sweaty hands on himself. He took a deep breath and carefully opened the box. Inside the box was a gold-embroidered parchment. He grasped the parchment and lifted it up. He felt the jolt under his feet. The column from which he had taken the parchment shattered in several places. As pieces of the pillar fell to the ground, grains of sand charged through the blocks. Scatt's eyes widened in fear. He turned around and started running.

He rushed through the corridor. When he got to the room where the dining table was, he saw the door on the other side swing back and forth as if it had been hit from the other side. He raised his hand to make sure the parchment was in his hand and continued running. Had just left the room when the double doors burst open and waves of sand began to fill the room rapidly from inside.

Some of the walls on which the stories were painted started to crack. Sand was gushing through the cracks. The floor of the corridor was beginning to fill with sand. When Scatt turned right and climbed the stairs in front of him, he wanted to take a deep breath, but he couldn't stop. He put the parchment in the bag hanging over his shoulder and went up the stairs.

The tremor had increased. Scatt was about to get away. But he could feel the movement of the blocks under his feet. They weren't just shaking anymore. They were also sinking. The strong wind blowing through the gap on one of the walls that met in the middle was bringing the sands inside as well.

Scatt stepped onto the pentagonal stone on the ground and extended one hand into the opening above. The sands were accelerating. Sand flowing through the gap in the wall first poured into Scatt's face and then joined the rising dune on the ground.

Scatt tried to reach out as far as he could, but it wasn't enough.

"Fuck!" he yelled.

When he was sure his bag was closed, he jumped and clung to his corner. He tried to pull himself up while nutating his head to protect his eyes from the sand, but it wasn't enough. Even though Scatt could not see clearly, the sands flowing from the side of his hand accompanied the sand entering the space. The building was about to sink. As the sand rained down on his face, he suddenly felt like his ankle was going to dislocate, and his feet were lifted off the ground, and then he fell to the ground. It was too quick. Realizing that it was no longer raining sand on his face, he wiped what he could with his hand, and when he opened his eyes, he saw Nathaniel holding his wrist among the grains of sand flying around.

"We have to get out of here before the storm ends!" said Nathaniel, and he took Scatt by the arm lifted him up. Even though they couldn't see their way, they moved forward at a fast pace. Scatt and Nathaniel were stooping and trying to run, as the white tents slowly gleamed from the inside. They tried not to be seen as shadows were reflected one by one on the walls of the tents.

They had managed to leave the area where the tents were, out of breath. The grains of sand flying fast through the air slowed down and landed where they belonged. After running up to the top of the hill, they let themselves go. They managed to stop after slid across several meters of sand to the other side of the hill. As they sat panting on the sand, they saw Rose coming towards them. Scatt couldn't look at Rose, as he still hadn't completely gotten rid of the sand in his eye. He just rubbed his eyes.

"Where the hell were you? Did you get the parchment?"

"On Scatt."

"How you know?" Scatt asked. His voice were showing how much surprised he was.

"I will explain but not now! We have to go to our car. Immediately!" said Nathaniel. He straightened up, grabbing Scatt's arm and helping him up, too. He passed Rose and started walking towards Fred and the car. Rose came up behind him.

"What's going on Nate?"

"You wouldn't believe me even if I told you." said Nathaniel, shaking his head.

Rose took bigger and faster steps, when she got in front of Nathaniel she stood crossed her arms. Right eyebrow rose.

"We can't learn without trying, can we?"

Nathaniel sighed and looked at Scatt. He was still trying to get rid of the sand in his eyes.

"Scatt, I hope sands didn't fill your ears because you want to hear it. Well... I guess..." He kept walking. "The power of the gauntlet is some sort of vision."

"Vision?"

"Yes. When I touched the hieroglyphs and walls in the building, I saw something with a headache."

"What did you see, our mythy Oracle?"

Nathaniel sighed deeply and he coughed to clear his throat.

"It all began with a standing man in the middle of the desert..."

M. V. BALDUR

CHAPTER SEVEN

Solomon slowly opened his eyes. He looked around. He was in a corridor with stone walls. behind him, there was a closed double-leaf door. He couldn't remember how he got here. The pain reminded him of the scar on his chest as he tried to straighten up. And he got up, groaning in pain. First, he took out the pieces of his armor one by one. Looked at the robe of royal cloth that was under the armor. It didn't look like "royal" anymore because of the blood that was strewn all over it. He took a deep breath and took off his shirt. Tearing it into pieces. He bandaged the wounds on his bare chest with these expensive pieces. He began to walk through empty and dark corridors.

The further he went, the longer the dark corridor seemed as if it would never end. Doors began to appear on the walls. Wooden doors stood in a row. There was neither a symbol nor a sign. Maybe if there was a coat of arms, Solomon would be able to tell which kingdom he was in. But there was nothing. He opened the first door. It was empty inside. There was nothing. And dozens of doors looked

like this room. He could die without opening half the doors. Blood was pouring from his wound.

He didn't know where to go. He opened one of the doors in the opposite hallway. Another empty room. Solomon sighed. He was about to admit that this palace was deserted until one of the torches on the wall lit up. Then another and another... Torches were reaching towards the end of the corridor. As if someone was guiding Solomon. Although Solomon could not understand how the torches were lit, the fire of hope rekindled within him with the torches. The torches led all the way to the double-leaf brass door at the end of the corridor. It was a runic-inscribed door with gold embroideries on it. Solomon put his hand on the stinging wound and made his way to the brass door.

He slid open the door hard enough for himself to enter, and then went inside. He was in a room with lots of empty long banners up to the opposite wall. A bright dazzling light emanated from across the room. Solomon couldn't take his eyes off the light. The light was attracting him. Solomon's eyes widened and he started walking slowly towards the light.

As he got closer, what appeared to be the source of the light began to become clear. A throne and someone was sitting on it. But he only saw it as a blackout. As he got closer, it became clearer and he heard that voice.

“Welcome Solomon!”

“Wha... do you know me?”

“Yes. Wisdom comes from my power. I spent the last of my magic while trying to save you and bring you here.”

“Who are you? And what kingdom am I in?”

“My name is Orin, the first heir of the magic. And I am the king of the Kingdom of Destiny. well, I was the king.”

"The kingdom of Destiny?" Said Solomon. He thought for a moment, but the name didn't sound familiar at all. "I had never heard of his name in my life."

"It's impossible for a mortal from your Earth to hear the name of this realm anyway, Solomon."

"Wa... my world? What are you talking about?"

"We don't have time for this! All you need to know is that the source of magic is our worlds. And as we lost the world we also lost what we have. Come closer, Solomon. See it with your own eyes."

Solomon was unsure of what had been told to him. Succumbing to his curiosity, he took a step towards Orin in fear.

Orin was a middle-aged man with long hair. From the man's left shoulder to the bottom of his right arm, he seemed to be joined to the throne. Her feet, her legs, her belly... those parts of him had completely turned to stone.

"Do not afraid, Solomon. Come closer. Let's take care of your wounds."

The touch of the light started to make Solomon relaxed. Feeling safe, he approached slowly. Orin put his hand on Solomon's chest, over his wound. Solomon's wound ached at the first touch, and then the pain completely disappeared. As Orin withdrew his hand, the star-shaped ring caught Solomon's attention.

"Now you can get rid of your rags, Solomon."

Solomon felt the pain completely disappear. He slowly opened the piece of clothing he had wrapped. The cut in his chest was no longer there. Solomon didn't know what to say.

"How did you...how did you do that?" ' asked Solomon. He couldn't take his eyes off his closed wound."

“With a little spell!” replied Orin.

“I... Uhh... why did you bring me here... into this world?”

“Because Solomon my people are in the midst of great destruction and not just mine but all are in danger. Only a great and wise king can stop this destruction. And only the owner of the Magic can choose the new heir of the magic. You were chosen and brought here, young prince. You are the third heir to magic.

“But if you couldn't stop him with your true power, how will I?” ' Solomon asked, trying to hide his fear.

“You're not going to attack the source of power like I did. By not givin' a second chance, and not trying to fix the people who choose the side of black magic. By fighting. By not doing what I did. As for power, once you accept the spell, you will be able to use the magic of your world. But you won't have the power of this world's magic. At least not yet. As much as you get rid of the darkness, you will have it too.” Orin put out his hand to Solomon. “All you have to do is take my hand.”

Solomon cautiously held out his hand. Orin grabbed Solomon's hand and said, “Use this power only to drive away the darkness! Go to the tower in the south of the kingdom, find the metal that will help you defeat the creatures, and the army of dark magic, and go to the volcano in the southwest! My blacksmiths are hiding in that mountain. Find them.” he said. He thought for a while. “Take my ring with you in case they don't believe you. From this day on, take care of this symbol, Solomon. Because now it is your symbol. Don't forget that this symbol will always guide you! The battle is up to you and the fate of the magic is up to you.”

Solomon and Orin's hands began to glow. The level of light grew higher and higher. It turned white and illuminated the entire throne room. Solomon closed his aching eyes. He could feel the heat coursing through his body. Through his veins and into his chest.

The feeling was gone. Solomon squinted one eye first to make sure the light had gone out. He could see some darkness, but no light. He opened his eyes fully. Orin was no longer on the throne in front of him. Orin was no longer sitting. Instead, there was only a ring.

He took the ring, Solomon went back the way he had come and came to the double doors he had seen when he first woke up. He opened it. It opened onto a beach, and when he looked to his left a mountain blocked his view. But it was impossible not to see the darkness seeping over the mountain and covering the sky.

Solomon remembered what Orin had said. But he had to cross the mountain to go south. There was a path to the west. A path that seemed to go all the way to the end of the mountain. He decided to take the path and see the end before he went up the mountain. The surroundings looked quiet and calm. The sun was shining in the sky. It was right overhead. Solomon wanted to think about his "world", but he couldn't help thinking about what he had just experienced.

He had entered a forest adjacent to the beach. Although the sun was not fully visible through the branches, Solomon could guess its position. It was several hours after noon and Solomon was tired. He was thirsty. He was also slightly hungry. As he walked along the path through the forest, he occasionally glanced back and thought about turning back. But he kept walking.

As Solomon examined his closed wound, he continued on the path that curved to the left for a while, paying no attention to the surroundings. When he looked up, he saw smoke rising from somewhere high up in the trees. He still hadn't reached the dark zone. "Maybe... Maybe it's people." He said in a low voice. And with great hope he moved towards the smoke coming from his path.

He hadn't even gotten close to the source of the smoke when he saw a lake at the foot of the mountain to the left of the road. Walked towards the lake and when he came to the edge of the lake, sitting down on his knees and washed his hands and then his face.

Until he started to drink, he couldn't realize how thirsty he was. His pants were soaked through. When he looked at his reflection in the water, he saw his bare chest. He put his hand on his chest where the wound should be. "Make me some clothes!" he said. Nothing happened. He put his hand with the ring on his chest, where his scar used to be, and repeated. "Make me some clothing!" Again nothing happened. "Oh God... It seemed easier when Orin was making it," he said and continued on his way. The mountain had been rising to his right and now it was rising to the east. Smoke was rising behind the mountain. The path continued south, independent of the mountain.

As he continued on the path, he realized that the mountain was slowly bending like a crescent. Ahead was a wide opening. A passage as wide as a palace entrance. He turned off the path and slowly made his way through the forest towards the open end of the crescent-shaped mountain where the smoke was coming from.

He was crouched behind the bushes, looking in the direction of the smoke. On either side of the mountain pass there were many sharp stakes rising up, and inside he saw people walking around half-naked and with paint on parts of their bodies. A few men with long spears were standing still at the entrance to the plain surrounded by mountains. Solomon decided to come a little closer. A little further on he saw the tops of stakes. There were different shapes of skulls. Some were looking like they belong to wolves but were bigger than normal size. And some were small as human's but still having different shapes. "The heads of demons," Their fangs were visible through their wide-open mouths. Above their ears there were horns that grew and curled. Solomon now saw the faces of these creatures, the beings whom Solomon was supposed to purify the world. And he realized he had no choice but to destroy them. He moved boldly forward. He stepped out of the bushes. "Maybe they know how to use this thing," Solomon said as he twirled the ring.

"Who are you?" ' one of them shouted. He used a different language. A language that Solomon had never heard of in his life, but

understood immediately. "Don't move if you don't want to die!" the man continued, Solomon stopped.

"I want to talk to your master!" yelled Solomon, using the language he had never heard.

"About what?"

"About putting an end to those demons," Solomon pointed to the heads on the stakes. he said and raised her ringed hand. "I am Prince Solomon, son of King David, and I have come to make a bargain with you!" Solomon yelled again confidently.

After the men talked among themselves for a while, one of them started running towards the mountain. After a while he came back and nodded. The two men with him also stepped forward and came to Solomon's side. One of them said, "Master Edwak has agreed to see you, stranger." said the two men in a deep voice, taking Solomon by the arms.

They proceeded calmly and entered the campsite surrounded by mountains. People walking around were looking curiously at Solomon. People walking around looked at Solomon with curiosity. They had abandoned their work and were watching a stranger brought into the camp alive. Solomon looked at the large and magnificent tent embroidered by different color and different symbols, in the middle of the camp. They entered the tent, in front of which two men were waiting. A man larger than the other villagers was sitting inside. Unlike the other men, this man had a wolf's hide dangling from his shoulders. The sharp bones at the end of the necklace he hung around his neck were swinging at the level of his chest with every movement of the man. The man had a long beard, but he had no hair. He held a piece of meat wrapped around a large bone in his hand and was eating it brutally.

The guards took Solomon by the shoulder and placed him on the ground opposite the big man. The man's voracious eating made Solomon realize just how hungry he was.

“Talk!” the man said, dripping the fat from his mouth.

“You must be Master Edwak.” ‘ Solomon began his speech. He couldn't take his eyes off the big piece of meat. “You know what this ring means.” said. The man stopped eating for a moment and squinted at the clearing.

“You are a Sorcerer.”

“Yes.” said Solomon. “I came here because I saw the creature heads you hang outside the camp, which means we're on the same side. I have a proposal. If you help me reclaim the Kingdom of Destiny, I will reward you with treasures you can't even imagine. Half the treasure of the Kingdom of Destiny will be yours. And in the meantime, we'll cut off the demon's head as much as possible.”

“How can we trust you, stranger?”

“I am a Sorcerer. I swear to keep the covenant as long as you stay. Solomon, son of David, is a man of his word.”

“I will let you know my decision tomorrow.” He turned to his men “Until tomorrow Soman need...”

“Solomon.” Sorcerer corrected.

“Give the stranger a tent and something to eat. And call the council,” Edwak told the two men who had brought Solomon. They caught Solomon from his both arms and made him rose. Before Solomon could say anything, they made him got out from the tent. They brought him smaller tent near the big one they just had left.

Solomon ate the vegetables and meat he had been given in his small tent and ate well. He knew that the people passing by the gate were secretly watching him. He went out of the tent. Two guards were standing at the door of his tent and as soon as Solomon stepped out they stopped him.

“Where do you think you are going?”

"I need some fresh air."

"No permission! Go back to your tent! You can't leave the tent until morning!"

With a sigh, Solomon did as he was told and went back into his tent. There was nothing in the tent but a peltry spread on the ground for Solomon to sleep on. It was too small to fit much in it anyway. Solomon sat on the ground and closed his eyes. He was trying to reach for the magic inside him, but nothing was happening. He reached his hand forward. He squinted one eye. Nothing had happened. He lowered his hand.

Solomon opened his eyes at the sound of the guards coming in. He had fallen asleep on the peltry.

"Master Edwak wants to see you."

"Finally." Said Solomon and stood up and left the tent with the guard. He made his way into the tent under the gaze of the villagers.

"What is your decision, Edwak?" Solomon asked, and Edwak gestured for him to stop. The guards immediately grabbed his arms.

"I'm going to give you a task to make sure you keep your part of the bargain. I want the heads of the prisoners. Can you do that, Sorcerer?"

"Just show me where they are." Said Solomon in a confident voice.

"Take the Sorcerer to the prisoners!" said Edwak. The two guards and Solomon left the tent. They walked between the tents. Solomon looked around curiously. He looked at the village that surrounded the mountain and the people who lived in it. Whoever in the crowd watching Solomon made eye contact with him bowed his head and hurried back to his unfinished business. Except for the

guards. They continued their duties without paying any attention to Solomon.

Solomon came to the center of the crescent-shaped mountain. They headed for the caves near the waterfall and a little lake. When they entered the cave, they passed through the caverns, which were barred inside. Most of the prisoners were lying on the floor. Solomon tried to determine whether they were dead or still alive.

Every few steps, the guards would appear, salute Solomon's companions, and pass by. Solomon was busy examining the cavities used as cells, one by one. When the guards stopped, so did Solomon. They opened one of the bars and went inside. Four people were standing inside. All four had their hands tied. Except for one, the other three were on their knees, sitting on the floor. Red whip marks were visible through their torn T-shirts. The fourth man was lying on the ground, writhingly. The other three men were around him on the ground.

One of the guards handed Solomon the axe hanging from his belt. Solomon took a deep breath and gripped the hilt. Guards stepped back. One of the men on his knees raised his head. When he saw the axe in Solomon's hand, he stepped forward as if accepting his fate. He raised his head to look at the axe one last time. He frowned. He stared at the ring.

"Where did you... Where did you get that ring?" prisoner yelled.

"None of your business, prisoner!"

"You stole the ring!" the man said through clenched teeth.

"How dare you!" Solomon had been unsure of the right thing to do, but with anger filling him, he was now fully prepared to do it. "How dare you accuse Solomon, son of David, of stealing! He gave it to me himself! In fact, he not only gave me a bloody ring, he made me The Sorcerer!" Solomon raised the axe to take the man's head.

“So, you...” The prisoner's eyes widened. But not with fear. The man awkwardly straightened up and lifted one of his knees. He lowered his head. “Prince Rodrin is at your service, my King. Forgive me.”

“What are you talking about?” Solomon remained motionless like a statue.

Rodrin looked up and reached for the collar of his torn shirt and pulled it down. It opened to reveal the star tattoo on his chest, same symbol on the ring.

“I am . Prince Rodrin, son of Orin.”

All the anger that had filled Solomon's veins vanished in an instant and he lowered the axe. He frowned. “This symbol will always guide you.” He said quietly. “I must do this for the kingdom.”

“Magic brings wisdom with it.” Rodrin said, bowing his neck. “Do what you must.”

M. V. BALDUR

CHAPTER EIGHT

His torn clothes protected him from the scorching heat of the sun. The man reached for his waist. He took a pouch from his belt and shook it. The sound of the metallic coins inside the pouch clinking together was heard. He lowered the piece of cloth that he had raised to his nose to his neck, took a deep breath and opened the pouch. Inside were three gold coins and one silver coin. The gold shone, but not all at the same level. They did not shine because they reflected the intense sunlight shining on them. The gold coins were the source of the light.

The more the man stepped, the more the gold shone. He walked without taking his eyes off the pouch. He kept going until his eyes were dazzled by the bright light. Finally, he stopped and picked up the brightest gold. He could see almost nothing. The light was blinding him. The man turned his head, averted his gaze and put the gold down. He started walking in the same line. He put the other two in the same line.

When the man looked in his pouch, only the silver coin was still there. He picked it up and hung the empty pouch on his belt. He squinted his eyes and looked at the gold on the floor. He got down on his knees and buried the gold under the ground with the sand he dragged from both sides. The ground began to tremble. The man quickly took a few steps backwards. The tremor turned into an earthquake and the sands where the gold should have been began to spread to the side. First a pyramid raised through the sand, then the rest of the structure. The man staggered and fell backwards as the structure rose rapidly. When he looked up, he saw the same structure where he had left the other gold coins.

He opened the double-winged door of the building, the exterior of which was decorated with magical symbols, and went inside. He reached into his bag and took out the scroll that glowed on both sides. he held the scroll left and right, trying to find the way. Whichever way it shone, he headed in that direction.

After a few doors and a confusing corridor, he found himself in front of the stairs. He climbed the stairs slowly and opened the double-leaf door. He first handed the scroll to the door opposite him. Seeing no difference, he took a few steps into the corridor on the left. But the result was the same. He tried the same on the right side. He opened the door opposite and proceeded with the scroll. The parchment was becoming as blinding as the gold.

By the time he reached the room that led no other way than the way he had come, the parchment was unbearably bright. He released the cloak he had tied the ends together over his chest. He wrapped the scroll in his cloak and, holding it by the cloak, moved to the center of the room. There was a pillar in the center. As he took steps, branches grew on the pillar as if a tree was growing. The branches took a certain shape. It formed a wooden box. He looked around. And he took his cloak off his shoulders and placed it in the box, leaving the parchment on top. He pulled his cloak quickly and turned his head to the side, frightened. He took a deep breath when he

saw that the light had gone out, but when he realized that the earthquake had started again, he gasped in fear.

He fell to the ground as the shaking intensified. He could feel the structure sinking into the sand. After getting up and finding his balance on the shaking ground, he closed the box where he had put the scroll and started to run. Squeezing the silver coin in his palm, he ran in fear.

Beams of light emanated from between his fingers. The man was trying to concentrate on running. He was about to be buried alive. He came to the door leading to the stairs. When he opened the doors, he saw grains of sand coming up the steps one by one. The sand was slowly rising to the ceiling above the steps.

The man closed the doors and leaned his back against the door as if he was keeping a wild animal closed. He took a deep breath. He looked left and right. He chose the right and started running. He knew he had chosen the right path. The money was getting brighter. As he ran down the corridor, the level of the sand inside had passed his ankles. He lifted his feet as high as he could so that his feet would not sink into the sand.

When he turned his head to the left, he saw the ladder half buried in the sand on the floor a few steps ahead and changed his direction. He grabbed the ladder and lifted it as if he were lifting a barbell. As the sand poured forward, the man felt his arms burning. When he freed the ladder, he took a deep breath and looked up.

He opened the square door in the ceiling using the ladder as a bar and put the ladder in. He climbed up as the sands rose higher and higher.

The four triangular walls surrounding him met in the very center. The man realized that this place without a ceiling was the first part of the structure he had brought to the surface, as the sand rose through the door he had left open.

He opened one side of the coin and held it so that the back of his hand blocked the light emitted by the coin from entering directly into his eyes. He tried to hold it in all directions, but it was useless. The man began to feel the walls with his hands. And he saw the giant star that had won on the wall. In the center was a symbol. The man lifted the coin and looked at both sides, knowing it would burn his eyes. The picture, faded by the lights, was faintly visible. It matched the one on the wall.

He put the coin on his hand with the symbol on the top and stuck the coin on the pentacle of the stone. The pentagonal piece of stone began to tremble, although it was hardly felt because of the earthquake. Slowly it slid inwards, scattering dust. The man pulled his hand away from the rock and backed away, and the rock collapsed on the sand. The man stepped on the pentagonal stone, put his hands on either side of the broken section above and pulled himself up. He tumbled free as the last square of the structure sank.

“So that's how the scroll came to the desert,” Scatt said.

“I still can't believe you have such power, Nathaniel.” Said Rose. Nathaniel answered without taking his eyes off the airplane.

“Me too, Rose. Me too.”

Fred opened the door of the plane as the sun slowly illuminated the airfield. He stood by the door and waited for Scatt, Nathaniel and Rose. They all boarded the plane in turn.

“Did you find the parchment?” he asked curiously.

“Yes.” Scatt said excitedly. He opened his bag and took out the scroll with great happiness. He looked at both ends of the scroll and turned the second end. As the lid opened, everyone on the plane was staring at the scroll with rapt attention. Scatt turned his hand over so that the scroll fell into his hand and opened it with the sticks on

either side. His eyes widened in excitement, but not for long. His gaze returned to the furrowed brow.

“Is something wrong, Scatt?”

“It's just...” Scatt said and turned the front of the parchment to Nathaniel. Nathaniel frowned at the gibberish. “I can't read what's written here, and I don't know if anyone can.”

Others looked at the scroll to see the language of it. Nathaniel sighed and took a step back.

“My father knew. I saw those letter once, when my father were writing something. I guess he was trying to practice.”

“Then we'll go to the library and you search your father's office, Nathaniel. And we'll plan our next step.”

“Or...” said Nathaniel with excitement, “Give me the scroll and I'll do my gauntlet's hocus pocus thing. We'll find what we're looking for.”

“Are you sure?” said Rose, “From what you've told us, your power is not one that you use by saying 'Abra Cadabra'.”

“I guess I'll have to try.” Said Nathaniel.

Scatt handed the scroll to Nathaniel. Nathaniel reached out to take the scroll, but stopped. He made a fist and pulled it back.

“I need to sit somewhere comfortable first.” He said and sat on the couch. He fastened his seat belt. “I don't suppose anyone has a drink?” Nathaniel looked each of them. No response. “As I thought.” He said and took a deep breath. He held out his hand to Scatt. reaching out the parchment he took it. Nothing had happened. Slowly he began to open the scroll.

When both sides were opened all the way, the letters shimmered and began to shift. The light reflected in his face seemed to invite Nathaniel. The letters glowed brighter and brighter as his

eyes grew wider and wider. Nathaniel focused on the parchment, on the writing. And then the moment began. He saw.

“Nathaniel?” Rose called, but there was no sound from Nate as his eyes closed. A light emanated from behind the metal fingers gripping the scroll tightly. Rose noticed the light, pulled Nathaniel's hand away and saw the eye behind the gauntlet glow. “I think it worked.” She said and sat down next to Nathaniel, looked at around herself. When she saw the diary of Nathaniel's father, she took it and started to read.

Rose's eyelids could take no more as Scatt looked around excitedly. She put the diary aside. Leaning her head back. She closed her eyes and plunged into the darkness.

“No!” Nathaniel woke up screaming. He was sweaty and scared. He was breathing deeply. Rose's eyes opened wide with fear, rapidly she stood up.

“Nate, are you okay?”

Gasping for breath, Nathaniel looked around. He looked like he just woke up from a nightmare. When he realized he was on the plane with the others, he tried to remain calm realizing that Rose asked a question he answered, “I think so.” He tried to calm himself by breathing in and out deeply.

“What did you see?” Scatt asked curiously.

“Uh... It's a bit complicated... He wasn't satisfied with just one thing.” Said Nathaniel. He was still breathing faster than normal.

Nathaniel hadn't opened his eyes, but he could see. Not with his own eyes, but someone else's.

A man with a black beard was standing in a room full of torches and streamers. In his hand he held an open book. On the cover of the book was a star in a circle. It was dark red, as if drawn in blood. But you could tell it had been scratched by the curved piece of leather protruding above the line. The man stroked his beard and began to run his hands through the pages of the book.

The man took one hand away from the book, walked away and stopped when he came to the table. He tore out one of the blank pages of the book and put it on the table. He dipped the quill pen on the table into the ink and began to write. When he was done, he rolled up the paper and put it in one of the cylindrical, ornate boxes. He handed it to one of the men standing behind him.

“Take this and get as far away as you can. When you get to the right place...” he closed his hand and opened it again to reveal a silver coin and three gold coins. “Use these. You will know when you need to use them.” When he finished his last word, all the torches in the room they were in died out.

The lamps on the ceiling, arranged in a specific order, glowed. Nathaniel stood at the head of the dimly lit corridor watching. As his long hair swung to one side, the man used his long sword to strike the man in front of him in the neck. Not with the sharp point, but with the grip. The man he struck fell to the ground, but the long-haired man didn't care. He kicked the door in front of him and entered with a loud bang. The man sitting at the head of the table inside fearfully reached for the drawer on the side of the table and the long-haired man quickly drew a gun from his waist. Aimed to the man. The man gave up on his plan and simply raised his hands. The long-haired man started to move forward. His blue eyes were filled with anger.

“I have been waiting for this for a long time!” he said through clenched teeth. He lifted the man up out of fear. The man was trying to run to the left because there was no way back. The man with

the long black hair rushed forward and struck the man on the head, using the grip of the sword again. As the man was thrown back, the long-haired man took a step forward, grabbed him by the collar, and threw him back. He quickly stabbed his sword. He drew it. Two more times he stabbed. As the man screamed in pain and fell to the ground, the long-haired man bent down and put his hand over the wounds.

The man got to his feet. He turned around and took one step ahead. Quickly turning on one foot, he swung his sword and walked out of the room as the man's head fell to the floor.

When Nathaniel opened his eyes, everything was in darkness. There was only Nathaniel. He turned around and saw the torch-lit path in front of him. Nathaniel wanted to go towards the torches that lit up one by one, showing him the way. It was his only desire. He forgot his team, he forgot his mission, he forgot his father. All he did was walking.

He marveled at the bright torches. As the torches burned, he could feel himself getting warm inside. After a while, the torches stopped multiplying. At the far end, at the very end, stood a throne. It was nothing but an empty throne. When he reached the throne, the torches went out and came back on at the same moment. This time a man with a long beard was sitting on the throne.

“You...”

“I am Solomon third heir of the magic.” Solomon stroked his beard and continued. “Nathaniel, you should know that the reason your eyes are open now is because of dark magic. Not my magic! Magic wants to be found. And it gives you the power to be found. The weaker the magic becomes, the less it affects you, the more your eyes will close. Eventually, you will have no power except the magic I give you. You will squint.

“You cannot stop what happens on this mission, Nathaniel, son of William. Destiny has already been written. And you cannot

prevent it. The eye only sees. It will show you nothing but what will happen. No matter what you do, Nathaniel son of William, you cannot change the destiny!" Said Solomon.

"What are you talking about?" said Nathaniel in a cocky tone, not caring who he was talking to.

"Let the eye show you." Said Solomon and raised his left hand heavily. As he clapped, the double doors behind his throne slowly opened to either side. A dazzlingly bright white light illuminated the area behind the doors.

A book with different symbols on its pages stood on a pillar. On the cover was a blood-red star and circle. Runic letters of the same color were scattered all over the cover. A hand was reaching towards the book from the bottom right. A human was reaching out to take the book. The thorns of the plant that surrounded the hand caused it to be covered in sores. But there was a hand closer than that. In the upper left corner, a black and red claw was reaching for the book. It wanted the book.

"And what could Solomon have meant by that?"

Nathaniel didn't speak for a while.

"Maybe it means that no matter what I do, I can't leave the library."

"So why did you wake up scared?"

"You know... No one wants to give their last breath under the claws of a creature. " Nathaniel tried to smile. "Maybe he showed me that I was going to be partners with you Rose, and that's why I woke up scared. I'm not sure."

"For all you've seen, there's nothing that can help us." Said Rose, not hearing of his words.

“In fact, we now know that the parchment leads us to a book.”

“But still it doesn't lead us anywhere.”

“Because we can't read it.” Nathaniel's gaze focused on the diary in Rose's hand. “Is there anything in the diary?”

“Not yet, no.” Rose said and picked up the diary again and handed it to Nathaniel. Inhaling, he took the diary and started to read.

“I think I've found something,” Nathaniel said as the plane slowed down on the concrete road to the airport. He said and frowned. “What kind of name is that? Whatever it is. It says that my father learned the alphabet on the scroll from Professor Dor Elnore.” and he realized the plane had stopped. He unbuckled his belt. “I'll tell you the rest in the library.”

When everyone got off, including Fred, they got into the car and Fred started to drive.

Nathaniel frowned and found a folded piece of paper in the diary and picked it up. He unfolded it completely and glanced at it. He slid into the middle seat and rested his elbows on the edge of the two front seats. “My father put this piece of paper in long after my father told me about the professor. The article on the back page of the newspaper reads. 'Professor Dor Elnore, a great contributor to History and Archaeology, has not been heard from for the last few weeks.'”

“Then we've lost our only lead.”

“Apparently so did the FBI agents who were on a mission to find the Professor lost too. According to my father, the FBI knows where the Professor is.”

“So, did your father stop looking for the Professor?”

Nathaniel scrolled a few more pages in the diary. He came to blank pages.

"He didn't stop writing. He had to take a break because of the mission." Said Nathaniel with a sigh.

"Which mission?"

Nathaniel took a deep breath. For a moment he felt his throat tighten. He tried to swallow. Finally, he answered hoarsely. "Washington. The mission where everything changes."

After a deathly silent ride, everyone but Fred got out of the car.

Nathaniel sniffled and put his hand on the car. He bowed his head and looked through the window with a smile as a mask for his emotions.

"Captains never abandon their ships, Alfred. But here's an exception: park the car in front of the door and come back."

Nathaniel climbed the stairs and stopped in front of the door. He quickly turned back to his friends, who were slowly climbing the stairs. "Guys, I think we have a problem!" Rose and Scatt looked intently at Nathaniel. "Vex not here!" They crossed the steps and joined Nathaniel. They passed the empty door, opened it, and went inside.

Jason came from the elevator. He was holding Nathaniel's trench coat. He saw Nathaniel and came up to him. He handed the trench coat to the owner. Nathaniel smiled and took the trench coat and stretched it forward and checked it from head to toe. He put on the trench coat. And he reached into the inside pocket on the left side.

"Jason, where's my flask?"

"Yes, I'm sorry. I forgot." Jason said and reached into his inside pocket and pulled out the flask covered with metal engravings and handed it to Nathaniel. Nathaniel took it and shook it, checking

the inside. He removed the lid. Taking a big sip of his expensive tequila. He grimaced and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. "Where's Vex, by the way?" he asked as he put the lid back on his flask.

"He's not outside the door."

"You're right because I'm here." Said the huge man behind him and Jason jumped. Vex put his hand on Nathaniel's shoulder. "Did you get the scroll?"

"Yes, Vex, but it's written in the alphabet, we can't read it." As Nathaniel explained, Scatt took the scroll out of his bag and handed it to Vex. "We tried to find someone who could read it, but..."

"Your father could read this. And you should have been able to read it too! Didn't your father teach this to you?"

"You know... I am more like an action man more than a nerd."

Vex sighed. "Same Nathaniel, as always."

"Do you know anyone else who can read this, Vex?" Rose interrupted.

"The man who taught Nathaniel's father."

"So you know the professor!"

"What? Of course not! It was your grandfather I had in mind. I was thinking of him."

"No. My grandfather was laid to rest a long time ago. According to my father's diary, Professor Dan Alone... Dor Elnore, Professor Dor Elnore or something like that, he taught him."

Rose handed Vex the piece of newspaper. No one said anything until Vex read it. Vex looked up from the paper and handed it to Jason.

"I want you to find everyone connected to this story, Jason, as fast as you can."

"We'll go up to the third floor and wait for you."

Nathaniel lifted his head from the table and looked around. Vex sat briefly on the chair and then returned to his post at the door. Rose was pushing her chair back as if she wanted to break the back legs, trying to make a balance with them. Scatt, tired of sitting, so he stood next to the window and looked out at the magnificent building outside.

At the sound of the elevator heard, everyone looked up with great curiosity and turned to the elevator. It was Jason. He pulled up a chair and sat down.

"Professor Dor disappeared near Mount Everest. FBI agents went looking for him and Bridget Forlands, who wrote the first story a few days after he disappeared, was fired from her job. And no matter where you look, I can't find that story in the newspaper you gave me. It's like..."

"Like it was covered up." Nathaniel said, frowning.

"Then we must find the journalist!" said Scatt.

"Yes. And lucky for you, after she was fired, she found a job in a company."

"Where?"

Jason answered by pointing to the company across the library.

"That's good news." Nathaniel said with a smile, standing up. "Soon this mission will be over."

They walked out of the library, across the street, and one by one they passed through the door of the building that stretched into the sky. Nathaniel stopped in front of the door. Smilingly, he gave the camera a two-finger salute and stepped inside.

Inside, Nathaniel took steps along the right wall towards the table, and looked around. He was mostly looking at the pictures hanging on the wall. When they reached the front of the table, Nathaniel made a quick move to leave his teammates behind and put his arms on the table, was looking at the woman was sitting behind him.

“Welcome. How can I help you?”

“We're looking for someone. He started working here a while ago. Her name is... Bridget Forlan...” Nathaniel stopped when he saw the name tag on her lapel. A small smile appeared on his face. “I think we found the person we were looking for, guys. Ms. Bridget, I hope you don't mind if we ask you a few questions. It's about Professor Elnore.”

“They fired me for talking about him. I don't want to go through that again.”

“I'm guessing the person who hired you was the owner of the company, right?” Nathaniel asked.

“Yes. Did you know the owner?”

Nathaniel pulled an ID out of his wallet and handed it to her. “William Cooper. My father. Yeah, no one can believe it. And I can assure you my father hired you for Professor Elnore. Because he was an old friend of my father's. You used to get fired for talking about Professor Elnore, right? Now you'll get fired if you don't talk about him.”

The pale woman looked at Nathaniel's face and took a deep breath.

"I don't know much. He disappeared somewhere near Mount Everest. First, the teams that went looking for him disappeared, then the FBI agents who were looking for him. After the disappearance of the FBI agents, when they realized they couldn't deal with it, they closed the case and erased it from the world. They fired me from my job and took all the files on the Professor."

"If we get the files from the FBI... can we find the Professor?"

"I'm not sure if you can find him, but you can find the paths he took."

"Thank you, Bridget. You did us a big favor. We owe you one. See you soon." Said Nathaniel and turned, and started to walk.

When they arrived at the library, without hesitation they went up to the third floor and took their seats. Soon Vex and Jason joined them with quick steps. Jason stood and paced back and forth while Vex sat in a chair.

"This is completely insane. You're going to try to break into the FBI base east of the city? This is completely insane!"

"You're right, Jason, this is completely insane." Said Nathaniel, "That is why it will be fun."

"It's not going to be easy." Said Rose in a serious tone.

"Probably not." Said Nathaniel and took his feet off the table.

"I have good news and bad news." Said Vex.

"Start with the bad news." Said Nathaniel and Vex continued as if he hadn't heard him.

"The good news is that they are moving the base now. It might be easier to get in and out. The bad news is that they are moving the base. If they move, the mission is over. The new building

is a skyscraper with state-of-the-art security systems. You're more likely to break into the current base than the skyscraper."

"How much more likely?"

"Your chances of breaking into the skyscraper and succeeding are roughly... Zero. Maybe minus one. But you have a two percent chance of breaking into the current base. Maybe."

"Consider it done, Vex." Said Nathaniel in a mocking tone.

"The base is surrounded by walls topped with barbed wire. There are watchtowers on all four corners. I'm guessing there are at least four or five people on guard in each tower. With the soldiers in the garden and inside the building, that's over fifty. And most importantly, they are not our enemies and they won't know it."

"If you can get past the men, there are three different buildings inside. Three buildings are connected at the back. One wrong move and all the soldiers could fly at you."

"Before we talk about the difficulties inside, let's talk about how to get in."

"I can cut the power for a few minutes so you can get in. All the soldiers would be blinded, especially those in the tower. unless they have something for night vision. If they do, it was nice meeting you guys."

"So we're going to try to get into a base that's almost impossible to get into. And then we're going to try to get out in an even more impossible situation." Said Rose. "What could go wrong?"

"Maybe we don't have to get out." Said Nathaniel, touched his head with his pointy finger. Everyone waited curiously for the rest of Nathaniel's words without making a sound. "Maybe we won't even have to go in! We'll steal the file while it is transported! Even better, we'll steal the vehicle with the file!" said Nathaniel and stood up

excitedly. He continued talking, not caring about his chair falling back.

“But first we have to distract them. Or attract them. We'll organize an attack on the base. Something too flashy, and then we'll rush them and hurry them up! We'll make them make the delivery earlier! We need a distraction... Like... an explosion! And some bullets! We'll scare them into rushing the move and we'll get the file we're looking for during the move. Of course, I'll need all of you for that.”

“I knew I suggest the right person for to be leadership.” Said Jason looking like he was so proud of himself. “Nathaniel, tell me what you need for the plan you have in mind. You'll have it in a few hours.”

Nathaniel thought for a moment as he walked to the window.

“Hmm... How many armored vehicles do you have? And a few men, of course.”

Nathaniel was looking out the window. His eyes were fixed on his father's company.

“Nate.” Jason called out. Nathaniel straightened up and took one last look at the darkening sky, then turned around.

“Is everyone ready?” he asked.

“They're on their way.” Jason said and put the computer he was holding on the table and turned it on. He turned the screen so that Nathaniel could see it. Nathaniel picked up his walkie-talkie and waited.

“We can start.” Jason said and Nathaniel brought the walkie-talkie closer to his face.

“Soldiers to the east, mobilize!”

At first, the night was dark and quiet, as it always was. Between the walls, soldiers were standing guard, changing their positions. Until the sound of cars coming from the east. The cars were moving fast, approaching the FBI base. The dust they passed over was lifted into the air and formed a cloud behind the vehicles. As the vehicles continued to approach the base, the lights from the two towers came on as if the sun was rising. The light fell on the vehicles coming towards the base.

“You have entered FBI territory! If you do not turn around, we will open fire!” a voice shouted from loudspeakers throughout the building. The vehicles kept driving anyway.

“Westerners, take action!” Nathaniel ordered over the radio. Just as on the east side of the building, vehicles appeared in the west. They quickly approached the building. Lights also appeared on these vehicles.

“This is the last warning! Turn your vehicles back! Or we will open fire!” the voice from the loudspeakers announced. In response, the windows of the vehicles opened. They extended their guns out of the windows and started firing at the wall.

“North and South troops, you're next. Remember, no hitting the building!” Nathaniel said, squinting at his computer screen.

One of the men in the center and one step ahead of the others nodded as they moved through the trees. Together with the men beside him, they slowly moved away from each other while moving forward. When they came to a clearing between the trees, they put the big guns on their shoulders. The man in front aimed and fired his grenade launcher. The small bomb traveled quickly, landed near the wall, and exploded with a loud, deafening bang. As the same sounds came from both sides, the soldiers inside the building split in two. They moved cautiously in two different directions. As soon as the

men in the tower gave the last warning, the explosions went off and they went straight to the attack.

From the open part of the tower, the agents aimed their bazookas at the cars below. They aimed and fired at the car on which the light shone.

As soon as the man in the car with the white light shining on him saw the rocket speeding towards him, he opened the car door and jumped out. At the last moment, he stepped aside to avoid being run over by a passing car and survived. One of the other exploding vehicles flipped upside down in mid-air and fell to the ground. Another tipped over on its side.

“Vex lights.” Nathaniel continued to watch the screen. The lights were still on. “Vex!” shouted Nathaniel. “We need the lights to go out!”

“I’m trying!” Vex protested, not taking his gaze off the computer. He was sitting across from Nathaniel.

FBI agents came out of the building to find the men attacking from the north and south. They scattered through the forest and moved quickly. And the lights went out.

“Great job, Vex! Saviors, hurry! Northern and Southern troops return to your vehicles! Your turn!” Nathaniel shouted. In the darkened tower, the engines roared as the FBI agents continued to shoot the vehicles with their headlights on. It was barely audible over the explosions, but it grew louder and louder. On both sides, men on black motorcycles lifted the fronts of their bikes and sped forward, braking sharply. Those who had jumped out of their vehicles got in the back and then quickly returned. Both sides quickly executed this plan. And the lights came back on. But all the FBI agents saw was the junk of exploded cars.

“Good job, everyone!” Nathaniel exclaimed excitedly. “All that’s left is to steal the file.” Vex smiled and nodded.

“Well done, son. Well done.”

Before the sun had risen, Vex shook Nathaniel, who was sleeping on a chair. Flinched, Nathaniel woke up and grabbed his trench coat at the last moment before it fell to the floor. He looked up at Vex standing over him.

“FBI is on its way. The ninth one has the files.”

Nathaniel turned his gaze back to his team. Rose was lying with her head in her arms on the table. Scatt was asleep in a chair, as was Nathaniel. He closed his eyes tightly and opened them. He swung his trench coat over his back, quickly put on his sleeves, and clapped his hands together.

“Let's go.” Nathaniel said as he turned his head towards Vex who was standing to his left. When he heard no sound from his team, he turned around. They were both still asleep. “Come on!” Nathaniel protested.

Nathaniel woke everyone up one by one. As soon as everyone was awake, they left the library. Outside the door Fred was waiting for them, leaning against the car. Everyone got into the vehicle and they set off.

Black armored vehicles drove between tall buildings. All fourteen vehicles were driving with their backs to the newborn sun.

“Get ready, the vehicles are coming your way. You don't have much time. You have to set everything right.” Nathaniel said over the radio. Jason started the car and stepped on the gas.

When the first armored vehicle passed him, he took a deep breath and pressed harder on the gas.

“The first vehicle passed. The second vehicle passed. The third vehicle passed...” Scatt started counting. Jason's Hands gripped the steering wheel of the car tightly. He looked out the window. The red car was speeding towards him. Black cars were passing between them. Jason's breathing began to quicken as the cars got closer together. He could hear his heartbeat getting louder.

Scatt yelled over the radio, “Car nine! Now! Now!” Jason squinted his eyes and moved toward the red car. He took his foot off the gas and turned his head to the side. He started to brake lightly.

As the red car passed Jason's car with a sudden movement and braked, Jason tried to do the same. The only difference was that it did not stop with the brakes, but with a big quake, hitting the lamppost. Jason looked up. He could clearly see the lamppost through the shattered pine into the bonnet of the car. Jason unbuckled his seatbelt. After wiping his bloody nose with the back of his hand, he staggered out of the car and looked at the front of the car

Rose got out of the red car in front of him.

“Watch where you're going! You almost hit my car!”

“Me?” Jason asked angrily, “You were driving the wrong way!”

As Rose and Jason's drama continued, the armored car braked to avoid hitting one of the two vehicles changed direction, and turned left on command.

“Good job!” Nathaniel radioed. He crossed his arms and looked at the screen in front of Scatt.

To catch up with the armored vehicles ahead, those behind were to take the first right turn. “Your turn, Vex,” Scatt said with a smile.

The vehicles came to the intersection and the first vehicle turned right. Before anyone could realize what was happening, the

speeding truck slowed down and entered between the first and second vehicles. It blocked the road completely. Vex got out of the truck and opened the hood. Smoke was rising.

“You god damned! Come on, you have to work! We’ve got a long way to go to Medford!” said Vex, wearing a red plaid shirt, trying to fix his truck loaded with wood.

“Now it’s your turn.” Scatt said over the radio. Nathaniel took a deep breath as he stood in front of the wall. He reached for his flask and took a sip. He put on his mask, nodding to the men standing behind him. The other five men behind him put on their masks, as Nathaniel did. They moved toward the vehicle that was standing a few meters away from the wooden truck. Further down the road behind the woodcutter, armored vehicles were coming forward. Seeing Nathaniel and those behind him in the rearview mirror, the agent signaled to those sitting next to him and they got out of the vehicle. Just as they reached for their weapons, Nathaniel and his men pointed their guns at them. The FBI agents gave up their weapons and raised their hands. Nathaniel signaled as he extended his guns to the back of the vehicle. Two men opened the doors and one of them pointed his gun at the back of the vehicle with Nathaniel.

Just as the doors opened, the sound of gunfire and Nathaniel cursing in pain were heard almost simultaneously. As his gun fell from his hand, FBI agents got out of other vehicles and surrounded him. The other men dropped their weapons.

“You are under arrest!” said the man in the suit. He looked to be in his forties with graying hair. He was the one who shot Nathaniel in the hand.

“Sorry sir, but not today!” Nathaniel smiled and opened his trench coat to the both sides. Although he couldn’t see what his men were doing, he was sure they were doing exactly what he was doing. All the agents could clearly see the bombs strapped to their bodies. “Do you know how many civilians live on this street?” Nathaniel knew the FBI agent would be silent. “That’s what I thought. All we want is the

files in this vehicle. Let us take it and let us go. No one has to die.” Said Nathaniel. At a signal from the man in the suit, the agents lowered their weapons. Two of his men opened the doors of the vehicle wider. Inside there was nothing but agents pointing guns at those who opened the door. “There should be a file here somewhere.”

“After your attack yesterday, I decided not to put files in the vehicles.” Said the man in the suit with a dirty smile on his face.

“Alright, now we will leave safely. Unless you want everyone who lives around here to explode. If one of us gets shot...” Nathaniel looked down at his bullet-riddled hand and grimaced, remembering the pain all over again. “One more shot and this place will blow! Your agents and you and hundreds of civilians! I hope I made myself clear.”

“Yes.” The man in the suit said through gritted teeth. Nathaniel and his five companions walked with heavy steps towards the shutter on their left. One by one they moved forward. With each step they kept looking around them. When they reached the door, two men began to close the shutter. As the shutter closed, the commander of the agents saw Nathaniel and three of his men removing their bombs. And the shutter closed completely.

“Surround that building! Now that they got rid of the bombs, we've got them! You open the damn shutter!” he roared angrily. The two agents quickly raised the shutter. The gray-haired dignitary entered first and his soldiers followed him, filling the interior. To one side of the garage stood a black vehicle that looked like an FBI armored car. It was exactly the same. On the other side of the garage was a door and bombs stacked in front of the door. The commander pointed at the bombs with the tip of his gun. The two agents approached the bombs cautiously for a while.

“You!” the commander said, pointing at a group of soldiers with the tip of his gun. “You surround the vehicle! The rest of you, I want a complete search of this building!” The soldiers followed orders. They surrounded the vehicle within seconds and two men

opened the door. As the doors opened, the lights lined up on the ceiling flashed. They instantly reached a blinding level. The agents could not see their surroundings and kept their eyes closed as they burned with pain. Soon the bulbs exploded noisily, one by one. The lights went out. Sunlight illuminated the interior.

“What are you still waiting for?” said the commander, spewing all his anger “Didn't I tell you to open the doors of the vehicle? And you upstairs! Come on, don't dawdle!” while the two soldiers standing closest to the rear door of the vehicle opened the half-opened doors fully, wide open. Everyone around the vehicle pointed their guns inside. It was empty. The commander slammed the door of the vehicle in anger and pulled out his walkie-talkie.

“What's your status?”

“First floor clear, sir.”

“Second floor clear, sir.”

“Third floor clear, sir. We've lost them.”

“Can't you guys do anything? They can't have gotten far! Stop the traffic in the city! Set up a three-kilometer-wide perimeter here! If a fly passes through the designated area, I'll know! And someone get me that woodsman! Go!” The agents rushed out of the garage and dispersed. Shortly afterward, men came down from upstairs to carry out the new order.

General Christian Sharp was sitting at his desk, reviewing the paperwork for the files to be moved. But he was distracted by the sound of footsteps coming from the corridor beyond his door. He couldn't focus on anything. Frowning, he tried to look for the source of the noise. Suddenly his door opened and a man entered, panting.

“Sir,” he said in a clipped greeting. “I apologize for disturbing you and entering your room without permission, but we

have an emergency. Our base is under attack!” Christian's eyes widened, he quickly stood up from his desk and hurried out into the corridor. The soldier was now trying to keep up with the general.

Christian walked past the agents sitting at their computers and came to the wall with the giant screen. Then, with a few quick steps, he walked over to the man sitting closest to him at the computer.

“What's the problem?”

“Sir, a group of vehicles are rapidly approaching us. What are your orders sir?”

“Hmmm... This is really interesting. I wasn't expecting company. For now, just place a small unit at the entrance and follow procedure,” Christian said, waving his hand dismissively. “The rest of you get back to your duties. But stay alert. You could become reinforcements at any moment.” Christian leaned closer to the screen and began to think. “What are you up to?” he asked curiously.

“Sir, we've got vehicles approaching us from the west side!” said another man standing in front of the computer.

“Stick to procedure! Give the second warning!”

“Sir, they're opening fire!”

Christian made a swift move to grab the radio of the man in front of him. Frowning angrily, he shouted.

“Shoot those damn vehicles! Wreck them!” Christian said and handed the walkie-talkie to his agent as if he had hit him in the chest. “I want to see all the cameras on all four sides on the main screen! Now!” said Christian and focused on the huge screen on the wall. On two of the four split screens, the cars approaching the base were clearly visible. Until one of the bullets hit the camera. For a while, the screen appeared tingling. The one of the agents in charge of the camera projected another camera facing in the same direction.

With the sound of explosions, the bottom two camera images showed flames rising. The bright flames rose with the explosion for a moment and then quickly died out. But the explosions did not stop.

“Send troops to the northern and southern fronts! Get those damn attackers! Magnify the image of the eastern front!” Christian ordered. As the image grew, the clearest thing to be seen was the car in the foreground, which exploded and flipped over. For a brief moment, a small smile appeared on Christian's face. Suddenly the lights went out and Christian cursed with all the rage he could summon.

“Somebody turn on the damn lights! Hurry up! If you can't open the lights you will be all get fired you useless bastards!” he shouted. At the sound of his harsh voice, the men who were working on the computer became even more frantic. They ran their fingers faster across the keyboard. Christian started rubbing his temples with his thumb and forefinger.

When the lights came back on, Christian took a deep breath. He looked around as if seeing it for the first time. The explosions had stopped. The sound of cars too. The light reflected by the towers shone in all directions, but they couldn't see any intact vehicles. The vehicles that could be seen were all scattered, having exploded and drowned in flames.

“They knew they couldn't get in. And they wanted to intimidate us.”

“Sir, should I send a team after them?”

“Send a unit to the vehicles. I don't think we'll catch them, but send a unit in the direction of the vehicles. This time with vehicles. Let's see what they can find.”

“Any other orders, sir?”

Christian narrowed his eyes and leaned against the table behind him. He crossed his arms. He thought without paying any

attention to the soldier waiting for his orders. "Delivery!" he said excitedly, waving his index finger. "Their aim is to prevent the delivery or they are after the delivery themselves. Do you know what we will do, soldier? All the documents and files loaded into the vehicles... Unload everything inside the vehicles. And make the delivery early. We'll leave at sunrise."

"Are we sending the vehicles empty, sir?"

"What? No, no. They'll be full of soldiers. Put ten men in the first and last vehicles. I think the rest of the vehicles will be enough for five men, including the driver. And this stays between us for now. We'll make it look like we loaded the vehicles into the system. If they can cut our light, they can get into our system. In fact, make it a little easier to access the system from the outside. Only for these vehicles, of course."

"Yes, sir!" said the agent standing next to Christian and quickly disappeared. Christian looked at his agents for a while and then returned to his room. After filling out the unfinished paperwork, he closed his eyes in his chair and fell into a light sleep.

The disturbing sound of the alarm woke Christian up. The sun had not yet risen, but its light was slowly illuminating the horizon. Christian stood up and straightened his tie and hair. He picked up the gun on his desk and his badge, which looked like a wallet. He left his room and walked down the corridor. Every soldier he passed gave him a military salute and quickened his pace.

When he reached the vehicles, the agents were waiting for Commander Christian. When they saw him, they lined up side by side.

"All hands on deck!" Christian said and the soldiers got into the vehicles. Christian got into the armored vehicle closest to the exit of the garage. The soldier next to him opened his computer and put it on his lap. The back doors of the vehicle closed and the vehicle started to rock. The armored vehicles got out one by one.

Christian was looking around with his eyes wide open. And on the right side of the road he saw the vehicle trying to move from the opposite lane. "Here we go." He said quietly as the vehicle he was in moved forward. "Turn on the cameras in the vehicles." He said to the agent standing next to him. After a short while, small frames began to appear on the computer screen. "Play them in order. Start with the third vehicle." They started checking the cameras of all the vehicles in turn.

"Sir..." said a scratchy voice on the radio. "We have a problem."

"Which vehicle are you in?"

"Nine, sir." Christian pointed to the screen with the finger holding the radio and the agent at the computer switched from the camera of car seven to nine. There were two crashed cars in front of the camera.

"A car accident? Seriously? What's next, a blind man trying to cross the street?" Christian brought the radio closer to his mouth. "We're dealing with rookies, guys. But we're still gonna play their game. Turn left. Turn right at the first break and try to catch up with us." He pulled the radio away from his face. "Turn on the camera on the tenth vehicle. Their target is most likely the ninth vehicle." He picked up the radio again "All vehicles that do not deviate from the first route will take the shortest route to the rear."

The tenth vehicle continued straight for a while and then reached the first fork in the road. The ninth vehicle passed. The horn of the tenth vehicle was heard. It had to stop because of a truck that suddenly appeared in front of it.

"A wood truck? What a scam! Stop number nine. Something's wrong." He said sarcastically. "Wait for the fish to approach the bait. We're on our way to you. "

"Understood, sir."

“Good! Hurry up, we have to catch up with them!”

The ninth vehicle was standing outside. The two front doors were open and the soldiers stood with their hands raised in front of the men who were pointing guns at them. “Now, everybody out of the vehicle!” Christian said and got out, pistol drawn. He walked sideways, stepping sideways. He saw the man in the mask and trench coat shouting orders. He closed one eye, took aim and pulled the trigger. The man in the trench coat cursed and dropped the gun.

Christian's men from both sides of the street surrounded Nathaniel and his men and pointed their guns at them. Christian slowed his pace and walked towards Nathaniel.

“You are under arrest!” Christian said with a warm smile.

“Sorry, sir, but not today!” said Nathaniel. He grabbed his trench coat by both sides and opened it. His men did the same with their jackets. bombs were strapped to them with different wires. Christian frowned. “Do you know how many civilians live on this street?” All the FBI agents, including Christian, were speechless. “That's what I thought. All we want is the files in this vehicle. Let us take it and let us go. No one has to die.” As the FBI agents slowly lowered their weapons at Christian's gesture, Nathaniel's two men opened the doors at the rear of the vehicle wide. Inside, two armed agents were waiting for the men who had opened the door. “There should be a file here.” Nathaniel said as he squinted his eyes and looked all the way around the back of the armored vehicle.

“After yesterday's attack, I decided not to put files in the vehicles.” Christian said confidently.

“All right, now we're going to get there safely. Unless you want everyone who lives around here to explode. If one of us gets shot...” Nathaniel grimaced as he remembered the pain in his hand once more. “If you shoot again, this place will blow up! Your men, you and hundreds of civilians! I hope I made myself clear.”

“Yes.” Said Christian. Gritting his teeth in anger. Nathaniel and the five men with him moved with heavy steps towards the unblocked garage on the left. Christian looked angrily at the men in front of him. Every now and then they would turn back to look at him, making sure they wouldn't be shot. When they reached the door, the two men began to close the shutter. As the shutter closed, Christian saw Nathaniel and three of his men remove their bombs. And the shutter closed completely.

“Surround that building! Now that they've survived the bombs, we've got them! You open the damn shutter!” Christian roared angrily. The two agents quickly raised the shutter. The gray-haired dignitary entered first and his soldiers followed him, filling the interior. To one side of the garage stood a black vehicle that looked like an FBI armored car. It was exactly the same. On the other side of the garage was a door and bombs stacked in front of the door. The commander pointed at the bombs with the tip of his gun. The two agents approached the bombs cautiously for a while.

“You!” the commander said, pointing at a group of soldiers with the tip of his gun. “You surround the vehicle! The rest of you, I want a complete search of this building!” The soldiers followed orders. They surrounded the vehicle within seconds and two men opened the door. As the doors opened, the lights lined up on the ceiling flashed. They instantly reached a blinding level. The agents could not see their surroundings and kept their eyes closed as they burned with pain. Soon the bulbs exploded one by one. The lights went out. Sunlight illuminated the interior.

“What are you still doing?” the commander said, spewing all his anger, “Didn't I tell you to open the doors of the vehicle? And you upstairs! Come on, don't dawdle!” while the two soldiers standing closest to the rear door of the vehicle opened the half-opened doors fully, wide open. Everyone around the vehicle pointed their guns inside. Inside the empty vehicle. The commander slammed the door of the vehicle in anger and pulled out his walkie-talkie.

“What's your status?”

“First floor clear, sir.”

“Second floor clear, sir.”

“Third floor clear, sir. We've lost them.”

“Can't you guys do anything? He can't have gotten far! Stop the traffic in the city! Set up a three-kilometer-wide perimeter here! If a fly passes through the designated area, I'll know! And someone get me that woodcutter! Go!” The agents rushed out of the garage and dispersed. Shortly afterwards, the men who had come down from upstairs carried out the new order.

CHAPTER NINE

Axe in Solomon's hand rose. He brought it down quickly as Rodrin closed his eyes tightly. The axe broke the chains on Rodrin's hands. Solomon stood up without waiting. He straightened his hand holding the axe handle and turned full circle to strike the axe into the neck of one of the guards. As the second guard, seeing blood spurting from his friend, thrust his spear forward, Rodrin grabbed it and pushed him away. They both held the spear tightly. They tugged and pushed each other. Solomon broke the chains on the arms of two others. He was straightening the one on the ground when one of the kneeling men wiped away his tears and shook his head from side to side. Solomon let go of the dead.

Rodrin headbutted the man holding the spear. He dropped the spear involuntarily as blood spurted from the man's nose. He took a few steps back and slammed his back against the wall. Rodrin nailed him to the wall with his spear. He saw another guard running at him. He threw the spear with all his might. The spear knocked the guard off his feet. Rodrin came to the guard and pulled the spear from

the body. "Take their spears!" he said commandingly. The other two prisoners did as the prince said and took up their weapons.

Hearing the voices, the guards poured in through the cave entrance. Most of them were holding pointed spears. So did the men with Solomon. Solomon had an axe in his hand. The number of sentries was growing. The glowing points of the spears were too many to count.

"We won't get out of here alive!" said one of the men.

"We can find a way out back." "What do you say, master?" said Rodrin.

Solomon paused briefly, raising an eyebrow when he realized Rodrin was addressing him. When he remembered what kind of situation they were in, he pulled himself together. He turned his gaze to him. "Lead the way, Prince Rodrin! Lead the way!" Rodrin began to run deeper into the cave. Solomon and the others followed the Prince.

The cave seemed to have no end, like the mouth of a monster. Pointed stalactites stretched down from the ceiling. A liquid dripped from the end. Where it fell, a small puddle had formed. Solomon stepped on the puddle. He kept running, splashing water around. From behind, the light of torches illuminated the stone walls of the cave. The voices of the guards echoed inside.

There was no light except the torches of those following behind them. As they ran, they tried to take every step carefully. They stopped when the cave split into two roads.

"Which way?"

Rodrin thought for a moment. He looked both ways.

"To the left." He said and they kept running. When the guards arrived in front of the cave, they split in two and scattered in different directions.

At the last moment, they noticed the wall of the cave and stopped. They felt the wall with their hands because their eyes were blind. They were completely surrounded. The cave slowly lit up. The guards were approaching.

"Where is the exit door?" asked Solomon.

"You will open the door, Master."

"How?" Solomon asked, then turned his head to the only way out.

"How? With magic, of course!"

"But I don't know how to use it!"

"Then you'd better try to find a way." Said Rodrin and stepped in front of Solomon with his other two friends. "We'll try to hold them off until you find a way out."

Solomon put his hands on the wall. He didn't know what to do. He was trying everything he could think of.

"Give me an exit!" nothing happened. "Open up!" again nothing happened.

Rodrin tore his gaze away from Solomon and turned to the men on either side of him.

"It was an honor to fight alongside you, my friends."

Before the men could answer, the guards attacked. The battle began. The tips of spears clashed against each other. The wooden parts crackled. The men were in constant motion.

Solomon took his hands off the wall and looked at the battle raging behind him. He girded his axe and twirled it around his hand. He threw it swiftly. It struck one of the guards. Rodrin pulled the axe out of the guard across from him. The other man leapt into the air and swung his spear at Rodrin. Rodrin stepped to the side and brought his

axe down in the center of the spear. The man with the broken spear stepped back, took a step forward and thrust his spear.

Solomon watched Rodrin kill the man and then realized he had to get back to his own task. He turned to the wall. He put his hands against the wall. He closed his eyes. He began to hear the sound of water drops running down the stalactites. He did not hear the sound of the spears or the shouts of the men. All he heard was the sound of the drops.

Solomon took a step backward. He threw his head back with his hands facing forward. He could feel the power moving from his chest to his hands. The cave began to tremble. Some large rocks tumbled down. Cracks were heard from the stalactites. The guards raised their heads and stared at the cracks in the ceiling. They backed away from the pebbles and dust that fell on them. Rodrin and his men had done the same. They had retreated to Solomon's side.

Solomon gritted his teeth as the rocks on the stone wall in front of him moved one by one. His hands trembled as the rocks moved back. And made way for Solomon. Rodrin smiled and nodded.

"I knew you could do it, master." He said. This time it was Solomon who took the lead. Seeing the prisoners escape, the guards rushed forward. But the stalactites raining down on them would not let them. When a stalactite several feet in size fell on one of them, the others decided to retreat.

Solomon was very happy to be back on the green. He looked at his ring with joy. And then at the cave that had opened. The rocks that had been scattered on either side of where they had come out moved again and settled back into their original positions. Solomon turned to Rodrin and saw one of the men trying to wrap a worn cloth around his shoulder. He went over to them.

"May I..." Solomon didn't know exactly what to say, but Rodrin and the others understood. Solomon put his ringed hand on the shoulder of the man sitting on a rock. He closed his eyes. He

breathed in and out deeply. Then he opened his eyes. The wound was still the same.

"I am sorry."

"At least you tried, Master Solomon. And thank you for saving us."

"Something told me it was the right thing to do. Why did they take you prisoner? Tell me so I can be sure my decision was the right one."

Rodrin finished bandaging the man's wound, stood up, and lifted him from the rock where he had been sitting.

"You can be sure we will tell you everything on the way, Master Solomon. But we must be on our way. They may be coming after us."

They walked through the trees. They walked, occasionally looking back.

"My father, Orin, went to the old palace, the palace by the shore, a few months ago. And he didn't return for a long time. So we set out to find him. We found him in the palace... We found him on his throne... You saw him. The only way to free him was to save the kingdom, at least part of it. And we went to Edwak's tribe for help. It turns out that Edwak has no difference from the creatures we fought." Said Rodrin. Then he lifted his head. He saw the sunlight through the branches growing dimmer and dimmer. Because Solomon had the Ring and the power, Rodrin knew what had happened to his father. He wiped a tear from his eye. They continued on their way.

Solomon stopped when he could not see in the darkness of the night.

"It would be nice to find a place to spend the night."

"You are right, master Solomon." Said the big man with the injured shoulder. He stroked his long beard. "We should make camp."

“Very well. Let's find something to burn.” Said Solomon, “But before that, let me say this. We fought shoulder to shoulder, so stop using that 'Master'. It goes for all of you.”

“It's an honor, Master Solom... I mean Solomon.”

The red fire illuminated the faces of all four. Solomon, like the others, held his hands to the fire, trying to warm himself. For a long time, no one spoke. There was no sound but the howling of wolves and the crackling of the branches as the fire burned. Finally, the weaker of the men decided to break the silence.

“Solomon, where do you come from? From which kingdom?”

“From Israel. David's kingdom. You've probably never heard of him before.” When Solomon received nods of agreement, he continued. “I come from a different world, at least that's what Orin told me.”

“And your world... What is your world like?”

Solomon looked around. “Not very different, actually. Where I come from, a man cannot move rocks with his hands. In other words, there is no magic. Other than that, not much difference. I will solve your problem, save your kingdom, and try to return home, but I need to know how. I need to make sure my father is alive. Orin brought me here, to this world, in the middle of a war at sea.”

“I'm sure he's fine. After all, he was of sacred blood. At least he interceded.”

“I hope you're right,” Solomon sighed. “Rodrin, can you tell me about these creatures we're going to fight?” To change the subject.

“Sure.” Said Rodrin as he looked at Solomon with dancing fiery eyes. “First, Solomon, you need to know that there are two kinds of magic. Two spells that represent Darkness and Light. Two spells,

one for destruction and one for creation. Of course, both can be used for the opposite.

“Every magic has a world where it is believed to be born. Our world represents the light. We believe that the magic of light is born first in this world and then spreads a little bit to other worlds. And in the same way, there is another world where it is believed that darkness is born.

“In every world, there is a representative. And the representative of our world is my father... I mean, it was my father.” Rodrin's throat tightened for a moment. “According to my father, when he went to the tower in that kingdom, he was chosen by the power to be the representative of magic. He could do incredible things. And he vowed to use that power only for good. My father was as fair and tolerant as he could be and the kingdom lived in great peace. Until the creatures came.” As he said the last sentence, Rodrin's eyes locked on the fire again. He remembered everything he had experienced. It all came alive before his eyes. “It all started a few years ago.”

“My father woke me up one day in a great hurry. For a while, in the stupor of sleep, I didn't understand anything he was saying. My father must have realized this too, because he grabbed me by the shoulders and shook me. When I awoke, he let go of me and said in the most serious voice I had ever heard, 'Son! We have a serious problem! We have to prepare the army! Hurry up! He is coming! He was pacing back and forth in my room. Of course, at that time I had no idea who my father was talking about. In fact, no one knew him except my father.

“Who's coming?” I asked. I saw the fear in his eyes when he turned to face me. I was sure nothing could scare my father. Until then. 'The representative of darkness!' my father said in fear. I still had no idea who he was, but seeing him like that was enough for me.

“We gathered all our armies. We took the armies of the other kingdoms. When my father explained the danger we were in, all the

kings agreed to unite their armies without opposition. And we went to war.

“The darkness spread like an epidemic. Plants died, and the sky darkened. Everyone who touched the emissary's hand became a creature. literally. They became hideous creatures with fangs and long claws. They attacked villages and kingdoms. They killed indiscriminately.

“And we lost the war. My father tried to take back his lost soldiers and turn them back into humans but without much success. And slowly our world fell into darkness.

“The representative of the darkness sent a different man to each kingdom. Our kingdom is under the rule of a creature called Grimor. If you destroy Grimor, you will save our kingdom. And if you destroy the emissary, you will save not only our kingdom but the whole world.

Solomon raised his head in disquiet.

“I don't have the power to defeat the emissary.”

“Now first.” Said Rodrin. “Every territory you clear of the carnation will increase your power.” With a deep sigh, Rodrin stood up. He shook off the dust. He turned away so no one could see his watery eyes. “We'd better go to sleep. I'll take the first watch. Windsor, you take the second watch. Azderson...”

“I have the third one. You got it.”

“Then that leaves me with the fourth.” Said Solomon. No one disobeyed him.

When the sun rises and begins to light up the forest, they leave the extinguished fire. They walked through the forest until the sun was just overhead, peeking through the leaves of the trees. After a while, when the trees were gone, they came to the beach. A mixture of green and gray, washed by the hideous waves of the sea. At the end of the

sea, Rodrin pointed to the ruins visible on the horizon. A rampart, partly destroyed, with ruins not clearly visible behind it, and the palace, half of it obviously destroyed, stretching towards the sky. The only thing intact was the tower rising on the left side of the palace. The sturdy tower rising in a sky of gray and red.

“The Kingdom of Destiny.” Said Rodrin.

“Orin told me about a tower.”

“The tower in the south of the kingdom. It is the first place where my father possessed magic.” whispered “To get there, we must first cross the sea. Edwak has commandeered our ship, so either we build a new one or...”

“I'm going to get you across somehow, so let's see if I can split the sea in two and we can go through it, or maybe I can make us all fly like birds,” Solomon said, and he walked to the edge of the sea where water soaked the sand!”

Solomon put his hands out in front of him like in the cave. He closed his eyes. He tried to focus on the sound of the water lapping on the beach. After a long silence, the only sound he heard was “Close your hand.” The voice whispered. Solomon did as the voice said, trying to stay calm. He closed his hand and opened his eyes. Suddenly his closed hand glowed as if holding a blue flame. He opened his hand to see the source of the light rising from his palm. The light quickly went out. Now there was only a small piece of ice in his hand. He smiled, trying to hide his excitement. “Wisdom comes from my power.” He said with a grin.

“Throw it!” the voice whispered this time. “Throw the ice into the sea!” Solomon listened to the whisper echoing in his mind and did as he was told. He threw the piece of ice into the sea. “Repeat!” the voice said, and began to speak words in a voice Solomon had never heard before. Solomon repeated the words one by one. Suddenly a light shot up from the bottom of the water. The water

began to crackle. The crackling grew longer and wider until it formed a thin path to the kingdom.

No one could believe what they were seeing except Rodrin. As the Sorcerer's son, Rodrin was not surprised by what he saw. But he was elated. He walked over to Solomon with a smile. "You are getting better and better at this. But I still wondered what it would feel like to fly."

"Maybe someday," Solomon said. With a nonchalant expression. "After you, Rodrin. Someone needs to guide this Sorcerer."

They walked single file along the icy path. Sometimes the rising waves splashed on the ice and soaked their clothes. In strong waves, they lost their balance and saved themselves from falling at the last moment. Solomon the Sorcerer stopped when he saw the fin above the sea. The long fin diving in and out from far away was huge. And it was swimming swiftly towards the ice path. Solomon looked again to make sure. And the fin sank into the water. Solomon looked for a while longer at where the fin had sunk into the water and then continued on.

Solomon kept walking, looking both ways. As he neared the shore of the Kingdom of Destiny, he saw blackness in the gray sea. A fast-moving shadow. The closer he got, the bigger it grew.

"There they are! Get them!" voices shouted from behind them. Everyone instantly turned around to look at the shouting man. Edwak and his men were on the ice road, coming towards them. At first, the men stepped on the ice in fear, but when they saw that nothing happened, they started to run on it.

"Run!" shouted Solomon. He started to run after Rodrin.

The army behind them was slowly closing the gap. They had not even reached the coast of the kingdom.

The biggest of Rodrin's men, Windsor, was only a few paces in front of him and he was tired. He was out of breath. He had slowed his pace a little when he remembered the army behind him. And he tried to keep going. The others, realizing Windsor had fallen behind, slowed their pace and stopped.

"Go ahead." Windsor said. "I will hold them off."

Solomon looked at Edwak and his soldiers.

"We left no one behind!"

Both men pointed their spears at each other. Rodrin handed Solomon the axe from his belt.

"It was an honor to meet you."

Solomon took the axe from Rodrin's hand. Twirling it, he said, "It's not over yet. We will fight!"

Rodrin smiled desperately. "We will, but we can not win."

Edwak laughed and stepped in front of his soldiers.

"Only four prisoners against all the warriors of my tribe? You are dead!" Edwak drew his sword. "Attack!"

CHAPTER TEN

Vex was standing in his usual place at the door as Nathaniel and the five men with him climbed the steps of the library. Nathaniel was walking up the steps one by one with his head bowed. As he passed Vex, he said, "It's a good thing we listened to you and took your soldier clothes. Otherwise, we'd be in jail. Or dead."

"I guess the mission didn't go so well."

"The man in charge... He only put men in the vehicles. "

Vex put his hand on Nathaniel's shoulder, "Don't worry, son. We'll figure it out." He said.

"I hope so, vex. I hope so. I don't know how you came here that fast but I am grateful you weren't caught."

"I guess I am just lucky." Vex said. unconsciously putting his hand on his chest Nathaniel raised his hand as if he just remembered. The blood had dried from his hand, but the wound was still fresh.

“There must be someone in the Library who can take care of this, right?”

“Oh God!” Vex said in alarm. “What are you still doing here?” Vex pushed Nathaniel off his back and into the library. He forced him to walk with quick steps. He walked forward, looking around. They walked between the shelves, trying not to attract anyone's attention. As soon as they reached the elevator, Vex put Nathaniel in and got in himself. The elevator went down one floor. Vex continued to drag Nathaniel without slowing down. He entered through one of the doors in the hallway. Inside were white beds. And a few closets. It looked like a small budget hospital. “Come in, sit over there.” Vex said, pointing to one of the beds. Nathaniel went over to the bed while Vex went around opening cupboards and rummaging through drawers. When he found everything he was looking for, he sat down next to Nathaniel. “This could hurt.”

Nathaniel took his flask out of his inside pocket. And took a big gulp.

“This is not my first rodeo, Vex.”

When Vex had finished cleaning and bandaging the wound, he took one last look at his creation. And he nodded his head in agreement. Nathaniel stood up and looked at his bandaged hand. It was painful to move it. Just trying to keep it still, he left the room with Vex. They took the elevator. Vex made sure Nathaniel was okay until the elevator went to the next floor. When the elevator reached the ground floor, he got off. Nathaniel would get off to the third floor.

The elevator doors opened on both sides and Nathaniel stepped out. After a few steps through the shelves full of books, the desk in front of the window was revealed. Without getting up from her chair, Rose turned back in the direction of the footsteps. “Where have you been?” she asked with a mixture of alarm and anger.

“We didn't get the file and we had to run.” Nathaniel grimaced and raised his bandaged hand. “And then there's this.”

Nathaniel pulled up the chair next to Rose and sat down. She took a deep breath. "So, what do we do now? They must know what we're after. And who was that man?" Nathaniel held up his wrapped hand. "Sometimes I regret not wearing the gauntlet, maybe it would have slowed the bullet down a bit."

"That man..." Vex said, stepping out of the dark shelves, "Christian Sharp."

"You know how to make a good entrance, Vex." Said Nathaniel. "You really do."

"A soldier who joined the army at eighteen. The best soldier of the last twenty years."

"That's what they think because I didn't join the army."

"Nate, let Vex tell the stories."

Nathaniel sighed and gestured for him to continue.

"Thanks, Nathaniel." Vex said with a slight nod of his head. "Number one in the management of troops and the use of weapons," he held up his scarred hand for everyone to see. "There are even rumors about him. The kind of rumors you might call legends. He's now the head of the FBI in Washington state."

"He's also the asshole who shot my hand off." Nathaniel frowned and turned to Vex.

"And how do you know all this?"

"I did some research."

"I think we're facing a real threat. A strategic battle. My black queen against his white queen. It's a real..."

"You're over-dramatizing things, son." Said Vex and sat down in one of the chairs.

Rose squinted and stared at the shelves in front of her, thinking a way as all other members did. After a few minutes, her eyes widened and she jumped to her feet. Raising both hands, she signaled the others to stay at the table and started to run. She got into the elevator. No one could figure out where Rose had gone. They all stared at the shelves where Rose had disappeared.

Soon Rose came running out of the elevator. She was holding a piece of newspaper in her hand. Smiling, she walked over to the desk and threw it on the table.

“I saw this newspaper in the hands of the employee on the ground floor.”

“Walter...”

“His name isn't a distinguishing detail at the moment, Jason.”

“Let Rose tell ‘the stories’” Nathaniel said.

“What is the title of the news on the main page?” Rose asked, knowing the answer.

Scatt, frowning, was the first to read the news aloud.

“Mayor Mr. Dorson delivers his first speech“

“That's right. Dorson won the election a few days ago.” Rose said. She glanced excitedly at each of the people sitting at the table, hoping they got her plan.

“Rose, you're a genius!” said Nathaniel excitedly as he pulled the newspaper in front of him. “Even though I don't like Mr. Dorson, we need to visit him. We can use him to get the files we're looking for!”

“Please don't tell me you're planning to kidnap Mr. Dorson.” Said Jason with a sigh.

“We're going to kidnap the Mayor, Jason.” Nathaniel said smilingly.

“But... but this is sheer madness!” protested Jason. He shifted his gaze from the determined Nathaniel and Rose to Vex.

“As crazy as attacking an FBI base with a bunch of armored cars and grenade launchers, splitting the convoy of armored cars into three and robbing one of them?” Nathaniel asked with a small smile. Then he put on a serious expression again. “If you have a simpler plan, I'm all ears, because I can't think of any other way.” Jason shook his head from side to side with a grimace. “That's what I thought.”

Jason sighed and looked at the faces of everyone at the table in turn for a while. All were looking so convinced, Even Scatt was. “That's great! This is really great!” he muttered as he started walking towards the elevator. After everyone at the table had watched Jason leave, Nathaniel broke the silence that had surrounded the table.

“So how can we kidnap the mayor? Does anyone have any ideas?” he asked. He looked at each person, but no one spoke up. “That's going to make it a bit difficult.”

“I have to go, if you need me you know where to find me.” Said Vex and got up from his chair and disappeared into the shelves.

About ten minutes later Jason came out from the elevator. He was holding a bag. It was easy to see from the look on his face that he was still uneasy. Nevertheless, he came back and put the bag on the table, right in front of Nathaniel. Nathaniel opened the bag. There were two guns on two different sides, pointed at each other. In the center were neatly lined up what looked like small needle-like bullets.

“I'm still not in favor of what you're going to do, but you're going to do it with or without my help. So I would rather be a part of it.”

“The mayor will probably have bodyguards with him. You have to neutralize them. Once you hit them with these bullets, they won't wake up for a long time.”

Nathaniel nodded as if impressed. “Good job, Jason. Really.” Jason couldn't believe Nathaniel was complimenting him, “But these guns don't look good. Not like a pistol or a revolver, but more like... It looks like the first gun ever invented.” Said Nathaniel. “But I guess we have no choice.” He took a gun from the bag and handed it to Rose, who was sitting next to him, her arms crossed. “This time there will be three of us on the mission. Scatt, you'll be at the computer again. Rose and I will enter through the front door.” One by one, they took the arrow-like bullets from the bag and carefully loaded them into the gun. When they had loaded the gun until there was no more room in the magazine, Nathaniel pointed the gun to Jason, who was standing upright, and moved the gun, making a sound as if he were firing. He put the gun on the table. He removed his scabbarded revolver and held it out to Jason with both hands. “Take care of him.” Nathaniel said. Jason took the gun in one hand and seemed to be trying to figure out what it was. Nathaniel looked at the strange-looking weapon again with a grimace and sheathed it.

“You'll also need these.” Vex said. His voice was further than his appearance. He came forward from the way of the elevator and threw the body armor on the table.

“We mustn't forget this.” Said Nathaniel and put the flask from the inside pocket of his trench coat on the table. He could feel everyone staring at him. He uncapped his flask and took a sip, grimacing.

“I'll go see what I can find out about the mayor.” Jason said after rolling his eyes. And he left again.

Nathaniel waved his arm and looked at his watch. His watch was still not working. He took a deep breath and crossed his arms. When he saw Jason coming, he smiled and straightened his chair.

Jason pulled the chair opposite Nathaniel and sat down.

"The Mayor is at his home now. I hope you have a plan to kidnap him."

"Sort of." Said Nathaniel. "Can you call Alfred to come over here? And we need a vehicle to transport the mayor in comfort."

"We have all kinds of vehicles in the parking lot. I'll have Fred stop by the parking lot on his way."

"Thank you, Jason. You've been really helpful this time." Said Nathaniel. Jason smiled back.

As the sun set, it painted the area in a red light. As soon as Fred arrived, Nathaniel, Rose, and Scatt went to the exit of the library and got into the waiting car. Fred started to drive.

Nathaniel dragged open the black car door. He put his hand on his chest and felt the steel vest. Immediately after, Rose got out of the vehicle and disappeared between the villas with quick steps. Nathaniel closed the car door and moved more slowly than Rose.

"Two people are waiting at the gate of the garden. There are two waiting in front of the door of the house. Six in the garden. Three on the right and three on the left." Said Scatt over the radio.

"Let's get started," Nathaniel said after taking one last look at the vehicle he could barely see. He said, touching the uncomfortable earpiece in his ear. He took a sip from the flask he took out of his trench coat pocket and grimaced. Without putting his flask back, he started to move forward. He lowered his face to the ground and skewed his steps. He started walking as if he had lost his balance. He swayed left and right. His hands rose and fall by will. The guard on the right, the one close to Nathaniel, thought something

was wrong and reached for his gun, but he didn't draw it. He just stood at the ready. When Nathaniel took a few more steps, he said, "You're not allowed to come near here!" he said, holding out his other hand. But Nathaniel continued his drunkenness. The man took a few steps forward, quickly drew his gun and pointed it at Nathaniel. "I told you you're not allowed to come near here!" He said to Nathaniel, who was close to him. He put the gun to his head. It was clear that he could not see much in the darkness of the night. "Put your hands up. Show your face!"

"All right." Nathaniel said and slowly raised his hands. He raised his head slowly too.

A quiet groan came from the second guard. The man with the gun to Nathaniel's head turned around to see the man collapsed on the floor. Behind the collapsed man Rose was standing. Before the distracted man could even move, Nathaniel grabbed the gun resting against his forehead and quickly pulled it to the side. He grabbed the pistol from his belt and held it to the man's neck, taking it from the man's loosened fingers without any difficulty. Nate gripped him tightly by the knot in the man's tie. Without removing the gun from the man's neck or his hand from his tie, Nathaniel quickly pushed him into the garden.

Through the iron gates of the garden, Security stumbled backward and started to walk backward. Not letting his tie, Nathaniel was also walking behind him.. Rose was right behind Nathaniel.

A few meters from the front door of the house, Securities were already pointing their guns at Nathaniel, but they couldn't take aim. They kept moving their guns, trying not to shoot their friend. "We've got reinforcements coming in from both sides." Scatt said over the radio. Nathaniel pulled the trigger on his gun. He dropped the man's tie and quickly crouched down. He fired two shots. Both men collapsed in different directions. Nathaniel pointed his gun to the right side of the house to Rose, who came up behind him, and went the other way himself.

The moment Rose turned to the side, the fist exploded in her face. Staggering backward, dazed with pain, she dropped her gun. The security drew his. Rose kicked him in the hand to avoid being riddled with holes. Putting her raised foot down, she quickly ducked under him and punched him in the face with all her might to avenge his bloody nose. The man staggered back two steps and pulled his bloody nose. In a rage, he pounced on Rose. As Rose collapsed on her back in pain, she saw his gun lying next to her, she reached for it. quickly pointed the gun at the slumped man and fired. Security collapsed on top of him.

Nathaniel moved slowly towards the left side of the house with his gun pointed forward. He was breathing calmly. As soon as he turned from the wall of the house to the left side of the garden, the guard leaning against the wall quickly grabbed Nathaniel's gun. Nathaniel fired but missed. The guard pulled Nathaniel toward him and kicked him in the stomach. Nathaniel was thrown backward and fell on his back. Nathaniel saw the security toss the strange pistol to the side and, despite the pain in his stomach, Nathaniel lifted his back off the ground and drew his father's pistol, which he carried on the other side of his belt, and pointed it at the man. Reaching for the gun at his waist, the man froze.

"Don't move." Said Nathaniel in an ice-cold voice. He sat up slowly. The man took the opportunity to reach for his gun. Nathaniel took a quick step forward and held the man's gun level with his stomach. Security fired. Nathaniel's eyes widened. The man's hand relaxed, if only briefly. Nathaniel quickly pushed the gun aside and struck the man in the face with the butt of the gun. As the man collapsed, Nathaniel picked up his ugly gun from the ground. He shot the security guard in the neck with it. He looked at the bullet lodged in the belly of the body armor. And he continued.

Rose looked over the edge of the wall, saw the guard with his back turned, and stepped forward and fired. When the man passed out with his hand on his neck, the guard standing over him was exposed. The guard had already drawn his gun the moment his friend

started to fall. He was pointing it at Rose. Rose quickly jumped up to dodge the bullet. She put her back against the wall again and began to back away. From the left side of the garden, two guards came out in quick steps. They drew their guns. One of them bent down and looked at their fallen friend, while the other moved forward, holding his gun tightly. They walked cautiously in Rose's direction. Until one of them collapsed. The second man standing froze, staring at the security guard lying on the ground. In the white light of the moon, the small arrow stuck in his neck appeared. The man who had been checking on his friend crouched on the ground slowly got up and moved towards the man who had been shot from behind. Without taking his gaze and his gun away, he bent down to check his pulse and jumped to his feet, clinging to the wall. He kept his eyes on the corner. Nathaniel was waiting for him on the other side of the wall. He gripped his gun tightly.

The guard looked at the weapon gripped tightly in both hands. Then he released his lower hand. Slowly he reached for his earpiece.

“The Mayor's house...”

He hadn't even finished when Rose appeared in front of him and hit him full force on the shoulder of the arm holding the gun. As the gun flew sideways, the man pulled his hand away from his ear and charged at Rose. Rose held out her gun. The man took a quick step to the side, grabbed the armed hand and pulled it towards him. He slammed his fist into the center of Rose's face. she was thrown back, but he didn't let go of her arm. Rose squeezed the trigger. The bullet grazed his leg. Rose took a quick step in front of him, turned her back and put his arm over her shoulder. Gritting her teeth, she pulled the arm down. The crack of the arm was lost in the man's scream.

Nathaniel stood in the corner and waited. As soon as he saw the pistol, he sprang into action, grabbed the man by the hand, and pulled it towards himself. He quickly realized that it wasn't doing much good and dodged a punch to the face at the last moment. He

fired his pistol, accompanied by a scream from the other side of the garden. As the man collapsed, he ran towards the source of the scream. He turned at the base of the wall. He saw Rose holding her nose in pain, shooting the man in the neck.

Nathaniel ran to Rose and angrily grabbed her arm and dragged her towards the door of the house.

“If you shot him with a pistol, at least he could have died in peace.” Nathaniel said angrily as he continued to pull on Rose's arm. “We have to hurry. They must have heard the scream. We must get the Mayor now.”

Alexsander Dorson, Mr. Mayor, was asleep with his feet up in front of the TV. He had not finished beer bottle in his hand. He was wearing a bathrobe. His white undershirt was visible through the open collar of the robe. He was awakened by a horrible screaming sound and looked around. The sound had stopped. She put the glass bottle on the coffee table next to the sofa and took a remote control from the coffee table. He turned off the TV, put on his soft tights and left the living room with heavy steps. He had walked down the hallway and taken the first step on the stairs when there was a knock at the door. The Mayor sighed and went to the door without changing his pace. He was about to look through the binoculars when the bell rang. He looked through the hole in the door. Two people were standing in front of the door. One was a woman and the other a man. What caught the Mayor's attention the most was the gauntlet on the man's hand. He saw the small detail in the field of view of the binoculars. He was looking at his security guard lying on the floor. Frowning, he took a step back and rubbed his eyes. When he looked through the binoculars again, he realized what he had seen was real. Frightened, he started to lock the door. One of the men outside knocked on the door.

“Mr. Mayor, I suggest you come with us. If you make it difficult, you and your family could end up like your security guards.” Said Nathaniel and lifted one of the guards by the hair. The mayor could only see half of the head through the binoculars. He

closed his eyes and looked behind him. Then he looked back in front of him.

“All right, but promise me you won't do anything to my family.”

“Of course, all we want is you. And I have good news for you. We won't kill you or torture you. You'll just be our guests for a while. In the end, no one will get hurt.”

The Mayor carefully unlocked the locks on the door one by one. When he opened the last one, he turned the handle. the door opened heavily. Then he opened it all the way and stepped out. He looked fearfully at those standing before him. Then he turned his gaze to the guards lying on the ground. There was no blood on them.

“What... What did you do to them?” Mr. Mayor asked in a calm tone.

“Of course, we just neutralized them, just like...”

“Like what?”

Before the mayor could realize what had happened, Rose fired the ugly gun she was pointing at the mayor.

When the mayor awoke, he realized he had a headache, but he couldn't put his hand to hold it. His hands were tied behind a chair. At that moment he realized that he was in an old warehouse with big old worn walls. The dirty windows did not let the sunlight in. The only light inside was the old light bulb hanging on the wall. At that moment Mr. Mayor wanted to scream in fear. But with the cloth over his mouth, his screams could only be heard as mumbles. He stopped screaming when he saw the two masked coming into the warehouse. The two masks were walking side by side, and on the left hand of the male one was a glowing gauntlet covered with various embroideries. The mayor couldn't tell whether the gauntlet was emitting the light or reflecting the light reflected on it. Their kidnappers were now wearing masks. Mr. Mayor tried to remember his kidnappers, but he

could not remember them at all. As they got closer, the mayor closed his eyes and turned his head to the side in fear.

“Don't worry,” she said. “We just want something to get from the FBI. If they give it to us, nothing will happen to you.”

The mayor opened his mouth to ask realizing the piece of cloth tied over his mouth he shut up.

“Until then, how about a chat? For example, how did you get elected mayor even there was Mr. Philip was an opponent? I don't understand it.” Said Nathaniel. Mr. Mayor looked at Nathaniel with a frown. He waited for a while. Then he said something, but it was hard to make out because of the cloth covering his mouth. Nathaniel glanced at Rose and pulled the piece of cloth down from the Mayor's mouth.

“What are you talking about? Your friend Philip died about six months ago!” the Mayor said with fearful eyes.

“What?” Nathaniel could only say, frowning under the mask and looking at Rose for confirmation. When Rose nodded, Nathaniel took a step backwards as if he had been shot in the chest.

“So... So I haven't been here for six months?” Nathaniel asked Rose. He felt his throat tighten. Rosa shook her head slowly from up to down slowly.

“I'm sorry, but more than that. You've been gone for about a year and a half.” Nathaniel's eyes widened.

“A... A year and a half?” Nathaniel managed to say and looked at the Mayor “Congratulations Mr. Mayor.” He said and stormed away. Rose replaced the cloth that had been lowered around the Mayor's neck and followed Nathaniel, accompanied by the Mayor's murmurs.

“Nathaniel!” Rose called after Nathaniel when she was sure they were far enough away from the Mayor. “Nate, can you stop for a

minute?" Nate stopped and with trembling hands took off his mask and threw it to the ground.

"Nate, what's happening to you?"

"I... Damn me... I must have let my father down!" said Nathaniel. He leaned against the wall behind him.

"Nate, why are you saying that?"

"Bob was right. A year and a half? I've been... I was so wrapped up in my father's death and the booze..." Nathaniel's eyes widened and he sank to the floor, his back to the wall.

"Nate, listen to me." Rose began. She sat down next to Nathaniel. "Everyone wants to run away when they lose someone or even when they're in pain and..."

"And I ran away! Damn it! I was too drunk to realize!" Nathaniel said as he put his head in his hands.

"You can't honor your father if you keep doing this! You need to be the old Nathaniel! The Nathaniel who was cynical, but also the Nathaniel who overcame everything! Nate, we need to be yourself. I need my old partner. If we pull this off, even Solomon will be proud of us! You have a mission that no Cooper, no Headknight has ever had. No matter how this mission ends, your father will be proud of you. And so will Solomon."

"You're right." Nathaniel took a deep breath. "I just didn't know... I... I will be honest Rose. This is not about the time. Yes I am shocked but... I feel I already disappointed my father when... When I run away... This thought... being too weak to continue... Why I feel I am damned."

"Well," Rose sat next to Nathaniel. "You are in team, you are the leader. Isn't that mean you are back. You are back for parchment, which is... the reason why they created the library. Technically, You will be one of the greatest because we will find it. So you can think

that you just skipped the boring side quests.” Rose stood up and reached her hand to Nathaniel.

“Yeah. Let's show that old geezer Solomon, what we can do,” Nathaniel said, sniffing. He caught her hand and stood up. Picking up his discarded mask and put it back on. “Thank you, Rose. It is good to have a friend.”

“My my, I never thought I could hear it from you.”

“What can I say. Today is your lucky day. You won't hear it again.” Said Nathaniel and in that moment Scatt came in. He was holding a cell phone. He handed it to Nathaniel.

Nathaniel took the phone. Scatt put his hand in his pocket and took out a piece of paper and handed it to him. Using the hand that held the phone, Nathaniel took off the gauntlet and put it on one of the wooden crates. He took the paper from Scatt's hand and wrote the number on the paper. He dialed and waited.

“Good afternoon.” “May I speak to Mr. Christian?”

Nathaniel said in a mocking voice. After a pause, he said, “It's about the mayor.” He said and immediately heard the voice of the FBI agent who shot him in the hand.

“I guess you must be the asshole who kidnapped the mayor.” Christian said in a stern tone.

“And you must be the asshole who shot my hand.” Said Nathaniel, imitating Christian's tone. “You know why I'm calling.”

“Oh, yes, I know very well. Trade.”

“To tell you the truth I'm impressed Christian, do you know what we want to trade for?” Christian was silent for a while.

Nathaniel had his answer. “Not good enough Christian, anyway. The file I want is Mr. Elnore's file.”

Christian was silent for a while.

"I wonder why, of all things, you'd want a document on a missing explorer. I mean, who would kidnap the mayor just for a missing man? I mean, I can understand if it's a professor who knows the codes to nuclear missiles or an explorer who found the well of youth, but Mr. Elnore? The only people who know him are in a small town."

"And if anyone does, you won't let them talk, will you? Like you did back in the day. I can't answer your question completely, but I can tell you that Mr. Elnore is more important than you can imagine. There's a great war coming, Christian. Believe it or not, it's going to happen. And no country has the technology to win it. The only chance is to find Mr. Elnore and use his help to prevent it."

"What, Mr. Elnore is not just an explorer, a professor? A scientist working for some secret government project?" he said, clearly mocking.

"No. He's just an explorer, and what he's found and what he knows is very important. But don't worry about that. We both have something we want from each other. You want the mayor and we want the files. Even if it's a copy, it'll do. Which is probably what you're going to do anyway, and that's what you're going to have to do."

The sarcasm in Christian's voice was replaced by teeth clenched in anger and he sighed. "All right. I hope you already choose the place."

"We have, but it's not just the meeting place that's the problem. It's also the location of the eight copies of the file you're going to copy. Once we get the file, we'll check its authenticity and release the mayor."

"Well, why should we believe you? After we get the file..."

"How can you trust us not to kill the mayor, is that your question? How do you know you won't catch us if we show up at the

swap meet? we have the upper hand here. I guess you don't want the whole country to know the mayor's been kidnapped."

"Damn it! All right, all right. Attacking the mayor's house without a mask wasn't the smartest move. As far as the guards remember, we'll catch you both sooner or later. But for now, I'll play your game."

"You have no choice but to play it anyway." Nathaniel said with a smile. "I'll send you the location of all eight locations, you have half an hour to get the files ready." Said Nathaniel and hung up the phone and threw it to Scatt. Scatt tried to catch the phone with one hand and succeeded. A small smile appeared on his face.

"Scatt, you know the eight places we've identified, right?"

"Yes, I'll check with Vex one more time and let the FBI know. When are we going to pick up the files?" Scatt asked.

"Four hours if the files are ready. I feel like I'm going to collapse any minute from lack of sleep, so let's hold them off."

"Rose, you know what to do next, right?" asked Nathaniel and when Rose nodded, Nathaniel took off his mask and put it next to his gauntlet. He picked up his gauntlet and started walking. "Let's go Scatt!" he said and together they left the warehouse and got into Nathaniel's Chevrolet waiting at the door. Nathaniel put it in gear and stepped on the gas.

As they sped along, Scatt shuffled through the music recorded in the tape that matched Nathaniel's car. They were all at the least thirty years old. He randomly picked one of them and when he was about to put it on when the car slowed down and stopped in front of the Library. He got out of the car with Nathaniel, not showing his low spirits. Vex was waiting in front of the library as usual.

After greeting Vex, Scatt and Nathaniel went inside and took the elevator down. Before the elevator door closed, Nathaniel turned to Vex.

“Vex, do you know where Jason is?”

“He was in his room, resting.” Said Vex and Nathaniel thanked him and got off the elevator. He came straight to Jason's room. He knocked on the door and after a short while Jason opened the door.

“Hello, Jason.” Nathaniel said and continued without waiting for Jason to answer. “Do you want to come with me to pick up the files from the FBI?”

“Sure. When will we leave?”

“We'll wait for approval from the FBI first. Of course, we won't get it right away. We'll go a couple hours after we hear back. And don't forget to bring my revolver.”

“All right. I'll see you later.”

“See you.” Nathaniel said, and as he was about to leave, he stopped and turned around. “And just so you know, we're going in my car. Wear your cleanest clothes.”

“Sure, sure...” Jason said in his fake demeanor and closed the door.

Nathaniel threw himself on the bed as soon as he entered his room. He took a deep breath and closed his eyes.

The sound of Jason's non-stop knocking woke Nathaniel from his sleep. Cursingly, Nathaniel got out of bed and sat up. He rushed to the door and opened it. Jason lowered his hand which was trying to knock one last time, and straightened his jacket.

“What's so urgent?”

“The FBI planted the files. And it's been about two and a half hours. I think it's time for us to go.”

"All right, you take one of the fake license plates and wait for me in front of the car."

"Okay. Don't be too late." Jason said and Nate nodded and closed the door. He let out a deep sigh and walked slowly to his desk. He picked up the picture on the table. He turned his back and leaned against it.

"I won't let you down, Dad. I will find that damn book no matter what the outcome." He put the photo back. He sighed and left the room. He took the elevator upstairs. As he walked through the shelves on the ground floor, he reached into his trench coat pocket and pulled out his car keys. Jason was waiting with the new license plate. "You're faster than I expected." Nathaniel said when he saw the license plate on his car.

"I changed it while you were asleep."

"All right, get in the car and don't touch my car again until I tell you!" Nathaniel said with a scowl. He opened the driver's seat and sat his seat. Jason took his seat and handed Nathaniel his gun. Nathaniel took his revolver and holstered it. He started the car and drove off.

Nathaniel's seventy-two was the only vehicle that broke the silence of the night. He drove for a long time on empty roads with the loud roar of the engine. After a while he slowed down and drove in silence. After a few blocks, it stopped. Nathaniel turned off the headlights and glanced out the window at the empty streets.

"Over there." He said, pointing his finger at a box under a street lamp. "So I think that's it. Now it's your turn, Jason. Show your ingenuity and get the contents of that box."

Jason took a deep breath, trying to ignore the rhythm of his racing heart, and said, "Okay." He got out of the car and walked slowly towards the box. He took each step carefully. Every few steps he passed under the light of a street lamp and took a step out of the darkness. When he came to the box, he slowly bent down, opened the

lid and looked inside. Files, scattered notepapers, photographs... They were all inside the file. He closed the lid of the full box and took quick steps back to the car.

Nathaniel opened the door for Jason from where he was sitting and took the box from Jason's hands as soon as he sat down. He threw the lid of the box out the half-open window like a Frisbee.

"I guess these are what we want. Good! Let's go back to the library." Said Nathaniel and put the lidless box on Jason's lap. He turned on the headlights and started the car.

"Nate, can you tell me why you called me for this mission? Is it because it's too easy?"

"My team needed rest." Nathaniel said "And if there were a sniper, I wouldn't want to risk my life." Added with laugh, keeping his gaze on the road he drove off.

Vex walked slowly inside and grabbed one of the chairs by the end and dragged it to the front of the elevator. He sat on it and crossed his arms. He was about to close his eyes slowly when he noticed two people entering in the darkness of the night. He stood up and reached into his pocket. "Catch!" he said and threw it. One of the two people didn't realize what was happening and stepped aside, while the other caught what Vex threw in the air.

"Lock the door and come back, Nathaniel." He said and pressed the button for the elevator to arrive while Nathaniel gave the key to Jason and joined Vex.

The elevator doors opened as Jason arrived. Nathaniel handed the box to Vex as the light from the elevator illuminated those around him.

"Vex, this box belongs to Mr. Elnore. I wonder if..."

"Give it to me, son. It'll be ready tomorrow morning."

"Thanks, Vex." Said Nathaniel and got off the elevator with Jason.

Vex went up to the top floor with the files and walked through the shelves, sat down at the round table in front of the window. He turned on the old lamp on the table and put it in the furthest corner. He turned the box upside-down over and emptied everything inside onto the table.

"Now we begin." Said Vex, shuffling through everything in the box. He stacked the files on one side of the table. He put the voice recorder next to it and gathered the scattered papers. He left a notebook at the end. He took the notebook and opened it. "Professor Dor Elnore's Diary" was written on the first page.

Nathaniel walked to the exit of the library with Jason and opened the door using the key Vex had forgotten to take back. Vex was not in his usual place. Nathaniel cursed and searched the remaining two floors of the library. And he found Vex asleep on the third floor. He was sleeping with his head between the pages of a book.

"There you are." Nate said, knowing Vex was asleep. He put his hand on his shoulder and nudged him awake. For the first few seconds Vex tried to understand what was happening.

"Sit down." Vex said, yawning. He picked up the white cup next to the files and brought it to his mouth. There was nothing in the cup but the coffee stains that had accumulated at the end. Sighed, Nathaniel reached into his trench coat pocket, pulled out his metal flask and handed it to Vex.

"This should do the trick."

"No, it won't." Vex said and declined the offer. "This notebook is Mr. Elnore's diary. This is the last voice he recorded. More than half of these files were a waste of time. These are the files where the rescue team that went looking for him got lost, where their signal was lost. And this is the file where the clues that point to

Elnore's last known whereabouts were pieced together. God, we should get an FBI agent in the library!"

"And where was he? Did you find out?" Nathaniel asked, staring at Vex curiously.

"The agents' signals were lost in a cave on Mount Everest. You get the team together and get ready for Everest and I'll call Jason and tell him to call the rest of the team."

"Vex, what would we do without you?" said Nate and stood up from his chair.

"You're right, you would be sitting desperately without me." Vex said and Nathaniel smiled slightly and was about to walk by Vex when Vex grabbed Nate's arm. "Son, you have to be prepared for anything. Something tells me everyone who goes there not just disappears." Nathaniel shook his head slightly in reply, patted Vex on the shoulder, and kept walking. He had taken a few steps when he stopped. He turned around.

"Vex, I need to go downstairs."

Nathaniel rummaged through his own closets and found a couple of thick coats, but they would be useless on Everest. Sighing, he threw them all on his bed and left his room. He took the elevator to the ground floor and walked to the glass doors. As he passed through the door, he said hello to Vex who just came his duty place, while Nathaniel was descending the steps he took out his cell phone and made a call. As the phone rang, the distant sound of an engine began to grow louder. Nathaniel put the phone to his ear and walked slowly away from the library. Just then the source of the sound, the motorcycle, stopped in front of the library.

Rose got off her bike and put her helmet on. Nathaniel finished his phone call as he climbed the steps and caught up with Rose before she reached the last step.

"So Everest you saying?"

“Yes as Vex told me. Anyways I've arranged for the equipment we'll need. It should be ready in a couple of hours at least.”

“Well that's good news. “ Rose said, and as she climbed the last step, she nodded to Vex standing in the doorway, going inside.

The taxi pulled up outside of the library and Scatt paid the cabbie and got out. He greeted Vex and went inside and went straight to the third floor to the new conference table.

“Sorry I'm little late.” Scatt said and sat down at the table. Jason sat down with Nathaniel and Rose looking at him.

“If you ask me if your mission is hard or easy, the only answer I can give is that I really have no idea. On Everest, Mount Everest, you will enter a cave. It's where the explorer Elnore and the men who tried to rescue him were last seen. After that, I can't say anything because I don't know.”

“I think that's all you have to say.” Said Nathaniel. “I need to make some calls, and then we can hit the road. Can somebody call Alfred? Jason?”

“Sure.” Then Nathaniel took his phone out of his pocket and disappeared into the shelves.

When Nathaniel came back, he put his phone back in his pocket. “I think it's time to release the video.” He said and looked at Rose.

“Don't worry. I've sent it to every news channel I could find. It won't be long before it's on the news.”

“Good! Then all we have to do is wait.” Nathaniel said with a dirty grin.

Christian stood in front of the corkboard, going over each piece of information one more time, trying to figure out who the kidnappers of the Mayor were, until he was sure he hadn't missed anything. But he kept thinking he was missing something. He had put everything he could find about the requested file on the table and of course there were the pictures he had heard from the mayor's bodyguards. He went through all the information again. Then someone knocked on his door and his attention was suddenly diverted. He sighed deeply and walked slowly to his desk. He sat down in his leather-covered chair. "Come in!" Christian shouted, and the door to his office opened.

"Sir, we've found the mayor, he's doing very well. He's in one of the safe houses over there as ordered. Do you have any other orders?" said the red haired man in a suit.

"Check on the mayor at his safe house. I don't think they'll try again, a little cautions won't hurt."

"Yes, sir." Said the agent and closed the door behind him. Christian rose from his chair and went to the clipboard on the wall. He started all over again. And this time his door opened without a knock. A woman walked in with her long brown hair pulled back.

"For God's sake..."

"Sir, I wouldn't have come in that way if it wasn't an emergency."

"What's those bastards done this time?" exclaimed Christian.

The woman hurriedly handed Christian the tablet, which she held in one arm. Christian raised one eyebrow and took the tablet. He started the open video.

It showed a masked woman standing with a cloth stuffed in her mouth standing next to the mayor sitting in a chair. The mayor's eyes were closed. He was sleeping with his head tilted to the side. "As you can see, we have Mayor Dorson. But don't worry." The

woman continued with all her sarcasm and altered voice. "Because right now the FBI has given us what we need as exchange of Mayor's life. In short, we had great power when we had the mayor. We got what we wanted from the FBI just by kidnapping the mayor, but how much power do you think we would have if we kidnap the president of the United States?" the masked woman finished her words and the video ended.

"Damn it!" Christian said and threw the tablet on the floor with anger. He started breathing angrily as the tablet shattered. "Destroy this video now! From everywhere! And where was it released?"

"All the channels..." she said in a low voice, afraid of Christian's reaction. And then there was a knock on the half-open door, a tall agent entered.

"Delete that damn video from everywhere!" Christian said angrily, pointing at the broken tablet.

"Yes, sir." Said the woman in fear. The other agent in the room cleared his throat as he left the room with quick steps without lifting his gaze from the floor.

"Sir..."

"What is it!"

"Sir." The agent cleared his throat again. "The general manager wants you. He's on the phone right now."

"Just when you thought things couldn't get any worse..." Christian put his hand to his face and took a deep breath. He straightened his jacket as if his suit was wrinkled. He sat down. "Get the general manager on the phone." He said and picked up the phone on his desk.

"Sir..."

"What is this disgrace, Christian?"

“Sir,” Christian swallowed loudly and continued. “I think their intention is to mislead us. As you know, the file they took from us...”

“The one we gave them.” Corrected the director general in a stern voice.

“The file we gave them will lead them directly to Mount Everest, Sir, and their words about kidnapping the president is a distraction. so they can easily find what they are looking for.”

“So tell me, Christian, what do you want to do?”

“We know exactly where they're going and I think we should take advantage of it. Sir.”

“The President is in danger and I don't want you doing anything else!”

“Sir I... I only need five agents. Let me take a team of five. If you are right, I will return empty handed and we will not have lost much, but if I am right and you don't let me go, then we will have missed a great opportunity. Sir, please allow me.”

The director was silent for a while. He sighed deeply and finally said, “Only five agents.”

“Thank you sir, for your trust.” Said Christian and the director hung up the phone. He looked at the agent standing in front of him. “Find the five best agents and get a plane to Everest. We will fly undercover. And get the equipment ready.”

“Yes, sir.” Said the agent and left Christian's office. Christian got up from his chair, picked up his gun from the desk and holstered it. He approached the clipboard with heavy steps. He looked angrily at the sketches of the criminals. He grabbed the male sketch and pulled it angrily. The paper, torn where the thumbtacks had been, was left in Christian's hand. Christian crumpled the paper and threw it with all his might.

He closed his eyes. He was breathing fast. He tried to breathe slowly. When he calmed down, he returned to his desk and sat down. He put his head in his hands.

Rose, Nathaniel and Scatt came out of the door at Vex's duty place as Fred waited with his arms crossed in front of the gray car. They made their way to the car.

“Alfred, do you have the equipment I asked for?”

“Yes, Nathaniel. It's waiting for you on the plane.” Said Fred and started the car.

As the car reached the airport a huge passenger plane flew overhead. Soon Fred stopped the car. Nathaniel got out and started walking towards his private plane. The others followed close behind.

Nathaniel took out his metal flask and took a sip before entering the plane. He took his seat on the plane. Then he took another sip. He watched Scatt and Rose take their seats. When they were both settled, he said, “All right, Alfred, start the damn flight. And get us to China.” He said. The plane started to accelerate.

The wheels of the plane came off. The plane slowly descended and landed. Nathaniel opened his eyes. He yawned and tried to get up. But the seat belt held him back in place. He freed himself from the seat belt and climbed down through the opened door. “Alfred, where's our equipment?” he asked loudly as the cold penetrated him. Slowly he began to shiver. Fred stepped out of the airplane in his thick woolen coat and put on a load of dark green backpacks.

“These are things you might need on the road. And these will protect you from the cold...” Nathaniel didn't wait for Fred to finish, grabbing one of the thick coats he had and putting it on. Rose and Scatt, who had just gotten off the plane, also thanked Fred and got dressed.

When everyone was dressed, Fred pointed to the black car coming towards them. And he said, "Here's our car."

The black snowmobile left tire tracks covered by falling snowflakes. It ascended up the curving slopes of the mountain. They were approaching an increasingly dense snow cloud. Soon a car appeared in the snow cloud. It was creating a cloud by scattering the snow under the tires behind it. In front of the car was the FBI logo. He braked sharply to avoid hitting the FBI car. The FBI car also stopped and its doors opened. Men came out from all four sides and drew their guns.

"You're under arrest for kidnapping the mayor!" Christian yelled. "Get out of the vehicle now and keep your hands where I can see them!" Christian's face broke into a nasty smile as the driver's side door of the car slowly opened. Then he squinted. He wasn't looking at the car in front of him. He was trying to figure out what was approaching fast from a few meters away. When he saw the approaching vehicles, he fixed his curious gaze on them.

Two cars approached at great speed, braked at the last moment and parked sideways. The car had Chinese writing on it. The Chinese got out of their cars and pulled their guns on the FBI. The man at the front shouted.

"You are under arrest for attempted armed assault while in the territory of the State of China! I will repeat it only once more!"

"What the hell is this? Is this a joke?" said Christian, frowning.

The driver's door of the car in the center slowly opened. And Fred stepped outside. He threw his hands in the air and looked both ways as if he didn't understand anything.

"Sir, you are under arrest for kidnapping the Mayor! Please don't resist!" Christian said, ignoring the Chinese.

“Didn't you hear the man, sir?” Fred said with a smile, “You are under arrest for armed assault in the Chinese government.”

“You're not him. What are you, that punk's driver or something?”

“What are you talking about? There's no one else in the car but me!” Fred protested mockingly.

“This is the last warning!” the Chinese man said, “If you don't choose to come with us to the police station, we will open fire.”

Christian angrily lowered his gun. He gestured for his team to lower their weapons as well. One by one, the Chinese policemen handcuffed the FBI agents. As one of them grabbed Christian from behind and led him toward his own vehicle, Christian took the opportunity to look inside the car Fred had gotten out of. The driver was right, it was empty.

“How did you know we would be here?” Christian asked the man holding his handcuffed arms behind his back. But the man didn't answer. He just looked at him with a dirty look on his face. It was clear he didn't speak English.

Nathaniel reached down from the edge of the slope and grabbed Rose by the wrist. He counted down from three and pulled her up, holding his breath. Then he grabbed Scatt's one arm and pulled him up with all his strength. Scatt lay on the floor for a while. He was breathing rapidly. He was sweating in the cold air. As he slowly sat up, a panting Nathaniel stood up. “Scatt, I think God has something against you, or Solomon.” He said as he removed his hands from his knees.

“I know.” Scatt replied in a clipped voice.

Scatt unhooked the thick rope with hooks from his belt, followed by Nathaniel and Rose. The rope kept them tied together as they climbed the mountain. For Scatt with one arm.

“Which way are we going?” Rose asked. Nathaniel looked at Scatt as he pocketed a sip of his drink. When Scatt realized the question was directed at him, he dropped to one knee and put the bag on his back on the floor. After rummaging around in it for a while, he found what he was looking for. He picked up the rectangular device that resembled a telephone. He put the backpack back on. He waited a while for the device to turn on. Then he frowned and tried to figure out where they were.

“That way.” He said at last, pointing with his finger, leading the way. Rose and Nathaniel followed Scatt. After a short walk they came to a steeply rising mountainside. Nathaniel sighed and handed everyone back the rope with the hook. They started climbing.

They knocked their hooks against the ice-covered mountain and slowly began to ascend. The wind whistled louder and louder as they ascended. The snow coming down from above obscured their view. Yet they kept going. The crumbling stones were tumbling down or the pole was falling down. Scatt was trying to get out from the bottom. He was climbing the mountain as fast as a one-armed man. The main reason he didn't fall was the rope tied to a Rose and Nathaniel.

When Scatt reached the very edge, he tried to pull himself up. He had used up all his strength. Nathaniel and Rose grabbed Scatt's wrist and helped him up. As soon as Scatt was out, he collapsed and lay face down on the ground.

“Next time I'll stay out of the field.”

“Like Jason?” Nathaniel asked breathlessly.

“Like Jason.” Scatt nodded breathlessly. The device sounded like an alarm, causing him to look up as if it had just woken him. He looked alternately at the device in his hand and at the cave in front of

him. "This is it." He said, "This is where Elnore the Explorer was last seen."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The soldiers at the front of the army couldn't do anything but swung their spear forward when a huge mouth came out of the water and completely covered them. Afterward the mouth colored with blood sank back into the water. Everyone tried for a moment to understand what had happened. And they ran in fear. But the shadow under the water did not stop. It kept going after Edwak's men as they fled to their own island. It is raised rapidly and jumped into the air. The creature's horrible shape was now clearly visible. Its fangs did not fit in its long mouth. The huge fins on its back made it look even more majestic. The creature split the ice path in two. Then the creature plunged back into the sea where it belonged. One by one, one by one, the men who fell into the water from the cracked ice path sank to the bottom of the water screaming as they tried to swim to land. Within a moment, the place where they disappeared was tinged with red.

When Solomon came ashore, he turned and looked back at Edwak's men. Some had managed to escape to the land they came from. And the shadow in the water was no longer visible.

“Did you call it?” Windsor asked. Without taking his gaze from the sea.

“I don't think so.”

“As far as I know, you draw your power from worlds and perhaps you have a connection with the creatures of this world.” Said Rodrin.

“Or maybe it was just luck.”

As they entered through the ruined walls they could see the city better. They began to walk beside the ruined buildings, reduced to piles of stone. They passed a few walls that were barely intact. With a sudden movement, Rodrin stopped the others and leaned against the wall beside them. He poked his head out and glanced around. He saw the creatures moving through the ruins, baring their fangs. After what he saw, he decided to change direction. He could no longer move as easily as when he had entered the walls.

They started moving forward, hiding behind the ruins. Occasionally they saw dark shadows. Sometimes the shadows of creatures flying through the air would pass over them. After each creature they encountered did not notice them, they took a deep breath and continued on.

Each time they looked through the ruins, on either side of the surviving wall. And more and more creatures were appearing in the darkness. Growls rose from behind the buildings. Some of them sounded as close as if they were right on the other side of the wall. Rodrin took a deep breath and managed to get behind the next wall. Solomon followed him. Then Windsor, trying to hide with his big belly, and finally Azderson.

Solomon came out from behind the wall where he had been hiding and took quick steps towards Rodrin, who was waiting at the foot of the ruin ahead. Suddenly the blackness leapt in front of Solomon. It raised its giant long claws in a hideous roar and swung at Solomon. Solomon ducked at the last moment and the sharp claws

scratched the collapsed wall behind him. Solomon saw the creature's ugly face more clearly as the wall emitted its ear-splitting sound.

Rodrin shot out like an arrow and drove his spear between the shoulder blades of the creature's back. Blood oozed from the wound with a crackling sound. And the creature quickly turned around, swung its hand at Rodrin. The claw was right in Rodrin's face. Rodrin was quickly thrown to the side.

Two hands gripped the top of the debris. They were pointed hands with three claws. Then a head appeared on the wall. Another appeared and another and another... They jumped over the surrounding debris, over the side and surrounded Solomon and his friends. The two creatures in front of Solomon blocked their way. The air began to thicken. It looked like a dark cloud. It gathered, moved and finally took shape. The mist took on a human-like shape. A person with pale skin and dark eyes. It approached Solomon with heavy steps. Solomon chose not to move. Frowning, he stared at the man, fear filling him with every step the creature took. The man brought his face as close to Solomon's as he could. Then his black eyes widened, he stepped back. He looked at his hand.

"So you are the new representative of magic! My master will love it!" the man said in a pair of echoing voices. One was a normal human voice. The other was more hoarse and thick. "Kill the others!"

"No!" shouted Windsor and Azderson in unison as they rushed forward. They raised their spears and held them out one by one to the creatures surrounding them. "If you want to take Master Solomon prisoner, you have to get through us first!" said Azderson. Windsor nodded.

"You will die anyway." "Kill..." said the pale man and froze before he finished. He looked at the spear that went in one side of his stomach and came out the other. His gaze focused at Rodrin who had thrown it, with blood covered face. Rodrin sat up in great pain. Enough for him to throw the spear. He was breathing heavily. He pulled the spear out. As the wound closed, the mist that had formed it

began to surround the spear. When he let go of the shaft, the spear lifted from his hand and flew at Rodrin at speed. Rodrin knew he could not escape. He closed his eyes and shielded his face with his arms.

“No!” Solomon shouted as he held out his hand to Rodrin.

CHAPTER TWELVE

“Great!” said Nathaniel. He was still trying to catch his breath. “Let's go inside.”

“We can't just barge into a cave where the explorer and agents met their end.”

“I agree with Rose.” Scatt said and knelt on the floor. He put down his bag full of gizmos. After taking out a few tools one by one and placing them next to the bag, there was a satisfied mumble, indicating that he had found what he was looking for, and Scatt took out a small vehicle with tracks that resembled a small tank. He put the vehicle on the ground and took out of his bag a remote control that resembled a one-armed joist. On the top of it there was a square screen.

He looked up at Nathaniel.

“Fred's put something really useful in there.” Scatt said and turned his gaze back to the device, pressed the button and started the

car. After a brief flicker, the camera's image came up and Scatt put the vehicle into motion.

The vehicle made a low whirring noise as it was driven into the cave. It traveled along the crooked cave paths for some time. When he was deeper into the cave, nothing was visible on the camera screen. Scatt pressed one of the buttons next to the screen with his nose. The two headlights on the front of the vehicle light on. Although the vehicle's light did not illuminate the cave completely, it allowed the vehicle to see where it was going.

No matter how deep it went, there was nothing but rock. Until it started to get brighter. The cave glowed as if it was letting in the sunlight. Scatt moved the vehicle's camera to focus on the source of the light, something hanging on the wall. The flame of the torch hanging on the wall swayed as if dancing. After seeing the torch, he began to drive even more slowly. The torches continued to appear as he drove.

Scatt's eyes widened as he looked at the camera. He slowed the vehicle down and moved it.

The shadow of the flame from one of the torches fell on the men standing against the wall. The men were wearing furs that fell from their shoulders to their bare chests. With heavy weapons in their hands and long beards sprouting from their helmets, they were guarding the corridor between them. Occasionally they said something to each other and laughed. After that, when they didn't have anything to talk they reverted to military discipline and focused on their mission. Scatt quickly drove the machine back.

Nathaniel checked the entrance to the cave again, then crouched behind the large boulder he had found.

"The plan is simple. I'll draw the men's attention and bring them outside - I don't think they have many guests anyway - and you go in. Sneak in. And you find the professor. Secretly. You will the professor out."

“Secretly.” Rose guessed the rest of the sentence. Nate nodded. “You think you can hold off security until we get the professor out?”

“It's just two cavemen. How hard can it be?” Nathaniel said and stood up. He pointed to a spot near the entrance of the cave. “Stay there. I'll run them down from here.” When he saw that Scatt and Rose were moving, he started to move too and began to walk through the cave.

Nathaniel could feel the temperature was rising. It was much, much hotter inside the cave than outside. Now he knew how those men weren't freezing just wearing pelts. As he shone his flashlight around inside the cave, he noticed the light from the torch and turned it off. He started walking more carefully.

He was about to turn into a cave corridor when he saw the men standing guard and for the last time he leaned his back against the rocks. He took a deep breath and threw himself where the men could see him. He threw the flashlight at the head of the man with the helmet. As the ringing from the helmet filled the cave, both men turned to Nathaniel, who had thrown the Flashlight, and ran at him without a second thought. Nathaniel froze at first, but he regained his senses and started running before the men got too close.

Nathaniel came out of the cave panting. after a quick glance at Rose and Scatt poking their heads out from behind the rocks, he focused on his own work and kept running. He had bigger problems. The two men behind him were running too fast for their size. They were getting closer and closer to Nathaniel.

As Nathaniel breathed in and out rapidly, he glanced at the men who were catching up with him. Nathaniel couldn't understand how they could run so fast. He put his thoughts aside and focused on running. He had to buy as much time as possible. If he stopped running there would be fists involved.

When Rose and Scatt saw Nathaniel running with two men on his heels, they entered the cave with slow steps. As Nathaniel had said, they were moving stealthily. They made it to the crossroad without any trouble and without meeting anyone. Rose first looked at the rocky road ahead. Then the corridor that were guarded by the big men. After a brief pause, she took quick steps towards the corridor formerly guarded by the two men chasing Nathaniel. Scatt was also after Rose.

Soon bright lights appeared between the corridors. And there were more and more of them. Blue diamonds seemed to be interspersed among all the dull rocks. When they came to the place where the crystals were getting more and more dense, something caught Rose's attention. She saw the grass stretching between the two dull rocks on the ground. And she realized that it wasn't as cold as it had been. She was even beginning to sweat through her coat. She turned her gaze to Scatt. He was in the same situation. He was tugging at his collar to cool off a little.

Suddenly the blue crystals turned red. Rose took a step back to see what was happening and saw the brightness at the end of the corridor. Squinting, she saw the fire coming at them fast. The fire was coming at them fast from the far end of the corridor. The fire filled the entire cave from top to bottom, coming towards Rose and Scatt as if there was nowhere for it to fit. Rose tapped Scatt's arm as she tried to understand what was happening. Then she grabbed Scatt's arm and they started to run.

Nate was exhausted. He was out of breath. Two big men were coming up behind him. There was less than three meters between them. And it was getting shorter and shorter. He came to an abrupt stop with all his might. As small stones tumbled down from where his feet had been, he waved his both arms to balance and avoided falling at the last moment. He looked at the cliff at his feet. The very bottom of the cliff was not visible. Beyond a certain point, it was invisible in the falling snow. As he was about to take a deep

breath, he remembered the men behind him and turned around without wasting any time.

In a sudden movement, as he ducked and turned to the right, he felt the wind of a huge hand passing over him. She took a step back and jumped forward, punching one of the two men full force in the face. As the man's head rolled to the side, Nathaniel looked down at his hand, red with pain. He regretted not hitting him with his gloved hand. When the gaze of the man who had been punched focused on Nathaniel, Nathaniel realized that the punch had done nothing but make the man angry. With the end of the hammer in his hand he stopped his friend, said something to his friend who tried to step forward. Nathaniel didn't understand anything. He didn't even see the fist that hit his face so fast. And his eyes darkened. Nathaniel began to feel he needed to rest. He felt suspended in the air as he fell towards the cliff. As he sank into the darkness, the last thing he saw was the man grabbing him by the collar.

Rose and Scatt were running with all their might. The fire was coming after them as if it wanted to roast them. When the crystals on the walls of the cave faded, so did the fire, but Rose and Scatt had no intention of stopping. When they realized that the air was getting cooler, they looked back and saw that the fire had reached the last of the crystals. As if there was an invisible wall, the fire crashed into the void and curled back. It couldn't get even an inch closer now.

"Let's get out of here now! We should find someone else who can read the scroll!" Scatt said, barely breathing. They continued down the corridor, breathing deeply. Soon they saw the torch-lit entrance. It was a few steps away. They kept walking. When they reached the crossroads, they saw two large men standing in front of them. They both swung their fists at the same time. Scatt and Rose collapsed at the same moment again.

Rose slowly opened her eyes. She felt drunk, yet she could feel herself being dragged by her chained hands. She looked up. The big man was holding the center of the chains. In his other hand he held his axe, almost crawling on the ground. Then her gaze shifted directly in front of herself. Scatt was awake and standing. He was walking forward. The second man had his axe pinned to his back, holding Scatt's one arm with one hand and his armless shoulder with the other. Through the dirty cuffs of his trousers it was clear that he was being dragged along, just like Rose.

Rose tugged at her hands, but he was too strong. He held the chain tightly, as if he had hands of steel. The man realized that Rose was awake and quickly lifted her into the air as if she were a light bag. When Rose was in the air, Scatt saw her rise a few inches off the ground. Then she fell quickly to the ground, landing on her feet. The man pulled her in front of him. He let go of Rose's hands and pushed her back, forcing her to walk.

Rose put her hands together and attacked the man standing a step behind her with her upper body. The man didn't even flinch. He quickly caught the hands coming towards his face. He pulled Rose towards him and punched her in the face. Rose tried to bring her chained hands to her bleeding nose, but he wouldn't let her. He grabbed the chains and kept pulling Rose.

Scatt looked around. He couldn't attack with one arm held tightly behind his back. He couldn't attack even if he wasn't being held tightly or if he had both of his hands. And when he saw that Rose couldn't do anything, he realized that all he could do was memorizing the ways they passed and find a way out. He left the fighting to Rose and Nathaniel. If Nathaniel was alive.

As they advanced further, they realized that the big men had come to their base. The ceiling was much higher and wider than the thin pathways of the cave. The walls and ceiling were more organized. The flat area they were moving across was divided into several parts. Each one was a field where different things were planted. Some of the workers were plowing one part of the field,

some were sowing the seeds, some were harvesting the crops. Scatt, Rose and the two men were walking along a straight path that ran right through the middle of the fields.

“If my hand weren't hold, I would shake your hand and congratulate you for creating such an ecosystem in the freezing cold of Everest.” For a long time the man was silent. “I think you don't understand what I'm saying. I wish my dear Emily could see all you created.” Scatt said with a sigh.

They came to the two men guarding the wooden gate in front of the wall at the end of the field. The man holding Scatt's arm handed Scatt to one of the two men in front of the gate. He handed Rose to the other and they returned to their places. The two guards led Scatt and Rose through the wooden door and through corridors with straight walls. On either side of every door in the corridors, men with different weapons stood guard. The last two guards brought Rose and Scatt into a room with a metal door. The two men standing in front of the door banged on it in a steady rhythm and in a few seconds the door opened. The guards led Rose and Scatt inside.

The room was colder than the other parts they have passed, with cells lined up one after the other it was getting colder. The guards led Rose and Scatt through the bars of the dungeons. They passed cells with skinny hands reaching through the bars and men lying dead on the dark floor. They stopped in front of two small cells and waited. Soon two more guards came from across the street and talked among themselves. Soon the guards took Rose and Scatt's backpacks, placed them against the wall opposite the cells and searched them. They took everything they found that looked like a gun. They put them both in separate cells. The cell doors closed, shaking the bars of the whole cell.

“Don't worry, Scatt.” Rose said, trying to lift their spirits. “Nathaniel will find us and get us out of here.”

“I hope you're right.”

They heard the metal door creak open. Footsteps were getting closer. Three people were coming towards Rose and Scatt's cell. Nathaniel was the first to emerge from the darkness, falling to the floor, pushed from behind. The light didn't illuminate enough, but the voice was definitely Nathaniel's.

"Damn you Viking bastards!" shouted Nathaniel as he struggled to his feet. "Hey hey hey hey, don't you dare touch that gauntlet! Hey hey hey, Bastards give my gauntlet back!" he shouted angrily as the clang of the cell opening was heard, followed by Nathaniel's creative profanity as he was thrown into the cell.

"Nate, you know that they don't understand what you are saying, right?"

"Of course I figured it out." Nathaniel grunted, sitting on the floor with his back against the wall. "Looks like this is where we're going to spend the rest of our lives. Does anyone have a harmonica?"

"They took mine." Scatt said sadly as he sat on the floor.

Soon the sound of the metal door opening again was heard throughout the cells. But this time it was not a normal opening. The door slammed open against the wall. Again the sound of footsteps approached the cells, but faster. The guards were not walking, they were scratching. When they reached the front of the cells, they opened the door and handcuffed two of them, for scatt they used the same method. Holding his arms and shoulder. They took them out as quick as they could do. They were on the run, dragging Rose, Scatt and Nathaniel after them.

They left the dungeon of cells and went down the corridor, stopped in front of the double-leaf brass door. Two men were standing in front of the doors pushed the doors, They led Rose, Nathaniel and Scatt inside.

Inside the room, a man with a gray goatee and hair was examining a book with his back turned. As soon as the doors opened, the man turned to face the door. In a cold, harsh voice he began to

speak to the men who had brought the prisoners in. One of the men pointed to Nathaniel.

“Where did you get the gauntlet?” the man asked. He had a strange accent. Nathaniel kept looking at the man, puzzled. “I will not ask the question a third time! Where did you steal the gauntlet?” the man shouted, banging his fist on the table. Nathaniel looked at him with a startled frown.

“Stole it? That fucking gauntlet is mine!” he yelled back.

“Is it?” the man asked angrily. And he stormed to his feet. He barked orders to his two soldiers standing just outside the door. His soldiers quickly left the room.

“If you're telling the truth, you won't mind if I close the gauntlet's eye. After all, you can open it again.” The man said and leaned back against the table behind him. “If you can't open the eye, all three of you will die a painful death.”

“You... you know our language! And... and the knights!” said Scatt with wide-open eyes.

“You are not the first knights coming my base and also...” the man said and put his hand on the helmet on the table. “I am one of them.”

Nathaniel opened his mouth to ask a question but interrupted by the doors behind them opening, letting guards come in. One of them was holding Nathaniel's gauntlet. Another held a bright blue crystal. The commander calmly gave an order to his soldiers as he took his seat at his desk and they both placed what they had brought on the table. Then they returned to their places. The Headknight, the owner of the helmet, bent down and took out a mortar and a stone from one of the drawers. He put the gauntlet right in front of him. The crystal in the mortar.

“The special thing about this crystal is that it can absorb magic. And I will turn it into dust and spread it all over the gauntlet.

Then, as the eye closes, I will spread the crystal dust off the gauntlet and you will reactivate the gauntlet.” Said the commander and put the crystal in the mortar and started to smash it with a stone. “Or the eye will not open and you will all die.”

The Headknight made sure he had smashed the crystal well and poured it all into his palm. He whispered a few words quietly and blew the crystal dust onto the gauntlet. The crystal dust began to sparkle as it spread all around the gauntlet. The gauntlet was now covered with what looked like thousands of tiny stars. And the eye began to glow. The light dots flowed through all the details of the gauntlet. Continued to move on it. The light of the gauntlet slowly fade away and finally the eye slowly closed. The commander blew again, blowing away all the glitter on the gauntlet, and the dot-like pieces of light disappeared into the air.

“Your turn.” Said the commander and the two men behind Nathaniel grabbed him by the arm lifting him up. They pushed him in front of the gauntlet.

“My hands looks like their owners, they like freedom. In order to open the eye I need them.” Nathaniel said, raising his eyebrows and reaching his hands out.

“All right.” He said and gave his men an order, his soldiers did as they were told. When Nathaniel's hands were free, Nathaniel rubbed his wrists for a while and then looked around.

“Do you have a knife?” Nathaniel asked and the man quickly drew a dagger from his waist and slashed Nathaniel's hand with no bandage. Nathaniel grimaced after a moment of standing still, he smeared his blood on the gauntlet. Right over the eye. Then he slowly put his hand back into the gauntlet. “Now it's time for the oath. I should warn you in advance, my oath is not your oath. Bit different. Great Solomon... I pledge my life... blah, blah, blah... Nah. So cliché” Nathaniel said emphasizing. “Let me show you what a real oath looks like. My own creation.” Said Nathaniel, smiling. “Damn old Solomon,” Nathaniel started, looking the goatee man straight in the

eye, "I swear on the soul of my father that I will fight in your name and do what you ask. Following the steps of the scroll I will fulfill the purpose of being Headknight." Said Nathaniel and there was a moment of silence.

"It didn't work." Said the Headknight. Nathaniel opened his mouth to protest when the gauntlet began to glow. Magical streams of light flowed through the channels and gathered in the eye. And slowly the lid of the eye opened. The commander held out his hand as he stood up. "I apologize, child of Colder, for accusing you of stealing your own belongings, your own inheritance. But I am sure you will understand. I could not let the gauntlet be stolen, I had to be sure you are the one son of Colder." The commander then pointed to Rose and Scatt. "Your friends?"

"Yeah."

With the order of the Headknight. soldiers immediately released both of them.

"And by the way who hell are you?" Nathaniel asked, trying to hide his excitement.

"I am Headguard Hadrick. My military unit is called the Guardians, as my title suggests. We are a unit sworn to keep the balance of magic in your world. For centuries we have been covering the signs of the Kingdom of Destiny. We make sure that no one knows about magic, the great power of Solomon or the Kingdom of Destiny. Exempt, of course, the Headknights and their descendants. You must be hungry. Follow me." He said.

While all the men in the room were saluting Nathaniel, Headguard started to walk towards the door. Three of them followed him. Nathaniel was moving as fast as he could to keep up with him, walking in the same rhythm. Rose and Scatt followed them behind.

"How long have you been on Mount Everest?" Nathaniel asked as he walked fast.

“Since the first Headguard, I think.”

“Damn, it means centuries! But did anyone know you were here all this time? Were you in contact with the other guards?”

Hedrick slowed his pace and turned to Nathaniel.

“I think you have a lot of questions, brother. Well, I'll answer as many as I can. Very few people know we exist. Now you are one of them.”

“Great!” said Nathaniel with smiling eyes.

They walked through the long corridors and stopped in front of one of the wooden doors and immediately one of the two guards in front of the door opened it. The head guard went ahead and went inside. The others stayed in line.

The interior was like a section of an inn. Wooden tables, soldiers sitting at the tables clinking mugs in their hands, the smell of food coming from behind the closed door... The head guard sat down at one of the tables. He gestured for them to sit down. Without hesitation, Nathaniel sat across from the Headguard. Rose and Scatt sat next to Nathaniel. The Headguard raised his hand and made a gesture, and the man who had taken the signal entered with quick steps through the door from which the fragrances were coming.

“Now I would like to ask you a few questions, why did you come here?”

“Well, if we start from the beginning, we found the scroll of the Solomon, Headguard Hadrick. And when I picked up the scroll, he showed me something, probably you know that I have the ability of seeing a vision.”

“Of course. Who wouldn't know the story of Colder?”

“Right.” Nathaniel said with disappointment that he did not know. “Anyways I see few things. A man, a book, Solomon

and..." Nathaniel paused briefly and then continued. "That's it. Lastly, that old man showed me himself."

"I suggest you to speak more respectfully, when you speak of heir of Magic, King Solomon." Headguard said.

"I apologize. I suppose you're right." Nathaniel quickly tried to change the subject. "By the way my name is Nathaniel, Nathaniel Cooper. I realized I didn't mentioned it."

"Nathaniel kin of Coldor, pleased to meet with you." He said and held his hand. Nathaniel shook it.

"And getting to the point. We can't read the writing on the scroll, and I think the only one I know who could read it is here. in your base."

"Maybe I can read it too." Said the headguard and Scatt looked at Nathaniel waiting for his approval. When Nathaniel nodded, he put his hand where his bag should be.

"You still have our things."

"Oh yes, you're right. After dinner they will be yours again. And this man you're looking for, is he one of my guards?"

"No. I think you're holding him prisoner. Professor Elnore, also known as the Explorer. He must have come here a few years ago. A few groups of soldiers came after him."

The Headguard stroked his goatee and thought for a moment. "Reidola keeps a record of who tries to get in. After lunch, she'll take you to the person you're looking for. And if you need anything else, feel free to ask. My men are in your command."

"Thank you, Hadrick." Nathaniel said, his gaze focused at the man behind the headguard. The big man was coming toward them with a tray. He placed the tray on the wooden table. On the tray were bowls of soup, still steaming. Next to the bowls were stewed meats on large plates. On another plate were various vegetables. The guard

holding the tray distributed everything on the table and left the them alone with all the foods.

“You can eat as much as you want. There are more inside.” Said the Headguard and took the small bowl from the long plate and downed the soup in one swallow. Nathaniel froze with the fork in his hand and looked at the Headguard. He smiled, put the fork down, picked up the bony meat and began to nibble. Scatt ate with fork and spoon without sacrificing his gentlemanly manners. Rose, on the other hand, did not eat very politely, nor did she eat like Nathaniel.

“So, tell me about you and your men. Where is your Base hidden? In a mountain like mine? Or under the sea maybe?” Hedrick asked, the juices from the meat he had eaten soaking into his beard.

“Better than that. The best place to hide something is in a place that’s in sight.” Said Nathaniel, narrowing his eyes and smiling.

“I disagree with you.” Said the headguard and leaned forward, his hand behind his back. He quickly raised the dagger he was gripping and stabbed it into the table. “My dagger is not hidden right now.”

“It’s not, Headguard. Our base is a library.”

“Then it’s not hidden. Everyone can see the library, right?”

“Yes, but the secret part of our base is underground. The library is just for show.”

“So it’s not in plain sight. It’s hidden.” Said the Headguard. “My base is inside the mountain and yours is underground.”

Nathaniel took a deep breath to explain, but exhaled without using it. He accepted, downed the small bowl in front of him in one gulp, as did the Headguard.

“We’ve had enough rest, let’s go to this prisoner.” Nathaniel said after the soup. The Headguard stood up. Nathaniel, Rose and Scatt did the same.

"Follow me." Said the leader of the guards. And he started walking. Nathaniel took his place next to the headguard and Rose followed behind. Scatt was about to go with Rose when he saw the knife on the table. He grabbed the hilt with one arm and tried to pull it out. After pulling with all his strength, he was able to pull the knife out. He quickened his steps and came up to Hadrick.

"Headguard, you left your dagger on the table." Scatt said, grabbing the end of the knife and handing it to Hadrick. Hadrick looked at Scatt's face. "Keep it. You'll need that."

"Why..." Scatt said and swallowed, then continued. "Why would we need it?" he asked.

"You know the rebels are looking for the same thing you have found. At least the descendants of the them. They will try to walk the path you will go. A lot of people are going to die at the end of this. All of you will have to kill someone. If you find the book before they do, there won't be a problem. But if they get the book, we're doomed. Dark magic will corrupt them and make a terrible pact. They will sell their souls for more power. And the souls will be just a small soldier in the army that spreads darkness. But don't worry, I trust you. I believe you will succeed."

"Your trust made me so relaxed." Nathaniel mumbled. "It's nothing serious. Except that if we don't find a damn book, the world will face with its fucking end!" He raised his voice for the last sentence.

"No, the world won't end if you lose the book." Hedrick said, shaking his head from side to side. "It would be much worse."

At the end of the deathly silent corridor walk, they came to a training room filled of armor and weapons. Inside, two, three or four men were practicing in rings a meter off the ground. Some were trying to knock down their opponents with their bare hands, while others were clashing large axes in their hands. A woman was practicing on one of the closer rings. The moment the Headguard

entered, she knocked the man off his feet. The woman got out of the ring as the big man collapsed. She walked over to the headguard and his company, who were waiting by the door. She was dressed in leather and fur. Around her neck she wore a necklace with teeth. Her brown hair ended before falling over her shoulders. After a short conversation with the Headguard, Nathaniel touched Hadrick's shoulder.

"I wonder if she speaks English too?" Nathaniel asked.

"Yes, she speaks." The woman replied for herself.

"Reidola, this young man, Nathaniel." Hedrick gestured to Nathaniel standing next to him. "Show her your gauntlet, boy." Nathaniel held up the gauntlet he wore on one hand.

"I am Nathaniel Cooper, the rightful heir to the gauntlet of Colder, the Headknight." Nathaniel said, puffing out his chest.

"And this is my daughter, Reidola." Hadrick said, gesturing to the woman standing next to him.

"Nice to meet you." Said Nathaniel.

"Reidola, Nathaniel wants to know if we've caught anyone who have tried to break into the cave in the last few years."

After a little bit of thinking she answered.

"Yes, there was an old man. And then two groups of armed men. Actually, the old man is the second prisoner I kept record of. My father was in charge of this mission before me."

"Can you take us to him?"

"I would love to, but that old man is dead." Said Reidola. He spoke in a cold tone, just like his father. Only his voice was thinner. Nathaniel froze.

"come again."

"he is dead. I'm sorry, son of Coldor."

"Fuck!" shouted Nathaniel and covered his face with his gloved hand. He began to breathe deeply. He took his hands away from his face again. "All right. We need to think calmly." He said and continued to breathe deeper for a while.

"So, do you have anything on the guy? Maybe he had something when he came here. Maybe... Maybe not a thing but someone. Did he have a cellmate?"

"His belongings were buried with him. I can have his grave exhumed if you want." Reidola squinted and thought for a while. "There was a young man the old man talked to all the time."

"Let's talk to that prisoner first. If that doesn't work, we'll try to get the explorer's things."

"Reidola will accompany you from here. I have some business to attend to." Hedrick said and turned to his daughter. "Reidola, take care of our guests. Don't forget that Nathaniel is a Headknight. In the meantime, return their belongings when you take them to the cells." Said Hadrick and started heading down the corridor in the direction they had come from.

"Follow me." Reidola said emotionlessly and headed in the opposite direction to the way the Headguard had gone. As she walked down the corridor she called out to one of the men. The man with his beard tied up, standing by one of the doors, came up to Reidola and started walking with her. After Reidola spoke to him, the man quickened his pace and disappeared into the corridors.

"He'll bring your belongings to the holding cells."

"Thank you." Scatt said with a small smile.

As they entered through the metal door, one of the two men in front of the door removed the torch from the wall, handed it to Reidola and accompanied them with his friend standing on the other

side of the door. Reidola and Nathaniel were now walking at the front, Rose and Scatt in the middle and the two guards at the back. The guards were watching out for hands coming out of the bars around them. Guard's one hands were on the weapons they carried at their waist. They were looking around with their eyes.

After a while Reidola began to advance, shining the torch into the cells. She moved in front of the cells without stopping. She was just glancing at the prisoners, pointing the torch at them. After passing through dozens of cells with iron bars, they found themselves in front of metal doors. After passing several metal doors, Reidola slowed her steps and stopped. Squinting, she glanced at the cell doors around him, one by one. She pointed to one of the cells. "gave an order in her language, and without hesitation, the larger of the guards behind her stepped in front of the door, took out the key ring hanging on his belt. He grabbed one of the keys and unlocked it. He stepped to the door pulling it towards him. When Reidola stepped forward, Nathaniel stepped back and entered after her. Behind the metal door, there was a man in chains. He was sitting on the floor with his hands chained to the wall. It was not hard to see the cuts and bruises on his wrists from the metal chain. Likewise, it was impossible not to see the cuts on his bare chest. With his head bowed, the man looked up as he heard the metal door open. He looked at those standing in the doorway with great anger.

The man looked at Nathaniel who had come in after Reidola. He stared at Nathaniel for a while. Nathaniel looked back. Finally the man started to speak "You... You're not one of them. But you're not handcuffed either." He turned his fury gaze back to Reidola.

"You shared a cell with Professor Elnore. You must have spoken to him. Do you know why he came here?" Nathaniel asked in a calm and as soft as possible tone.

"Yes." The man murmured.

“Why did he come?”

The man sighed and reluctantly answered the question. “He was looking for me.”

“So... so you know him! And how long have you known him?”

“Since I was a kid.”

“We need your help!” Nathaniel said, his voice rising with excitement.

“Why should I help you?”

“Because we are not asking for us we are asking it for all the world. If we can't achieve what we are trying to, the world will be in great danger.

“Professor Elnore and my father were very close friends and the Professor taught my father an alphabet, a language. Did the professor tell you anything about Solomon?”

“Yes. Every fucking day.”

“Are you one of the knights?”

“No.”

“Then why?”

“Maybe that's because the Professor was a descendant of that old man!” the man shouted.

Nathaniel's eyes widened.

“Solomon... The great sorcerer?” Nathaniel asked. He was still reeling from what he had just heard.

“He's the only Solomon I know.” The man said indifferently.

“Damn it! So... Last things Solomon did? Or... Or do you know anything about the book?”

The man stared at the wall behind Nathaniel for a moment as if he hadn't heard what Nathaniel had said. Then he turned his gaze directly into Nathaniel's eyes.

“If you want to make a deal, you have to untie my hands.”

“Do you have anything worth making a deal for?”

“I don't think you have the comfort of questioning.”

“Have I met you before?” said Nathaniel, putting aside all seriousness. “Because I could have sworn I've seen you somewhere before.”

“I have no idea who you are.” The man said, and Nathaniel put a gloved hand to his chin. He squinted at him. Then he stood up. The prisoner's gaze was fixed on Nathaniel's gauntlet. Nathaniel turned and walked out of the cell. He leaned against the wall in front of the door.

“What are you going to do?” Rose said as she walked out of the cell.

“I've never liked the guard system. Maybe the guy in there is here because he made a card trick. Nobody knows.” Said Nathaniel. His eyes were looking at the dark corridor surrounded by cells on both sides.

“Except Reidola.”

“You're right.” Nate said and took a deep breath. He opened and closed his eyes, “You know, that guy in there is telling the truth. He might be our only chance.”

Nathaniel re-entered the cell. “Let's go to our table to make a deal. I guess they don't feed you well. Prepare this man a nice meal. And a decent place to make a deal.” He turned his gaze to the man in

chains, "I can arrange many things, my friend, but I can't uncuff him. As a precaution."

Reidola looked at Nathaniel with furious eyes.

"What are you talking about? We can't get him out of his cell!"

"It's not a request, Reidola, it's an order from the Headknight." Said Nathaniel in a cold, icy voice.

Reidola sighed loudly. Reluctantly she gave the order to the guards to carry out the order given by the head guard. The guard holding the keys unlocked the man's handcuffs. For a few seconds the black-haired man enjoyed his freedom, rubbing his worn wrists. It was short-lived. Immediately afterwards they put the small handcuffs on his hands. The man sighed.

"Let's go and make our deal." Nathaniel said with a smile.

The guards, who had never seen a criminal being taken out of his cell before, looked at the handcuffed man in front of them in surprise but tried not to show it. The guards took him by both arms and led him to the mess hall. Nathaniel, with the confidence of being the Headknight, saluted a few men around him and continued on his way. They entered the mess hall and Nathaniel pointed to one of the tables. As the guards seated the prisoner at the table, the guard with the braided beard returned to his post after handing the three bags back to Rose, Scatt and Nathaniel. Nathaniel looked at the guards surrounding the table.

"Scatt, can you hand me the scroll?" Nathaniel said, holding out his hand. Scatt placed the scroll in Nathaniel's bare hand and sat down next to Nathaniel. "Before we begin, I want to know your name."

"My name is Ian. Ian James Fate."

“All right. James,” Nathaniel said and cautiously placed his gloved hand on the other side of the parchment. When nothing happened, he exhaled deeply and opened the Scroll. He placed it on the table, turned it over and handed it to James. James frowned and looked at the paper. “Can you read this writing?”

James looked at the parchment and quickly answered.

“Unfortunately not. the only one who could read it died at the hands of your big friends. They locked him up in this filthy prison,” James said in a dull voice.

“Then you are useless to me.” Said Nathaniel and sat up. He turned his back. He started walking. As he stood up, the two guards next to James grabbed his arms. They forced him to his feet.

“I thought the object you were looking for was more important than the path you took.” James said calmly as he stood up. He seemed in no hurry to get away from the guards.

Nathaniel stayed where he was, before turning his head back to look at James' face. Then he turned back and sat down. He gestured for the two guards to sit James down.

“What do you mean?” Nathaniel asked, frowning.

“This scroll belongs to Solomon, doesn't it? And you believe it will lead you to the book. I don't know where it will lead you, but if I were Solomon, I would create a very long and arduous path to find the book that the first rebels tried to seize, the one with the magic hidden in it, and I would put the scroll at the very beginning.”

Nathaniel squinted his eyes and sat again in front of him.

“How much you know about the book?”

“When I was a child, the professor was the only one who came to our house. The last of Rehoboam's line. And my father was a very close friend of his. My father got used to helping the Professor

try to find that sacred magical book that his ancestors told him about.”

“And did he find it?” asked Nathaniel excitedly.

“He was very close. He would have found it by now.” Ian paused for a moment. “If some asshole hadn't stabbed him to death three times!” James's calm voice grew louder as he neared the end of the sentence. The anger filling his eyes was now clearly visible.

“I'm sorry to hear that.” Said Rose, “And your father's studies. Do you know where they are?”

“Sort of.” Said Ian and looked at Nathaniel. Nathaniel squinted at James for a moment as he looked at him. His eyes widened with a twinkle. He shook his head slightly.

“Could you excuse me for a moment?” said Nathaniel and quickly jumped up. Although he stumbled at first, he regained his footing without falling. With quick steps he walked towards Reidola, who was watching them leaning against the wall. Reidola was frowning and looking at Nathaniel who was coming towards her. When Nathaniel got in front of Reidola, he grabbed her arm and pulled her aside. Reidola was about to protest when Nathaniel whispered in her ear. “Is there any chance you remember James' crime, that he stole a... a piece of magical equipment? Maybe... a sword?” She searched her mind for answers.

“Yes.” Said Reidola, responding in the same tone. “How do you know?” she asked raising one eyebrow.

“What else do you know?” Nathaniel asked, ignoring Reidola's question.

“I know he killed a man with that sword.”

“Damn it!” Nathaniel said Nathaniel. “I think it's time for a meeting.”

Nathaniel called Rose and Scatt to him. As they left the table, Reidola sat down to keep an eye on the prisoner. When the man with the tray of food for James walked past Nathaniel and came to the table, Nathaniel looked around once more, making sure no one could hear him.

“It’s same person with the scroll showed me. Reidola said he came here to get a magical sword and kill someone with it. Just like in the vision, the scroll showed me another way. A new one because the first one was closed. And as James said, it’s not the path we follow, it’s what we seek. We have to make the deal with James.”

“Besides, this is our last chance.” Rose said and gestured to the table. Nathaniel stood up and moved towards the table again. When he got to the table Reidola stood up and made way for Nathaniel. Nathaniel sat down opposite James, who was eating his food with great appetite.

“I think it’s time we discussed the terms of the agreement.”

“You’re right.” James said and swallowed his mouthful. “My part is simple. I will help you until you get the book and make sure the rebels are defeated, and you will ensure my freedom and safety. I’ll be untouchable, and I want my things back, and of course...” James looked down at his three bare chests. “Give me some decent clothes.”

“You heard the terms Reidola.” Said Nathaniel, pulling the scroll away from James, rolling it over and handing it to Reidola. “If your father can’t read the writing on the scroll, tell him the deal.” Reidola nodded and left the dining hall.

Nathaniel looked at James with great attention.

“Who was the one you killed with the sword?”

James took another big bite of his food. He chewed slowly and when he swallowed he replied. “None of your business.” He said

in a stern tone and started eating again. Nathaniel responded with a sigh.

Soon Reidola returned and handed him the parchment, shaking his head from side to side. "He can't read. And..."

"And?"

Reidola took a deep breath "he said he trusted you with the deal. He said you could take the prisoner if you wanted to."

"That's good news!" said Nathaniel and turned back to James. "James, the deal is simple. You will come with us handcuffed until you help us find the book. After we find the book, we will uncuff you and you will be released."

"If you want me to help you, you must remove the handcuffs. Otherwise you will have to find someone else who knows where the book is."

Nathaniel took a deep breath. "I guess you'll do the opposite of what I say for the duration of the mission. All right, I accept. Welcome to the team, Ian James Fate." Nathaniel got up from the table. "Let's get out of here!" he said excitedly. "I hope Alfred is okay. Otherwise one of us will have to drive the plane." He turned to Reidola. "Are you packing the food?" he asked.

They started walking the way they had been dragged inside. Nathaniel walked side by side with Reidola, occasionally doing his best to make sure the guards he passed could see his gauntlet. As they passed through the field in the mountain, Scatt turned to the guard who was right behind them.

"You've done really well. Congratulations." He said with a small smile. He hoped the guard understood what he was saying.

They walked out of the field and through the tunnels lit dimly by the torchlight for a while. As they neared the exit, Rose glanced into the cave with the crystals that she and Scatt had entered.

She quickened her pace and joined Reidola and Nathaniel. "What's in there?" she asked curiously.

"All I can tell you is that if you go that way, they won't even find your body. The guards in front of the entrance protect you from the inside, not the inside from you." Said Reidola. Rose nodded her head in understanding.

After the end of the torches, they walked in the dark cave for a while. When they came out of the darkness, they barely opened their eyes for a while. Nathaniel turned around. He raised his hand.

"See you again, guardian Reidola." Said Nathaniel, who turned back with his back to them.

"See you soon, Headknight." She said and disappeared into the dark cave.

"I hope you are good at mountain climbing. Or in our case, mountain descending." Nathaniel said, turning to James.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Solomon's eyes were dazzled by the all-encompassing white light. He closed his eyes tightly.

“Just trust the magic!” said the same voice as by the sea.
“All you have to do is give yourself over to the magic!”

Solomon opened his tightly closed eyes. He was on the battlefield. Was watching Valefar who was throwing the spear second at Rodrin. And with yellow flames from the eyes of Solomon, the spear stayed in the air. He felt his strength grow with the white light that made him blind. He could feel the warmth spreading from his chest to his whole body and it made Solomon feel better. Trusting the power what Solomon did.

He realized, The spear was not the only thing that stopped. Everything around him stopped. He went to Rodrin, knowing he could no longer hold this spell. Blood oozed from the claw marks on his face. He put his hand on his chest. Rodrin sat up, breathing deeply as if he was about to suffocate. His large eyes focused on the spear

hanging in the air. Solomon lifted Azderson and then Windsor. He looked at his team, who stared at him in astonishment.

“The spell won't last much longer! We must get to the tower at once! Hurry! Follow me!”

As Solomon and his companions disappeared into the ruins and the spear flew quickly into the empty wall, Valefar spun around angrily. He could not see Solomon or his other friends. “Go and find them!” he said, gritting his teeth in anger.

They continued through the ruins, watching their backs every few minutes. There was no sign of the creatures. No sign of whether they were after them or not. All they knew was that they were getting closer and closer to the tower. They made it out of the ruins and walked through the withered forest. On both sides of the path they passed flowers with their heads bowed. After a while they decided it would be better to leave the path and go through the forest. They continued on their way, trampling the grass between the trees. They passed a structure of jet-black pillars surrounded by ivy.

When they finally stopped, they were all smiling. The tower of stone blocks reached to the sky in all its splendor. Solomon grasped the iron handle of the double-hinged wooden door. Frowning, he let go of the handle without turning it and put his hand on the door. He was doing as the voice told, the voice become a thought-like or an instinct-like rather than a voice to listens. As if his hand was being drawn with a magical, invisible chalk, a yellow light emanating from a point drew the shape of Solomon's hand. When the drawing was complete, Solomon withdrew his hand from the door and a circle formed around the hand symbol. Then the runes surrounded it and the lines stretched all around the door. It glowed brighter and brighter and dimmed. The door creaked open slowly.

Solomon did not wait until it was fully open before he stepped inside. He turned around to make sure the others were following. When he saw them coming in single file, he continued on his way. They walked down the first corridor they came to. It was

short and dark. After taking a few steps into it, with the last step of Solomon the torches on the wall, buried in the darkness, began to burn. When the last of the torches in the corridor was lit, the steps at the end of the corridor were illuminated. Rodrin picked up one of the torches on the wall as they made their way up the winding staircase.

When they reached the first floor, they found an empty floor and continued on. On the second floor there were several wooden tables. On one of them were small jars of ink and a few quills. On one or two others there were stacks of parchment papers. Behind the tables, the shelves that filled the remaining spaces were filled with books. The third floor, like the second, was a library. And the fourth, and the fifth... They kept going up.

Windsor stopped, panting. He bent down and put his hands on his knees. Breathing deeply, he looked around. he looked at the dusty floor with the shelves and the desk and the chairs around the desk. He straightened his back and continued up the stairs.

As the light from the torch in Rodrin's hand illuminated the steps, strange noises could be heard coming from upstairs. Slowly and carefully he made his way upstairs, the voices coming from behind the glowing bars. The creatures that saw the light could be heard growling as they shook the bars.

"Let's keep going." Said Solomon and continued up the stairs. Windsor was once again having trouble breathing. he stopped. But he didn't wait long. When he saw the red eyes behind the bars, he kept going.

They saw many floors filled with different things. After a few floors full of beds, they made it to the end of the stairs. Windsor's face was red and he sat on the step as they ascended. Rodrin and Azderson were also out of breath, though not as much as Windsor. Solomon could feel the magic flowing through him. He was not tired at all. On the contrary, he felt stronger.

Solomon took a few steps towards the door opposite him. Then he stopped and turned around.

“Stay here if you want. Rest.”

“I'm coming with you.” Rodrin said. Azderson nodded in agreement. All three of them were now crouched on the step, staring at the plump Windsor.

What are you looking at? Of course I'm in! Sure...” he held out his hands. “though, I could use a little help.” Rodrin took Windsor by one hand and Azderson by the other and helped her to her feet.

Solomon put his hand on the door handle and this time he swung it open. The light shining behind the door caused Rodrin, Azderson and Windsor to close their eyes. But it didn't affect Solomon much. He just squinted against the white light. He moved into the light and disappeared from the sight.

“Protector,” Solomon said, as Rodrin, Azderson and Windsor covered their faces so they could see nothing but hear all. “You have something that belongs to me. Something I inherited, and I have come to claim it.”

“Welcome, Sorcerer Solomon! I do not yet know if you are worthy of your inheritance,” said a calm, ordinary voice from the light. There was not even a tone in his voice. “So I will come with you, though I am not your companion in the meantime. I will only be with you to ensure the safety of the metal. But you must know that I was made for war and if I find you are not worthy of the metal, I will take it from you.”

“I agree. Now, will you give me the metal?”

“Of course!” said the voice and the white light faded. The men slowly removed their arms from in front of their eyes and They opened their eyes to see him, the owner of the voice. He was larger than a man, kneeling in front of the huge chest. In his silver armor he resembled a knight. A lush green bush grew on the right shoulder of

his armor. Branches with sharp thorns reached down from the bush and wrapped around the green armor up to the wrist. On his left arm, half of the fire symbol was visible, just above the wrist. On his chest, three long arrowheads pointed in different directions, a blue liquid swirled in the one on the right. The one pointing upwards was split in two, bright gold on one side and black on the other.

Solomon reached for the chest to open it, but before he could, the Protector grabbed the two handles of the metal chest and stood up. As he stood up, the tower seemed to sway, the armored man a statue just beginning to move. He stood up, small pieces and dust scattering around the armor.

“If you open the hatch, the creatures will sense the magic and it will make you a completely open target so we will transport it with it's chest.”

“Let's get going,” Solomon said, and with a sudden gust of wind, white wings spread in all their splendor from the protector's back.

The protector turned around. Gigantic, barely fitting into the room, curled its wings and emerged through the arched doorway behind it onto the balcony. Solomon and his companions followed. They entered a balcony that was wide open. Protector spread his wings wide. The white wings were now more clearly visible. As the wings opened fully, Solomon and the others stepped back, their eyes widening. The protector began to take off, flapping its giant wings. After some distance, he slowly began to descend down the tower.

“Do you have wings too?” Rodrin asked, still not believing his eyes. His gaze was still on the Protector.

“Not to my knowledge.” Solomon said, unable to take his gaze off the Protector. “But I wish I did.”

When they left the tower, all but Solomon were panting again. Solomon let them rest for a short while and then they set off. The Protector flapped his wings and flew a few feet above the

ground. As if invisible, he flew straight ahead, ignoring the creatures. The chest in his hand seemed light as he carried it, as if it were filled with feathers. Solomon and the others were ducking a little behind the trees.

All that could be heard through the trees was the flapping of the Protector's wings and the sound of grass crunching under people's feet. As they walked towards the volcano rising from behind the trees, Solomon suddenly stopped.

"Be careful! There are incoming!" he said, and growls could be heard. The men picked up their weapons. The shadows behind the trees were moving. They came towards quickly. Only one of them was walking slowly. The pale-skinned Valefar took his time walking through the creatures.

"Hold out your weapons!" Solomon said, and his men did as they were told. All three held out their spears. Solomon quickly made a fist and moved it in front of the weapons. First the golden ring glowed, then the weapons. As the creatures surrounded them, Solomon flipped the axe in one hand and handed it to Rodrin.

"Keep it." Solomon said as Rodrin gripped the axe tightly and took his position.

"Protect Solomon!" said Rodrin.

"I can take care of myself," said Solomon and clenched his fists at his sides and in front of him. The inside of his ringed hand glowed as he slowly moved his other hand away from it. The shining metal was revealed in the lights. And Solomon quickly withdrew his hand, pulling the sword from his hand as if drawing it from its scabbard. "Protector, we could use your help right now. You were made for war. This is war."

"This is not the battle I was expecting, Solomon, I'll be waiting for you at the end of the road," the Protector said, and with a flap of his great wings he took to the air and flew away.

"Damn it. Looks like we're on our own." said Solomon and ran towards the nearest creature with his sword.

Solomon stepped back and thrust his sword sideways into the belly of the creature as it tried to pounce on him. The creature screamed, spilling its black blood, and its scream faded into silence. He swung at another from the side and missed. The creature leapt at Solomon and he and Solomon fell to the ground. The creature raised its claw and a spear pierced its head. as Windsor drew his spear Solomon dodged under the carcass as Windsor drew his spear.

Azdersen emerged from Windsor's side and swung his spear swiftly. As the spear found its target, he raised it into the air. The creature died as its feet lifted a few feet into the air. Azdersen turned in the direction of the snarl, and when he turned around, the creature before him was struck down with an axe blow. Rodrin pulled the axe from the body. Another of the creatures attacked Azdersen's arm. Azdersen screamed in pain as he looked at the creature biting his bleeding arm. It wasn't pulling its fangs out of his flesh, it was sinking in deep. Rodrin, who was a few steps ahead of him, threw his axe. Azdersen took it and, like an executioner, chopped off the creature's head.

Windsor grabbed his spear by the very end of its shaft and swung it to the side. He made a scratch on the creature's face. He leapt into the air and raised his spear. Without landing, he quickly threw it at the creature's head. When he landed, he drew the spear that had nailed the creature's head to the ground. When the first pull failed, he put one foot on the creature's head and tried again. Just as his spear came out, another jumped on him from the side.

There was no end to the creatures. New ones kept coming and their numbers were growing. Solomon skillfully dodged the claws of the creatures and moved towards his target. Valefar was his target. When Valefar realized this, he too began to walk towards him like Solomon.

Solomon swung his sword through the air. Valefar clapped both hands together and caught the sword in mid-air. He kicked Solomon in the stomach from below. Solomon was knocked off his feet. He saved his sword as he fell to the ground. Valefar was not going to let Solomon go. He rushed forward and swung his claw-like hands with sharp nails.

As the claws closed in on Solomon, there was a brief whistle and a white arrow pierced Solomon's palm, scratching Solomon's arm. Everyone who heard the sound and saw the arrow turned in the direction from which it came. A man in leather armor emerged from the dark trees. He took another arrow from the quiver on his back and placed it in his bow.

"Heir to magic, the best units of the Destinay Kingdom are honored to serve you and your magic." Solomon smiled and grasped the metal arrow in the distracted Valefar's hand. He drew it towards him and swung his sword swiftly. Valefar, who recovered at the last moment, tried to step back and save his head, but Solomon's target was not his head. His arrow-stabbed arm collapsed to the ground. Valefar staggered backwards in pain, holding the cut with one hand.

"You're too brave for a bloody human!" the creature managed to say.

At that moment more shadows began to move around the trees. The shadows of bipedal beings were coming from all sides. Men in the same leather armor as the archer man began to appear around the creatures.

"Like I said. The best unit in the kingdom." the archer said with a smile on his face. "My troops are at your disposal. Pren... King Rodrin."

"Attack!" said Rodrin.

White, embroidered arrows flashed through the air. Whistling, they found their targets. They flew swiftly, stabbing into the creatures. Suddenly Solomon felt the wind of the arrow passing in

front of his face, but it did not stop him. He kept moving towards Valefar. The creatures tried to run towards the men of the kingdom as they were struck down by white arrows. But before they were halfway there, they were knocked down by arrows to the head.

Valefar saw Solomon raging towards him. Behind him, his soldiers were falling one by one. His rigid body began to deform as he slowly took a step backwards. Gradually the dark mist surrounded him and he himself began to take on the consistency of the mist around him.

“You're not going anywhere!” said Solomon and swung his sword at the half-fog creature. The sword passed through it and came out the other side.

“Oh you humans! You think the sword can hurt everything!” he said as he became transparent.

“But magic can!” said Solomon and swung his right fist at the creature. The ring glowed as it touched the dark mist and knocked Valefar to the ground.

“Next time...”

“There won't be another time, Valefar!” said Solomon and held out his fist towards him. The ring glowed brighter and brighter. First the shadows around Valefar slowly moved towards Solomon's glowing ring and were drawn to it, then Valefar in screaming shadow form.

Solomon turned around. He saw two soldiers in leather armor lying among the creature carcasses on the ground. Up ahead, Windsor lay on the ground. Both of his friends were on their knees by their friend's head.

“Help!” Rodrin shouted. “Somebody help!”

The two armored men crouched beside Windsor, looked at the wound where the blood was pouring fast, and clumsily bandaged it and carried it away.

“My king...” the archer said, coming over to Rodrin, who was watching Windsor leave. “It is not safe here.”

“You are right. Take Windsor back to your campsite with your men. We need to get to Solomon to the Exca's.”

“Then let me and my men go with you.”

“You know the Exca are not very hospitable. You make sure Windsor gets better.”

“Yes, sir.” Said the archer and disappeared into the forest with his men.

The closer they got, the more frightening it looked as smoke slowly belched from the burning mountaintop. No one spoke the whole way. Usually it was Windsor who spoke. Soon the silence was broken by the growing sound of wings. They grew louder the closer they got to the volcano. It was waiting for them in front of the mountain as if suspended in the air, Protector was flipping his wings. Solomon looked up. Then he took his gaze away from the Protector and approached the wall of the mountain. He spread his hands wide. A few words came out of his mouth, words he had never known before. As the rocks shuddered and dust settled around them, they moved and opened.

When the dust cleared and the entrance was visible, Solomon was the first to step inside. Inside was a large hall, decorated with different symbols. Torched, embossed pillars with torches were moving inward, raising the ceiling ten or fifteen meters. Giant, burly statues stood between some of the columns. Most of them held a hammer with a handle reaching to the floor. They wore a hooded cloak that fell back over their shoulders. In the silent corridor Solomon began to move forward.

He had been watching Solomon without making the slightest sound since he had closed his protective wings and entered. Solomon moved quickly, leaving the giant arched doors behind him. The door at the end of the corridor was bigger than the other doors, and the statues on either side were even bigger.

A giant shadow grew from the door at the end of the path.

"Who dares to trespass on the mountain of the great blacksmiths?" he said in a deep voice.

Solomon raised his hand so that the man could see the ring.

"Great blacksmith, do you know this ring?"

The blacksmith's angry groan echoed through the empty hall, "Know it, you say? I made Orin that ring, the ring to help him use magic, and you stole it?"

Solomon rolled his eyes and sighed. "Why does everyone think I stole this ring?" he said, showing how uncomfortable he was, "We both know it's impossible to steal anything from Orin. With his magic, he could turn me into dust in an instant."

"And who are you to claim that Orin gave you the ring?"

"I am Solomon, son of David. the new heir to magic. And I need you, great blacksmith, for the salvation of this world."

"If Orin has chosen you, we are honored to serve you!" the man said, stepping through the arched doorway into the torchlight.

"My name is Duricrod. I am the chief blacksmith of Orin." Said the blacksmith, dressed in a cloak like the statues. He moved between the pillars, banging the handle of the long hammer he held in his hand against the ground.

"Are you alone here?"

“If I were alone, there would be no point in me being the head blacksmith. Wouldn't it? So no. I am not alone. You can find at least eight blacksmiths on this burning mountain! The remnants of our people have taken refuge on this mountain. Our forges.”

He moved closer to Solomon. Then he turned his gaze to the Protector. “Protector,” he nodded. He said. The Protector merely nodded. He turned back to Solomon. “Follow me, master of magic.” Solomon did as he was told without question.

After passing under several stone arches, they found themselves next to a staircase. Solomon, Azderson and Rodrin climbed the steps in silence and with their heads bowed. Before they reached the end of the steps, the blacksmith entered one of the corridors. The others continued to follow. Soon they passed through an arched doorway, much smaller than the one they had seen before. The other side of the door led to a pathway surrounded on both sides by lava. On the opposite side stood a double-leaf door. Two men in armor and with axes stood guard in front of it.

Carefully they walked through the lava, which bubbled and burst. Everyone except the protector and the blacksmith, their host, kept walking, looking at the lava that surrounded them on both sides. When they came to the door, the two guards quickly opened the doors on either side.

Blacksmith's tongs were hanging on one wall of the room they entered. There were different shapes of tongs and right next to it a hole had been drilled. Lava flowed down through the hole in the wall. It was following a path cut into the floor. At the end of the path was a huge circle with a huge star inside. It looked as if it had been drawn with lava. One of the triangles on the left side of the star didn't have lava just around it like the others. It was completely covered with lava. And on the back of the star's triangles was an anvil.

Blacksmith Duricrod turned to the Protector and said, “Open the chest!” “The creatures cannot sense the magic inside the mountain.” The Protector put the chest down and opened it. He took a

step back. He went to the blacksmith tongs. He leaned his hammer against the wall. He ran his hand in front of each one in turn and picked up one of the tongs. He opened and closed it several times as he moved towards the chest.

When he reached the top of the chest, he gripped the thin iron at the end with his tongs. Then he took the tongs in one hand. He held it up and examined it.

“Very impressive! I didn't think Orin could find more of this metal, I forged the ring from it.”

He took his hammer back from the wall. With slow, careful steps he stepped over the small rivers of lava and came to the anvil in the center of the star. And he plunged the metal into the lava up to where his tongs held it.

After a while, when he lifted the tongs, the metal came out of the lava in one piece. It looked as if it had been painted fire-red as the lava dripped from beneath it. Blacksmith Duricrod struck the metal against the pointed end of the anvil several times, making sure that all the lava was gone, and then put it on the anvil. He raised his hammer and began to beat the red metal. The metal was slowly changing shape, sending sparks flying all around.

Solomon watched the blacksmith with great curiosity. The sounds echoed around the room, sparks flying from the metal for a long time. Until the sound gradually faded and the room fell silent. The blacksmith Duricrod turned around and raised his tongs. The metal still glowed red, but it was not the curved metal of old. It was a long sword now. At least the metal part of it. Duricrod put the metal back on the anvil. He took a step back and quickly tapped the handle of his hammer on the ground. The tip of the hammer began to glow. The blacksmith struck the sword with the hammer. A faint yellow light spread around with a great clang. The blacksmith struck twice more and then stopped.

Duricrod put the tongs back where he had picked them up. He went back and picked up the cold piece of metal with the runes on it.

“Did you think I was an ordinary blacksmith, Solomon, son of David?” said the blacksmith, noticing Solomon's gaze. “Now all we need to do is to find a hilt and scabbard for the sword. And when we find the right hilt, the blacksmith's work will be ready and Excalibur, if we use the language you use when casting spells, will be ready to use.”

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

While the cold wind reddening and numbing their faces, they made it to the foothills of the mountain. Nathaniel said they would walk the rest of the way and led the way ahead. The others followed close behind. James was not as cold as the others in his fur clothes. The guards' furs kept him warm enough. He held his wrists where the metal cuffs used to be. When the icy wind blew against his wrists, the pain of the wounds was eased a little. It was comforting him.

James looked around himself as he made his way in and out of the gently drifting snow. It was the first time he had been outside in a long time. A small smile appeared on his face. He was going to be free. He turned his gaze to Nathaniel at the front. The leader of the group was moving forward without breaking his stride. The snowflakes that fell on the gauntlet on his hand instantly melted and disappeared. Just a step behind him was Rose. Her brown hair was tucked into the thick hood of her coat. Scatt remained behind. The one-armed man's accelerated breathing was audible.

After walking for a while, they saw the oncoming car. The black vehicle came towards them at speed. When it got close, the driver braked suddenly and swerved. As the car turned sideways, all the snow under the wheels fell on Nathaniel. Fred got out of the car as Nathaniel cursed silently. Smiling, he motioned them to the car.

Nathaniel sighed and got into the front seat. James sat in the back between Scatt and Rose.

“You were right, Nathaniel. The FBI came after me and the Chinese government intervened.”

Nathaniel grinned, “I knew it would work, it was my plan after all.” He said.

Fred started the car. Straightening the rearview mirror, he adjusted it so he could see James in the back seat.

“New member?” he asked.

“For now.” Said Nathaniel and looked back between the two front seats. “James, this is Alfred, our chauffeur-driven pilot.”

“Fred,” Fred corrected as he made a U-turn.

“And this is the temporary crew member James.” Nathaniel finished his sentence and sat down in his comfortable seat. He buckled his seat belt. “Let's get out of this cold place.”

Fred started the car. After a silent journey for a while, they reached the airport. The car stopped next to the plane. When everyone was on board, Nathaniel took out his metal flask and took a sip as usual. He took off his gauntlet and put it in the box next to him. He looked at his bandaged hand. When he felt no pain, he rested his head on the back of the seat and closed his eyes.

Scatt sat in one of the armchairs on the right side facing each other. He leaned his head against the glass and closed his eyes.

When James entered the plane, the first thing he did was look around. He looked at Nathaniel as he settled in, trying to be a drunk. Then he turned his gaze to Scatt. Scatt squirmed on the seat for a with closed eyes, trying to sleep. James began to walk between the seats. He spotted the seat at the back. He sat on the back window seat. Rose, who came in right behind him, sat on the seat directly opposite James. She looked curiously at the murderer standing in front of her. Then she turned her gaze out the window.

“Nathaniel, the plane is ready for takeoff.” Fred said, coming out of the cockpit. “Are we going home?”

Without opening his eyes Nathaniel asked. “James, now it's your turn. Where are we supposed to go?”

James pulled his gaze away from the airplane window. He took a deep breath.

“Seattle.”

“What? Really?”

“Yes, Why?”

“Because we are living there too.”

“Well it might shock you but some of the head knights try to gather all the people who might know something near of them in case of they might need them. So I am not originally from Seattle but my father were living there.”

“Damn. Alfred, we're going home.”

After a long journey, Fred made an announcement that the plane had landed. Scatt unbuckled his seat belt and got out of his seat. His numb feet made him uncomfortable for a while, but he recovered before he reached the stairs. James opened his eyes after the announcement. He lifted his head from the window. He opened and

closed his eyes, trying to regain consciousness. He stood up. First he looked at Nathaniel. He still looked drunk. Then he looked at Rose, who had fallen asleep right in front of him seems so peaceful. Rose was breathing heavily. James woke her up by nudging her on the shoulder. When Rose opened her eyes, she didn't realize where she was at first, but she came to. Seeing that Rose was awake, James followed Scatt off the plane.

The usual gray car was waiting for them outside the door. They got in. Nathaniel turned around as Fred started the car.

“James, how about giving me the address where we're going?”

“I can give you directions. Just head south out of town for now.” “I'm not going to tell you everything you want all at once, we'll take it step by step. That way I can secure my freedom as much as possible.”

“I hope we find that damn book soon.”

“You bet I want the same thing. What did you say your name was?”

Nathaniel sighed. “Nathaniel. Nathaniel Cooper.”

“I'm... I'm Scatt Flag.” Scatt introduced himself. James nodded to Scatt standing next to him and then turned his gaze to Rose sitting to his right. Rose turned to James who was looking at her with blue eyes. “Rose Anton.”

“it's nice to meet you, I hope.” James said looking at Rose, and crossed his arms.

After a while, they reached one of the neighborhoods where old, dilapidated houses lined up in the darkness of the city. The car drove down the streets one by one. The houses were old. They were houses that no one bothered to renovate. Some were still standing

because of old people who didn't want to sell their houses. Others no one wanted to buy.

"There!" James said quietly, making a face, pointing to a house. "That's my father's house."

The house, with its cracked facade, looked like a ruin. Pieces of wood, obviously fallen from the house, were scattered all over the garden. Broken pieces of roof tiles that had fallen from the roof were all around the house. From the rusty metal gate that stood in front of the garden, a path lined with stones led to the house.

Fred parked the car and waited in the car. The others got out and walked towards the house. James went ahead and pushed the rusty gate, which had been saved from collapsing backwards by a screw, and it opened with a creak that could be heard throughout the neighborhood. They walked down the small stone path that led from the garden gate to the door of the house.

Gas lamps hung on either side of the door, surrounded by rusted iron. James looked on both sides. When he was sure no one was there, he cautiously stood on tiptoe and picked up one of the gas lamps. The glass on all four sides hid what was inside the kerosene lamp. James ran his hand over all four corners of the lamp and grunted in satisfaction. With a small click, one surface of the kerosene lamp opened. James put his hand through the opening. When he pulled it out, he was holding a key. He looked back over his shoulder. Nathaniel was looking at James, one eyebrow raised.

"What? Did you expect me to hide it under the welcome mat or the vase?"

"James, can you look over there?" Nathaniel said, pointing his finger at the window of the house. The glass of the window lay shattered on the lawn. "Locking the door doesn't do much good. Anyone who wants to get into this house has already done so."

James took a deep breath and faced forward, ignoring Nathaniel. He unlocked the door. He pushed the door. "Welcome to

my home,” James said as the door creaked open. James said. As emotionless as ever.

They looked around the hallway where the wall coverings were swollen and torn. Paintings that had fallen off the wall were on display on the floor. Spiders had covered them with webs. A chandelier stood broken in the middle of the hallway. Glass from light bulbs was scattered around. The carpets were dirty. The weathered wooden doors were all closed.

“James, we're home, like you said. What do we do now?”

“We need to find my father's research, his files.”

“Where are they?”

“Somewhere in this house.”

“What do you mean! You promised to give us his research!”

“I know, and my promise still stands. That file is here somewhere. It's just waiting for us to find it.”

“And where do we start?” said Nathaniel with a sigh.

“Over there. In my father's study.”

Without saying anything, Nathaniel walked to the room James had pointed to. He turned the dirty handle of the door and walked in. The others were just a step behind him. Inside, like the rest of the house, it was as messy as if an earthquake had struck. It was a dark room. The curtains closed the window all the way. Just in front of the window was a wooden table. There was a bearded bust standing on the table. It was covered with cobwebs as if it were covered with a cloth. On the shelves on either side of the room, stretching from floor to ceiling, there were occasional books. The books that were supposed to fill the remaining gaps were lying on the floor. Some were open. Some were upside down. Some had trinkets on them.

"Instead of all of us searching the same room, why don't we spread out? After all, the files we are looking for are not simple things and could be anywhere in the house. That's why I say we split up." Nathaniel said without taking his gaze off the bust on the table.

"I agree with Nathaniel." said James. "I'm going upstairs,"

"Not alone! Rose is coming with you. I need to make sure you are not runnin away."

"All right. Have it your way." James said in a calm tone and turned away. He walked out of the study with heavy steps. Rose followed him, keeping a foot of distance between them.

James started up the winding staircase that led to the top. The ground creaked with each step. Rose was right behind him. Rose felt uncomfortable every time she heard the creak of the wooden steps.

The upstairs seemed smaller than the downstairs. There were only two rooms on this floor. Two rooms with wooden doors opposite each other. James went straight to one of the doors. "Let's start in this room first," he said as he turned the handle and opened the door. They went inside.

In the center of the room was a huge unmade bed. The bedspread was on the floor. Next to it was a nightstand with a night lamp and a photograph. To the right of the room was a big closet. One of the doors of the closet was open. Clothes were hanging out of it as if they were flowing from the closet onto the floor of the room. Some were already on the floor.

"Ian," Rose said, "before the guards took you prisoner. Did you live here?"

James took slow steps to the side of the bed, as if he hadn't heard the question at first. He picked up the photograph on the nightstand. It was taken on the wedding day of James's father and the mother he never knew. He stared at it for a while. "No, Rose. I was

living in France.” James said and put the picture back. “Let’s start looking.”

The inside of the closet, like the room, like the whole house, was a mess. Suits, sweaters, T-shirts, haphazardly stacked. It all looked like it had been kicked into the closet. Rose frowned and looked at the empty closet for a while. And then the room. It was more cluttered than it needed to be.

“Ian, why is this house so messy?”

“Because, Rose, my father is no ordinary murder victim. Because the bastard who killed him was looking for something. He was looking for the same thing we were, and he killed my dad for that damn book.” James said, his breathing quickening. Rose stopped for a moment. She looked at James, unresponsive.

“You killed him.” She said, not taking her gaze from James’ blue eyes. “You avenged your father, didn’t you? And the Guardians took you prisoner for it.”

James averted his gaze from Rose’s. He tried to swallow. “There’s nothing in this room. Let’s go to the other one.” He finally managed to say. He walked slowly and passed Rose. Rose followed James with her eyes for a while. Then she started walking too.

They entered the second room upstairs. This room was smaller than the other room. At the same time, the pitched roof of the house was above this room. The inside was messy, as expected. The wooden toy chest on the floor in one corner of the room was wide open. Toys and small clothes were everywhere. The small carpet on the floor had been rolled up and pulled in front of the bed. Pictures hung on the walls of the room.

“This was my room.” Said Ian “I guess there’s not much to look at in here either.”

Rose remained silent and nodded in agreement. James left the room first. Heading for the door, Rose stopped for a moment

when she came to the pictures on the wall. After a quick glance at the pictures, she followed James down the creaky stairs. They both descended the spiral staircase. Just before the steps stood James's father's study. They saw Nathaniel sitting wearily in a chair behind the wooden desk. Scatt was staring blankly at the bookcase in front of him. The moment they entered, the gaze turned to them. Nathaniel jumped to his feet. He took a few steps towards James, who was coming towards him at the time, and ended up right in front of him.

"Please tell me you found something!" said Nathaniel. James and Rose's looks were in response. Nathaniel took a deep breath and covered his face with his hands. After a short silence, he shouted in anger and kicked the pile of books on the floor with all his might.

"Damn it!"

He turned his gaze to James.

"You... You promised us the location of the book! Where are the fucking documents?" he shouted angrily.

"I don't know." James said calmly.

"I don't know?" Nathaniel shouted and grabbed James by the collar and turned around in one swift motion. With two steps he slammed James against the wall. "So you don't know!" Nathaniel pulled James to him and slammed him against the wall again. "I guess you don't realize how serious this is!"

James's back hit the wall again and he heard a small sound. His eyes widened. He didn't care that his back hurt.

"Nathaniel..."

"You're a fucking waste of time!" Nathaniel pulled James back to him and pinned him against the wall.

"If you do it again..." James said through clenched teeth. He didn't finish the sentence.

“Your father gave his life for this research and all you're doing is distracting us!” said Nathaniel and slammed James against the wall for the third time.

James frowned angrily. With one hand he grabbed the wrist of one of the hands holding his collar. With the other hand he punched Nathaniel in the jaw with all his strength from below, between Nathaniel's arms. Before Nathaniel realized what had happened, he was knocked back a few steps by the blow. He recovered instantly and grabbed his jaw, which hurt as if it had been broken. Cursing, he stepped forward while James took up a position with his hands raised in front of his face.

Nathaniel shouted angrily and swung his left fist at James. James blocked the punch with his arm and hit Nathaniel's left shoulder with the free one. Nathaniel gritted his teeth as hard as he could to keep the pain he felt from coming out, but his grunt of pain escaped through his teeth. And with his right arm he punched James, who was exposed.

James was knocked off his feet as the punch exploded in his face. He collapsed backwards. Nathaniel was about to launch a second attack when he felt a chill in his neck. James took advantage of this and sat up. He saw Rose reaching for him. Nathaniel looked at Scatt holding the knife to his neck.

“Nathaniel, please snap out of it! You're the Headknight! I know you're angry and you're right, but killing James isn't going to help us!”

Nathaniel inhaled deeply and looked at James, who stood up. James had taken a step towards Nathaniel when Rose grabbed him tightly with the hand she had helped him up with and pulled him towards her.

“Ian! Get a hold of yourself! Will you please stop?”

James stopped with a sigh. He hadn't taken his gaze off Nathaniel. Still, he straightened his posture.

"You're right, Rose." He said, wiping the blood from his busted lip with his free hand. Nathaniel turned his gaze to Scatt standing in front of him. He saw the worry in Scatt's eyes. He saw the fear. He stood for a moment. His eyes could see nothing. He just thought. Even if it lasted a few seconds, it seemed much longer to him. He turned his eyes back to Scatt.

"You're right, Scatt, killing him won't help us. At least for now."

Scatt looked relieved. He let out a deep breath and lowered the knife from Nathaniel's throat.

"Thank God you didn't kill me either. We both know very well that me with a knife is no threat to you. "

"I won't harm my friends, Scatt. Don't worry." Said Nathaniel, squinting his eyes and continuing to look at James.

"You can hate each other, but don't you dare grab each other by the throat again during this mission!" said Rose. Neither Nathaniel nor James said anything. They stared at each other with angry eyes for a while. James gave a furtive look to Rose, who was still holding his hand, and let go of her hand. Then he moved his gaze to the bust on the table. "I want you to promise not to try to kill each other until this mission is over. Shake hands." Rose said, looking at each of them in turn. After a few seconds of deathly silence, James grabbed the bust by the throat and swung with all his might.

Nathaniel's eyes widened and he stepped back while pushing Scatt away so that nothing would happen to him. As the bust caved in the canvas, Nathaniel screamed in rage and jumped on James.

As rubble from the broken wall filled the room, Nathaniel, on top of the fallen James, angrily punched James in the face. James tried to dodge by tilting his head to the side, but the head knight's fist smashed straight into his face. As blood spurted from his nose, James struck back at Nathaniel in one swift motion. They couldn't see each

other well enough in the rubble-white room, but somehow they managed to hit.

James grabbed Nathaniel and quickly threw him to the side and climbed on top of him. This time he was on top. James punched Nathaniel in the face as the coast was clear. He grabbed Nathaniel's collar with one hand. He threw a second punch as blood poured down both of their faces.

Nathaniel blinked, trying to regain consciousness. When he realized a third punch was coming, he used the arm holding his collar as support to push James off of him. He straightened up. He was breathing furiously, like a bull. He stood up. He didn't want to try any harder. He reached for the revolver at his waist. He sheathed it and pointed it to James.

James coughed to get rid of the blood in his throat. He spit it out. He looked at James, who was pointing a gun at him. He was as breathless as he was.

"The documents... The documents are there." James said, pointing a bloody finger at Nathaniel's back. Nathaniel didn't even bother to look back to avoid being trapped.

"Rose..."

Rose was trying to understand what was happening. She was still bothered by the dust particles in her eyes. She blinked and saw the gun Nathaniel was pointing at James. She turned her head and looked at the hole in the wall. He put his hand through the gap. He felt around. And his eyes widened. He quickly grabbed all the files and papers he could reach. He took them out of the hole in the wall and shook them. He squinted and looked at the papers.

"Yes." Rose said, looking at the papers. "There are studies on objects that bear Solomon's imprint." Rose slowly began to shift the papers. "A lot of them. He has a certain knowledge of all of them." Rose frowned. She read what was written on the page again and again. Her eyes widened. "There... there's Colder's gauntlet

here!” Rose said in amazement. Nathaniel looked away as soon as he heard the gauntlet. He quickly walked over to Rose and grabbed the files from her hand. After examining the files for a short while, he read them again in amazement. And again.

“Jimmy Jimmy Jimmy, it seems your father knew about the library. And that my father had the gauntlet.” Nathaniel wiped the blood that continued to flow from his nose with his armed hand. “Did I have to point a gun at you to get you to tell me where the bloody files were?”

“Actually...” James paused for a moment and then straightened up. He came to a sitting position on the floor. “I didn't know... until I hit my back against the wall. I realized there was a gap, but...” James looked at Rose as he clumsily tried to clean the blood from his face. “Your fucking drunk leader isn't very good at listening isn't he?”

“I guess we're still on the same side.” Scatt said. He walked over to James and held out his hand. A small smile formed on James' bloody lips.

“You'll never give up, will you Scatt?” said James as he took Scatt's hand and stood up. “I guess we're back to our agreement. We're together until this is over.”

James walked over to Nathaniel who was carefully checking the documents in his hand. He quickly grabbed Nathaniel's hands and pulled them away. When he had the papers, he walked backwards and shuffled them. He grabbed one of them and pulled it out. Frowning, he read it again and when he was sure he had found the right document, he handed it to Rose.

“I said I'd help you find the book, but that doesn't mean I'm going to let you take my father's research with you.”

Nathaniel pointed the revolver back to James. “Can I shoot him now?”

“The thing is, Nathaniel, my father knew where the book was. So do I, but the book is protected. It's not a free-for-all. And to get in there...” James pointed to the document he had given Rose. “We need the key there.

“Even if you find the key, you can't figure out where to open it without me. In short, you want to shoot me? Go ahead. But don't forget that you need me to find the book.”

“Are you willing to risk your life for the damn documents?”

“No. I know you're not risking it because you need me. And if I didn't, I'd be dead already.” Nathaniel stared at James in silence for a moment. James continued to stare at him emotionlessly with his bloodied face. Nathaniel lowered his gun with a sigh. “You know I'm going to take those files from you, right?”

“When this is over, when we find the book and go our separate ways, you can try to get these from me.” Said James.

“And where is this key?” asked Nathaniel.

Rose looked up after running her eyes over the paper in her hand.

“In France.”

“France? Where in France?”

“I don't know, it just says France.”

Nathaniel frowned and stood next to Rose and took the paper from her hand. He made sure Rose had read it correctly.

“Isn't it marvelous? We'll find it in the next ten to twenty years!”

Scatt stepped forward cheerfully. He seemed to be on the edge of his seat with excitement. He looked at James, then at Nathaniel, then at Rose.

“Well... I have a friend. Well, more of a colleague than a friend. Mr. Steven. Anyway... Mr. Steven invited me to Paris a few days ago. He told me that he found artifacts of Solomon, of his time, of his kingdom. Artifacts with Solomon's seal on them! And... and maybe he has the key!”

“Scatt, you're wonderful!” said Nathaniel excitedly. “Can you call him?”

Without waiting, Scatt took the phone out of his pocket. After a moment of one-handed fumbling, he found the right number.

“Sword.” Said James.

“I beg your pardon?”

“We may say 'key' but we're not really looking for a key. The word 'key' is used in ancient writings, in papyri, in my father's and the professor's research. It can't be an ordinary key that will open Solomon's palace. It is not. It's a sword. A sword that belonged to one of Solomon's children.”

“And when were you planning to tell us this?” Nathaniel snapped as he involuntarily put one hand on his still-aching shoulder.

James noticed the anger on Nathaniel's face, but said calmly, “When the time comes.” He said and turned his gaze back to Scatt.

Scatt made the call and waited for a while. Then the phone was picked up.

“Mr. Steven, hello. I'll get straight to the point. Among the artifacts you found, is there a sword bearing the seal of Solomon? Yes, sir, I'll hold.” Said Scatt. He was on the edge of his seat with excitement. And when he heard Mr. Steven's voice, his face fell in disappointment. “No? Are you sure?” Scatt turned his gaze to James. “You're sure we're looking for a sword?” he asked. He waited desperately, anticipating James's answer. James answered with a nod.

“A sword.”

Scatt sighed and returned to the phone call. "Thanks for checking in, Mr. Steven. I'll be in France soon and if I make it to Paris I'll let you know... See you soon." Scatt said with a grimace and hung up the phone. "What do we do now?"

"Ian you..."

"Yes Rose, I used to live in France." Said James and blinked his eyes as if coming to. He turned to Rose. "I was going to go there after all this was over. My father told me many times before he died that he wanted to go on vacation to France. To Paris. But the week we were going... My father..." James was silent for a while. "After his death I had to go to boarding school, an orphanage. The professor said it would be safer for me to study in another country. After all, those who were after my father might try to get to me. He promised to visit me from time to time. When he convinced me, he asked, 'How would you like to study in Paris, son? And I agreed.

"It's all so clear, isn't it?" James continued, trying to smile. "My father had it all arranged. He found the key, he found the book. If you ask me, he also told the Professor to send me to Paris if anything happened to him. Dad was going to find the book himself. But... But he left me behind in case something happened to him. As his heir."

"Ian, it's good that you've grasped certain things, but it still doesn't get us anywhere."

James leaned back against the table behind him. He exhaled a deep breath.

"I don't know." He said as he fixed his gaze on the shelves against the wall. He made a face like the others. No one said a word. James put his hand on his father's dusty desk. He remembered his father working at this desk. The way he decorated this room, and then the last week he had seen him. First he frowned. Then his eyes widened. "My father..." was all he could say at first. He tried to swallow. His throat was tight. "My father knew what would happen.

They knew he had found the book. He... He knew he was going to die!" James lunged forward. "But he didn't tell me anything. About the whereabouts of the book. Because he couldn't let them get their hands on it!" He looked at Nathaniel, Rose and Scatt, who were all looking at him curiously. "He came home last week, frozen. And with..." James turned away and glanced around the shelves. He looked at the mess on the floor. He left the room with quick steps. Rose followed James. James took the curving steps three at a time without waiting. He didn't hear Rose calling after him. As soon as he reached the top floor, he entered his own room without waiting. Rose followed a few steps behind James and went inside.

One by one, James examined the pictures hanging on the wall. He quickly glanced through them all. He narrowed his eyes. He grabbed the ones that looked familiar and pulled. Along with the pictures, the wall paint that the adhesive had pulled off was removed. He looked at the other pictures but stopped when he couldn't find what he was looking for.

"Tan, are you going to explain what happened?" Rose asked. She couldn't understand anything. James put his hand on Rose's shoulder.

"Downstairs, I'll explain everything, just follow me." James said and left his room without waiting for Rose's answer.

He went downstairs with some pictures. He entered his father's study. He passed between Scatt and Nathaniel and came in front of the desk. He put the pictures on the table. Spreading them out so that they could all be seen clearly. "Do you know where these belong?" James asked excitedly. He knew there would be no answer. Still, he waited a while before explaining.

Pointing to one of the pictures, he began to speak. "This painting is of Notre Dame Cathedral. See those patterns there? They're almost impossible to see unless you go all the way to the bottom of the bell." He moved on to the next painting. "This statue is an incomplete drawing. Normally it has a gold cross on it. It's the

same cathedral.” He pointed to a picture with ornaments drawn in a certain order filling the circle. “This colored glass is the rose window. These are my father's drawings.” He gestured to a statue of two creatures on one of the shelves. “Two creatures. Imaginary creatures called Chimeres or Gargoyles.”

James jumped forward nimbly and quickly picked up the two trinkets on the floor. He jumped to his feet and placed them next to the other figurines on the shelves. He looked around curiously. He found another figurine rolled under the table. He quickly picked it up and put it back on the shelf. He pushed down the piles of books on the floor with his foot. He picked up the trinkets lying between the pages, under the books. He put them all next to the others. Finally, he picked up the broken figurine lying on the floor. When he put the head-shaped figurine down, he took a step back. He looked at the figurines with a small smile. There were about fourteen figurines on the table, including the one where only the head had survived. She turned around. He looked at Nathaniel, Scatt and Rose, who were looking at him like he was crazy.

He pointed to the knickknacks he had arranged. “Let me introduce you to twenty-eight Jewish kings, at least fourteen of them are here.” He gestured to the paintings and knickknacks. “These are all in the same place. They are all in the Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris.”

No one was looking at James without making a sound.

“My father bought all these statues in the same week. We painted the pictures in the same week, the last week before he died.”

Nathaniel looked around for a moment. One by one he looked at the evidence James had presented. “What you say really makes sense, James. If your father had told you these things, your life would have been in danger too. Instead he left you a set of markers. All right, let's do this. Take what you see here as evidence. We're going to the library.”

They didn't linger long in the old house. James piled up the pictures his father had drawn. He just wanted to take the pictures. He nodded his head up and down, indicating that he was ready. They left the house soon after. They walked to the car waiting outside the door. Fred, who was tired of sitting in the car, was waiting for them outside the car. When he saw them coming, he got into the car again. As he started the car, the others got in.

After a journey of about twenty minutes, Nathaniel's company came into view. Nathaniel looked up at the logo on the top of the company and smiled.

The car stopped very briefly. Everyone got out except Fred. Fred went to leave his car in the parking lot as usual. The others stood side by side and looked at the library. Nathaniel was the first to step on the steps. At the end of the stairs, in front of the door, Vex was standing as usual to greet the arrivals.

He looked up the steps. His eyes fell on James. He squinted for a while. Then he started to smile.

“Are my eyes fooling me or is this Ian James Fate?”

James looked up with widened eyes and looked at the big man waiting at the door. He smiled and raised one eyebrow. “Vex?” he said in surprise. When he realized that it was indeed Vex, he smiled and quickened his pace. “Vex!” he said once more excitedly. “I haven't seen you for years!”

“Son, you're the one who hasn't been around.” Vex said as he hugged James, who was coming towards him.

Nathaniel, Rose and Scatt were stunned. They stood where they were and looked at Vex and James, who hugged for a while in surprise. “So... So you know each other?” Nathaniel said in surprise. He didn't know what to say. “Vex, you didn't tell me you knew a murderer.”

“We've all committed crimes, Nathaniel. None of us are innocent.” Vex said and turned his gaze back to James. He grabbed James by the shoulders and took a step away from him. “Oh my God! What happened to you?” Vex's eyes shifted to Nathaniel, who was right behind James. “And what happened to you?”

James sighed and said, “I had a little trouble with the guards holding me, Vex.” Vex looked at him for a moment, one eyebrow raised.

“He's going to regret this.” Vex sighed and started to walk away. “I guess you haven't found Elnore.”

“He died a long time ago.” James said, locking his gaze on the path they were walking.

“May he rest in peace.” Said Vex and looked at the men on either side of him, their faces covered in blood. “Nathaniel, I think it's time to bring James into the fold. He fought shoulder to shoulder with the Headknight and deserves to know what's going on here.”

“Yes, that's why I brought him here, the recruit. He'll be part of the unit for a while at least. And Bob will be furious that I did this without his knowledge!”

One of the men saluted Vex as he passed between the shelves. Vex nodded in return.

“Since the Headknight approves, after you, James.” Vex said with a wide smile on his face. James returned the smile and got into the elevator. The others entered right after him.

When the elevator doors closed, Vex inserted the key and turned it. He made sure everyone turned around as he entered the code into the opening, then closed the floor and stepped onto the second floor. The elevator jerked a little and started to move. When James noticed that the elevator was going down instead of up, he looked again at the button Vex had pressed. Then the elevator

stopped. When the doors opened, James was the first to get out. He took a few steps between the white walls, looking around.

“Good thing you didn't do it in the mountain,” James said and turned around.

“Follow me, son.” Said Vex and got out of the elevator. He started walking. As he walked with James, the others followed behind. Nathaniel took his place next to Vex.

“Vex, don't you ever wonder what happened on Everest?”

Vex sighed and looked over his shoulder at Nathaniel's face. “To be honest, Nathaniel, I can guess.” He replied. “But I know that won't stop you, so you can start telling me, son. I'm all ears.”

Nathaniel was silent for a while. “You're right. I was going to tell you anyway.” Nathaniel began. Then he started to tell. He told everything to Vex, starting with the sip he took from his canteen when he got off the plane. How they drove up to the mountain and climbed the mountain from there, his brilliant plan to keep the FBI agents away, the inside of the mountain, the guards...

“From there we went to James' old house.” Said Nathaniel.

“What did you find?” asked Vex.

“The thing that led us to the book was a sword. James's father's files say it's in France.”

“Where in France?”

“In Paris. I think it's in Notre Dame Cathedral,” said James. “I think my father left me some markings that lead us there.”

“Good. I hope you find the book soon. This mission has gone on long enough. I want to retire.”

“Retire? If we find the book, you'll retire? But what about the library?” asked Nathaniel. “You know no one can go down there without you.”

“Sort of. The goal of the Headknight and their soldiers is to find the legacy and make sure it's safe. After that, this place can close. There are already people making sure people don't learn magic. The Book will cease to be a threat and my tiresome task will be over,” Vex said, involuntarily reaching for the necklace hanging around his neck. “But you must be careful. We are not the only ones looking for the book. You both know that very well.” Vex said, looking one by one at James and Nathaniel standing on either side of him. They both just stood there. They knew instantly what Vex meant, but they didn't react. They just looked at each other and kept walking.

Vex stopped. He raised his hand. A key dangled between his fingers. He handed it to James, “This is your room. There are clean clothes in there. Make yourself presentable and get a good rest. Then you can go upstairs if you like. I hope you remember the corridors we used to get here.”

“Thank you, Vex.” James said and took the key. After one last look down the hallway, he went into his room.

James closed the door behind him and took a deep breath. The room was dark. He reached his hand to the side of the door and looked for the light switch. When the room lit up with the light of the lamp, he walked to the center of the room. It was a room with a simple bed, a closet, a chair, and a table. An open door in the very plain room led to the restroom.

James took two more steps into the small room and came to the bed. He sat on it. He smiled at the prospect of sleeping in a soft bed after so long. He got out of bed with a stretch.

James styled his beard and took a hot shower. He made sure he washed the blood from his face. His face still ached. When he came out of the bathroom he found the clean clothes Vex had told him

about and got dressed. Even though what he was wearing was a dull T-shirt and jeans, he was happy. He was rid of the furry clothes. Yawning, he lay down on the white-covered bed. He exhaled peacefully as he lay on the bed. Closing his eyes, he curled up on the bed for a while, then found the most comfortable position and fell asleep.

James opened his eyes. The room had no windows. But the light from the open lamp was as disturbing as the first rays of the sun. James had no idea what time it was. He sat up slowly. He sat on the bed for a while, trying to regain consciousness. He went into the bathroom and washed his face. Then he looked in the mirror opposite. He straightened his back. He tossed back the long hair that had fallen in his face with both hands. He ran his hands over his beard and left the room.

He had been careful enough walking with Vex. He knew the roads. He had made a map for himself with the roads he had walked. It didn't take him long to get to the hallway where the elevator was. Someone was standing inside the elevator. Just as the doors were about to close, the man who saw James put his hand between the elevator doors and held the door. James quickened his steps and got into the elevator without keeping the man waiting any longer. As he greeted the man with his head, he saw that the man was looking at him curiously. He pretended not to notice and turned to press the button. The man had already pressed the button he was about to press.

"Funny, I usually know everyone here." Jason said, squinting his eyes.

"I am new."

"Who recruited you?"

"Nathaniel."

"Yeah, that makes sense. If anyone else had hired you, they would have opened a file in your name. But Nathaniel doesn't do paperwork."

When the elevator reached the ground floor, Jason wished James well and disappeared into the shelves. James looked around for a moment, then came to the only place he thought he might find Vex, in front of the glass door. He wasn't wrong. Vex was in front of the door. Vex saw James coming.

"Looking good, James." Vex said, patting James on the shoulder. "Nathaniel and the others are on the third floor."

"Third floor you mean..."

"No, no, no, it's just the third floor." Said Vex and held out his hand towards the elevator. "There are stairs at the back of the elevator if you want. You can use them too."

"Sure." Said James and looked around. He wondered how many of the people reading the books in their hands were library workers. Inside there was a group of students sitting around a table. They didn't know about the top beneath their feet. Just like other people didn't know about magic, or the book they were looking for, or anything else.

James snapped to attention and turned his gaze back to Vex. "One day, Vex, I need you to tell me the story of this place."

"Just find that book first. Then I'll tell you as many stories as you want, boy."

"That's an acceptable deal." Said James and started walking in the direction Vex pointed. Soon he saw the stairs just a few feet behind the elevator. There were no steps leading down. It only went up. And James started up the stairs. He didn't meet anyone until he reached the third floor. Everyone must have been using the elevator.

He got to the third floor and opened the double doors. He walked for a while among the labyrinthine shelves. This floor was nothing like the ground floor. There would be people everywhere on the ground floor of the library. But there seemed to be no one on this floor. The shelves were covered with dust. The books on them had

obviously not been touched for months. James kept moving forward, looking at the books on the shelves.

Finally, when he reached the end of the aisle of shelves, he turned right and came to a window that covered the wall from ceiling to floor. Nathaniel was sitting in one of the chairs in front of the window, arms crossed, wiping the blood from his face. Rose was sitting on one side of him and Scatt on the other. James pulled up one of the empty chairs and took his seat.

"You finally made it." Nathaniel said to James. "All I can say for now is that we are going to France. Because all we know is that we have to go to the cathedral and find the sword. Unless James has something to add. Maybe something we don't know."

"Nathaniel, there's a reason I haven't told you everything." Said James and stood up. "As I said before, I will say what I need to say when the time comes, because what we are doing is no ordinary mission. The consequences won't just affect us or the rebels, they will affect us all. It will affect all of humanity.

"I am risking the book by sharing what I know with you. If the descendants of the rebels can somehow reach us, if they can capture us, they will find out where the book is. They will find out at any cost. And I want their chances to be as small as possible.

"You need to know that the book is more valuable than any of us. We are not in any great danger now, but what happens next is unpredictable. Maybe we'll run into rebels and it'll come down to pistols. Maybe we'll end up in a worse situation than that. But no matter what, we must save the book. No matter what, the book must be your priority. That's why I don't have any information to give you for now. Let's get going. This has gone on long enough." Scatt quickly jumped to his feet as if he had been waiting for this moment for a long time. Nathaniel's gaze was fixed on the table as Rose stood up calmly. He stared blankly at the table. For a moment it was quiet. His breathing slowed. He remembered what he had seen. He remembered Solomon's voice. The voice echoed in his head.

“No matter what you do, Nathaniel son of William, you cannot change fate!”

Rose put her hand on his shoulder and Nathaniel woke up with a start. Blinking, he looked around. For a few seconds, he tried to comprehend where he was. When he saw everyone standing, he awkwardly sat up. The chair tipped back with a thud. Nathaniel was startled once more. He lifted the chair from the floor. One by one he turned to the faces staring at him in silence. And finally, “Let’s go.” He said.

Fred parked his car at the airport, close to the plane. When everyone got out, James rummaged through the bag the guards had given him back. He looked at the phone he took out of the bag. He tried to answer it but it wouldn’t pick up. Sighing, he turned to the others.

“I need to call someone and my phone doesn’t work.”

“You can use mine.” Rose said as she handed him the phone out of her pocket. James smiled and thanked Rose as he took the phone from her. He took a few steps away from those waiting in front of the plane. He tried to remember the number to call. It didn’t take long. He made the call immediately.

Nathaniel was determined not to take his eyes off James. He had one hand in his pocket and the other on his revolver. Ready to draw his gun at the slightest false move.

When James hung up the phone and turned back, he saw Nathaniel looking at him questioningly. He looked down and saw the hand on the revolver.

“I have a friend in Paris who can help us.” James said calmly. Not because he was scared, but because he felt he needed to explain. Without waiting for Nathaniel to say anything, he handed the phone back to Rose. Thanking her again, he handed the phone back to the owner and boarded the plane. She took the seat she had sat in the previous time. Nathaniel boarded the plane right after. Then Rose and

Scatt. Nathaniel took a sip from his iron flask as everyone took their seats.

James sat with his arms crossed. He looked out of the window for a while. The plane was passing through the clouds as it flew across the blue sky. The clouds obscured the area over which the plane was flying. James looked down and saw nothing but white. Sighing, he pulled his gaze away from the window. They were a long way from arriving in France.

His gaze fell on Rose sitting across from him. Rose looked bored too. He kept looking at her for a while, Then she looked up at Nathaniel sitting in one of the front seats. Nathaniel was writing something in his father's diary. James sighed again. He turned his gaze back to Rose. He didn't want to take his eyes off her. Taking a deep breath, Rose turned to him.

"How long have you been on the team?" James asked quickly. He averted his gaze.

"Not long if by team you mean Scatt, Nathaniel, you and me. Because the team was just formed." Rose replied happily. Watching out the window was getting boring.

"But you were in the library before, weren't you?"

"Sort of. My father is one of the two Headknights at the library..."

"All he does is sit in his chair!" shouted Nathaniel, interrupting Rose. "that bald old man is no Headknight! No offence Rose."

"That's what my dad says about you, Nate." Rose said, smiling slightly looking at James. "But of course he doesn't say bald, no, cocky, disrespectful, disobedient..."

"I know, I know, he says those things to my face too."

Rose stopped bickering with Nathaniel and looked at James. James gave a small smile, waiting for her to continue.

“Like I said, my dad is one of the Headknight at the library. That's why I've been there since I was a little girl, I trained there, and Nathaniel was my partner. At least for a while. Nathaniel's father was the second Headknight. And now... And now he's the Headknight.”

“What about Scatt?” James asked, glancing at Scatt, who had fallen asleep. “What's his story?”

“Not everyone in the library is sent on the same kinds of missions. Nathaniel and I were sent on the dangerous ones, and by dangerous I mean missions that require weapons. Vex keeps the library safe. You've seen it. He drops us off at the base. Scatt was a collector. He's one of the ones trying to find Solomon's belongings. And there was only one person who could compete with him. His wife Emily. He and his wife Emily were our best collectors.”

“were? you mean...” James said, but didn't continue. Rose nodded her head in agreement. James crossed his arms and looked at Scatt for a moment. Then he turned his gaze back to Rose.

“Have you ever been to Paris before?” James asked to change the subject.

“No.” Rose said, shaking her head from side to side.

“You'll like it. It's a really beautiful city.” Said James happily.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Solomon gripped the leather-covered metal hilt that the blacksmith had integrated with his sword. He swung it left and right. He held it straight and ran his eyes over its metal. He lifted it and looked at his reflection in the sword's runic-lettered metal.

“Chief blacksmith, you have indeed done a great job!” said Solomon as he thrust the sword into the scabbard at his waist.

“I am honored to serve the heir to magic. I hope you do the sword its due, Solomon.”

“I will do my best.” Said Solomon.

Outside the burning mountain, as the door they had entered closed, Duricrod disappeared between the pillars inside the vast structure.

“What do we do now, Solomon?”

“Do you know where your soldiers took Windsor?”

“There is a place deep in the forest where the survivors of our people are hidden. They must have taken him there. They change their location every once in a while. But the last time they were in the south-east of the forest.”

“Good! Show me the way.” Said Solomon and they followed Rodrin. The Protector, as usual, accompanied the others, flying a few feet in the air. “Isn't the rest of your army at the campsite?”

“Yes, all of them.”

“And do you think they are ready for battle?”

“We'll see when we get there.” Rodrin said, keeping his gaze on the road.

Solomon followed Rodrin, his hand on the hilt of his sword. Feeling the power beneath his hand, he kept going. Rodrin stopped suddenly. He looked around. “Over there!” he said excitedly. Pointing with his finger where he was looking. And they walked faster and faster.

First they saw a few tents through the trees. With every step they took, the smile on Rodrin's face grew a little bigger. The number of tents started to increase as they moved forward. Before the tents, as they passed men in leather armor holding spears in their hands, the men first saluted their king and then watched in amazement at the huge winged flying protector.

As they entered the camp, Solomon noticed that no one was looking curiously at the Protector. Everyone who saw the Protector froze for a moment and then went about their business without taking their astonished gaze off him. Rodrin smiled and looked around the campsite at his people. Then he frowned again and moved through the tents. He stopped in front of one of the larger ones. When the two guards at the door saw the king, they saluted and stood to one side.

“Solomon, can you use your magic to heal?”

"I'm not sure, but I can try." Solomon said and pointed his hand at Rodrin's face. Rodrin caught Solomon's hand in mid-air.

"If you can heal someone, it shouldn't be me. Follow me." Rodrin said and went inside. The Protector chose to stay outside. As he waited outside, he closed his magnificent wings to avoid attracting more attention. He knew there were still people watching him, but he didn't mind.

There were several men lying inside the tent. Their clothes were covered in blood. Solomon recognized only one of them. Windsor, who was lying at the very bottom of the tent.

When the man crouched next to Windsor saw that people were coming in, he stood up. He stood before the king. He bowed and saluted.

"How is Windsor?"

"It's hard to say, sire. He's alive for now, but his wound is too deep."

"Let me try." Said Solomon. The doctor moved out of Solomon's way. Solomon went to Windsor and got down on his knees. He put his hand on Windsor's chest. He closed his eyes. He remembered how he had been healed. He took a deep breath and felt the warmth in his body. The strength gathered in his arm. And the power flowed from his fingertips into Windsor's body.

Windsor opened her eyes with a groan. He looked around in pain. Just as she sat up, Solomon pushed her off his shoulder and made her lie down.

"Windsor, you need to rest."

"But..."

"That's an order!" said Solomon as he staggered to his feet. He lost his balance and at the last moment Rodrin caught him. The bugles sounded as Windsor closed his eyes.

“Follow me, Solomon.” Rodrin said as he left the tent and started walking in the direction everyone else had gone. Solomon followed him out of the tent. He looked up at the sky. He hadn’t realized it was getting dark. Then he decided to run to catch up with Rodrin.

“What’s going on, Rodrin?”

“It’s time to eat.” Rodrin said and pointed to the line in front of the cauldron boiling over a big flame. “I thought you might be hungry.”

“You’re right.” Said Solomon, his stomach rumbling with hunger, and stood in line with Rodrin. Azderson just quietly listened to what they said and did what they did.

Their turn came quickly. Solomon inhaled the fragrance of the meat stew in the wooden bowl. The smell of the stew whetted his appetite and Rodrin took two bowls. As soon as they had eaten, they returned to the tent they had come from. Windsor’s eyes were half open, staring at the ceiling of the tent.

“Windsor, I brought you something to eat.” Said Rodrin. Windsor’s eyes sparkled and he tried to sit up in bed. When he got up, Rodrin handed him one of the bowls. He was about to hand him the spoon when Windsor held it over his head.

“Rodrin.” He started his sentence. Then he got straight to the point. “The time for the great war has come and gone. We must gather the army and attack as soon as possible! What do you say?”

“If the war has to start, we’ll start it now.”

“When will the army be ready?”

“They’ll be ready before dawn.”

“Announce it to all the soldiers tonight. Let them rest. Because tomorrow morning we go to war.”

“To announce this,” Rodrin said as he handed his meal to Windsor who had already finished his meal. Windsor quickly devoured Rodrin's as well. “Now is the best time.” Rodrin got up from his seat. Azderson quickly put down his bowl and followed his King. Solomon took another spoonful of his food and went out of the tent with the others.

Rodrin walked over to the soldiers who were sitting around the cook, chatting. He ran his eyes over them one by one. And he found what he was looking for. Rodrin walked up to the man he had spotted. Seeing the king at his side, the man immediately straightened up. As he saluted the king, Rodrin pointed to the horn hanging from the man's belt. The man did as the king commanded and handed the horn to the king. The king took the horn. He took a deep breath and blew into the horn. All the soldiers in the campsite were now gathering around the King.

“People of the Kingdom of Destiny, tomorrow is the great day! With Solomon the Sorcerer leading the way, we will take back our kingdom! We will take back our kingdom from Grimor! We will destroy the filth that has plunged our kingdom into darkness! Of course, we cannot do this without you. With your help, we can win this war! Once we have won our kingdom, once magic has been lifted from our lands and banished for good, we will take back our friends, our families, and the friends we left behind! But like I said, I need your help. And I know that everyone here will join this fight. None of us will hide behind the trees like cowards! Now tell me! Who is with us!”

“I am with the Sorcerer!” the crowd chanted in unison. With excitement and enthusiasm.

“It was simpler than I thought.” Solomon said.

“They are exhausted from being in forest. They wants that all end so they are easy to convince.” Azderson answered.

“Tomorrow morning at sunrise we will take up our swords, shields, axes and spears and attack! Who will join the battle and show those damned creatures!”

The soldiers cheered again. They shouted with joy. “Let us go to war now!” some said, eager to regain their kingdom. This minority voice was lost amidst the enthusiastic voices of the others.

“The armies will be ready tomorrow morning, as you asked.” Rodrin said.

The sun was rising slowly over the horizons of the gray sky, shining on the shiny surface of the iron armor of the guards. Only the guard unit wore the metal armor. Solomon looked at the soldiers running in different directions in confusion and excitement. Some ran to one side to pick up swords, others to pick up shields.

When Rodrin came to Solomon, he was wearing a suit of armor similar to that of the guards.

“Solomon, we need to find you some armor.”

“Lead the way, my king.” Said Solomon and followed Rodrin. Solomon entered the tent Rodrin had entered. The first thing that caught his eye was the armor, decorated with all kinds of embroidery and gold stripes. What caught Solomon's attention most was the star symbol on the chest of the armor.

“This...” said Rodrin “is my father's armor... I mean it was my father's. And now you have the spell. So this is your armor too.”

“The throne is yours, so the armor is yours.”

“The throne is yours, Solomon. who possesses magic is the one who rules the Kingdom of Destiny.”

“Rodrin, I can not be the king, Can't sit on the throne of Kingdom Of Destiny. I have my own Kingdom that I have to rule in m world. Also I have no knowledge about this world. It would be hard to rule.

“You are the blood of Orin. You are the one who should sit to the throne. I will always be there whenever you need a help. But you will be the king of this kingdom. Not me. So the heritage of the armor is you.”

Rodrin sighed. “Thank you Solomon.” He looked at the armor for few seconds. “If you won’t take my father’s armor, I will give you mine.”

“I wouldn't say no to that.”

Solomon put on Rodrin's armor. It fit him perfectly. He tightened the arched buckle of the last piece of armor, the cuff, and walked out of the tent, smiling. He looked out into the clearing where the men, fully armed, were forming up in army formation.

“The army will soon be ready for battle.”

“Now that is good news. How is Windsor doing?”

“Better. Very well, in fact. You've healed his wound. He's just a little tired, I think.”

“Let's go, find Azderson and Windsor.” Said Solomon.

“I think I know where Windsor is.” Said Rodrin.

Windsor was standing among the weapons, choosing an axe. He picked up two crescent-shaped axes with the engraving clearly visible. He grunted as if to say he was satisfied. Finally he settled on two large axes.

“I'm glad you're up, my friend.” Solomon said. Windsor turned back to where the voice had come from. A smile appeared on his face.

“Master Solomon! Thank you for what you have done. Now I am ready to go to war!”

“Good! I'm not leaving one of my best men behind!”

“The army is ready for war.” Said Azderson. No one saw where he came from. “Awaiting your orders, sir, and the Sorcerer's, of course.”

“Here we go.” Said Rodrin and walked slowly to the front of his prepared army. With each step, he squinted and surveyed his men, his soldiers. Solomon was keeping pace with him. Waiting for orders, the soldiers looked at the Sorcerer and the King in silence. They were all waiting with great excitement for the order to fight. And the moment came. “Let's go and save our kingdom!” Rodrin shouted. At the same time, he unsheathed his sword and raised it in the air. Without breaking the formation, the soldiers raised their weapons like their king and began to cheer.

With the king's command and leadership, they set off. They marched in formation through the dense forest of vehicles.

When the army reached the end of the forest, where it connected with the Kingdom, they saw darkness in the distance. A horde of creatures were advancing towards the palace. Behind them, were creatures that looked more like men, pulling and dragging humans bound in rows with chains. Behind them, a man with pale skin, like Valefar, was advancing. Only bigger. Around him was a blood-red disk spinning rapidly.

“We still don't know what that thing around you is,” Rodrin said in a whisper. He looked at Solomon, crouched behind the bushes. “No survivors made it as far as Grimor.”

Solomon squinted at Grimor.

“Rodrin, take the three best warriors you can find and meet me in front of Grimor. You two follow me.” Solomon said, giving Azderson and Windsor a determined look. “The others fight to the end.”

Rodrin nodded and quickly disappeared into the army. Solomon looked at the guardian standing beside him.

“Will you join the battle, is this the battle you have been waiting for?”

The protector turned his face to Solomon. And sat cross-legged on the ground.

“Very well.” Solomon said with a sigh. He stood up from the bushes where he was leaning and looked at his soldiers briefly.

“Let's go and take back our kingdom!”

The soldiers straightened themselves for the last time with all their hope. The metal-armored guards took a few steps forward, while those behind them spread out widely to either side. When all of them had stopped, they raised their bows and placed their arrows. They stretched the bowstring and waited.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

When the plane arrived at the airport, everyone stood up except Nathaniel. Nathaniel didn't care about what was happening around him. All he cared about now was the diary in his hand and the pen dancing across the pages. He was too busy to see Rose standing next to him.

"Nate, what are you doing?"

Nathaniel closed the journal with a snap and looked up at Rose.

"What does it look like I'm doing?" he asked, boastfully. He raised one eyebrow and looked at Rose for a moment. "I'm keeping a diary as a Headknight, three friends on the trail of a magical book and..." he paused for a moment. He turned his gaze to James. He continued. "And him. It will be an entertaining story for posterity. It's told by the hero of the story, Nathaniel Cooper, in his own words!"

Rose paused for a moment and looked at Nathaniel with one eyebrow raised. Then she took a deep breath and stepped off the

plane. Scatt looked at Nathaniel with a smile as James followed close behind.

“Actually, something good might come out of this.”

“Thanks Scatt.” Nathaniel said with a smile. After a moment he added, “It's nice to have someone on my side.” He added.

As Scatt got off the plane, Nathaniel took a deep breath and looked at the diary. He had written everything down word for word. He picked up the diary from the seat. He looked in the box with his gauntlet. He didn't need it. He left his gauntlet and entered the cockpit. Fred was still sitting in the plot seat.

“Alfred, we're in Paris! Take a vacation after you're done with the plane. At least until we're done.” Said Nathaniel and got out of the plane. He took his place next to the others.

About twenty meters away from the plane was a dark blue car. The driver's side door opened and a man wearing a painter's beret got out, started walking. James squinted his eyes and looked at the man with the beret. In a few seconds, a smile appeared on his face. And that smile grew bigger and bigger. The eye of the man with beret widened. He quickened his pace. When he was close, he spread his arms wide and said, “Ian James! My brother!” he said in a loud voice with a French accent. You could hear how happy he sounded.

“Aleron!” James responded with the same joy. He stepped forward with his arms outstretched, just like Aleron, and hugged him. They hugged tightly and then let go of each other. They began to talk among themselves. Nathaniel looked at them both in turn. Then he turned his gaze to Rose.

“They are speaking French.” Nathaniel explained. He could understand a few words in between, but not all of them.

“Did you think they spoke German in France?” said Rose and turned her gaze to James “Ian we don't understand anything.”

“Let me introduce you,” James said without taking his gaze off his friend. He said. He was finally speaking in a language that everyone could understand. “My friend Aleron from the orphanage. He is like my brother. And Aleron, this is the team I'm temporarily part of. The leader of the team is Nathaniel. Rose and Scatt are with him.”

“A friend of James is a friend of mine.” Aleron said as she smiled, happy to see James. “There's our car.”

“I'll take the front seat.” Said Nathaniel as he walked towards the car.

“No, the front seat is always mine.” Said Aleron and reached into his pocket. He quickly pulled out the keys and threw them to James. James caught the key in mid-air.

“Let's go, buddy.” James said happily.

James was driving the car with great excitement. He watched the surrounding buildings and roads with joy. His hands were holding the steering wheel tightly. After driving through the city for a while, Aleron pointed to one of the houses ahead and said, “This is it.” he said.

James slowed the car and looked at his friend sitting next to him. “Do you seriously think I forgot my house?” he asked in a sarcastic tone. He slowed the car down and stopped in front of the house.

“Home sweet home.” He said and got out of the car with joy. The others also got out of the car. This house was nothing like James' father's house. The house was big and grand. Especially with the overgrown garden and the wall that surrounded it. The house looked as if it had been built several centuries ago, yet it was intact.

James went through the gate into the garden and made sure the others didn't follow. He kept walking. When Aleron was a few steps from the door of the house, he sped up, went to the front and

opened the door. Inside, the wooden floors and the kerosene lamp-like light bulbs matched the architecture of the house.

James took a deep breath in peace.

“Welcome to my home.” James said. This time with joy.

“The second floor is empty.” Said Aleron. “Our guests can stay there.”

“Yes. You're right. Follow me.” Said James and walked up the wide, polished wooden steps in the hallway of the house.

“Scatt, you stay here.” James said, pointing to one of the rooms. “Nathaniel, you're here. And Rose, you stay here. Please don't go into places that don't concern you. Or touch things that don't concern you.”

“All right, James, don't worry, I won't try to look for the body you buried.” Nathaniel said with a shrug. Rose nodded silently and went to the room shown to her. Scatt thanked him and went to his room, showing his usual sense of humility.

“Now...” Aleron continued as he saw everyone enter the room, placing his hand on James' shoulder. “Tell me what happened, Brother.” He said in a French accent.

Nathaniel locked the door to his room behind him. He put his diary on the inlaid wooden table in the room. He sat on the bed and put his head between his hands. Sighing, he stood up and sat in the chair next to the desk where he had placed the diary. He ran his hand over the dusty desk. Then he opened the diary. The pen was still between pages. He took a deep breath and held the pen. And began to write.

Nathaniel suddenly opened his eyes at the sounds. He had fallen asleep. He looked up from the diary with squinted eyes. He blinked his eyes. He woke up when he heard the knocking again. He pushed his chair back with a creak. He sat up slowly. Once he opened

the curtains behind him. He squinted again with the sunlight pouring in. Then he went to the door that kept knocking. He opened the door.

“Nathaniel, we're waiting for you downstairs.” James said from the other side of the door and left Nathaniel in his room. Nathaniel turned back and closed his diary. He ran his fingers through his hair, fumbling with it, and left the room. When he went downstairs, he saw the people sitting at the table behind the wide arched door at the end of the hall. Everyone was in the room except Nathaniel.

Nathaniel joined them. James stood up. He put the pictures on the table.

“Once we're inside, I suggest we split into two teams. Aleron will guide one team and I'll guide the other. One team can check the treasure room while the other goes up the two towers. Aleron will lead his team to the towers. I'll take the treasure room.”

“I guess you're giving the orders now!”

“Nathaniel, we three are strangers here. I'm just trying to help.”

Nathaniel rolled his eyes with a sigh.

“As long as we're in France I'll be following what you said but only here.”

“You'd be doing the right thing. Before we go to the cathedral...” James said and gestured to the wide archway. Everyone looked where James was pointing. Aleron appeared with two large trays. He put them on the table. On the tray there were croissants folded into a crescent shape. “As your host, I couldn't leave you hungry.” James finished his sentence.

Aleron distributed the tray one by one. Everyone was smiling, even if it was a small smile. They wore that little smile that was somewhere between amazement and happiness. Soon after, he

brought the coffees. After distributing the coffees to everyone, he sat down on one of the chairs.

“Enjoy your coffee.” James said, spreading his arms wide and sat down.

Everyone started to eat the croissants in front of them. They started eating their crispy croissants. No one spoke during breakfast. Everyone was busy eating their croissants with plenty of sauce. They were relaxing with the hot coffee they drank with them.

Soon everyone was full except Nathaniel. He could eat three more. When Nathaniel was sure that everyone at the table had finished their breakfast, he stood up.

“Thank you for breakfast. Now let’s take us to the cathedral, shall we?”

Everyone got up from the table, left the house and got into the car parked in front of the garden. The steering wheel was in James' hands again. With a smile, James started the car and sped through the streets of Paris.

After about twenty minutes the two towers of Notre Dame came into clear view. Soon the whole cathedral was visible. The giant circular rose windows shone with different colors. The sun shone directly on the bell, and from it golden beams of light spread out. The people in the carriage were mesmerized by Notre Dame in all its splendor.

The car stopped in front of Notre Dame. This time Nathaniel was the first to get out. The others also took their gaze from Notre Dame and got out of the vehicle. The front of the cathedral's two towers, reaching towards the sky, was full of people who had come to see Notre Dame. They were taking turns going inside. Nathaniel, Rose, James, Aleron and Scatt also passed through the visitors and entered through the arched doorway with the statues of the twenty-eight kings.

Nathaniel looked around to make sure they were far enough away from the gate. When he was sure that no one was following them, he took a quick look at the faces of his team, one by one.

“James, guide Rose to the treasure room. Rose, don't lose James! Scatt, Aleron and I will search the towers.” Said Nathaniel and looked again at the faces in turn, as if waiting for confirmation.

“You're the leader.” James said in a sarcastic tone as he held up his hands. “Let's go, partner.” James added and started walking. Rose moved quickly and joined James. Together they walked through the Cathedral.

Rose and James made their way to the choir loft, which seemed to be painted in many vibrant colors by the light from the rose windows. Before they reached the choir, Rose noticed the priest standing in the baptismal font. The sparse, white-haired priest was frowning, looking straight at James. He was looking her up and down, intently. Rose paused for a moment, holding her breath. Then, unperturbed, she grabbed James's arm. As James slowed his pace and looked at her, trying to understand what was happening, Rose pointed to the Priest using his eyebrows who was watching them.

“Ian, this may sound paranoid, but that Priest over there has been watching you for a long time.”

Ian looked where Rose was pointing. For a while he searched with his eyes for the person Rose had mentioned. And when he finally saw the man frowning at him, he smiled.

“Follow me.” James said and, tugging Rose by the arm, started walking towards the priest who was watching them. Before they reached the baptismal font, James shouted, “Father Agrican!” and waved his free hand. The priest's gaze softened into a smile as he stared intently at James, his brow furrowed.

“Jesus Christ! James? It's really you!” said the priest, opening his arms. “After a while I began to think you had lost your faith.” He concluded. The priest spoke English, knowing that James' first language was English. The priest's eyes lit up as he saw Rose standing next to James. “James, please don't tell me this lady is your wife, I hope you didn't make the mistake of not inviting me to your wedding.” The priest said sarcastically.

“Don't worry Father, of course I will invite you.” Said James and turned his face to Rose. “May I introduce Father, my friend Rose.”

“Of course, of course, she's just a friend.” Said the priest nodding his head slowly up and down.

James took a deep breath and continued. “Rose, meet Father Agrican. He is the abbot of this church.”

“Nice to meet you, Father.” Rose said with a fake smile.

“I was always happy to meet James' friends Ahh... Good old days. You and Aleron... You two were such a naughty boys.”

“Still, you knew how to handle us, Father. I'll give you that.”

The priest smiled, remembering the old days.

“Is there anything I can help you with? Anything at all?”

“I just wanted to show my friend this beautiful cathedral, which I consider my home.”

“Did you show her the treasure room?”

“Not yet. We're on our way there now, Father.”

“If...”

The young priest, following behind the priest, came up to the white-haired old priest and handed him the phone. “Sir, there's a call for you.” He turned his head to one side to make sure no one could

hear what he had to say, but James and Rose were standing very close.

“This young man is James. You can trust him. I've known him for years.” Said the Father. The young Priest stood where he was for a moment, uneasy, then decided to listen to the Priest.

“Sir, it's about the Pope's visit to the cathedral.”

The priest picked up the phone and looking at James said, “If you need anything, you know where to find me. Just don't ring the bell.” He said and turned around, started talking on the phone.

“Maybe the priest knows where the sword we are looking for is.” Rose said, not taking her eyes off the priest on the phone.

“I don't think so, the sword must be hidden.” Said James as he started walking again. Soon they reached the choir loft and the Priest was completely out of sight. They walked between the rows of benches on either side. They walked through the people praying and reading the Bible on the benches around, looking around. As they walked side by side, the two occasionally looked up from their seats to look at those passing by. Then they went back to their work.

“So you are a religious person.” Rose said before the choruses had passed.

“Not really.”

“I suppose you're not going to tell us anything about yourself except your name?”

James sighed and stopped for a moment.

“Aleron and some of my friends and I used to run away from the orphanage and come here, hiding. We came here because Aleron knew the Priests. And the priests would take care of us. They would take care of us for a few days and then they would take us back to the orphanage.”

“Why were you running away?”

James was silent for a while, his eyes fixed on one of the benches in the choir loft.

“I think the food was really bad,” James said and looked Rose in the eye. “Is that enough for now, Mss. Anton?”

“I think so.” Rose said.

When they reached the end of the choir, James gestured to the south side of the building. “The treasure room.” James said and they proceeded to the entrance he indicated. After paying the toll, they entered through the double-leaf wooden doors.

The door led to a room with all kinds of artifacts. Some of the statues of different sizes were surrounded by glass, others were completely open. Small depictions of Jesus were behind a glass case, along with other gold objects from ancient times. The books they considered sacred were sealed in a glass case, as were most of the other artifacts. The first room was connected by a door in the wall to another room, which in turn was connected to a completely different room. In each room there were different artifacts. They were all different except for the depictions of Jesus.

They were walking through all kinds of historical artifacts. Paintings, statues, old books with torn pages... But they could not find the sword they were looking for. James pointed to the artifact in a glass display case in the center of the room. Rose turned her head and saw the iron circle. It seemed to be surrounded by golden branches. “It's the crown of thorns that Jesus was believed to have worn on his head before he was crucified,” said Ian, “but it's no use to us.”

“What about that?” Rose pointed to the torn, yellowing garment hanging behind the glass. “I don't think that's going to help us either, though.”

“That?” James put his hand under his chin. “The tunic King Louis wore, if I remember correctly.” He squinted and read the

inscription on the glass. "Yes, I was remembering correctly. The tunic believed to have been worn by King Louis in the ninth century. But yes, just as you say, it's useless."

Right after one of the statues, they passed through a door and entered another room. This room was no different from the others. It was surrounded by old books, statues, crosses made of different materials. The only interesting thing was the metal artifact in the center of the room. It rose in trapezoidal shapes with various fist-sized heads around it. Rose walked around the metal structure with curiosity. Then she fixed her gaze on one of the crosses behind the glass.

"There are crosses everywhere." Rose said absentmindedly.

"Maybe it's because we're in a cathedral." Said James.
"Nothing about a sword."

Rose sighed and turned to James.

"You're right. Let's get out of here."

They left the treasure room with heavy steps. Without changing their pace, they headed for the choir section. After passing the first few rows, they sat on one of the long benches. They sat in deathly silence for a while. After a short while James took a deep breath. "Maybe Nathaniel and the others have found the sword." He said, and it was clear from his tone that even he didn't believe it.

"I hope they found something."

Nathaniel was not leading this time. He tried to keep quiet, even though he felt it was an insult to his leadership. Aleron, sensing that Nathaniel didn't like it, tried to take the lead as much as possible. Nathaniel didn't say anything about it because he knew nothing about it. All he did was climb the stairs to the bell tower.

When they got to the top they saw the huge bell. There was no one in the bell tower. Except Nathaniel, Aleron and Scatt, of course. Nathaniel looked at the gray, rusted bell.

“I thought it was made of gold.” Nathaniel said and looked away from the bell and looked around. The tower covered with wooden columns was arranged in an order that did not fit the interior architecture of the Cathedral. The ceiling was lined with wooden columns fixed on different sides in a certain order. They scattered and looked at the scattered wood. Slowly moving towards the bell, they looked around. Deciding that the place was empty, they headed towards the bell. When they passed through the chain in front of it and came to the bell, Nathaniel bent down and peered inside.

“It's just an ordinary big bell.”

“Nathaniel, the sword is hidden. Of course you can't see it at first glance. Otherwise it wouldn't be hidden, would it?” Said Aleron. And he bent down beside Nathaniel and looked inside the bell. Scatt stood where he was. He looked around blankly.

“You're right.” Said Aleron. “There's nothing here. Just an ordinary bell.”

“Then there's only one thing we can do. Going downstairs.”

As they walked back down the stairs, a few tourists were on their way up to see the famous bell of Notre Dame. They quickly passed them and went downstairs. They started walking in the direction Rose and James had gone.

As they passed the baptismal font, Aleron raised his hand to greet the priest on the phone. The priest returned the greeting with a smile and a nod, then returned his attention to the phone.

When they reached the choir loft, Scatt gestured with one arm to one of the benches, the one where Rose and James were sitting.

“Over there.”

“The sword is not in this building.” Nathaniel began. Nathaniel continued while he had killed the last hope of James and Rose. “Or the sword is not hidden. We've been foolish from the start. The sword belongs to the Jewish kingdom. In a cathedral, they wouldn't keep it out of sight. They either buried it under the church or put it in the wall when it was built.”

Nathaniel sat on one of the benches behind Rose and James. He thought. He looked around him. They were fighting a battle they couldn't lose. And the book was going to turn up anyway, but they had to find it first. He began to breathe in and out deeply. He closed his eyes tightly. He tried to empty his mind. He distracted himself from unnecessary thoughts, from where fate would eventually take them, from the outcome, and opened his eyes.

He looked at the cathedral. Its walls, the visiting tourists, the staff, the rose windows. With a sigh, he turned his gaze to the opposite side. He stood there with empty eyes. And he saw the statue at the far end of the church. His eyes widened.

“Isn't the purpose of hiding the sword to prevent it from being found? And where do you put it so it won't be found? Do you bury it somewhere? If you bury it, it might be found by chance. What if you put it inside the walls of a building? Buildings are temporary. People can tear down old ones and build new ones. But if you put it inside a religious artifact and surround it with priests... no one can touch it.”

James looked around to see what Nathaniel was referring to. He too saw the statue of Mary and her children. He looked at the golden cross on top. Smiling, he turned to Nathaniel sitting behind him.

“You mean the golden cross.” He said excitedly. “They would never break it. At worst they melt it, but they never break it. And if they do, the sword will disappear with the cross and the palace

will be locked forever. The sword could be lost forever. Just as Solomon wanted.

“Yes.” Nathaniel said in a confident voice. He was smiling too. “You’re right except for the last part. If Solomon wanted the palace closed forever, he wouldn’t have created a key. Solomon also told me that the magic in the book was meant to be found. That means the palace will open anyway. But if we open it with the key and get in first, we’ll be in control of a great power.

Scatt sighed, keeping his gaze on the golden cross.

“What crime are we going to commit this time?”

“We may be committing a crime, Scatt, but remember we are not criminals.” Said Nathaniel.

“I’m sure the FBI who blew up our cars think so too.” Said Rose. Nathaniel rolled his eyes and continued, ignoring Rose.

“First of all, the first thing we need to do is examine the cross. We have to make sure the sword is inside the cross. If the sword is not there, we have made a big mistake. We can’t disturb a place like this.” Said Nathaniel and paused for a moment. He sighed. “Does anyone have any idea how we’re going to know if it’s in there without breaking the cross? I can’t think of anything off the top of my head.”

James turned to face Aleron sitting behind him. They stared at each other for a brief moment and then James smiled.

“Are you thinking what I’m thinking?”

“Father Agrican?”

James nodded his head up and down in acknowledgment and said, “Father Agrican.” He said. He turned to the others. “There must be something about the cross in the cathedral’s registers. We can talk to Father Agrican and get the records. Follow me.” Said James and stood up. He and the others walked to the baptismal font.

Father Agrican was talking to the other priests and nuns surrounding him. The priests all wore the same outfit. Black pants, black shirt. There were some of them who accessorized with a bow tie. The nuns, dressed in their long black robes, listened attentively to Father Agrican. He was telling them again and again that the Pope was coming, what they should do, how they should behave. They all knew what to do, but Father Agrican was going over everything one more time so as not to take any chances. When he saw James and Aleron coming a few steps ahead, he gestured to the young priests and nuns gathered around him to wait. He walked towards James and Aleron.

"It is good to see you together again, Aleron, James." He said, finally nodding his head as if greeting them one by one by name. "How can I help you, boys?"

"Father, this is the team you see," James gestured to the cathedral with an exaggerated wave of his hand. "They came from America to research and write about this magnificent cathedral, Notre Dame. Aleron and I showed them around, but they said they need more information. I wonder... Is there a book or something where they keep records about the cathedral?"

"Yes, of course," the priest said and turned around and motioned for one of the priests in the baptismal ward to come over. The young priest walked quickly to Agrican. Father Agrican leaned into the young priest's ear and began to whisper. After the young priest nodded in agreement, Agrican turned his gaze to James and Aleron. "This is the young Priest Dieudonné. He will show you to the room where the records are kept."

"Thank you for your help, Father. We owe you one."

"Son, I stopped keeping track of what you owe me a few years ago. After all, you don't pay." Said Father Agrican and put his hand on James' shoulder. "I won't keep you any longer, go and write a good article. I want something worthy of Notre Dame."

“Don't worry, Father, we'll do something no one has ever done before.” James said and he and the young priest started walking through the cathedral. They passed through the tourists. They came to the deserted paths of the cathedral. They passed through the first door, which was only for the staff. Behind the door, two priests were walking briskly towards the door. A nun was entering one of the rooms while a cleaning lady was cleaning the place with a mop stretched out on either side.

The young priest said a few words in French and started walking.

“Follow me, he said.” James translated and they continued to follow the priest.

The young priest led them to a large, carved wooden door. He reached into his pants pocket and soon found the key ring he was looking for. He lifted it to get a clearer view of the ring with several keys lined up on it. Frowning, he turned the keys one by one. After passing about five keys, he decided to try the sixth. When he inserted it into the door and turned it, the door opened. He grunted in satisfaction and opened the door. He gestured inside. Everyone went inside.

Contrary to expectations, it was spotlessly clean. The floor, shining as if it had just been polished, almost served as a mirror. Religious books were lined up on shelves along both sides of the wall. On the walls were motifs of the cross and the hanging Christ. On the opposite wall, an embroidered cross stood at the top of two golden scepters extending from the floor. In the center of the two staffs was a chest, a small chest compared to the wombs. The young priest pointed to the chest in the center, where the designs of branches, waves and crosses were engraved. And he began to speak. James translated.

“Over there. The records you are looking for are over there.” James said. Then he turned his gaze to the Young Priest and thanked him. Then they all walked towards the chest. Nathaniel quickened his

pace and took one step ahead of the others. When he came to the chest, he held it by both sides and opened the lid. The chest opened with a disturbing creak. Inside were rows of books. There were about a dozen books.

Nathaniel took one of the books from the chest and handed it over his shoulder to Rose. He took another and handed it to Scatt and another to James. Finally, he took two and gave one to Aleron and one to James. He opened the book and flipped through it, frowning. Again and again.

“The fucking book is in French!”

“And you can't read it.” Said James with a sigh. “Alright, have Aleron drop you off and then come back here and while you rest, you and I can continue reading the books.”

“James, let me be honest, I don't trust you.” Said Nathaniel,

“Nathaniel, you need to put an end to these trust issues.” James said in a stern tone and quickly closed the book he was holding. “I could have gotten lost already if I wanted to. I brought you to the city where I grew up. If I started running right now, I'd lose you without any trouble. And you would never see me again. But I'm not doing it.

“I'm not doing it because we have to find this book. Because I swore I would find this book. I won't. I trust you implicitly because we're on the same side whether we want to be or not. And you know very well that the book is a problem bigger than both of us. We can't let anyone else get their hands on it, in fact it's better that no one gets their hands on it. Destroy it, yes, I think it would be best to destroy the book, but we're not there yet. We'll decide after we find the book. Let's just find the damn book! You should know, Nathaniel, I'm willing to do anything to find this book.

“All I'm asking you to do is trust me.” Said James. Nathaniel took a deep breath and nodded. He paused for a moment.

“Aleron, take Scatt and Rose home. You get some rest and I'll stay with James. I know a little of French.”

“Actually...” Scatt interrupted, clearing his throat with a few coughs. “I need to see a friend of mine. The friend I mentioned earlier. If you don't mind, Nathaniel, I'd like to meet him.”

“Of course!” said Nathaniel. “Rose?”

“I'll accompany Scatt.”

“Alright, now that everyone's agreed, we can go.” Said Aleron. He handed the book back to Nathaniel. Nathaniel took it in one hand, he took the books from Rose and Scatt too and put them in the chest.”

As Rose, Scatt and Aleron headed for the exit, James grabbed Aleron's arm.

“Can you bring the camera with you?”

“Sure.” Aleron said. He, Scatt and Rose left the room where the records were kept. After a few minutes of walking inside the cathedral, they managed to get outside with the tourists. They headed towards the navy blue car standing ahead. Scatt took a few steps away, asking permission from his companions. He called Mr. Steven on the phone he took out of his pocket.

“Good afternoon Mr. Steven... Yes, I'm calling you about the artifacts. I'm in Paris now, in front of Notre Dame Cathedral. If it's convenient for you, I'd like to meet with you. I'm very curious about the artifacts you found, especially those of Solomon... The Louvre, you said the Louvre, right?.. Okay, thank you, sir, I'll be there as soon as I can.”

Scatt hung up the phone and walked quickly to the car. Rose and Aleron were waiting for him in the car. Scatt took his seat in the front seat and Aleron, who was sitting in the driver's seat, turned to Scatt.

“Where are we going?”

“The Louvre Museum.”

“It's very close to here.” Aleron said and started the car. “less than twenty minutes.” He started driving. Gradually he increased the speed of the vehicle. They crossed the short bridge and drove on a straight road for a while. The roads were empty except for a few cars. Aleron's dark blue car drove calmly along the roads of Paris.

When the car stopped, Scatt watched the glass pyramid without moving for a while. The sun was shining right on top of it. And the light was scattered all around as if it were coming from there.

“The Louvre Museum. The museum that combines modern architecture with the historical structure of the Pyramids.” Scatt said with curiosity and happiness. He smiled his usual little smile. “I've never been to the Louvre before, I wonder what treasures they hide inside.”

“Enjoy yourself. I'll pick you up when you're done.”

“Thanks for the ride, Aleron.” Said Scatt and got out of the car. Rose got out of the car right after him. Aleron watched Rose and Scatt take a few steps towards the museum, then started his car. And drove away.

Scatt frowned involuntarily, his eyes bothered by the sun. As he made his way to the pyramid, he surveyed the line snaking in front of the door. The line was moving slower than he had expected. The closer they got, the more frightening it seemed. A line that seemed never-ending.

Rose continued to walk silently beside Scatt. They reached the end of the line and stood in it. People waited patiently for their turn and when the time came, they could go in. They saw a few people enter.

Scatt and Rose were still waiting in line when a hand from behind touched Scatt's shoulder. Startled, Scatt turned around to see a large man in a suit.

“Mr. Flag?”

“Yes, it's me.”

“My name is Arnold. I'm Mr. Steven's personal bodyguard, and Mr. Steven has assigned me to pick you up at the door. I will let you in without waiting in line and escort you to the room where Mr. Steven's collection is kept.”

“Of course,” Scatt said, “we're right behind you.”

With quick steps Arnold led them out of the line and straight to the entrance of the museum. He gestured to the guards waiting at the door. They cleared the way for Scatt, Rose and Arnold to pass through. Scatt was getting more excited with every step he took inside. He wondered what he would see.

Scatt wanted to visit the museum. He wanted to examine the buildings, listen to their stories, learn about them. But it was hard to do that with Arnold moving through the corridors of the museum at full speed. Scatt made guesses about the sculptures he saw and quickly passed the artifacts. He didn't stop to keep Arnold in sight.

Visitors to the museum filled the corridors and in front of the artifacts. As Scatt followed Arnold through the tourists, he managed to catch glimpses of half-naked statues and antique paintings lined up in rows. He recognized some of them, sculptures he had seen in books he had read years ago. But he continued on his way, unsure.

As they moved on, the number of tourists decreased. The farther they got away from the interesting artifacts, the fewer the tourists. Finally they came to an empty area where there was no one. There were no visitors and no artworks. There was only an empty corridor and doors. Arnold opened one of the doors and invited Scatt and Rose inside. Scatt entered the room first.

The inside of the room was covered with large, covered works of art. Some of the sculptures showed a little of what they looked like. On some of the paintings, a part of the picture could be seen through the open ends of the dusty cover.

At the far end of the room, a brown-haired man of medium height sat reading a book. When he saw people coming in, he looked up to see who was coming. When he saw Scatt enter first, he smiled, put the bookmark he was holding in his hand on the book and stood up. He put the book on the table in front of him.

“Mr. Flag, I haven't seen you in a long time, but you haven't changed a bit!”

“Except the arm I guess.” Said Scatt, holding out his one remaining hand to the man with empty eyes. “Mr. Steven, thank you for inviting me. We are in a bit of a hurry. Is there any chance I can see the artifacts right away?”

“As usual, Mr. Flag, you are hard to find available.” Said Steven as he shook Scatt's hand. Before he could withdraw his handshake, he gestured to the chair with his other, free hand. “Please sit. Only one of the artifacts you see here is truly worthy of your attention so...” He thought for a moment, trying to find the right words. “So Blessed.” He finally said, not sure he had the right word. He paused for a moment and then took his place behind the desk. Scatt sat in the chair in front of Steven's desk.

Steven gestured to Arnold, who entered the room. Arnold closed the door and then walked to the left side of the room. He lifted one of the covers. Underneath it was a matte black bag, more than a meter long. Arnold picked it up, walked over to the desk and put it on the table. He put his hands out to open it but, “Let me take it from here.” Steven said.

Steven took a deep breath and opened the metal buckles on both sides of the bag in front of him. He lifted the lid of the bag. Slowly he turned the bag towards Scatt.

Scatt's eyes widened and his heart began to race. Inside the bag was a bow with one side of the bowstring removed and arrows lined up next to it. There were various symbols on the bow. The most prominent was the star of Solomon. There were breaks and cracks in certain parts of the bow. The arrows, like the bow, were ornate and damaged. It had a metal, rusty tip.

"These... These symbols, all these..."

"It's from Israel. Carbon dating puts it in the nine hundreds BC. So it's probably a bow made in the time of King Solomon."

"This is... It's a marvelous artifact! Well... This..."

"Yes, Mr. Flag, I want to give it to you. I'm not very interested in Eastern civilizations. And you are the right person to give such an artifact to. You're one of the most valuable archaeologists I know."

"I don't know how to thank you, Mr. Steven."

"Don't worry, Mr. Flag. We're already even." Steven said and gestured to all the artifacts in the room. "If it wasn't for you, it wouldn't have been easy to find all of these."

"To be fair to you, these artifacts are the work of three people."

"Yes, you are right. And your wife... Mrs. Flag. Again, my heartfelt condolences. May she rest in peace."

"Thank you, Mr. Steven." Scatt said with the same dull look. He quickly recovered, smiled and looked directly into Mr. Steven's eyes. "Thank you very much indeed." Scatt stood up, closed the bag in front of him and stood up.

"Mr. Flag, you seem to have forgotten the procedure." Said Steven. As Scatt smiled back, Steven opened the drawer next to the desk in front of him and took out the papers. He put them on the table. On top of the papers, he put a pen that he tapped on the back

and opened it. Before Scatt sat down, he took the pen and silently read what was written on the paper and signed his name at the bottom. He slid the top paper aside and read the bottom one. It was the same. Steven's signature was on the same side of both papers. Scatt put his own signature on the second paper.

"This is yours." Steven said as he took one of the papers and put it on the box containing the bow and arrow.

"Thank you again, Mr. Steven. See you later." Said Scatt and took the bag and one of the papers he had signed. He and Rose left the room.

James sighed and turned another page in his book. He was looking for an article about the golden cross in the center of the cathedral. He flipped through the pages again and again, looking for key words. His eyes were tired from reading. He closed his aching eyes tightly and stood still for a few seconds. Then he opened his eyes and looked at Nathaniel standing in front of him.

Nathaniel had also started going through the books after the others had left. He knew certain words and kept going through the book, of course much more slowly. He was tired of it too. He put his finger on the page of the book and took a deep breath. He reached into his pocket and pulled out his metal flask and looked up to take a sip when he and James locked eyes.

"What?" Nathaniel asked. He took a sip from his flask.

"I'm guessing that I figured out why you don't trust me." James replied. "I mean, you trust me enough to stay in my house, you trust me enough to eat the food I give you, but you won't leave me alone."

"Could it be that I don't trust you because you're a murderer?"

"I don't think that has anything to do with it. I'm sure you're no angel either."

"Angels don't drink." Nathaniel raised his eyebrows and waved the flask in his hand at face level, then took another sip.

"We have no differences."

Nathaniel made a fake laugh.

"That's a very funny joke."

"You were going to shoot me yesterday. You carry two guns in your waistband. I'm sure you've used them before."

"I used them, yes, but I used them because I had to."

"Did you use them on the Rebel bloodline?"

Nathaniel leaned against the wall behind him with a sigh. He took a sip from his canteen.

"Yes, I did, but like I said, it was necessary."

"Then we are no different. You can be sure of that. It's just that you're hiding your suffering with your jokes and being frivolity. No matter how sad and devastated you are on the inside, you don't show any of it on the outside. You keep it all inside. You don't want to show anyone how sensitive you really are. You pretend to be cheerful, but you are not."

"I still don't see the resemblance."

James took a deep breath and looked around, remaining silent for a while.

"I've only killed one person so far." James said. His voice was getting quieter. "My father's killer. The asshole who served the rebel bloodline."

After James' diminishing voice, the recording room was deathly silent for a while. James and Nathaniel could only stare. James swallowed and took a deep breath.

"I do not know what you had been through but I can see that you are addressing me as a guilty as a criminal to make your burden lighter. Someone else should be to focus to blame so you won't blame yourself. That is why you act like that. I can see it in your eyes."

Nathaniel ignored James and took a sip from his canteen. He put the flask back in its place, in his inside pocket, and picked up the notebook he had last glanced at. He tried to continue his search in the notebook. As much as his thoughts allowed.

"I want you to understand that we are both fighting on the same side. We have a common enemy and I want nothing more than to see them lose.

"And for me to do my best in this fight, I need the leader to trust me! And you need to come out of your childish state and see the truth! We are on the same side! We want the same people to take the same advice! And you can hate me all you want, brand me a murderer. All I ask is that you be prepared to do whatever it takes to find that damn book!"

James looked directly at Nathaniel, waiting for his answer. But Nathaniel wasn't even interested. He was staring at the notebook in his hand as if he wasn't listening to what James was saying. James took a deep breath. Then he picked up the notebook he had left and continued reading from where he had left off.

For a while no one spoke. They seemed silently busy flipping through the books in their hands and turning the pages. All that could be heard was the sound of paper being turned.

Nathaniel shifted his weight from one foot to the other as he examined the pages of the notebook he was holding. He tried to focus on what he was reading. He skimmed the page from top to bottom.

He moved on to the next page. He checked the words carefully. And moved on to the next page...

After a while, when the door to the recording room opened, James and Nathaniel looked up. Both of them were paying attention to what was coming in. Aleron, Scatt and Rose entered. Aleron had a camera around her neck. Scatt had a long black box in one hand.

James put his finger between the notebook in his hand and straightened up. He walked towards them. When he stood in front of Aleron, she took the camera from around her neck and handed it to him. James handed him the notebook.

James took the camera and stepped in front of Rose, who was standing next to Aleron.

"I have to go and take a picture of the golden cross and you know Nathaniel's trust issues with me. Will you accompany me?"

Rose looked over James' shoulder for a moment at Nathaniel, who was still looking at the notebook in his hand. Then she turned back to James with a small smile.

"Of course!"

Aleron joined Nathaniel as James and Rose left the records room. She continued reading where James had left off.

By the time James and Rose had passed through the inner corridors and reached the main part of the prefecture, it was much quieter than before. There were fewer visitors. There was more freedom of movement inside. The young priests and nuns were absent from the baptismal font. Father Agrican was also nowhere in sight.

Rose and James made their way towards the golden cross. When they reached the choir loft, the first thing they noticed was that the pews were much more crowded than before. Then they noticed Father Agrican speaking in front of the golden cross. They made their way through almost the entire choir. When they were near the end,

James gestured to one of the front benches. They moved to the center of the bench and sat down.

"Ian, can I ask what we're doing here?" Rose said in a whisper. James said nothing for a while. He just fiddled with the settings on the camera he was holding. When he was finally sure he had it set to the setting he wanted, he lifted the camera and took a quick picture. Then he handed the camera to Rose. Rose looked at the picture. She frowned, trying to understand what had happened. Then she looked up and looked at James. Hoping he would explain something. James looked into Rose's curious eyes. He smiled at her shining eyes then put his hand on her arm and said, "I'll tell it at once. Follow me." He said quietly. He stood up and started walking. He apologized to the people sitting on the aisle side of the bench. He and Rose started walking towards the recording room.

When they reached the part that was off limits to visitors again, Rose stopped James by the arm.

"Ian..."

"The recording room is just over there. I'll tell you everything when we get there." James said and kept walking.

"Why are you acting like a detective out of a novel?"

James stopped. He quickly turned to Rose and smiled, "It's more fun that way." He said and started walking again.

Rose rolled her eyes and sighed. She followed James.

They entered the recording room. Aleron, Nathaniel and Scatt entered, standing side by side, looking at the book Aleron was holding. As soon as they noticed them, all three turned their gaze from the book to James and Rose.

"James! I think we found it!" Aleron said excitedly. He hurried towards James.

"I'm all ears."

"It says here," Aleron said and looked down at the book in her hands. "The statue of the Virgin Mary and her children was in the cathedral when it was finished, but without the cross. On June seventeenth, one thousand four hundred and thirty-one, the cross was forged.

"In other words, the same year as Joan of Arc's death." Aleron double-checked what the book said. When he was sure he was telling the truth, he continued. "About two weeks later, in fact."

"Joan of Arc was a female knight in the French army in the fifteenth century." James explained, turning to Rose. "Of course, she was burned to death afterward. But not in this cathedral."

"Not in this cathedral, no. After she was burned, the sword she used in battle disappeared."

"But... Wasn't his sword found in the monastery of St. Catherine?"

"James, you've really listened to the history lessons." Aleron said, raising an eyebrow. "Yes, it was found buried behind a throne in St. Catherine's Monastery. There's a legend going around, true. But I don't think it's very honorable for a knight to bury his sword under the throne. It wasn't with him when he was cremated. Or they didn't put it in his tomb. But someone must have found it. Someone who knew and admired his exploits. If he couldn't save her, he could save her sword, her symbol. They wouldn't have left the sword when Jeanne was cremated. But imagine ourselves as the one who hid the sword. You have the sword of a great warrior, a faithful saint, and how can you keep her memory? The golden cross. By putting it in a golden cross in one of the most important cathedrals."

"So you're saying that the sword that Solomon wanted hidden somehow ended up in France. Maybe Jeanne's father or mother brought it. Or someone even older. It's possible. Take a look at it." James said and handed Aleron the camera. Aleron took the camera and looked at the pictures. His eyes widened.

“What we're looking for is definitely inside the cross.”

“So you solved everything with a camera, a magical camera?” Nathaniel asked sarcastically.

“Usually what we call 'magical' items have different energies and can probably do things by channeling those energies. And this camera tests the energy levels of such items.”

Aleron handed the camera to Nathaniel. Nathaniel squinted at the picture.

“The priest looks good in the photo.” Nathaniel said. His eyes were on the light from the golden cross behind the priest. He looked at the photograph of the light, which seemed to be getting brighter and brighter, symbolized with different color. “But I think what interests us is the colorful lights behind the priest.” “I think it's time to think about how to get the sword.”

“I have an idea.” Aleron said excitedly as he stepped forward. “But it's going to leave a lot of damage. And we'll need some really good equipment. But for that... we gonna need a lot of money.”

“Or we can borrow what your plan requires.”

“No need to borrow.” Rose said. Looked at Nathaniel with her annoying smile. “But we need your bank account Nate.”

Nathaniel looked at Rose with a sigh. Then his glance turned to Aleron.

“What's the plan?”

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

“Loose the arrows!” Solomon shouted and arrows rained down on the creatures. “For the Kingdom of Destiny, Attack!” said Solomon and he started to run, his new sword over his shoulder. This time the guards rushed forward with Solomon. They unsheathed their swords and charged, shouting.

Grimor saw his men slumped to the ground and the guards rushing towards them. He smiled and grasped the handle of the axe at his waist. He held it out towards Solomon and his army.

“Kill them all!” he said in a voice thicker and more terrible than Valefar's.

Solomon swung his sword swiftly, as if dancing. With each swing, pieces of the creature, split in two, fell to the ground. And each time he was splattered with black blood. His heart was beating fast, but he did not feel the slightest fear. As he moved towards Grimor, he thrust his sword into the belly of the roaring creature. Bending down, he came sideways under the sword. Quickly he raised his sword up

and swung it to the side. As the creature's body fell to the ground, Solomon moved on to the next one.

Right behind Solomon Windsor and Azderson appeared. Windsor kneeled in a moment, swung his axe and stabbed the creature. Azderson first stepped on the knee of his fallen friend, then on the creature's face. He leapt into the air and threw the spear at the creature behind the man with axe. He nailed it to the ground from its back. As he landed on the creature he had nailed, he pulled the spear from it and saw the head of the creature in front of the axe fall to the ground. He looked at Windsor. His face was covered in blood, as was his own. Windsor nodded to his friend. And they continued to go after Solomon, fighting.

When Rodrin saw the beast leaping at him with its mouth open to devour him, he moved swiftly to the side and swung his sword. The creature groaned and spilled black blood. Rodrin finished it off with his other sword. When the growl behind him sent shivers down his spine, he quickly turned around and locked eyes with the creature as it leapt towards him. Just as the creature was about to strike him with its huge claw, he was kicked in the stomach from the side and thrown to the other side. As the feet of the guard who kicked him hit the ground, the creature stood up. One of the guards standing on either side of him brought his sword down on its neck as soon as it got up, while the other swung it upwards. As the creature's head rolled on the ground, they went to Rodrin.

“We must catch up with Solomon the Sorcerer! Hurry!”

Solomon was slowly approaching Grimor. He swung his sword to the left and sliced the creature in two. At that moment another jumped at him from the right. Solomon turned quickly and held out his hand. The creature was completely frozen by the light blue fog from its claws and fell to the ground, shattering into dozens of pieces. This spell had not gone unnoticed by Grimor. Now Solomon was attracted to it like a magnet. Grimor was now moving towards Solomon. He had just raised his sword when he saw Rodrin. He had brought three guards with him, who followed close behind.

“Here they are. The best warriors in the kingdom. But why did you only want three?”

“Because...” said Solomon and turned to Grimor. He held out his right hand. And the ring began to glow. He turned his hand over, palm up, and closed his fingers one by one. As he clenched his fist tightly, the ring grew brighter. And he began to pull his fist towards his face. His hand was shaking. Grimor's steps slowed for a moment. Along with the redness around him.

The reds became faces. They wore blood-red leather jackets. Their faces were hidden in the shadow of the crimson hood. In their hands were curved swords that resembled hooks. They held them upside down and swung them horizontally back and forth. In front of Grimor stood two guards, one each on his left and right, and two behind him. Six soldiers stood before them, moving their swords with agility and skill.

Rodrin's eyes widened under his helmet. “These... What are they?” said Rodrin. He hoped his voice did not betray the fear in it.

“Six of Grimor's most loyal soldiers. Their swords cover their bodies with magic. They form the red circle only to inspire fear. I have enchanted your six to see them, and if I do more, I may not be able to defeat Grimor. While you fight them, I will take the source of the darkness.”

Rodrin sheathed his sword. With great courage he took his bow from his back and drew an arrow. He waited for the bowstring to slip from his fingers. The arrow soared swiftly and flew towards the foremost of the red-robed soldiers. Without blinking, the soldier swung his hooked sword to the side and deflected the arrow. The guards stepped forward to attack. Windsor shouted and raised his axe. He charged with Azderson. At the rear, Rodrin followed, tossing his bow to the side and drawing his sword from its scabbard with a great thud.

Solomon followed, hoping the six soldiers would create an opening. As they neared the redcoats, Rodrin who rearmed his sword instead of his bow, charged. The man dodged the incoming sword with the hook of his sword and quickly swung the sword in his other hand. Rodrin ducked under it. He kicked him in the foot. The man was knocked off his feet. And he went down.

Windsor swung his axe swiftly to the side. The redcoat swung his sword and met the axe with the inside of the hook. Windsor looked at the redcoat, grunting in anger. The axe spun with his body and the weapon slid out of the sword. The red warrior quickly stepped forward, gave the spinning axe man a huge slash across the back and took his place.

One of the guards who had followed Rodrin advanced cautiously. He wanted his opponent to strike first. And so he approached. When he was very close to the red vest, the man swung his sword from the side. The guard defended himself with his sword. As soon as the swords clinked, the red soldier swung his second sword high above the ground. The guard took a quick step back. The sword only just barely touched his armor.

The second guard swung his spear forward with all his might. Grimor's man slammed the spear into the ground with the hook of his sword. He struck the spear with all his might and it broke in two. As he drew his metal-armored sword, the man in the red vest leaned down and attacked the man's knee. As the man fell to his knees, the man in the red vest stepped forward and drew a semicircle in the air with his sword and plunged it into the scapula of the kneeling guard. As the man screamed in pain, he thrust his other sword the other way. He quickly pulled his swords to different direction.

Involuntarily ignoring the sound of the guard's dismemberment covered by his screams, Solomon rushed through the gap to Grimor's side. He continued on, knowing he had to ignore it to end all this pain. The six red guards who had spotted Solomon could

not turn back to protect their king, fighting the men who had seen them, though they did not understand how.

“Grimor, child of darkness, I am King Solomon, heir of the magic! And I have come to take back the kingdom of my power!” Solomon said angrily. Grimor approached him with heavy, small steps. He stopped less than a meter between them. He tilted his head to look at Solomon's face. Black mists were coming out from between the black, metal armor. On either side of the horrific helmet were horns that curved up to the sky. Small horns on either side of the chin. His red eyes radiated anger and fear. The mist on his helmet was thrown back like a banner from the shadows. On his back was a huge sword and shield. Two axes at his belt. All matte black.

“Move Forward!” shouted Grimor's terrible voice. “Bring death around! While I have some fun with this little mortal!” As the redcoats widened the circle, he threw his free hand to the other axe on his belt. And quickly drew it.” I am the general of Darkness! I am Grimor! I am destruction...”

Solomon quickly swung his sword to the left. Grimor took a step towards Solomon, struck the sword with his axe and drove the broadside of his other hand into Solomon's face. Solomon was knocked off his feet, lifted into the air and fell backwards.

“Come on, heir fallen, get up!” said Grimor. He was laughing, though his helmet did not show it. Solomon stood up. He wiped the blood from his nose with the back of his hand and spat on the ground. He gripped the hilt of his sword with both hands. He swung the sword with all the fury he could, shouting. He lunged at Grimor's neck. Grimor shook him with his axe and swung his other hand at Solomon's stomach. Solomon leapt back with his sword and dodged this time. He drove his sword with all his strength into the arm with the axe, which was still swinging to the side.

Grimor groaned angrily as his arm fell to the ground.

“My arm... So... So it is true. They manage to create more of those fucking metal... Now I have a worthy opponent! I knew Orin had chosen a new representative the moment the spell Froze the whole kingdom, never thought it would be worthy!”

He brought the remaining axe to the cut part of his arm. One by one, shadows emerged like ropes from between the cut armor, wrapped around the axe and pulled it towards the cut. Grimor gripped his huge sword with his good hand. The whistle of his sword echoed across the battlefield.

At Grimor's command, the red-robed man had sliced through the Guard's shoulders stepped forward to finish what he had started. He advanced with heavy steps. On his knees, the soldier tried to reach for his spear. He was tired and sweating. If he picked up the spear and swung it instantly, he could hit his adversary in the center of the chest. But his arm would not listen to him. his hand wouldn't even move, He closed his eyes as if he thought it was the end. This was it. The man in the red hood placed his left handed sword on the man's left shoulder with the hook facing his target's neck and did the same on the right. He aligned his elbows with his hands, which held the hilt tightly. He quickly spread his arms to his sides. The blood gushing out of the guard was the same color as his red vest.

Grimor swung his axe swiftly at Solomon. Solomon reached his sword to the left and stopped the axe. Grimor attacked, this time using his sword. Solomon quickly pushed the axe away and swung his sword at the Grimor's coming at him from the air. With the tips of the swords pointing to the ground, Grimor swung his axe and Solomon jumped backwards. Weren't fast enough. The axe had split his shoulder, even if only at the tip.

Solomon raised his sword and Grimor swung his axe in the opposite direction, pushing Solomon's sword aside. Solomon who just pushed to the side, swung his sword and brought his sword down to make himself free from the axe, dodging the sword coming at him in the same direction as the axe. He took a step forward and plunged his sword into Grimor's chest.

A shadow was approaching from the direction of the palace. As they got closer, their silhouettes became clearer. Creatures were approaching. More of them. Thousands of them. They snarled as Grimor fell to his knees. As a small smile of satisfaction appeared on Solomon's face, Grimor quietly spoke his last words. Too quiet for Solomon to hear. Solomon solemnly grasped the horn that stood at the level of his face and pulled his helmet closer.

“Your sword... “It will be a true prize of war!” said Grimor and drove his sword into Solomon's belly. Solomon let go of his sword. He fell backwards, bleeding from his stomach. “You must make sure you hit your target, Solomon!” Grimor stood up and pulled the sword from his chest. There was a hollow where the sword had been thrust. Gradually it filled with shadow and returned to its original shape. Solomon could see no more than that. His eyes grew darker and darker. He was sweating profusely. The pain he felt increased the exhaustion of his body. Fear filled Solomon. But it didn't last long because His heart stopped beating.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The wind blew through the half-open window, ruffling James's hair. He was trying to drive as fast as he could. He was overtaking the cars in front of him. He looked in the rearview mirror at the vehicles behind him. Just as he was about to look at the road, the setting sun caught his attention. As the sun was slowly adding yellow color to the blue sky, James noticed the vehicle in front of him at the last moment. Tightening the steering wheel, he quickly turned the steering wheel. Then he turned the other way.

"What time is it?" James asked without taking his eyes off the road.

"Quarter to six." Aleron said as she gripped the handle on the car door.

"If we're going to do this..." said James and turned the steering wheel and swerved, seeing the barriers blocking the road at the last moment. He slammed on the brakes and swerved to the right. The tires screamed and left their tracks on the ground. The car

stopped before it hit the barriers. “Shit!” James yelled as he got out of the car.

“What do we do now?”

“We don't have time. We're on the I'Archevech Bridge, aren't we?” James asked as he walked to the back of the car.

Aleron mumbled as yes. James opened the trunk of the car and took out a long black bag. He carried it to the front of the car and put it on top of the car. He unlocked the locks on either side of the bag and lifted the lid. When he saw the bow inside, he couldn't help smiling and gripped it by the hilt. Breathing deeply, he walked to the edge of the bridge, looked under the bridge for a moment, then raised his head and focused on his target. He threw his shoulders back. He took his position so that the cathedral stood next to him. He began to breathe in and out deeply. Aleron carefully removed the single arrow from the bag. The arrow was free of the rusty metal at its tip and in its place was a shiny little cylinder. It was a cylinder, sharp again at the very tip. Aleron handed the arrow to James.

“The compressed hydrogen gas at the tip of the arrow has increased its weight by about ten to fifteen grams. Be careful when you shoot it. We don't want any trouble.”

James carefully took the arrow from Aleron's hand and placed it on the bow.

“To be honest, I don't know what effect ten grams of weight will have, but I'll manage, the target is big enough. The damage won't be too great, will it?”

“If you can hit the roof, the impact will be much less. Like we want.”

James took a breath and started to stretch the bow. While the bow was being stretched, James was moving it to the position he wanted, lifting it into the air. The moment he stopped stretching the

bow, he stopped breathing. The tip of the arrow pointed to Notre Dame Cathedral.

“Jesus, if you are real, forgive me.” James whispered and the arrow slowly slipped through his fingers. It flew swiftly towards the cathedral. As soon as it hit the roof of the cathedral, the wooden roof began to burn with a great cracking and explosion noises that were mumbled. As the flames raged, engulfing part of the roof, the first part that the arrow struck began to crumble with a crackling sound. One by one the fragments fell into the cathedral.

Dark smoke was rising from the cathedral. As it rose, the smoke surrounded the statue of Gargoyle and reached up to the sky, giving the statue an even more terrifying appearance. People were trying to get out of the cathedral in fear with screams, and those who did were fleeing in different directions. Those who could get far enough away from the burning cathedral were recording what was happening with their cell phones. Just like those who were passing by and saw the fire. The destruction of Notre Dame was being recorded with fear and excitement.

At that moment, a siren sounded, giving everyone hope. A red firetruck sped past several cars left and right and stopped in front of the church. As the firefighters got out, the crowd around the cathedral began to cheer. They were congratulating the firefighters, hoping to put out the fire as soon as possible. While one of them turned on the water and tackled the fire on the roof, another one rushed through the garden towards the church.

The firefighter heading towards the cathedral straightened the axe he was holding in his hand. As he moved forward with his axe, he saw the priest who had just come out of the cathedral, dressed in black, his face black with smudge, wearing a silver necklace. Old Agrican coughed and saw the fireman coming towards him, towards the Cathedral. His eyes widened with happiness and excitement.

“Merci Seigneur Jésus! Dieu vous a envoy pour aider! En très peu de temps...”

"I'm sorry to interrupt you, Father." Said the fireman, not having the slightest effort to understand what the priest was saying. "But I have a cathedral to save! Pray that we can save the cathedral."

The priest said, "God be with you, son." Like the fireman, this time he used English. The fireman nodded gravely and then rushed into the cathedral.

Flaming wood rained down from the sky. The fireman took his steps carefully. He looked up because of the great crackling he heard from above. At the last moment he noticed the flaming wood falling steeply on him and jumped to the side. The log crashed to the ground and then toppled over. When the fireman stood up, he realized that he did not have his axe in his hand. He looked around and saw that it was under one of the small fallen logs. Fortunately, there was no fire on it. It looked like a black piece of wood from an extinguished campfire. He grabbed the handle of the axe and continued on his way.

The flames were growing stronger with the falling roof fragments. The collapsed roof was more of a ruin than the walls around the cathedral. The walls remained more intact. The fireman jumped over the flaming pieces of wood at a run. He ran quickly, looking around. When he reached the choir, he saw that the benches had collapsed with huge pieces of roof falling on them. Those that didn't have pieces of the roof falling on them started to ignite with the flames dancing on the wood next to them.

The firefighter stopped for a moment. The dancing flames reminded him of something else. Torches. And torches were showing him the war. And war was the reminder of the death. He was startled awake by a piece of wood breaking on the ground just behind him. He hadn't realized it until the last moment. But nothing had happened to him. He took a deep breath and raised his head. He looked at the statue in front of him.

With flames rising on both sides of him, he moved towards the statue. With each step, he felt it getting hotter and hotter. He clenched the axe he was holding in his hand. When he came in front of the statue, he put his hand on it. He looked around. No one was in sight.

“God, if you're real, you know why I did this.” Nathaniel said and took a step back with a sigh. He held the axe well back. He pulled the axe back as far as he could. “In the name of Solomon the Bearded!” he shouted, striking the axe with all his might at the junction of the statue and the golden pilgrimage. He smiled. He held the axe even tighter. He was enjoying this. He struck again. And again.

Just as he raised the axe to strike once more, the cross toppled to the side with a crackling sound, faster and faster.

“Nate,” Scatt's voice echoed in his ear. “we have guests, you better hurry.” Nate put his hand to his ear.

“I'm almost done.” Nate said and looked down at the fallen cross. It was still in one piece. He raised the axe above his head and hit it with all his might. Again and again and again...

As the pieces scattered around him, metal was revealed. Brighter one. Each time he struck, it revealed more and more. And the smile on Nathaniel's face grew as the silver came out of the gold.

When he thought he had exposed enough, he threw the axe aside. He was out of breath. He was on one knee. First he grabbed the big barges and threw them around, then he swept all the small pieces, dust and stones aside with his hand. The sword, which looks like it forged just minutes ago from the brightest metals, was on the ground. There was a crackling sound along with the fires.

Nate gripped the hilt of the sword. He was about to raise it like a knight when wood falling from the sky reminded him where he

was. He quickened his pace. He ran through the cathedral. As he ran, he took a folded cloth from his pocket and began to wrap it around the sword. He was moving forward with excitement. He was dodging the flaming pieces of wood raining down from the sky. When he finished wrapping the sword, he hugged it tightly. The exit was right in front of him. Just as he was about to leave, two more firemen entered. Nathaniel froze for a moment.

“Quick!” he shouted. At the same time pointing with one hand in the direction he had come from. “Save what artifacts you can from the treasure room! There is no one inside! Living or dead, hurry! God is with us brothers and sisters!” Nathaniel sighed as the firemen ran in the direction he pointed without questioning Nathaniel's words. He was glad that the firemen also spoke English. Or they just run the direction that shown.

As soon as Nathaniel stepped out of the Cathedral, he came to the firetruck. When he saw the firefighters coming up behind him, he quickly leaned his back against the car. He watched the firemen enter the cathedral. After the firemen had gone inside, into the flames, he took a deep breath and came back to the firetruck he had gotten out of. He looked around a few times, and when he was sure that no one had seen him, he took off his helmet and threw it to the side, then took off his overalls. He was trying to hurry. When he poked his head out, he could just make out the dark blue car waiting for him across the street, behind the police fence, through the crowd. The door of the firetruck opened and a fireman got out. He handed Nathaniel a blanket. Nathaniel threw it over his back. He hid what he was holding as good as he could. The fireman put his arms around him and Nathaniel leaned forward. He and the fireman walked towards the police tape. Nathaniel began to cough with every step. Especially as he walked towards the policemen. The coughing was incessant. After the policemen helped him and the fireman going through under the tape, Nathaniel and the fireman disappeared into the crowd.

The car door opened and Nathaniel threw himself inside. Then Rose, in her firefighter's overalls, got into the car without waiting for Nathaniel to get settled.

"I got the sword! That feels really good! After a long time, the mission accomplished! No matter how much money I lost. We got the sword!" Nathaniel said enthusiastically. He unfolded the wrapped cloth inside the car.

The metal sword lay in the arms of Scatt, Rose and Nathaniel. There was no sign of rust on the thin, inlaid blade. Solomon's five-sided star was engraved in the center of the point where the hilt met the blade. On either side were different engravings.

"It's really beautiful!" Scatt said with a big smile on his face. He carefully ran his hand along the metal part of the sword. "And it is definitely an artifact from Solomon's kingdom. The star in the center of the sword is about all the Jews, yes, but do you see the fine details here, the inscription towards the top?" Scatt asked. "No? Okay." After a moment of wrangling, he managed to reach into his bag. And he took the parchment out of his bag and opened it. "As you can see, it's the same alphabet. It's exactly the same."

"Well, that's good news!"

James's attention was on the burning cathedral. The cathedral of his childhood was now in ruins. He was glad that Father Agrican had gotten out, but the whole cathedral was in fire. The firemen, the real ones, were trying to put out the fire.

James sighed and put his hands on the steering wheel. At least they had wrecked the cathedral for the right cause. He reached up to straighten the rearview mirror and looked at the people in the back. Everyone was happy. In their hands was the sword that led to the book. Rose was smiling. With a small smile, James adjusted the mirror to the perfect angle as he wanted. And he started the car. As the smoke rose over the cathedral, James's dark blue car drove away from the cathedral.

As the sun set and the moon take it's place, James stopped his car. He parked in his usual spot. He looked at the rising moon. He smiled and got out of the car. Aleron quickened her pace and got to the house before the others. He opened the door and went inside. He was followed by James, Rose, Scatt and the head guard carrying the Sword.

As soon as Nathaniel entered the house, he put the sword, still partially wrapped in cloth, on the table and opened the cover completely. His face was still smiling.

"What's next? Where do we go now?" he asked curiously. He was looking straight into James' eyes.

"Take it easy, Nathaniel. Let's get a good rest now. Because heading to the airport will be the first thing we are gonna do tomorrow.

"Are you kidding me? Fuck! Why didn't they just put everything in one city?"

"Actually, having things scattered in different places makes them harder to find. It's a distraction to keep the Rebel bloodline as busy as possible, if they had found the scroll. Also, the hiding times of the items found are independent of each other."

"Thanks for the explanation, Scatt." Said Nathaniel and turned back to James. "I'm getting tired of this. Where's the book?"

"The results my father found were a location on Narodnaya Mountain. In other words, Nate, we're going to Russia."

Nathaniel stood still for a while. He waited for James to continue. But James didn't keep talking.

"That's it? We just go to the mountain in Russia and get the book. We're not going to blow anything up or kidnap anyone?"

James was surprised by the last part of the sentence, but he shook his head from side to side without showing his reaction.

“No, that's it. We take the sword, we go into Solomon's palace and we get the book. Nothing else. We just go and get it.”

“In the end it will all be over. Now that's excellent news! We leave tomorrow at sunrise. Isn't that good for everyone?” Nathaniel continued when he saw no one disagreeing. “Good!” said Nathaniel and went up the stairs with the others. He went into his own room.

The diary was still as he had left it. It was on the table, closed. Nathaniel focused on the diary for a while. He thought about what he had written in it. Then he walked over to the desk.

“I think there are some things I need to erase. Things that will never happen.” He said with a small smile. As if it had suddenly occurred to him, he reached into his pocket and pulled out his cell phone. He called Fred. And told him to get the plane ready for tomorrow morning and hung up. He called Alfred, as usual. He turned around and threw himself down on the bed. “It'll all be over in the end.” He said to himself.

The next day, just as Nathaniel had said, the sun was just coming up and everyone was already sitting around the table downstairs, ready and waiting. They quickly ate their breakfast and left the house. James was driving the car as usual.

James parked the car right next to Nathaniel's plane. When Fred saw them coming, he went to the door of the plane.

“Good morning, did you find what you were looking for?”

“Yes, Alfred. We found it.” Said Nathaniel and held up the sword covered with a cloth with only the hilt exposed. “Before you ask, we're going to Russia.”

“Russia? Which airport?”

Nathaniel took a deep breath to answer. Desperate to exhale, he turned to face James.

“Which airport?”

"I don't know which airport we should go to, all I know is that the location is near Narodnaya Mountain."

"Narodnaya Mountain." Fred said with a small smile. "That's all I needed. It should be ready in a few minutes."

"Take your seats." Said Nathaniel as he walked towards the plane. Scatt, Rose and James followed close behind. As they boarded the plane one by one, Aleron grabbed James by the collar.

"I'm not coming, brother." Aleron said. James looked into his friend's eyes for a while. He was waiting for a reason. "The hero thing... well, it's not really my thing. Besides, one of us has to look after Father Agrican. He needs to stand by his side and cheer him up about the collapsing Cathedral."

"And that would be you."

"Yes. sorry, brother."

James looked at Aleron for a brief moment with sad eyes. He shook his head slightly and held out his hand. Aleron shook it with a bitter smile and hugged his friend, whom he considered like a brother.

"Don't take too long this time." Aleron said as he released James. "And something tells me you won't be alone when you get back." Aleron added as he watched Rose board the plane. He smiled and patted James on the shoulder. When James saw the direction Aleron was looking, he looked over his shoulder at the plane.

" See you soon, brother."

" Take care of Father Agrican. And of course yourself too. See you soon." James said and he and Aleron hugged once more and parted. he walked to the car while James walked to the plane.

When James was on the plane, Fred poked his head out of the cockpit door and looked in. He saw that everyone was accounted for.

"If everyone's ready, let's get going."

"Everyone's here, Alfred. Start the plane." Said Nathaniel. He had put the sword vertically on the seat next to him and was writing in his diary again. James looked intently at Nathaniel, who was writing in the diary. He watched him for a while, wondering how he was telling the story. Soon he decided to leave Nathaniel alone with his diary and made his way to the back seats. Scatt had taken his place by the window again. Rose was sitting in her usual place.

James made his way to the seat opposite Rose. He was about to sit down when he stopped. He changed his mind and sat next to Rose. He took a deep breath and leaned his head against the seat. As the plane started to move, the seat on which he rested his head trembled. As the plane accelerated, the shaking became more intense. Until the plane took off. James turned his head to the side as the plane finally lifted into the sky. First he looked at Rose. Then out the window, smiling.

For a long time there was silence on the plane. Scatt was asleep, Nathaniel was filling in his diary. James looked at the others one by one with a sigh. Then, with a sigh, he leaned his head back against the seat. He closed his eyes.

By the time the plane landed, Fred had already arranged for the right vehicle. Since Nathaniel and Nathaniel's company were paying all the expenses for the trip, he had been as generous as usual in his choice of vehicle. A monster truck-like off-road vehicle with big wheels was waiting for them right in front of the plane.

Nathaniel happily stopped his writing. He put the diary on the seat. Immediately he grabbed the metal bag at his feet in one hand. With other hand he grabbed the sword. He pulled the sword against his chest, hugged it tightly and exited the plane. Scatt followed in his footsteps. Rose and James behind them.

When they reached the car, Nathaniel put the sword and the box containing his gauntlet in the trunk. As he sat in the front seat, he

felt happier than he had in a long time. Soon the book would be in their hands. All they had to do was go and get it.

Once everyone was settled in the car, Fred started driving according to the coordinates he had learned from James.

As they drove away from the airport, the concrete road began to deteriorate. It turned into a bumpy road covered with yellowed grass and stones. Although it was not noticeable at first, the vehicle started to sway as they got closer to their destination.

The vehicle was sometimes bouncing and sometimes shaking on the road covered with rocks. They were passing through roads that a normal vehicle could not pass. Their journey with the vehicle had taken longer than they thought. Especially Nathaniel. He dreamed of reaching the book with great happiness. Without losing anything. No war. It would all be over. As soon as he found the book, it would all be over.

The car bounced to stop and Nathaniel got out of the vehicle with excitement. He took a deep breath. They were going to get the book. He looked around. They were in a messy area covered with stones, rocks, grass and plants. It wasn't as high as Everest, but it was still high. He squinted, annoyed by the sun shining directly into his eyes. He took the metal box and the sword from the trunk of the car.

"We're at the coordinates you said, James. What do we do now? Which way do we go?"

"Nathaniel, the coordinates don't take us to a certain point, a certain place. The coordinates take us to a certain area. It's here. The entrance to the palace must be around here somewhere. We need to find it."

"Damn it! Why can't anything ever be easy?"

"It'll be easier than blowing up a cathedral. We'll find it in a couple hours. We just need to split up."

Nathaniel raised one eyebrow and smiled. He went to the back of the car and put the metal box on top of it. He handed the sword to Rose.

“Or, as Headknight, I can locate the palace. I take the sword in my hand and the sword will show me what I need to see. Maybe where it was forged, the way Solomon used it, or the way he gave it to someone!”

“It's worth a try.”

Nathaniel looked around, folding up the sleeve of his trench coat that covered his left hand where he was going to put the gauntlet on. Puffing out his chest, he opened the box containing the gauntlet. The sun was shining directly into the eye on the gauntlet. And it was radiating all around the eye. Nathaniel took off the gauntlet with excitement but also with great care. He held it up to the sky until its shadow fell on his face. Then he looked at the embroidery and slowly put it on his hand. Raising one eyebrow, he turned to Rose standing beside him.

“The sword.” He said, holding out his hand.

“Do you want me to kneel when you give it to me?” Rose said mockingly. Nathaniel sighed. He took a step towards Rose and said, “Just give me the fucking sword.” He said in a calm voice. With his right hand, he grabbed the sword by the hilt and yanked it out of Rose's hand. When Rose let go of the sword and it was in Nathaniel's hand, it broke free of the shroud it was wrapped in.

Nathaniel began to breathe deeply. He breathed inhaled and exhaled, never taking his eyes off the sword. With his right hand, he held the sword by the top of the hilt. Inverted, he brought the sword closer to his chest. Opening and closing his gauntlet d fingers, he pulled the sword towards the hilt. And he gripped the sword with the gauntlet.

Nathaniel closed his eyes. He was breathing heavily. He was still conscious. He just closed his eyes.

The gauntlet of the Headknight began to glow. Beams of light flowed from the engraved patterns around him, straight into the center eye. The opened eye was getting brighter and brighter. Nathaniel couldn't see it. His eyes were still closed, but he could feel the warmth on his hand. The warmth flowing from the gauntlet to the center of the back of his hand. The power.

Nathaniel thought of the book. The book he had seen in the vision. Solomon's book. He shuddered as Solomon's words echoed in his ear. Magic wants to be found. He began to move through the darkness. He couldn't see where he was going. He didn't need to. The gauntlet was taking him.

"The spell wants to be found." Said Nathaniel in a whisper. "And it will show the eye." He started to walk. He walked with his eyes closed. The others watched Nathaniel curiously, making no sound, following him silently. Nathaniel walked calmly. The stance of the sword never changed. Nathaniel held it with the hilt at the level of Nathaniel's chest, the sharp point facing the ground.

As Nathaniel moved through the darkness, he heard a sound. It was a sound he could not make out. It echoed in his ears with every step. It was not Solomon's voice. It was different. They sounded like whispers spoken at the same time. They were both too complex to understand and yet in harmony with each other. But the voices were very different. Especially Solomon's. There was something different about these voices. Darkness. Not normal darkness. It was evil. The eye could not see the evil, the darkness, but it made Nathaniel feel it. The dark magic was guiding him.

After walking for a while, Nathaniel stopped. He couldn't see, but he could feel. The palace was under his feet. The magic of the book was showing him. His eyes opened slowly. At first he looked around, as if he could not comprehend where he was. They were a long way from the vehicle. Nathaniel was too busy with the voices in his head to realize how far they had walked. Then he saw the curious looks on him. Everyone was waiting for an explanation from him.

"I know why the coordinates take us to a region and not to a point. The coordinates take us to the palace, yes." Said Nathaniel. He looked at everyone's faces one by one. "And this whole region is the palace itself. The palace is somewhere under our feet. It is in the ground. But we don't need to find the palace, we need to find the door."

"Where is the door?"

"I think I know." He said, but he didn't seem to know what he knew. He looked around him. He looked at the mountainous area surrounded by rocks. He used the sword to point. "That way." He said. Nathaniel started walking towards where he pointed with the sword. He stepped firmly on the ground. With each step he took a good look around him. He was unsure, as if he might fall down at any moment. As he progressed, he began to climb up the side of the mountain of rocks. They followed a path that resembled a path on the small cliff.

Soon they came to a wide plain. Even though the rocks prevented the ground from being smooth. Nathaniel seemed to quicken his pace as they went on. Sometimes he would suddenly change direction and head in another direction. He watched the ground but moved without seeing anything. The only precursor was the gauntlet. The feel of the gauntlet. The knowledge.

Finally, Nathaniel stopped in front of a huge boulder. There was not the slightest emotion on his face. He wanted the sword, but he had no idea how to get to it. Nathaniel put one foot forward and lifted the sword. He made an arc in the air and with all his strength he drove the sword into the ground next to the foot he had put forward. The sword kept sinking in.

The sword cut through the rock as if it were cutting the air. And sinking in. Halfway in, it stopped. For a moment tiny wisps of light shot out of the corners and burned out. For a moment runes glowed on the sword and on the rocks on the ground. But everyone saw too little light to argue that it was real.

Under their feet, the ground, the mountain began to tremble. The ground shook. It was as if the earthquake wanted to throw everyone on the hill down. But it didn't. The tremor was as short-lived as the light show. Even after the earthquake on the mountain was over, the ground under Nathaniel's feet continued to shake. When Nathaniel stepped back, he saw the rocks beside the sword trembling and opening to either side. His eyes widened with excitement. He instantly forgot the feeling of the sword. The mission was over. The book would soon be theirs.

The rock split in two, revealing stone steps underneath. The steps led down into the ground. Sunlight illuminated the first few steps, but the rest were shrouded in darkness.

James bent down to Rose's ear, keeping his eyes wide open.

"You should have kneeled." He whispered.

Rose's gaze seemed fixed on the same place.

"I completely agree." She said in a whisper. She didn't want Nathaniel to hear.

"The darkness is calling us, my friends." Nathaniel said, turning away. He held out his hand towards the steps, inviting the others. Scatt excitedly went down first. Rose came down soon after. When Nathaniel looked at James to tell him to go first, James was faster.

"After you Headknight."

A small smile appeared on Nathaniel's face. He nodded and started down the steps. James had just joined the line when his eye caught the sword. It was just standing there, sticking out. He paused for a moment, looking at the people going down. Then he looked at the sword again. With a big step he reached the sword. He looked around once more. He gripped the sword by the hilt with both hands. He took a deep breath and drew the sword. The sword came up as easily as it had gone in. When James realized that the sword was

moving as if it was not stuck in anything, he pulled it completely out of the rock. He looked at the sword once more as if he was seeing it for the first time. He rubbed his hand over where he thought the runes had appeared. It was a perfect sword. James lifted the sword into the air. Looking over his shoulder, Nathaniel saw James on the steps. "Hurry up, King Arthur! We need to take back your father's throne!" he shouted. James stopped looking at the sword when he heard Nathaniel and started down the steps with it.

It was hard to see where the end of the stairs led. Nevertheless, they went down the steps. When it was too dark to see anything, they put their hands on the walls beside them and began to descend slowly and cautiously. They moved forward with sure steps.

Scatt put his foot forward and realized there was no step. Carefully he took a second step. Again there was no new step. Suddenly there was a gust of wind that filled all the steps. It rushed down and when it reached where Scatt was, it continued without stopping. For a moment, with the sound of a gust of wind, a light appeared on the wall ahead. A torch. The flame on it swayed as if dancing with the wind that lit it. Just ahead of it another one lit up. And another. The torches continued to burn as the wind filled the entire corridor and blew fast. One by one the torches lit up the darkness.

A corridor stood before them. Where Scatt stood, the huge double doors were wide open.

"Magic needs to change the way it guides us. It's enough of torches." Nathaniel said and started walking down the torch-lit corridor. The others followed close behind. "Finally, the mission will end! I'll be done with the library. I won't see Bob, I have a good life ahead of me."

"No offense, but your whole life seems to be the library." Said James as he came up from the back.

"Nathaniel, what do you plan to do after this is all over?"

“To be honest, I'm going to stop fighting, I'm going to go and sit on my throne, in the boss's chair and run my company. The knights don't have much responsibility anyway. If we put it somewhere safe enough to prevent the rebels from getting the book, all the problems will be solved. Right?” after a moment of silence Nathaniel asked. “What about you Scatt?”

“I think I'll retire, give up all things magical, maybe apply to be a lecturer at a university.” Said Scatt, walking with his head down. When he realized that everyone had stopped, he stopped too and looked up. Everyone had stopped because the corridor split into three different paths. Torch flames were waving in all three corridors.

“Which way?” Rose asked, looking at Nathaniel. Everyone was looking at Nathaniel now. James handed him the sword to use.

Nathaniel touched the sword with the gauntlet. He closed his eyes and began to breathe slowly. Soon he opened one eye and looked around. Nothing had happened. He opened the other eye. His gauntlet did not glow. It didn't show anything. Nathaniel shook his head from side to side.

“I'm sorry. I have no idea. I think the book's magic only escorted me to the door. Perhaps it has no power in this palace. After all, this is Solomon's palace and the book is full of dark magic.

“I think we'd better do what we always do and split up. James, Scatt take the right. Rose, you take the left. I'll go straight ahead, as you can imagine.”

“I guess you'll have to stop me if I try to run back, Scatt.” Said James in a mocking tone.

“Nah.” Said Nathaniel shaking his head. “We are in a magical palace. At least there are magical torches. Which means this place is magical to some extent. I have no idea if the corridors of the palace are safe. If there is something magical, you have the only weapon that can cut it. The glowing sword.

“To cut a long story short, I'm sending you with Scatt to protect him.” Nathaniel took a step towards James and held out his hand. “I trust you.”

James smiled and shook Nathaniel's hand.

“It's about damn time.” James said in a determined tone, suddenly serious. His gaze shifted to Rose. “What about Rose?”

Rose reached into her waistband and pulled out her pistol. With her other hand she drew her knife.

“She'll be fine.” Nathaniel said, looking over his shoulder at Rose. “He was my partner after all. He must have learned something from me.”

“You have nothing to teach me but childish behavior, Nate.” Rose said without looking back. She headed down the hallway Nathaniel showed her. The others watched Rose disappear down the hall for a while. Then they headed for their own corridors.

As James walked side by side with Scatt, his gaze fell on the sword in his hand.

“I wish we had found a scabbard for this sword before we left France.”

Scatt looked at the sword in James' hand. The yellow light from the flames of the torches was falling on it. The light on the sword moved constantly as the Alecs danced and swayed. James carefully lifted the sword. He put it on his shoulder with the broad side facing the ceiling.

“That's better.” He said with a smile.

They walked down the cobwebbed corridor for a while. They kept walking in silence, looking around. Up ahead, further down the corridor, there were doors on both sides. In a row, lined up, the doors stretched along the corridor.

When they came to the first door, James put his hand on the round handle and pulled it towards him. The door opened with a loud creak and dust rained down around it. It was dark behind the door. James picked up the torch hanging on the wall near the door. He shone the rustling flame inside.

Inside, it was empty. It was too small a room to fit much furniture. Like the corridors of the palace, the room was covered with cobwebs. There was nothing in the dirty, dark room. As he closed the door to the room, James suddenly stopped. He looked around. First into the empty room and then down both sides of the corridor. For a moment he thought he heard something.

“James, is something wrong?”

“I thought I heard something,” James said without taking his gaze from the hallway. He said. Then he came to his senses and turned to Scatt. “It's nothing important. Let's move on.”

Nathaniel whistled his way down the cobwebbed, gloomy corridor he traveled alone. His left hand was on his revolver. He walked straight ahead until he came to doors on either side of the corridor. But when he came to the doors, he started checking the inside of each door one by one. He took the first door by the handle and opened it slowly. Nathaniel took a big step backwards as he pushed it open. The door swung wide open and slammed against the wall behind him. Nathaniel took careful steps inside. He couldn't see anything, so he quickly went outside and picked up the torch on the edge of the door. He went inside again. There was nothing but dusty and cobwebbed furniture. He went into the next room. This room was no different. And the next one.

After long and tedious room checks, he finally came across a different door. This room, unlike the others, was closed by a metal door. Nathaniel opened it curiously. His eyes widened. A smile appeared on his face. The room was filled with weapons. Swords of different sizes lined up in a row, triangular, round and rectangular

shields, sharp and smooth maces, huge spears, double and single-sided inlaid axes... But no books.

Nathaniel looked at the weapons in front of the door for a while. He turned his back. He looked down the corridor. He looked at the weapons again. He walked over to the weapons with a small smile.

“As one of the Headknights, I think I'm authorized to use these, old Solomon.” He said to himself and came to the section where the swords were lined up. He glanced at the swords excitedly, trying to decide which size to pick, and when he decided it made the most sense to try it out, he grabbed one of the long swords by the hilt. As he drew it, the sword filled the air with metallic sound. Nathaniel swung the sword at the imaginary enemy. It was too long. He replaced the sword and moved on to the second.

He tried several swords until he found one that fit his hand perfectly. Finally he settled on one of the short swords. After swinging the sword as easily as he wanted, he was satisfied. He took a scabbard from the rack next to the swords. He put the sword in it. Then he widened the belt of it, putting it around his shoulder. The sword now rested on his back. Nathaniel left the room with great smile.

Rose moved forward at a brisk pace. She walked until she came to a door. She opened the first door. She took a torch from the hallway and entered the dark room. It was obvious that no one had been in the room for years. The cobwebs on the bed showed this very clearly. Rose had taken a few steps towards the exit when she heard a creak from behind her, coming from inside the room. Slowly she turned around. She stared in silence for a while. Her eyes searched for the source of the sound.

Finally, she decided that the source of the sound was the wooden closet on the left side of the room. As she slowly made his way to the cupboard, she drew his gun and quickly opened the doors. It was empty. Except for bugs and old dusty clothes. She exhaled a

deep breath and turned around. When she saw the shadow passing through the door, she rushed out into the hallway. But when she came to the corridor lit by dancing fires, she saw no one.

The corridor went straight ahead for a long time, without crossroad. James and Scatt talked all the way through and Scatt talked about the things he had found along the way and where he had found them. James listened with great attention.

They were looking through the doors in the corridor, not knowing what kind of room they were looking for. Just like Rose and Nathaniel, who swung his new sword as if he were an enemy.

At the end of the corridor, it again split into different paths. There were corridors leading in different directions. They seemed to wrap around the door in the very center as the paths split off in different directions. They went in different directions. In the very center stood a huge double-leaf door. The brass door was inlaid with gold. A prominent star was engraved in the very center, taking up the largest space. All the other decorations surrounded the star as if it were the center of the door.

Scatt's wide-open eyes watched the door. He was speechless. He was watching the door with excitement.

"I think..." he finally said, swallowing. "I think the book is behind this door."

"Let's go inside." James said and stopped, the sound of footsteps coming from different corridors could be heard very clearly. James lowered the sword from his shoulder. He took his position holding the hilt tightly with both hands. Thanks to the torches, his shadow was first seen coming down the corridor. As James breathed in and out calmly, he saw it was Nathaniel.

Frowning, he stared for a moment at the hilt extending from Nathaniel's back.

“Nice sword.” He said at last. And just then Rose appeared from another corridor.

“Thank goodness we won't need to use it.” Nathaniel said as he moved to one of the door wings. He took his seat and put his hands on the door. He looked at James standing next to him. didn't need to say anything. James handed the sword to Scatt. Scatt took it and James moved to the other side of the door. Nathaniel counted down from three. When it reached one, they both pushed the doors at the same time. The doors were made as heavy as possible, as if they were not meant to open. The doors opened with a great creak. They did not open both wings completely. They opened them just enough to let them in. And they went in.

“Well, they left the best for last.” Nathaniel said as he watched the large room with wide eyes.

The high ceiling of the room was held up by a row of embroidered columns. On either side of the ceiling were seven or eight meters of banners that reached almost to the floor, not far behind the pillars. Different pictures were embroidered on each banner. It was clear that each one depicted a different battle. Torches burning between the banners lined up in a row on the wall were the light sources illuminating the room. In the very center of the room, a straight red carpet stretched almost to the opposite wall. The carpet ended just in front of the throne. A few steps up, the throne was covered with embroidery like everywhere else. The most prominent was the circle on the throne and the star inside it.

“Headknight Cooper...” James said, gesturing to the red carpet. “After you.” Nathaniel gave a small smile, puffed out his chest, nodded and began to walk. As Nathaniel walked across the carpet, he noticed how clean the throne room was. It was not covered in dust or cobwebs like the other rooms. On the contrary, it looked as if it had just been cleaned a few minutes ago.

While Scatt going inside he gave the sword back to James. After him Rose went in and lastly James. They walked across the red

carpet to the throne. "So where is the book?" Nathaniel asked as he slowly climbed the steps in front of the throne. As he unsheathed his sword, the clang of metal filled the throne room. Nathaniel sat on the throne, raising one eyebrow and smiling. He rested the tip of the sword on the floor and posed with both hands on the hilt.

"What do you think the chances are of finding a crown in one of the rooms?"

Scatt gestured to the armrest of the throne. When everyone turned to face it, they saw the gold ring. The ring with the star symbol engraved.

"This... Could this be it?" Scatt asked as he took a step forward. His breathing quickened and he came to the ring. He looked at it with wide-open eyes. "Could this be Solomon's ring?"

No one made a sound. They stood like statues, staring at the ring. Scatt slowly took the ring and looked at it. He turned it around. He looked all around him. "I think... I think it's his!" he said excitedly. "Solomon, the heir of magic!"

"Scatt, I can imagine how excited a ring would make you, but we have more important things to do. Like getting the book. We must find the Book."

"The seal of Solomon!" he finally said excitedly. He showed the symbol on the ring to the team members who turned to him. "What else but the seal of Solomon can open Solomon's treasure?"

Nathaniel sighed.

"Solomon, why are you dragging everything out so long? Now we have to figure out where to use the ring?"

"Nathaniel..." James said, gesturing behind Nathaniel. Without question, Nathaniel turned to where James was pointing. James was pointing behind the throne. The star behind the throne.

"It's worth a try."

"I guess I owe you a thank you." The man said. Everyone looked in the direction of the voice, at the entrance door. A man in a long black coat was walking slowly towards the throne. His hair was cut so short that he was almost bald. "Old Solomon went to a lot of trouble for a book. He had to go to a lot of different places and do a lot of different things to find it. You know, attacking the FBI base, kidnapping the mayor, the fire you set. It's all a lot of work. Can't do by myself. Again, I have to thank you. If it wasn't for you, I would have had to take care of it all."

"Who are you?" Nathaniel asked angrily as he stood up. He was clenching the sword in his right hand with all his anger.

"Jacob Blacked." James said in a calm yet quiet tone. The others' curious and uneasy glances went back and forth between James and Jacob.

"You can call me Jack, it won't take long anyway. I'll kill you all and take the book."

"If," Nathaniel said confidently, "you know about Solomon and everything else..." he raised his left hand, "you know what this means." When the metal gauntlet lifted, the eye in the gauntlet seemed to be watching Jack. Nathaniel's, target of his owners.

"Headknight Nathaniel Cooper, I know you can't use your gauntlet. How do I know?" Jack spread his hands wide. "The same way I know all this. I think it's thanks to the mole in your little library. But don't worry, even if you can use it..." and he opened his black coat. Two knives hung on each side. "I have these too," he said, pointing to the small, quadrilateral knives without handles, resembling arrowheads.

"I think you'll be able to use your sword, Nathaniel." Said James. He opened and closed his fingers one by one, moving the sword into a more comfortable position.

Nathaniel shook his head from side to side. "I don't think so." He said, and with his free hand he pulled the revolver from his belt. He pointed at the moment. He cocked it and pulled the trigger.

The sound of the gun going off echoed through the room as the bullet flew rapidly towards Jack. And it skidded to the side with a clang. Jack grabbed the lapel of his coat with one hand and spread it open to the right, while the other hand was outstretched in front of him. A few inches from the level of his hand, the knife sticking out of his coat seemed to be suspended in mid-air. The only movement it made was spinning on its axis.

"Damn it! Why can't my gauntlet cast spells like that?" Nathaniel said angrily and leapt down the steps of the throne. At Blacked's gesture, he swung his sword to parry the blade that was coming at him. The blade retreated after the first clash, then struck again. Blacked sent a second knife with his other hand. As the blade sailed towards Rose, James brought it down from the air in an arc. Blacked took the remaining two blades in his hands.

"I think it will be a fitting battle." Blacked said with a smile and rushed forward with his knives. Scatt threw himself behind the throne before Blacked could attack. Nate and James were clinking their swords with strange blades floating in the air. There was no target they could cut. All they could do was defend themselves. And even that was as difficult as it could be. Blacked smiled at the sight and walked over to Rose with his knives.

Rose took small steps back, hoping to keep the swords in Blacked's hands, so as not to close the distance between them. She reached around her waist and gripped her weapon. She was about to point it at Blacked when he threw the knife. The knife quickly struck Rose's hand with the pistol. She escaped with a small cut. But before she could pull the trigger, the gun fell from her hand. And so did the knife. Her spell was only good for two knives.

This time Rose drew the knife from her waist as she lunged forward, screaming. She swung it at Blacked. Blacked backed away,

evading the attack. As Rose tried to defend her knife again, Blacked punched Rose in the face with his free hand. Rose staggered backwards and Blacked went at Rose with a nasty smile.

James blocked the reattacking knife with a big arc. The knife struck again in a different arc. Again and again... James stopped his sword at the last moment as he swung it. Nathaniel was in front of him as he collided with the blade coming towards him. James almost hit him. James blocked the attack once more and saw Nathaniel backing up a little more. Nathaniel was moving as much as he could with each thrust, backing away.

James smiled when he saw which way Nathaniel was heading. Nathaniel was taking the battle towards Blacked. James followed his team leader's plan. Nathaniel struck the blade once more with his sword and it swung back. A small crack appeared on it, from the very tip to the back. Nathaniel knew he hadn't done it.

As Scatt hid behind the throne, he looked at James and Nathaniel, who were dealing with the flying knives. Then Blacked and Rose, who were fighting with knives a few feet away. He took a deep breath. With his heart racing, he stood up and jumped on Blacked without waiting.

Blacked, who was focusing Rose, couldn't see Scatt. And they collapsed together. Without waiting, in a fit of rage, Blacked punched Scatt in the face and threw him off. As Scatt skidded to the side, Blacked noticed the shiny thing falling from Scatt's hand. The metal ring that had fallen from Scatt's hand lay on the ground. Blacked smiled. But Jack wasn't the only one who had noticed the ring on the floor. As soon as Rose saw the ring, she jumped towards it without a second thought. As soon as she picked it up, she put it on without waiting. She stood up straight.

"Finally..." came the whisper that only Rose heard. Quiet and hoarse.

The star on the throne shimmered, starting at the top and spreading out over the symbol. A filter of light flowed across the entire shape. It filled the entire star and the circle around it. And at that moment the palace began to shake. There was an earthquake in the palace hidden in the mountain. The walls trembled under the spell, the banners shook as if they would fall to the ground. The flames of the torches went out and flared up again. Pebbles and dust poured from the ceiling. Blocks of the wall behind the throne began to move. Certain blocks shuddered and separated into two different sides. It didn't last long, but everyone in the room stopped fighting for a moment and tried not to fall. Except Scatt and Blacked. They were already on the floor.

When the wall opened sufficiently and the shaking stopped, a dim light poured into the room through a crack in the wall. Behind the bricks illuminated by the dim light there was a white pillar rising up. On the pillar was a book covered in torn leather. The book, with certain geometric shapes engraved on it, was right in the center of the light.

When the tremor stopped, if only for a moment, everyone stopped and looked at the book in the crevice. Everyone's eyes widened, except Nathaniel's. Nathaniel, on the contrary, was restless. One by one, his visions were coming true.

Rose went numb. Her hands went limp and the ring, which was larger than her finger, slowly slid down. It fell to the floor. She couldn't hear anything. The surroundings went dark. She could see nothing but the dim light in front of her. And that went dark too. Rose's knees gave out. And she collapsed.

When the blades moved again, Nathaniel and James raised their swords and prepared to attack. But the blade was not aimed at them. They flew fast, slicing through the air towards Scatt and Rose. Neither of them could see the blade. But the knife did not kill them. The cracking metal blades stopped right in front of both their throats. They both froze.

Without thinking, Nathaniel turned his revolver on Blacked. He was about to pull the trigger when James grabbed Nathaniel by the shoulder. He nodded to Rose and then to Scatt. Nathaniel cursed silently when he saw the knives around their necks.

“Cooper, you may have drawn your gun fast, but you can't compete with my thinking. My thoughts rule my magic , and the moment you pull the trigger, your friends are dead.”

“You're running out of knives.” James said solemnly. “Your magic is becoming too much for them. It's tearing them apart. And when they're gone, you won't have time to master new blades. That's why you don't kill them.”

“Impressive! You guessed right, yes. But I'm not going to wait for my knives to disintegrate. I could slit their throats in an instant. But I've decided to offer you a chance, you see. I'm in a good mood today. If you let me have the book, I'll let your friends live.”

“Nate, no...” Scatt said quietly. He shook his head from side to side.

Nathaniel breathed in and out deeply. He thought. He couldn't let his friends die. He could find another way for the book. A plan, maybe. But he couldn't bring his friends back. Besides, he hadn't been shown anything like this. He knew it wouldn't end like this.

“Destiny has already been written.” He said quietly. Only James, standing next to him, heard those words. “All right. You can have the book. But first you have to let them go.”

“No! Don't!” Scatt shouted. He pulled the knife against his neck with all his strength. The knife didn't move. All it did was cut Scatt's hand. Scatt gave up trying to kill himself.

“I'll get the book first and then I'll let your friends live.”

Nate looked at James's face. James nodded. Nate shifted his gaze to Scatt and then to Rose. "Damn you, Solomon! All right! First you get the book and then you let them go!" Said Nate, "But I won't lower my gun."

"Yes, you will. You're in no position to make demands here, Cooper. Put the damn gun down."

Nathaniel sighed. Slowly he put the gun down. Blacked pointed to the side with a dirty smile on his face. Nathaniel pushed the gun to the side with his foot.

"Good boy." Said Jack and walked over to the book on the pillar. "That's the biggest problem with you 'good guys'. You don't understand when you have to do sacrifice." He walked forward, looking back over his shoulder until he was in front of the book. And when he got in front of the book, he stopped. The dirty grin on his face grew even bigger. His eyes widened with excitement. "All these years... All these centuries of fighting between the two sides... Now it is ours!" he said and picked up the book by both sides. "It was good to do business with you gentlemen."

Scatt slipped his bloody hand into his coat. "Son of a bitch." He said quietly, and with all his strength he grabbed the metal part of the Headguard's knife and threw it at Blacked. Blacked stayed where he was for a moment in great pain. For a brief moment the pain prevented him from thinking. In that brief moment, James saw the knife lodged in Blacked's back, and without waiting, he unsheathed the gun under Nathaniel's trench coat. He took aim at Blacked and fired. Again and again. As Nathaniel dove for his six-shooter on the ground, James kept firing relentlessly.

Blacked couldn't think as blood poured from every part of his body. The pain he felt all over him wouldn't let him think of anything else. Just like he couldn't hear around him. With each bullet, his body moved involuntarily and his legs went numb. First he fell to his knees. He fell on his chest as his eyes glazed over.

James came to Blacked's side with heavy steps. As Blacked's blood spread everywhere.

"I never want it, Jack. But I had to do it." He said. Then he went to Rose, who was unconscious on the floor.

As all the blood drained from his body, Blacked heard James' last words. But he was too tired to understand. Just as his eyes were closing, he heard a whisper.

"We're on the same side, Jacky. Just take the ring."

Blacked did the only thing he could with a strength he didn't know where it came from. As his own blood dripped from his hands, he reached for the ring with the last of his strength. He slipped his finger through the ring lying next to Rose. He tried to pull it towards him, but he couldn't. She was too tired.

The dark mist from the ring began to envelop Jack Blacked's hand. When it covered his whole hand, the veins on his wrist swelled. They darkened and darkened. The darkness spread from the veins in his wrists to his whole body. Blacked forced himself to his feet as one by one the bullets in his back spilled out of the wounds onto the ground. James and Nathaniel saw Blacked getting up and pointed their pistols at him. Before they could fire, Blacked waved his hand at them and they were both knocked off their feet. By the time they found themselves on the ground, Blacked was on his feet. He reached behind his back, pulled out the knife with the handle and threw it to the ground.

His brown eyes were darkened by the blackness coming out of both side of his eyes. First the whites disappeared, then the brown part. His eye was completely black. The blackness in his hand grew thinner and longer and began to surround Blacked. Just as a smile appeared on his face, he grimaced in pain. Groaning in pain, he grabbed one hand. The hand where the ring had slipped into one knuckle of his finger. But the sound was not Blacked's. There were

two or three different voices. They were all together. They were in harmony and at the same time completely opposite.

Blacked raised his hand. The bright light from the ring, a mixture of blood red and golden yellow, crackled across his finger. White smoke began to rise, as if on fire. Blacked angrily take off the ring. Without waiting, he threw it to the ground.

He smiled when he realized that the pain, the pain of the ring, had disappeared. "At last..." he said in a voice much thicker than Blacked's. "I am free." Nathaniel and James started firing, guns in hand. But the bullets disappeared before they reached Blacked. Jack started to laugh. Then it turned into laughter. "Idiots!" he said and kept laughing. He turned away, ignoring Nathaniel and James, and reached for the book. The book came to his hand as if attracted by a magnet. Blacked opened the book. At that moment, all the smile disappeared from his face. "Damn Solomon! You and your ridiculous lock spells!" he shouted in anger.

Blacked took a deep breath.

"Very well, so be it. I guess I'll have to gather my own army," Blacked said and turned a few pages. When he found what he was looking for, he began to read. The thick voice was more distinctive than the others. And it came out earlier than the others.

As Blacked continued to read the book he held in an obscure language, the palace trembled again. Not as strongly as before, but it trembled. Waves spread from the book. Transparent waves, scattered in all directions, as if they would not be interrupted. The torches began to flicker out. The open pages of the book shimmered. The surroundings began to darken, as if absorbing all the light, all the illumination. The book was the only one shining.

When it was dark enough, so dark that no one could see the end of their nose, the book went dark too. And the whole palace went dark.

Nathaniel opened his eyes. He was on the floor. He couldn't remember how he had fallen and his head hurt. He sat up as he put his hand to his aching head. He looked where he was. He was in the palace. Rose, Scatt and James were lying on the floor. Blacked was gone. Nathaniel looked around again and again. Blacked was gone. with him, the book was gone too.

Nathaniel stood up. James was standing closest to him. The first step toward him made him stumble. He managed to save himself from falling. And he walked more carefully. He crouched down next to James. James' chest rose and fell heavily, just like the others. Nathaniel grabbed James by both shoulders and shook him. He called his name. And finally James opened his eyes. He stood up, squinting at first, unable to get used to the light. He looked around.

Nathaniel, seeing that James had regained consciousness, continued. He woke Scatt and Rose. When everyone was awake, Nathaniel exhaled a deep breath. He walked slowly towards the throne. Then he threw himself down on the steps of the throne. He was lost. He put his face in his hands. He felt more like a failure than ever. He had broken his promise to his father. And worse, the rebels had the book. With a power he couldn't understand.

Scatt forced himself to his feet. As he made his way to Nathaniel's side, he stumbled at the first step. But that didn't stop him. He kept walking towards Nathaniel with quick steps. Nathaniel pulled his face away from his hands and turned to Scatt. In his eyes he saw something he had never seen before. Anger.

"You let this happen!" Scatt shouted as he reached Nathaniel.

"I did what I had to do." Nathaniel said in a calm tone. "I couldn't leave my friends dead."

"And what do you think is going to happen now? Are the rebels going to let us live? Nathaniel, we're going to die anyway! And you've ruined so many people's lives just for the two of us! The

rebels, with their power, will rule the fucking world! And for what? Because you didn't want to sacrifice us!"

"You know I can't make that decision!"

"You had to!"

Nathaniel stormed to his feet. His angry eyes met Scatt's.

"You have no idea what I saw! Of what was going to happen! How I feel! You see, I did what I thought was right!"

"Enough!" James shouted, getting tired of the two of them fighting. He walked slowly towards them. "We may have lost the book. But not everything. We just lost the book." James came over to Rose, who was sitting with her back against the wall, offered her his hand and helped her up. "Blacked, or whatever that thing is, said he was going to raise an army. And if you ask me, from the things we've seen, I'd say that magic has been unleashed.

"Yes, we lost the battle of the book, we lost the book, but we're not going to sit around waiting for our deaths just because we lost a battle. It's just that the power of the rebels wasn't locked up in the book," James held out his hand to Nathaniel. "The knights' power was also locked in the book. Now that all power has been restored, not only are they stronger, but so you are!"

"Yes, we are in for a much bigger war than before. A single battle. One battle that, if we win, could end everything forever." James walked between Scatt and Nathaniel. "I wonder what kind of powers Solomon gives to a Headknight, the men he trusts most. That power he took back.

"Now we must go warn the Library! We must go and warn the knights and guardians! We must warn them so that everyone is ready for battle. I think we're going to see a war on a scale not seen since Solomon. "As James continued to speak, he saw Solomon's ring lying on the floor. He bent down and picked it up. Looking at the ring, he continued to walk and talk. "And we will defeat them as

Solomon did! We will..." James stopped suddenly. He took his gaze away from the ring and looked at the banner waving in front of him. His eyes widened. Without a word, he stepped between Scatt and Nathaniel. Without taking his gaze off the banner, he continued walking toward her.

"Do you see anything different in the room?" James asked. He turned around to see the others looking around. "The room is really bright. More than first time we come" He said and paused for a moment. "Although the torches aren't lit." He reached for the banner behind him. He pulled it down with all his might. The banner tore and folded and fell to the floor. The moment the banner fell, the throne room became even brighter. Through the window where the banner used to be, the blue sky could be seen. The warm light of the golden sun filled the throne room.

"Wha... Where are we?" Scatt said, looking out the window with widened eyes. "Our... We last..."

Nathaniel stepped forward. He moved towards the window. The gauntlet began to show him.

"If you ask me..." James said from where he stood.

"We're in the Kingdom of Destiny." Nathaniel finished the sentence.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

He opened his eyes. He was in a black void. He felt the pain in his stomach and the pain reminded him of what he had been through. He started to move forward. He didn't know why. He moved forward and saw the light. As he got closer, he realized it belonged to a torch. And there was more. The torches kept going.

As Solomon moved forward, a new torch flickered. With each step Solomon felt the pain fade as if his wound was healing. He kept following the light. Until he came to the empty throne. He came in front of the throne. A golden light appeared on the throne and took shape. It took the shape of a human body.

“Solomon! Do you know why you came here?”

“Am I dead?” Solomon guessed. It was the only answer he could think of.

“You are not using your power in the right way. And you are about to die!”

Solomon remembered the moment when he had recovered from the intoxication of peace and died. He took a hasty step forward and said, "You have to help me! If I die, your magic will be gone forever! And innocent people will keep dying!"

"I brought you here because, as you said, you are our last chance. Normally magic is only supposed to come in certain places, like inspiration, but you've reached your end. We don't have time anymore, so I have to teach you everything."

"How long will it take?"

"This long." Said the power and suddenly it appeared in front of Solomon and touched his head. Solomon took a deep breath and gasped. He opened his eyes as wide as he could.

Taking a deep breath, Solomon quickly woke up as if he had had a nightmare. His wide-open eyes sparkled with magic. He opened his eyes as if he saw everything, as if he knew everything. A smile appeared on his face. It faded when he remembered where he was. He stood up, though his breathing was not quite right. He was no longer bleeding. His sword lay on the ground at Grimor's feet.

"Sorcerer, you see. Without your full power, you cannot deal with me. We could fight forever. But you see my creatures approaching fast behind you, don't you? When they get here, your army will be completely destroyed! And when I get tired of fighting you, I'll leave you to my soldiers, who will do their best to make sure you don't die. They love to inflict pain. Unless you give me the secret of your magic. I'll kill you in peace."

"You are right about one thing, Grimor." Solomon said confidently. He snapped his head from side to side. "You can't kill me and I can't kill you either. At least not under these circumstances." Solomon stepped back, opening and closing his fingers.

He quickly reached his hands forward. He flexed his fingers. He whispered spells. Golden fire flickered in his eyes. Circles formed in front of his hand. And triangles and runes. Some of them quickly

began to circle around Grimor, and a small triangle formed directly beneath Grimor, growing larger and larger. From the ends of the golden yellow triangle, golden yellow chains rose with a great noise. They wrapped around Grimor's arms. They wrapped around his neck and legs. The chains pulled him down as if he were sinking into quicksand.

"You don't have the power to stop me, Solomon! How long do you plan to hold me? Until the sun goes down? Until my creatures tear apart all your men? You cannot hold me forever!"

"With my help, he can." Said a familiar voice from the sky. Scattering dust, the protector descended and its huge wings folded and then closed completely. Solomon turned to the Protector with great curiosity. "I give you the power of nature, Solomon." He put his huge hand on Solomon's chest. And his hand began to glow. Solomon could feel the burning power radiating from the hand on his chest. As the power spread throughout his body, it began to hurt Solomon. It hurt like it was burning through his veins. Solomon clenched his teeth together as hard as he could to keep from screaming. He closed his eyes. The green light in his hand glowed along with the arrows on his chest on the right side.

When Solomon opened his eyes, the light had gone out. A book stood where Grimor used to stand. Solomon picked it up curiously.

"Why the book?"

"I only gave you the power of nature to imprison it, and it was your power that decided what you would create."

Solomon ran his hand over the book as he whispered the magic words. When he removed his hand, a seal lay on the book. Circles and symbols surrounded the six-headed star and gave it different shapes on the cover.

"We are in the same si..." Solomon looked around in surprise. The protector was gone. But his sword was here. He had left

the metal and gone. Solomon smiled slowly. He picked up the sword he had been deemed worthy of, and looked around to see the creatures slumped on the ground. Those who had run snarling towards them were also down. There were no clue they were there. Slowly the army of the kingdom gathered around Solomon. Solomon had succeeded. He looked at the soldiers gathered around him with a big smile. They were all as happy as Solomon. Solomon picked up his sword and sheathed it.

Rodrin walked through the soldiers and came to Solomon's side.

"You did it." Rodrin said excitedly. He looked happier than Solomon had ever seen him.

"We did it." Solomon corrected him. He looked around him. The kingdom, the ruins, the palace... "So, what do we do now?"

"We need to slowly restore the kingdom, it may take years."

"Are you talking about the buildings? Or the adaptation of the people?"

"I think both." Rodrin said with a sigh.

"I can help with the structures." Said Solomon. He started walking and continued. "The Darkness not only took over your city, it rebuilt it. But they didn't do it all with their claws. This time, Rodrin, I will lead the way!"

Rodrin followed Solomon. Soon the line was joined by a bloodied Windsor and Azderson. Azderson joined the line after throwing his spear on the ground, which was broken in half in cold blood as if nothing had happened. Windsor joined after spitting out his broken teeth, which were moving from one side of his mouth to the other.

After walking through the forest for a while, they stopped. They saw sand mixing with the grass. As they continued on their way,

trying to understand what had happened, they came across the desert that had replaced the forest. All the grass, the greenery, the trees... All of it was gone.

“Here... What happened here?” Rodrin could only say. He couldn't understand anything.

“A small price to pay to stop Grimor.” Said Solomon and kept walking again. He made his way to the black pillars. When he got to it, he stepped onto the Black marble floor. He stood in front of the short pillar that rose in the center of the surrounding pillars and placed his magic book there.

Suddenly a light shone from the book and the pillars. It shone so brightly that it blinded everyone around and quickly went out. Waves of air began to spread from the pillars. It was invisible to the eye, but it was moving rapidly, tilting the grass to the side. The black grass was tilted with great force, and after the wave passed over it, it stood up lush and green. The wave shimmered as it passed over the buildings, and it moved quickly, correcting and repairing the color of the houses. But the palace was the brightest.

The palace had shed its terrible black veil and was restored to its former splendor. It reflected and illuminated the light of the sun, as if the magic was still there. Through the blue sky, the yellow sunlight made the sand around the white pillars shine. Solomon picked up the book from where he had placed it and landed on the sand.

“In the name of the great Orin!” Rodrin could only say, his eyes widening at what he saw. As soon as he recovered from his astonishment, he continued. “After so many years... after so many years, our kingdom is restored! I don't know how to thank you, Solomon.”

“You're right. Because you don't have to thank me. I made a promise when I took this power and what I'm doing now... I'm just fulfilling that promise. And I'm going to ask you for something big.

When the time comes, together we will clean up this world. One by one, we will reclaim the lost territories. And I can't do it without the army of the Kingdom of Destiny.”

“You know I will always follow you. Even if it means death.” Rodrin's face tensed. “But my army...”

“Don't worry, Rodrin, I won't send your army to their deaths. I will make sure they are strong enough to fight the creatures when the time comes.”

“You're not leaving now, are you?”

“No. I'll stay a while longer. Let's get out of here. We have a throne to put you on.” Solomon turned to Windsor and Azderson. “Am I right?”

Windsor did not hear much of what was said as he watched the change around him in fascination. He remained dumbfounded until Solomon spoke his name. When he heard his name, he came to his senses. He looked at Solomon with a smile and nodded.

All the warriors, all the soldiers, all the rescued people were filling the palace garden. Everyone was entering the garden with great enthusiasm. Those who couldn't fit in the garden were outside the palace trying to get inside. Seeing the blue sky, people were filled with great happiness. It was exciting for the whole kingdom to return to their home.

Solomon looked up at the palace of the Kingdom of Destiny.

“It looks more beautiful up close.”

“It looks more beautiful because it is free from darkness, Master.” Azderson expressed his opinion.

“I hope King Rodrin's work is done quickly because I am ravenous right now.” Said Windsor. He noticed Solomon and Azderson looking at him. “What is it? Aren't you hungry?” he asked. Solomon smiled and turned away.

King Rodrin emerged from the main double-winged door. He was free of his blood-soaked armor. He walked forward, holding both sides of the coat of shiny cloth he wore. His gaze swept over the people. Everyone was there for their king. Rodrin took a deep breath and smiled. He looked at Solomon and nodded. Solomon stepped forward. Behind him Azderson, holding the golden crown.

Solomon stood in front of Rodrin. He waited for Azderson to join him. Rodrin got down on one knee.

“As heir to magic, Rodrin, son of Orin, I am honored to proclaim you as the King of the Kingdom of Destiny!” Solomon said and took the crown from Azderson's hand and placed it on Rodrin's head. The smile on Rodrin's face grew as he stood up. First the guards fell to one knee before the king. Then the peasants. And finally Windsor and Azderson.

CHAPTER TWENTY

James, Rose, Nathaniel and Scatt stood at the window for a while looking out. They decided to go out of the palace, hoping that James and Nathaniel were right. They decided to go out of the palace the way Nathaniel had used. Because James wanted a scabbard for the sword he was holding.

When they got to the armory, James found a scabbard that fit the long sword he was holding, adjusted his belt, and put it on his waist. Nathaniel decided to get himself a second sword. He took the same sword and slung it over his other shoulder. Rose and Scatt did not touch the old weapons from centuries ago. Rose had a pistol and Scatt had the headguard's knife.

It was spring outside. A gentle breeze blew across the sand towards the blue sea. In the cooling breeze they began to walk beside the sea. Far away, they saw people out to sea, fishing in their small boats. The sun shining behind them hid their faces, their clothes and their appearance. Nothing was visible except their black faces. They kept walking, not knowing where they were going. After a long time

on the beach, they saw the forest on their left. There was a wide clearing in the middle of the forest joining the beach. A path.

They decided to take the path through the forest. As they walked along the path, the trees around them became denser. They encountered bigger bushes and grass. But there was nothing blocking the path. . No matter how much it was blocked on both sides, the path was straight ahead.

As they continued walking on the path, it started to get dark. The trees on both sides of the path were dense, blocking the sky. The sunlight that tried to illuminate the path through the branches and leaves was slowly fading.

“We can't keep going all night. Soon we won't even be able to see the end of our noses. Maybe we can find something around where we can make a fire. We can't keep walking in the dark.”

“We could make camp.”

“We could try. Or we could make a fire and keep going.”

“That makes more sense than sleeping in the woods.” Scatt suggested.

“I suggest we split into two groups.” Rose said, “Let's look on both sides of the trail. We'd better find something to eat, I'm getting hungry and we need water.”

“I don't need water.” Said Nathaniel, and with a confident smile he pulled his flask from his inside pocket and held it up to his head. Not even a second later he put it down. “Shit! It's over.”

“Nathaniel and Scatt, you take the right side of the path. James and I will take the left. We'll meet back here in half an hour, tops.”

“In the meantime, think of it as an expedition. Who knows, maybe there's a farm nearby. Or a town or something like that. You've

seen the fishermen. If we don't see anyone in half an hour, we can light a fire and rest for a while. Then we'll move on."

No one said anything after James. Everyone had accepted the idea. James and Rose started walking one way, Scatt and Nathaniel the other. Scatt took out the head guard's knife and started leaving marks on the trees he passed. He did this every two or three trees. He didn't want to lose his way.

Rose and James made their way through the trees. The wind blew slowly, growing stronger and colder as it grew and as the sky got darker. James walked with one hand on his sword, alert at all times. Rose was right next to him.

After walking through the woods for a while, James pointed with his hand to the bottom of the field that led downwards. Although She couldn't see all the way down to where James was pointing but could see the puddle of water with the moon reflected in it in patches. They took quick steps down the slope through the trees. There was a small lake where James had pointed. It was a lake formed by the water flowing from a small waterfall gushing from the mountain behind it. Together with Rose they went to the lake. James washed his face and then drank some water. Rose was staring at the place where the lake and the mountain met. James turned to where she was looking and saw the bush at the corner of the mountain. Blue roses grew out of the green bushes. Rose moved towards the flower. She circled the pond and James followed a few steps behind her.

A loud rustling caused them to stop. They stood like statues, watching the rustling coming from different directions. The rustling of trampled grass was joined by howls and roars. The combined sound echoed through the forest.

James took half a step forward and raised one hand and held it in front of Rose. His other hand was poised on the hilt of the sword. He unsheathed the sword a few inches. If he had to be quick, he didn't want the sword to get caught in the scabbard. He heard a growling sound. It was getting closer and closer. It moved in different

directions, changing its path. So James was. Finally, the bush split in two. There was something moving through it, coming towards them.

“Calm down.” Ian said, sounding as calm as he looked. Rose had been in this situation before. She drew her pistol, as if she knew what was going to happen. She tried to aim at the shadowy figure emerging from the bushes. The creature was blending in with the darkness of the night. The darkness hid the silhouette of the creature. Rose pushed James forward and started firing. The bullets didn't stop the creature. When it was close, which didn't take long, it swung its claw at Rose. As Rose closed her eyes with fear, the claw snapped off her wrist. As blood spurted from the cut, James spun around and made another thrust with the sword. The second thrust struck the creature in the neck. As the creature's body fell to the ground, James grabbed Rose's arm and started to run.

Rose started to run without resisting him. As they ran through the forest, they began to hear growling behind them. One by one the growls and howls grew louder. They all came from different places. Behind them, beside them and in front of them. The sounds were coming from all directions.

They had to keep running, even though they could not see anything around them. The weak moonlight filtered through the leaves of the trees, but it was useless. It was not enough to illuminate the forest. As James and Rose ran through the forest, they saw two dark suits ahead. They moved slower than the others. James was readying his sword for anything when he saw that one of the silhouettes had lost one arm. It was Nathaniel and Scatt.

Nathaniel turned around, howling and growling sounds come from everywhere. He saw James and Rose running at them. Raising one eyebrow, he waited until they were beside him.

“What's going on here...”

“Just run!” shouted James, interrupting Nathaniel. Scatt and Nathaniel started to run too.

Even though they were running fast, the voices were getting closer and closer. They were running through the dark forest without being able to see anything clearly. They didn't know where they were running or in which direction. They were just running. Until Scatt, who had been left behind, tripped over a protruding tree root. Scatt fell to the ground in pain while the others stayed a few steps ahead of him. Nathaniel immediately took Scatt's one arm. Scatt took his first steps. Once he was sure his footing was secure, he began to pick up speed.

“Thank you.” Scatt said and gave Nathaniel a friendly pat on the shoulder and kept running. Nathaniel knew he could run even faster, but he decided to go side by side with Scatt. The roars continued to come from all directions. But they were not as far away as before. They were getting closer and closer. They ran, looking around.

They rustled through the grass and broke through the bushes. The creature jumped from behind a nearby tree. Nathaniel saw it at the last moment but could do nothing. Nathaniel fell forward. But the creature was not on him. It was nowhere near him. He looked up to see James struggling with the creature as it pushed him from behind. The creature was clawing at his face as if to tear it open, and James was pushing with all his might against the claws gripping his wrists.

The creature growled to James's face. It opened its huge mouth and tilted its head to the side. As it brought its face closer to bite James, It heard the whistle of metal in the air and looked up. Nathaniel, its executioner, had raised his sword. Nathaniel quickly brought his sword down on the creature's neck. He was about to breathe a sigh of relief when he heard a growl behind him.

“Oh, shit!” he said and swung his sword behind him. Rose took a step towards Nathaniel, her back turned to her, and drew the second sword from his back. She swung it at the creature coming at

her. The bullet didn't hurt the creatures, but the weapons of the Palace did.

Scatt leaned fearfully against a tree. He squeezed the headguard's dagger with all his might. He squeezed until his fingers turned white. The creature's huge claw swung at him. The claw scratched the bark of the tree as Scatt ducked in fear. Scatt closed his eyes, not knowing what he was doing, and thrust forward the dagger he clutched with all his might. He opened his eyes at the disgusting sound the creature made, and saw the blade plunge into its belly. But the creature was not dead. Scatt pushed the dagger upward with all his might.

Lying on the ground, James tried to spit the blood out of his mouth. Without wiping the creature's blood from his face, he reached for the sword at his side. As he tried to sit up, another creature jumped on him. It nailed James to the ground with one claw and raised the other claw to smash James' face. James cursed the pain of the claw in his shoulder as he drove the sword with all his might into the creature's belly. The bloody sword metal from the creature's back quickly moved to the side and sliced through the creature. As James tried to throw the creature off him, the creature swung its claw as it drew its last breath. The claw did not hit James in the face. But it left four large gashes in his chest.

James sat up with a short, not very loud moan. He tried to hold the wound on his chest with his free hand, but the cuts were too long and deep. He cursed silently when he saw the creature running at him on all fours. He stepped to the side. He made a clumsy half-turn to the right and swung his sword at the creature. It was breathing more and more deeply.

As Nathaniel wiped the blood of the last creature off his face, he saw another creature coming on all fours. He reached for his gun and pointed the barrel of the gun. He pulled the trigger. The click said it all. There were no bullets left. Nathaniel twisted his sword around his wrist. He rolled his chest to the side as he raised the sword over his shoulder. He was ready to attack the incoming creature.

As the creature fell to the ground, Nathaniel broke his stance. An arrow with blood-red wings was lodged in the creature lying on the ground. Its torso and arrowhead were also red. A stranger's arrow. Then another arrow pierced the neck of the creature chasing Scatt, who was looking for the dagger he had dropped near the tree.

Then there was a whistling sound. The sound came rapidly closer. And the sound stopped as the arrow stuck in front of a tree. A small pouch was tied to the arrow. Another arrow shot through the trees and quickly cut the pouch on the first arrow. The pouch split in two, and a dust resembling white sand came out and spread everywhere. It created a fog as sands spread everywhere. The creatures stayed where they were for a while. Then they changed their direction and started to come out of the dust. After a few seconds they ran away on all fours.

As the fog cleared, someone approached through the trees, from the side where the arrows were raining down. As he approached, the thing he held in his hand glowed. The fire burned. The torch he held was enough to light the night.

The man approaching them was wearing a red vest with a blood-red vest with a hood. In one hand he held a torch and in the other a bow that matched his outfit. Red pieces of cloth were wrapped around the bow in certain places. A quiver was tied to the sides of each leg. As he got closer, his curly hair appeared from under his hood. He opened the hood. The young man put his bow on his back.

"Thanks for helping!" Scatt said excitedly. He was still holding the Headguard's knife in his hand.

"My name is Merlin Vern Mattson," said man with red hood. He used a different language. But everyone understood the Kid. He looked at them for a while. "You are not from around here."

“No, we're not.” Nathaniel took the word. The words came straight out of his mouth. He spoke a language he had never heard before. “I wonder where exactly we are?”

“Near the village of Radland.”

Nathaniel couldn't figure out how he understood the conversation, but he kept asking his questions.

“And have you by any chance heard of a place called the Kingdom of Destiny?”

“Are you kidding me?” Merlin asked. He stood for a while to be sure strangers not trying to joke about. “of course I know.” Merlin continued. Confusedly. He gave a small laugh. Then he noticed the seriousness in Nathaniel's bloody face. And “It's two or three days away.” Merlin paused for a moment and looked everyone over once more. So Merlin joined Nathaniel's Seriousness “And where do you come from?”

“That will be very difficult to explain.”

“Actually, it's not that hard,” Rose said. “We come from Solomon's world and...” She took Nathaniel's gloved hand and lifted it. “My friend Cooper, he has Colder's blood.”

“You... you're a Headknight of Solomon?.” Said Merlin, and without waiting, he dropped to one knee.

“Merlin of Radland, stand up.” Nathaniel said, pleasure written all over his face.

“We need your help.” Said James “Maybe you can help us... to the kingdom... You... You can help us...”

“Are you all right, James?” Nathaniel asked. James looked at them for a while, holding his chest.

“I...”

The sword slipped through James's fingers and fell to the ground. Immediately afterwards, James collapsed.

“Shit! Hurry up! We have to get him to the village now! It's not far!” Merlin bent down and grabbed James by one arm. Nathaniel took the other. James couldn't see anything because of his darkening eyes. He could see nothing, hear nothing, feel nothing. Everything was dark to him.

CHAPTER TWENTY ONE

“Rodrin,” Solomon said. As he dismounted in front of the white pillars, he said, “Thank you for coming all the way here with me. And for hosting me in your palace these past few weeks. But now I must return home. To save this world, I must return to my world. There is something there that I seek. These pillars, Rodrin, they must be protected. Whatever happens, put a force here to protect these pillars.” Said Solomon and came to Rodrin holding the halter of his horse. He opened his arms and hugged Rodrin tightly. Then Windsor opened his arms and hugged Solomon. And finally Azderson.

“I'm going to miss you, Master Solomon.”

“Windsor, what did I say? Don't ever call me master again.”

“Yes, Mas... Solomon.”

“Windsor, Azderson, Rodrin, try not to join any battles until I return.” Said Solomon, trying to smile. “Take care of each others.” Solomon closed his eyes and spread his arms wide. The sand started to fly. It surrounded him like a vortex. Dust flew in the air and joined

the sand. It completely enveloped the pillars. Soon the grains of sand and the wind suddenly stopped. The cloud of dust began to dissipate. Solomon was no longer between the pillars.

Solomon opened his eyes. He realized that his arms were still outstretched. He lowered them. And a smile appeared on his face. He was in the sea. In knee-deep seawater, he made his way to the shore. He saw the ships of his kingdom.

The fishermen looked at him curiously as he continued down the beach. Solomon ignored them and kept walking. When he entered the city, he seemed like an ordinary man to everyone. No one knew that he was someone who suddenly existed.

When Solomon arrived in front of the palace, the guards held out their spears. And they blocked Solomon's path.

“Who do you think you are, trying to enter the palace of the kingdom?”

Solomon tilted his head to the side.

“I am Solomon. Son of David, Prince of Israel and Judah, rightful owner of the Throne!”

The guards stepped back in fear. Now they recognized their beard-growing prince.

“Majesty, we are really sorry! We did not recognize you! Please forgive us!” and they fell to their knees.

“Stand up. And open the doors.” Solomon said calmly.

He was escorted by one of the guards at the entrance to the palace. Solomon enjoyed walking through the corridors of his palace, his home. He was looking at the decorations and paintings on the walls as if he was seeing them all for the first time. When they came to the door of the double-winged throne room, the guards opened both doors wide. Solomon walked through the door alone.

"Father..." he said. He took a few steps then froze. He and his brother, who was sitting on the throne, were staring at each other.

"Solomon!" his brother said. He stood up and running towards him. Solomon was happy to see his brother. But he was waiting for someone else to sit on the throne. His knees went weak. At the last moment, his brother caught him before he fell to the ground. He hugged him tightly. Solomon was crying.

"Please tell me my father came back on the ship!"

"I'm sorry, Solomon. He... we never saw him again. The few survivors said that everyone else was dead, including you and my father. Maybe you are here... maybe my father is here..."

"No." Said Solomon, shaking his head from side to side. "I... I can't believe he's dead!"

"Solomon, you'd better get some rest. Take the guards at the gate to escort you to your room."

"No need, brother. I can take care of myself." Said Solomon and his brother hugged him one more time and then let him go. Solomon sniffled and wiped his tears. This one was shorter than the other. Solomon left the throne room without looking back.

He walked quickly through the corridors of the palace. It didn't take him long to find his own room. When he entered the room, everything was exactly as he had left it. He closed the door behind him and walked into the room. For a few seconds he stared at his desk full of books and papers. Shouting in anger, he knocked over the desk. He kicked the chair.

"Why the hell didn't you take him?" he shouted. "Why did you save me when you could have saved a real king?" He took off the ring on his finger. "What's the point of your power if I can't save my father?" He quickly threw the ring into the corner of the room. He walked with heavy steps towards the balcony. Tears were pouring

from her eyes. He placed both hands on the edge of the balcony. He closed his eyes and sighed.

When he heard the sound of the waves crashing against the ship, he opened his eyes curiously. He was standing on the edge of the ship. He turned his head to the creaking steps. His father was coming down the steps of the pier. Solomon frowned and looked at his father with great curiosity as he came towards him. When his father came to him, Solomon took a deep breath and repeated the history. He looked at the wound on his father's face.

“What happened to your face, father?”

The king smiled slowly and put his hand to the wound on his face.

“I am a warrior, son.” He said and put his hand on Solomon's shoulder. “Why are you so thoughtful?”

“I postponed my wedding for this deal, Father.” He played the scenario.

“Solomon, you will be a great king in the future. A king who will rule Judah, Israel and perhaps much more.” Solomon's father smiled and continued. “And great kings have to make great decisions. A king gives priority to his people, his kingdom no matter what. Treaties with other states are like wars. Only difference is that you don't shed blood. It is like a war on paper. Of course, sometimes it can be beneficial for both kingdoms. It's like our covenant “

“Then I think I'd better learn a little more about the covenant we're making.” said Solomon with a sigh.

“I agree with you on that, King Solomon.” Said Solomon's father. Smiling. Solomon took a step forward. He hugged his father tightly. The king smiled and pushed him away. He held Solomon's shoulder with both hands. “You will be a great king, Solomon. My heir.” A tear fell down Solomon's face and he was dazzled. He looked

at the reflection of the sun's light from the ring. It was his father's ring. On the ring was the six-pointed star of Orin.

His father was the second heir of the magic. Who saved Solomon from dying.

Solomon blinked and found himself on the balcony. The ring was on his finger. He walked into his room, twirling the ring from side to side on his finger. He sat on his bed, couldn't hold back his tears any longer and started to cry.

Solomon opened his eyes and saw that his room was dark. He got up from his bed. He walked through the open curtains to the balcony. He looked at the moon and stars shining in the sky. He took a deep breath and went into his room. He raised his hand and looked at his ring. He slowly walked out of his room. He was startled to see the guards standing before him. They both saluted as soon as they saw Solomon.

"The king has ordered us not to leave your side, Prince Solomon." One of them said. They both bowed their heads together.

"Do you know where my brother is now?"

"In the dining room, Majesty."

"Then let's go to the dining room." Said Solomon and started walking.

When Solomon entered the dining room he saw the crowd at the table. When Solomon entered there was a brief moment of deathly silence. Then everyone stood up quickly. The young man closest to the door hugged Solomon.

"Brother, I thought you were dead! Thank God you're okay!"

"Natan, brother, I can't tell you how happy I am to see you!"

"Solomon!" Solomon's elderly mother called out.

“Mother! I missed you so much!”

“You are here! That means that maybe... Maybe your father...”

“I'm sorry, mother, but he sacrificed himself to save me.”

“No! It... “

Solomon hugged his mother tightly. He tried to comfort her as tears welled up in her eyes.

“Jerimoth, Tamar!” Solomon called to his two brothers standing behind his mother. “Aren't you going to hug your brother?”

After Solomon hugged both of his brothers, the King gestured to the table.

“Let's eat!” The King said and everyone took their places at the table. Solomon took the first chair next to his brother, the King. The same chair he had sat in when his father was king.

“Solomon, where have you been all this time?”

Solomon took a deep breath. He ran his fingers over the table in turn, thinking.

“I was in the Kingdom of Destiny.”

“The Kingdom of Destiny? I've never heard of such a kingdom in my life. Is it one of the kingdoms to the west?”

“South.”

“So, what did you do there? I mean, why did it take you weeks to get back here?”

“That's the part I might find a little difficult to explain. I was given great power, the opportunity to become someone really important. And with the power I was given, I saved the kingdom of destiny.”

Everyone at the table was now looking at Solomon as if they didn't understand anything. Solomon sighed.

“Do you believe in magic?” Solomon asked. There was no answer from anyone. Solomon shook his head and looked at his golden goblet. He drank all the wine in the goblet. To prove that he had finished it all, he turned the goblet upside down. Then he ran his hand over it. And his hand glowed slightly. Satisfied, Solomon turned the goblet over again. This time the blood-red wine began to spill from the goblet. Still had same looking blankly at him, took a deep breath and pushed back his chair. He stood up. “Well, I guess the best way to tell you what I've been through is to show you.” Solomon said and clasped his hands together. He whispered a few words. He opened his hands and blew into his palms. Golden dust flew out of his hand and spread all over the room.

The dust shimmered and took shape. They saw a golden ship and Solomon and his father on it. Those at the table recoiled, frightened by the glitter and magic that filled the room. Jerimoth and Tamar clung to the back of their chairs as Solomon swung his ringed hand backwards through the air and the golden ship turned to dust again. The dust flew away and disappeared.

“I'd better tell you the story myself,” Solomon said as he made his way to the table. He sat down and took a large piece of lamb. He put it on his plate. He cut a small piece and put it in his mouth. As he chewed his food, he began to speak. “My father and I saw pirates and bandits coming towards us...”

CHAPTER TWENTY TWO

Slowly James's eyes opened. He grimaced with a throbbing head and tried to sit up. He sat on the floor in his gutter. Resisting the headache, he tried to figure out where he was. He was in a wooden hut. Shelves all around the hut were filled with different things. Some were filled with different kinds of liquid, others with plants and leaves. Different dried plants hung from ropes suspended from the ceiling. He groaned in pain as he tried to get up from the bed of pelts on the floor. He remembered the wound on his chest. It had been bandaged. James put his hand over the wound and stood up. He looked around. He saw the only chair in the room. A shirt was hanging on it. James took the shirt from the chair and slowly put it on. The shirt was too big, but it was better than his torn T-shirt. And Of course, he didn't know where his shirt was.

He picked up his sword, which was propped against the wall next to the chair. After attaching the scabbard to his belt, he released the sword. He looked at it with a smile as it came out of its scabbard with a metallic whistle. And sheathed it again. He walked through the

other, empty hides on the ground and went to the only door he saw. And he opened it.

As he stepped out of the hut, he noticed the sun shining in the sky. He squinted and looked around. He was in a village with many huts, just like the one he woke up in. The surroundings were green. Just beyond the border of the small village he could see the mountain rising and the green forests surrounding it. Some of the people passing by were carrying buckets of water. Others were walking their sheep. Children were running around playing and James heard a familiar voice behind him.

“How are you?”

James turned around and came face to face with Rose.

“I’ve got a bit of a headache, but I’m fine.” He said, smiling awkwardly, looking around once more. “Where are we?”

“We’re in the village where Merlin lives. Redland.”

“And where is everyone else?”

“At Merlin’s house. Follow me.”

James watched Radland and the people of it, while dealing with his headache. The way they dressed, the things they used, the way they lived. They looked like people living in the Middle Ages.

Finally they came to Merlin’s house. Merlin’s house was the closest to the forest. Rose stepped forward and knocked on the door. Merlin, the owner of the house, opened the door. He invited them in. James entered the house first. Merlin led him to a large wooden table. At the far end of the table sat Nathaniel. Next to him was Scatt.

“You must be hungry.” Merlin said and gestured to the table. James pulled up a chair opposite Scatt and sat down.

“Good to see you’re alive.” Said Nathaniel. James smiled and nodded. When Merlin left the room, Nathaniel approached James.

"These people here don't know anything about gunpowder weapons." He whispered. "Or even gunpowder. They don't even know about cars, machines, trench coats!"

"Are you serious?" asked James, raising his eyebrows.

"Yes! I started telling Merlin about what we went through on the way here and... it's like we're in the dark ages. He's speaking a language I don't understand! God, this magic is getting weirder and weirder."

"Then you'd better put your weapons away."

"Damn it! But you're right. I need to put my pistols away."

Nathaniel sat back as Merlin returned. Merlin came back with a plate. It had various breakfast foods on it. He placed it in front of James. James thanked him and began to eat.

As James put a piece of the cheese into his mouth once more, he looked at the house sitting on the table. The house had several rooms. Then he turned his gaze to Merlin.

"Do you live alone, Merlin?" James asked. He gave a small smile as he ate his breakfast. As Nathaniel had said, he was speaking in a language he didn't know. He wondered how far he could go.

"Yes." Merlin said, nodding. "I used to live with my brother, and a few months ago he went to the Kingdom of Destiny to join the army."

"Then I have good news for you. If you come with us, you can see your brother again. And in the meantime, you can guide us. What do you say?"

Merlin looked at Nathaniel. He smiled.

"I would be honored to serve the Headknight."

“Good!” said James and leaned forward, putting his arms on the table. He swallowed the piece of bread in his mouth and continued. “What about this... Can you fill us in on what happened in the jungle? What exactly were we up against? How did you manage to make them run away?”

“Good question. The creatures after you go by many different names. Demon's Hound, Wolfs of Grimor, Hellhound, Barghest. But Radlanders prefer to call them 'beasts' or 'monsters'.

“They are cursed creatures, creatures of vengeance. If you don't attack them, they won't attack you. The magic on them holds them back. But they don't wait until you attack. They harass you. They follow you. They scare you. Until you attack. And when you attack, they try to kill you and all your comrades. All of them. In packs.

“There is an area where there are buildings from when they were cursed. Most of the buildings are not intact, but they exist. Those buildings and the flowers that bloom around them, the plants that grow, they can't get close to them. The curse not allowing that.”

“And what about the Barghests who don't want revenge? The ones who attack even if you don't?” Rose asked, crossing her arms.

“The Barghests on our island were born the way they are now. I think the ones you mentioned are the ones who are cursed in different ways.”

“How do you know all this?”

“I learned it from my father and brother, they took care of the creatures before me.”

“What language do you speak?”

“The common language. Almost the only language spoken in the whole continent.”

“Apparently my parents had the blood of Solomon’s Knights too, so I can easily understand and speak a language I don’t know.” James said with a smile.

“Or rebels.” Said Nathaniel, having his annoying smile. James sighed and put the last morsel on his plate into his mouth.

Suddenly there was a loud scream. A woman’s scream. Followed by the thud of things falling rapidly to the floor. Everyone at the table stood up without a moment’s hesitation. As they hurried towards the exit of the house, Nathaniel unsheathed one of the swords he had leaned against the wall. James stepped out, clutching the hilt of the sword at his waist.

As soon as they opened the door, a horseman rode past them. There was not just one rider. There were others running their horses through the streets of the small village. The horsemen rode their horses rapidly around. As they passed by the stalls, the horsemen rode their horses right into them, spilling everything on the ground. A stall close to Merlin’s house was knocked over. As the apples tumbled to the ground, the man standing behind the stalls threw himself to the ground and looked for a place to hide. People were trying to save themselves from being crushed under the horse. Shouts from all over the village made it clear that the horsemen were not standing still.

James unsheathed his sword. He twirled it around his hand and stepped forward with Nathaniel at his side.

Seeing the two men drawing their swords, one of the horsemen drew his spear from his back and swung it at James, who stepped forward. James raised his sword and stepped back. When the metal part of the spear met the sword, James gritted his teeth to stifle the pain in his gut. he grabbed the wooden part of the spear and pulled it away, all the while swinging his sword. The sword struck the belt that tied the saddle to the horse’s belly. The horse neighed and reared, and the man on it fell to the ground with a small cry. James picked up the remaining spear and saw Nathaniel fighting the other rider. “Nathaniel!” he called out and threw the spear at him. As

Nathaniel caught the spear, James raised his sword and finished off the man as he tried to rise from the ground.

Nathaniel drew his sword and swung it at the oncoming horseman. As the swords clashed and trembled, he turned to James, who called out to him, and caught the spear James threw with his free hand. The second rider attacked in the same way. This time Nathaniel deflected the attack with his sword, spun around and struck the man's metal chest with the spear he was holding. As the man fell to the ground, Nathaniel grabbed the reins of the rearing horse and pulled. When the horse put its forelegs on the ground, Nathaniel jumped on it. He swung his sword at the neck of the man on his feet. And he kept riding.

Nathaniel saw James on the ground, protected from the horsemen's attack, and rode towards him. He galloped his horse towards the rider who had attacked James. The man who had noticed Nathaniel, instead of tackling James, pulled on the reins and urged his horse towards Nathaniel. Swords clanged as they faced each other at speed. They clashed without letting the horses get too far apart. After the swords clashed, they pulled the reins as far as they could, preventing the horses from moving away. The most the horses could do was to turn in a circle. Nathaniel and the rider continued to meet their swords in the air as the horses turned and turned. Metallic clanging mixed with other sounds.

A rapidly whistling arrow pierced the rider's neck. The man put his hand over the wound as blood spurted from the hole. Immediately he fell to the ground. Merlin drew another arrow from the quiver and placed it in his bow. Drawing the arrow lightly, he began to run.

As soon as James had finished with the man on the ground, he ran through the streets of the village. He ran in the direction of the screams and the neighing of horses. He kept running until he saw a man on horseback. When he saw him, he attacked.

The horseman forestall James to it. James blocked the sword thrust from above with his own. He ducked, spun on his axis and charged. But his aim was not high. He swung the sword behind the man's knee. Small pieces flew in all directions through the open space covered by the chain mail and the sword sliced through the man's leg. As the man screamed in pain, James struck again. This time he aimed for his hand. The hand holding the sword did not miss. As the man screamed once more in pain, James made one last move and knocked the man off his horse.

Immediately jumping on the horse, James tapped the reins and squeezed the horse with his feet. He urged the horse forward at a trot. Then he saw Nathaniel on another horse. He, too, was riding his horse at a trot. James followed the leader. Nathaniel rode the horse towards another rider who was causing screams. A few meters ahead of the man's horse, there was a man on the ground. As he rode toward the woman on the ground, he heard the sound of hoofbeats behind him. Looking over his shoulder, he saw Nathaniel coming at him with a spear. He also armed himself with a spear. He took his horse by the reins and turned it toward Nathaniel.

The man held his lance straight, like a noble knight. His horse stamped its foot and kicked up dust. Nathaniel, as if accepting the challenge, stopped his horse and followed him. He straightened his lance as he did. For a few seconds the horses looked at each other as they pounded the ground. And then they both hit the reins with all their might, like sheep. As the horses started to run, they spurred them on. The two riders ran towards each other, shouting.

They were approaching each other fast. They rode towards each other without hearing the sounds of the peasants fleeing in different directions, the voices of crying children. Both spears were aimed at the other's chest. When the tips of the spears aligned, Nathaniel used his sword to deflect the spear that threatened his unarmored chest and thrust his own spear into the man's chest. As the man fell from the horse, Nathaniel released the stuck spear. The spear fell to the ground with the man.

Scatt saw the soldier riding out of the wooden houses and drew a dagger from his belt. He threw the dagger into the air and turned it half a turn, carefully holding it on both sides of the metal. He took a deep breath and threw the knife at the horseman with all his might. The knife spun rapidly in the air and moved towards the horseman. The hilt of the blade struck the man's armor, and the blade did nothing but rattle the armor. The rider turned to Scatt, who had thrown the knife. Drawing his sword, he rode towards Scatt. As Scatt's eyes widened in fear, Rose, unsheathing Nathaniel's second sword, rushed forward. She raised the sword as she pushed the rider aside before he reached Scatt. The rider spun the horse around after ringing his sword. As she raised her sword to swing again, she was knocked back by an arrow through the opening of her helmet. Merlin stepped forward, puffing out his chest, and slung his bow over his shoulder.

James and Nathaniel dismounted and rode out into the wide green that looked like the village square, surrounded by wooden houses. From the other side Merlin, Scatt and Rose came. Soon the villagers began to come out of their houses. They emerged from the stables and from behind overturned stalls and gathered around the strangers standing in the square. They looked at the strangers in strange clothes with fear and curiosity.

One of the villagers broke through the crowd and stepped forward. "What do you think you're doing? Now we're all going to die because of you!" he shouted in a forked voice, spewing all his anger while pointing at Nathaniel, James, Scatt, Rose and Merlin in turn.

"What are they talking about, Merlin?" James asked in a whisper.

"The soldiers we killed are Lord Hugo's soldiers. A troop sent to intimidate us. They come in, loot the village, take what they want under the pretext that they are protecting us."

"Protecting you from what?"

"From a threat that doesn't exist."

"More will come! Lord Hugo will come here with his whole army! We've lost everything!"

"When the soldiers first arrived, no one liked the way they took what they wanted. We protested. And in a few days Lord Hugo arrived with his whole army. He said he would destroy the village if we 'politely' opposed the Lord's soldiers coming to take our rights. This all started two months ago. It started when Lord Hugo's father died."

"You strangers! You are responsible for everything! Maybe if we give you to Lord Hugo, he will spare our village!" The old man looked the strangers up and down. "Catch them! All of them!"

"Calm down, Chuk!" Merlin shouted, stepping forward.

"You, you have joined them, Merlin! We must hand you over to Lord Hugo too! You killed with them!"

"Because it's time to fight! We can't live in fear and let them take what they want!"

"So tell me, how can we defeat them? Their knights in armor outnumber the population of our village! Nearly twice as many! Or are you relying on your new friends?" Old Chuk looked at them with his critical eyes once more. "These strangely dressed warriors?"

"They are no ordinary warriors! Let me introduce you to Nathaniel Cooper! The last of Coldor's line, Nathaniel the Headknight!" Merlin continued as whispers could be heard from the villagers surrounding them in a circle. "The Headknight is not here by chance, he is here to fulfill his destiny! He has come to save us with the power evolved by the great sorcerer Solomon! With him and his loyal friends we can save our village! Together we can defeat Lord Hugo and his army!"

Nathaniel looked at the people, who were smiling and whispering with joy. Then he raised an eyebrow and looked at Merlin. He walked over to Merlin and leaned into his ear. "I'm going to help you ? Me? For your information, the Gauntlet has no hocus pocus powers. It just helps me dream." He whispered.

"The Headknight says he will help us and we can do this together!" said Merlin. Nathaniel covered his face with his hand as the people of the village began to cheer loudly. Sighing, he turned to the others.

"I think the spell has worn off. He no longer understands what we say."

"Now, if you'll excuse me, the Headknight needs to go over the details of his plan." Merlin said and took Nathaniel by the arm. As he dragged him through the crowd, they acted as if they had already won the battle.

They passed through the crowd in a line and arrived at Merlin's house. As soon as everyone was inside, Nathaniel closed the door and looked out the window. He could feel the enthusiasm of the villagers.

"Merlin, do you understand what I am saying?" asked Nathaniel.

"Yes and I'm sorry if I've put you on the board," Merlin said, bowing his head, "but it's time to rise up. I don't think Lord Hugo will give our village another chance. If we'll die, we will die fighting."

Nathaniel sighed and sat down in one of the creaking chairs. He stood for a while, covering his face with his hand. He thought.

"Kingdom of Destiny, how can we summon the army of the Kingdom of Destiny? Is there an emergency horn we can blow or something?"

“let alone getting help from the Kingdom of Destiny We can't get there and back in time. They have confiscated our watercraft except for a few boats. The boats are fishing near the palace where you came from. We can't get an army from the Kingdom of Destiny.”

“Damn it! Well, how many are they? Or how many will attack?”

“About a hundred and twenty. Most of them will probably be horsemen.”

“Great!” said Nathaniel angrily, banging his gloved fist on the table. “And the village? How many of you?”

“About forty men and thirty to forty women.”

“Do you have weapons?”

“Not really. Hugo's men took all the weapons we had.”

“How much time do we have?”

“Four to five days, give or take, We have time until they realized their men won't come back.”

“All right. What can we do in four days? Any ideas?”

“Do you have any horse and carts?” asked James.

“Yes, there were a few, but they took all the horses in the village.”

“And they brought us back a few. How far is the palace on the beach from here?”

“By carriage? A day or so.”

“The palace has a cellar full of weapons. That's where Nathaniel's swords came from. We'll go there in the carriages, get all the weapons we can and come back.”

"I don't think we can fight them, though." Nathaniel said as he leaned back, crossing his arms.

"We'll do our best." Said James. "We have to."

Before it was dark they dragged the men they had killed as far away from the village as possible. Immediately afterwards, they and the villagers went in search of the scattered horses. When they found the horses grazing in the open areas of the forest, they brought them back to the village and tied them to two carts covered with rotten wood and secured with screws that didn't quite hold.

Merlin adjusted the horses' blinders once more. He didn't want them to see both sides of the road. They only needed to see in front of them. When he had adjusted the blinders on all four horses, he took his place beside James in the front carriage. He took the reins of the horses. One by one, a few villagers climbed into the back of the cart they were driving. Nathaniel took the reins and sat next to Rose. Nathaniel was driving, behind the cart that Scatt sat waiting for it to move. When about three villagers had mounted both carts, Merlin shook the reins and the horses began to move.

As they rode slowly away from the village, Merlin took the reins in one hand and put his other hand into the quiver strapped to his right leg. He pulled out small, full pouches and handed them to James.

"For protection from the creatures."

James nodded and called to Rose, who was sitting in the car behind them. Rose looked up and threw a few of the pouches at him one by one. Rose caught the pouches and gave all but one to the villagers behind them.

Merlin occasionally glanced behind him as he swung the reins, and when he was sure that Nathaniel had the horses under control, he turned back to the front. As they drove the carts along the one-cart path through the darkening forest, rustling began to rise from behind the trees. Combined with growls and howls, it became even

more frightening. The villagers sat huddled together on one side of the cart, clutching their pouches tightly in their hands, waiting. It was clear that they had encountered the creatures from which the voices came before.

When they could barely see where they were going, Nathaniel handed the bridles to Rose sitting next to him. The villagers handed Nathaniel the torch they had lit in the back of the cart and one of the pouches from behind. Nathaniel jumped down from the cart and hurried to the front. James took the torch and got out of the other cart. They both proceeded, lighting the way for the cars they got out of.

From the raised voices, everyone was sure that the creatures were approaching. The howls emanating from the depths of the dark forest, illuminated by the weak light of the torch, took people's breath away and prevented them from sleeping, no matter how tired they were. It was still a few hours before sunrise.

Not even half an hour later the voices stopped. Because now they could see the silhouettes behind the trees at both ends of the path. Some were looking at them on all fours, others were leaning against the trees, rubbing their claws on the bark and watching them with their heads poking out of their sides. They made no growl or howl. They were just watching. The pouches that disturbed the creatures prevented them from getting too close. But they were watching. From all sides. With their big red eyes, they were looking at people one by one. They looked like they were going to pounce on them at any moment. Rose swallowed. When the flames of the torches in Nathaniel and James' hands flashed in the faces of the creatures a few feet away, Nathaniel and James saw them most clearly. Their breathing deepened as they tried to pull their gaze away from the creatures. But they couldn't help looking as the horrible faces of the creatures on either side of the road lit up. James gripped the scabbard of his sword tightly. He was watching carefully. Ready to defend himself at the slightest movement.

One by one, the creatures began to disappear as it grew lighter, as the black blanket of the sky began to turn blue.

As the sun shone on the mountain around them, all the creatures had already disappeared. At least they couldn't see them. Nathaniel waved his torch as the carts began to move across the mixture of grass and golden sand. Nathaniel slowed his pace and waited until the carriage Rose was driving pulled up beside him. When it did, he jumped in. Rose handed the reins to Nathaniel.

The carriages came to a halt just outside the two winged palace gates. The wolves poked their heads out from behind the carriages, and Merlin's eyes were wide open, staring at the palace before them.

"A palace that hasn't been entered for centuries..." Merlin began but couldn't finish.

"No one has ever entered it?"

"No, it was locked for a long time. No one has ever managed to get in. They say they even tried to break the doors down when they wouldn't open, but they couldn't."

"Do you know where the key to the palace is?" Nathaniel asked as he came up to Merlin. Merlin shook his head from side to side. Nathaniel raised one eyebrow and looked around. He leaned into Merlin's ear as if he was keeping a secret. "James' sword."

"Are you... are you serious? A sword?"

"The sword Solomon used to lock the palace. So it's not 'a sword, it's 'that sword'."

Merlin looked up at James. Then to the hilt of the sword he was gripping in his palm.

"Let's go in!" said Nathaniel. "I'll show you Old Solomon's palace."

The two villagers and Scatt waited by the carts while the other villagers, Nathaniel, Rose and James, entered the palace. Wide-eyed, the villagers made their way through the corridors of the centuries-locked palace. They followed Nathaniel. After a while, when they reached the armory with its metal doors, they entered.

“Our priorities are bows and arrows. Take what you can and carry them to the carts, then come back.” James said. He took one of the large blankets the villagers were holding and spread it on the ground. He took one of the bows lined up and removed the bowstring. Then he put it on the blanket as it was. The others followed James.

They stacked as much as they could carry on the blanket and then closed it tightly. Everyone loaded as much as they could lift and left the armory. With quick steps, they placed the weapons in front of the carts outside the palace. Those who were waiting by the carts placed the weapons in an orderly fashion behind the carts.

They loaded the arrows into quivers and took them out by the belts of the quivers. When they thought they had enough bows and arrows, they switched to swords. They loaded them in the same way and brought them to the carts.

In a few hours they had all the weapons they could fit in the carts and they set off again. The carts, with their loads, looked as if they might tip over at any moment. There was only one person sitting on each cart. Merlin and Rose. They both rode the horses calmly. The villagers, Nathaniel, James and Scatt, walked past the carts.

They came to a path through the forest and continued on. The villagers moving between the carts looked up, guessing the time through the leaves that partially obscured the sky. Immediately afterwards, they looked to both sides of the road. They wanted to get to the village before dark.

As the wind blew swiftly behind them, as if heralding the coming darkness, voices raised from the forest. There were howls. Even though they came from far away, the villagers were starting to

get scared. As the six villagers walked between the two carts, they drew closer together. Nathaniel walked on their right and Scatt on their left. Walking with the Headknight helped the villagers to relax a little. James walked in front of the first cart, lighting the way with a torch.

They poked their black noses through the bushes that split in two with a rustling sound. Their blood-red eyes glittered as they scanned the passers-by on the path. But they could not approach. They could only watch. The villagers gripped the weapons they had taken from the palace tightly. It was almost like a hug.

The creatures could do no more than watch them until dawn. Then they slowly made their way back into the forest. As everyone on the path took a deep breath, the entrance to the village came into view.

When they arrived, the villagers were waiting for them in the village square. When the cars stopped in front of them, they started to surround the car. Everyone was curious to see what was inside the carts.

“We have the weapons. First give the bows to those who can shoot arrows. Give the swords to those who can use them. If there are more swords, give them to those who can't use them, as long as they know how to stab them. We need to get the children and the old people to safety.”

“You heard the man!” shouted the Headknight. “Those who can shoot arrows and those who can use swords, line up! We will distribute the bows first, then the swords!”

The circled crowd moved as the Headknight's shout. One group quickly formed a line, while another group moved away from the others. As Merlin and Nathaniel opened the blanket covering the weapons, Rose stepped forward and took one of the bows and a quiver full of arrows. She also picked up a sword.

“Merlin, is there somewhere we can take those who cannot join the battle? Somewhere that might be safe?”

“The Sanctity Land might be safe for them for a while. They'll hide behind the ruins while the fighting is going on.”

“Take them there when the arms distribution is over.” Said James and stepped in front of one of the carts. He unhitched one of the horses and walked by the reins. He stroked his brown horse's white-spotted nose as he rode away from the carts. Then he mounted the horse. Slowly at first, then faster and faster. Finally, the horse was galloping.

When it was completely dark, one of the heavily armored soldiers looked over to where the tents were pitched and the campfires burning. He turned his head and looked at the soldier standing next to him. The second soldier had turned his back and was already walking away at a fast pace. Some of the other soldiers were sitting around the fires. Some were eating and some were sipping drinks.

The armored soldier watched his friend disappear into the trees at a run for a while. He was quite far from the camp, which was set up in the open, but not so far that the light of the camp could not reach him. He broke through the bushes and split in two. After walking towards the camp for a while, he heard rustling. He looked behind him. As the rustling grew louder, the man started walking. He changed direction and walked.

He took his steps as big as he could. He was trying to walk past them without looking at the black shapes he saw. The shadows were moving fast, going from one tree to the other. When the shadows became clearer, he started to run. He knew they were coming after him. He could hear them.

Amidst the growls and howls, he found himself next to the lake that reflected the white stars in the sky. Looking around, he kept

moving, one hand on the sword at his waist. He felt very uneasy. He ran his fingers over the crest on his chest. There was a Dragon without wings or legs. And it was writhing, forming a whirlpool. At the edge of the lake, he saw blue roses rising above the green bush at the foot of the mountain. He went to the rose and plucked one. He took a whiff of the rose's scent. He put it in a small pouch on his belt, took the sword out of its scabbard and swung it swiftly behind him.

He cut diagonally across one side of the creature's abdomen, which he could not see clearly in the darkness. He cursed as blood streamed down his face from the crevices of the helmet and began to run. From behind every tree and bush another creature leapt out, causing him to change direction. He threw himself to the ground and dodged the creature at the last moment, picked himself up and kept running.

He swung his sword. He twirled it and swung it. Whatever came his way, he used his sword without stopping. He cut through all the obstacles one by one. He tried to run faster and faster as the horrible sounds of the creatures grew louder, but he felt his strength running out. Then he saw a horse near a tree. He jumped on the horse whose bridle was tied to a branch. He cut the bridle with his sword and ran, holding the horse by holding the two part of cut bridle with one hand. The more he swung his sword at each creature in front of him, the louder the creatures became, as if they were getting more and more angry. They kept attacking with growls.

He thought he was riding the horse in the wrong direction. Until he saw the light of the campfire. He smiled a little under the helmet. At that moment he swung his sword at the creature that jumped at him from the side. As the creature fell to the ground, he took a deep breath and kept the horse running.

As the rider drew nearer to the camp, the men sitting around the fire that had been lit closest to it reached for their weapons at the sound of the hoofbeats. Some gripped their axes, others drew their sheathed swords. They were relieved to see that the one coming out of the trees bore their coat of arms. They put down their weapons and

went back to their old selves. The rider came quickly and galloped through the tents. For a short time there was dead silence. No one understood what was happening. Everyone was watching the rider.

And the howls began to rise. One of the brave soldiers who had drawn his sword was foolish and went to where the trees were thicker. Before he could swing his sword, the creature jumped on him and bit him on the neck. The soldier screamed but the creature paid no attention. His friends who had risen to help him hesitated when they saw the creatures emerging from the trees. But the creatures did not. They went straight to the attack.

Everyone in the campsite started to run. Some of the men shouted, "Barghests! The Barghests are attacking! On the north side!" The creatures were tearing the soldiers apart and the soldiers were slaughtering the creatures. The rider, who was not involved on either side, kept riding, dodging the creatures attacking him.

When the rider saw the soldier in front of him, he did not stop his horse. He kept riding on him. When the soldier threw himself to the ground and escaped, he heard a growl behind him. His eyes widened. He quickly turned around. The creature was coming towards him with its big claws. Suddenly it pounced on him, its fangs baring on their sharp teeth as blade. The soldier was not as fast as the creature.

People in the camp shouted and swung their swords at the creatures. Those who came out of the tents hunted as they tried to understand what was happening. Some drew their bows and shot arrows at the creatures in the distance.

As the rider spurred on, he jumped his horse over the camping fire in front of him. Looking around, he saw that some of the roofs were on fire. Others had collapsed. He rode his horse towards one of them that was still intact.

And then some of the soldiers started shouting again.

“We are under attack, archers are attacking from the west!” One by one the creatures were picking them off, while at the same time, they were trying to dodge the arrows coming at them.

Amidst all the chaos, the armored man managed to mount one of the white horses and rode towards the area where the arrows were raining down. He rode his horse, preferring humans to creatures. And he knew the creatures could not shoot arrows. He rode his horse quickly, dodging the incoming arrows. Pulling the reins left and right, he spurred on. Dodging all the arrows, he rode towards the archers at the front. He unsheathed his sword. Just as he swung his sword, the creature jumped on him and knocked him down

The rider slowed down his brown horse, dismounted, and moved out of the way of one of the running soldiers. Then he picked up one of the bags hanging next to the horse and entered one of the few remaining tents. First, he removed the helmet from his head and threw it aside. Then he opened the sack and quickly changed his clothes. Just as he was about to leave, he saw the dark brown hooded cloak in the open chest. He picked it up and put it around his neck.

When James came out of the tent, his horse was taking small steps away. James caught the horse before it could pick up speed and mounted. He swung the reins. The horse began to gallop. He unsheathed his sword and attacked whatever he came across. Soldier or creature. It made no difference. He turned the horse and rode in the direction of the arrows.

As he galloped, an arrow flew past him. Then another and another. James swore and turned his horse and rode off into the woods.

“The armor suits you, Scatt.” Nathaniel said as he patted Scatt on the shoulder in a friendly way. “But it makes no sense to wear it near the Barghests. Don't leave the area where Merlin showed.” Nathaniel turned as Scatt nodded. “Now it's our turn.”

Nathaniel shouted as he unsheathed his swords. The whistle of both swords whistled through the air in harmony as the villagers behind Nathaniel threw down their bows and picked up their swords. They charged, shouting with Nathaniel. Their voices were barely perceptible in the battle between the creatures and the heavily armored men, but their swords were felt.

Nathaniel crossed his swords to protect himself from the airborne sword. The armored man kicked Nathaniel in the chest. Gasping for breath for a moment, Nathaniel took to the air and fell hard to the ground. The soldier came to Nathaniel before he could get up. He raised his sword. Nathaniel rolled away from the sword coming down from above. As he did so, he realized he had left his swords on the ground. Cursing, he pushed aside his long trench coat and grabbed his pistol from his belt. He pointed it at the man. And pulled the trigger. The bullet ricocheted off the soldier's metal chest. It ricocheted off and disappeared. The man looked at the small scratch on his chest and turned in surprise to the pistol in Nathaniel's hand. Then he raised his sword again, ignoring Nathaniel's hand. He swung the sword at the ground, through Nathaniel.

His head rolled as the sword landed on his neck. Then the headless body of the armored man collapsed. James held the reins of his horse tightly in one hand and raised the sword in the other. His horse neighing angrily. Once his forelegs were back on the ground, James launched his next attack. Nathaniel rose from the ground and picked up his swords. He rubbed them together quickly and returned to the battle.

Scatt had chosen to wait for the others behind the trees. He held the head guard's dagger tightly, just in case. Now and again he poked his head out to see how the battle was going, then went back into hiding.

Merlin took aim with his bow held at his side and released the arrow. As the arrow struck the armored soldier in front of him, knocking his lifeless body to the ground, Merlin caught a glimpse of the sword rising from the side. He raised his bow to defend himself

when the sword reached out, piercing the soldier's abdomen. As the soldier fell to the ground, the owner of the sword pulled it from the body.

"Routh." Merlin said, nodding to his fellow villager.

"Merlin." Routh replied. Merlin's eyes widened.

"Routh behind you!" he shouted as he placed another arrow in his bow. By the time Routh turned around, the sword had already struck. Merlin quickly drew the bowstring and shot the arrow into the face of the man at his feet. As the man was knocked off his feet and crumpled to the ground, next to Routh on the ground.

As Rose sprinted towards one of the soldiers, she stopped at the last moment to let the creature jump at the soldier from the side. She left the soldier alone with the creature and moved on to the next one. She swung her sword swiftly. Steel clashed against steel. Again and again the swords clashed. When both sides raised their swords to strike again, Rose turned her body sideways and kicked the man in the chest. As the man fell to the ground, Rose did not approach him. As he struggled to get up, she heard a growl behind him. Cursing, he turned in that direction and the creature pounced on him.

The number of creatures was rapidly increasing and the number of armored men was rapidly decreasing. One by one they collapsed to the ground, dying. The creatures tried to get closer to the Radlanders, but they could not. Herbs gathered from the Sanctity lands kept them away from the creatures.

After a long and bloody night, the silence of death reigned. As the fires of the flaming tents danced and swayed, the creatures passed through them and wandered around the campsite for a while longer. On the ground, they stepped over the bodies of armored men scattered everywhere. Soldiers lay on the ground, some slashed with claws, others with swords.

Even as the sun began to rise, the creatures continued to roam the campsite. The bloodthirsty creatures wanted more. They wanted revenge.

The Radlanders returned home with great joy. They walked through the forest, glad to be rid of Lord Hugo's men. A few men carried the bodies of the dead and the wounded on horses. But still the peasants had the euphoria of victory. Even if most of the glory belonged to the creatures.

They continued along the path to the village. After walking through the trees for a while, they came to a clearing. The lush green grass shimmered as if by magic as the sunlight shone right on it. There was a lake right next to the greenery. It too served as a mirror for the sun. A little further on, on the tops of the short rising hills, row after row of collapsed white pillars could be seen. Some of them were still standing, others had completely collapsed and some were broken into two or three pieces.

From between the pillars first came curious glances. When they saw who was coming, the children behind the pillars started running around with great joy. They hurried down the hills. Behind them the old people came down the hills with careful steps. All of them, everyone, all the Radlanders gathered around the Headknight and his friends. They began to cheer with great joy and enthusiasm.

"I could get used to this." Nathaniel said, puffing out his chest and smiling. "But we have to take the army of the kingdom of destiny to take back to our world, don't we? Merlin, now that we've taken care of your problem, can you take us to the Kingdom of Destiny?"

Merlin looked them over, raising one eyebrow.

"The ships that can carry us all are in Hugo's castle. There are many ships there. We can take the one we want. I don't think

anyone will give us any trouble, especially after today. But, to be honest, I suggest you don't go dressed like that."

"There's nothing wrong with my clothes." Nathaniel insisted.

"Nate, Merlin is right." Said James as he nodded. "Merlin, can you find us... Can you find us some clothes that fit in here?"

"Sure. Take the day off. I'll try to find you some suitable clothes."

"Well, I could happily listen to those cheers for another day." Said Nathaniel. He looked at the children gathered around him. They all had their eyes on the gauntlet. Nathaniel raised one eyebrow. Then he got down on one knee. He held out his gloved hand. The boy in the front looked at the gauntlet and then at Nathaniel's face. When Nathaniel nodded, the boy carefully touched the gauntlet. When he saw that nothing was wrong, he looked at it more relaxed. Then his friends came. They touched all over the gauntlet. They ran their fingers over the open eye.

After a while, when it was time to leave the sanctity land for the village, Nathaniel stood up. He patted the head of one of the children and together with the villagers they set off for the village.

After a day of walking around the village looking for the right clothes for Nathaniel, James, Rose and Scatt, Merlin had finally found a pair of pants, a shirt and a cloak for each of them. The villagers were ready to do anything they could to help the Headknight and his friends. It didn't take Merlin long to find the right clothes.

The next day, in the early hours of the morning, after Merlin had distributed the clothes to everyone, they all went to their assigned room in Merlin's house and changed. While they were getting dressed, Merlin set the table.

Rose was the first to get dressed, and she took small steps and sat down at the table. James came right after her. When he saw

them sitting at the table, he spread his arms and turned around. It was clear from the smile on his face that he liked the clothes.

After waiting at the table for a while longer, Scatt arrived. He had folded the free sleeve of his shirt, although the cloak hid the sleeve that wasn't there. Nathaniel came last. He spread his arms wide, revealing the rolled-up sleeves of the shirt. "I'm starting to like these clothes, the only problem is..." said Nathaniel and unfolded his cloak. He adjusted the straps of the swords and put them around his waist. "I had to take my swords off my back." He paused for a moment to look at the swords hidden under his cloak. "Now that I think about it, it's no different than wearing a trench coat in Seattle. It covers the weapons again." Said Nathaniel and joined the others sitting at the table.

When they were well fed, they left Merlin's house. On the battlefield, they went among the horses gathered from the horses running in different directions and picked up the ones that suited them. Merlin, who had been guiding the others, rode into the forest at the front and the others followed him. Scatt and Nathaniel rode right behind Merlin, while James and Rose rode at the back.

CHAPTER TWENTY THREE

“And here I am.” Solomon said while wiping his mouth. The eyes of everyone at the table widened at Solomon's words. Solomon continued as if he didn't notice. “But I won't be around for long.”

“Are you planning to return to the Kingdom of Destiny?”

“When the time comes, yes. But I have more urgent business. Like going north to the cold lands. I will go there and build my own kingdom. I ask you, brother, to announce it to our people. Is there anyone who wants to come willingly, who wants to join my kingdom, to whom I will give the riches of the kingdom I will build?”

“Will you leave immediately?”

“No. I will give our people time to think, and we have a wedding to do. Of course, it won't be a regular wedding. We'll just get married in the palace and leave after it.”

“I'm really happy for you, Solomon, but do you think it's wise to split the kingdom in two?”

“We will not split the kingdom in two, brother. I'm just going to take a group of people with me, and if you won't let me, then, brother, you'll have to step down from my throne.” At the last sentence, everyone at the table froze. Their gazes went back and forth between Solomon and the King. It did not take long for the King to make up his mind.

The King smiled and took a sip of his wine. “You are a great warrior, brother, but you are still not a great king. For a great king must know how to listen to those around him. And if you think I am afraid of your threats, you are wrong. I am Nogah, the eldest son of David! You may take those of my people who wish to come with you and some of my personal guards.”

“Thank you, brother.” Solomon said and rose from his chair. “Can you send some soldiers to accompany Naamah?”

The king sighed.

“As you wish.” He repeated.

“Enjoy your meal.” Said Solomon and left the dining room. He was now walking through the corridors of the palace, followed by two guards.

“Take me to the library.” He said to the guards walking one step behind him. “I'm not sure I remember where it is.”

One of the guards led the way and after a moment opened one of the doors wide. He held it open until Solomon and the other guard behind him entered. He closed the door behind them. Solomon walked through the shelves of the huge library. He ran his hands over the dusty books. Every now and then he picked up a few and kept moving forward, holding them one on top of the other.

When he was sure he had enough books, he piled them on one of the tables. He pulled up a chair and began to flip through the books by candlelight.

He examined the map he found among the pages and ran his ringed hand over it. Soon the borders of his kingdom shimmered on the map. The light gradually shifted up the map to a specific region where the borders were drawn. He closed the book with a slight smile on his face. He picked up the candle and looked at the guards who had fallen asleep on the chairs. Rolling his eyes, he quietly left the library. Yawning, he went to his room. He blew out the candle and threw himself on his bed.

Solomon woke up earlier than usual. This time it was the knock on the door that woke him from his soft bed. Solomon yawned and opened the door. A guard stood before him.

“Sir, I'm sorry to disturb you, but the king wants you to come the throne room.”

“Very well. Tell my brother I'll change, and I will be there soon.”

“Yes, sir.” Said the Guardian and returned to the throne room as Solomon closed the door. Solomon took from his closet the outfit he had brought from the Kingdom of Destiny and dressed quickly. He guessed who was waiting for him in the throne room and excitedly tried to fix his hair and beard. He hurried out of his room and came to the Throne room. After taking a deep breath, he smiled and signaled the guards to open the door.

The doors opened on both sides. When Solomon entered, the first thing he noticed was that the throne was empty. The second was Naama, who turned to him with emerald green eyes. They both smiled at the first sight of each other. They took slow steps towards each other. Naama's first tear fell before Solomon's. With great joy they quickened their steps. As the doors closed behind Solomon, Solomon ran to Naama and hugged her tightly.

“I thought I would never see you again, Solomon.”

“Neither did I, to tell you the truth.” Said Solomon. And he hugged Naama even tighter.

“I know you like the throne room, but can we go out into the palace garden?”

“As you wish, Queen Naama.” Said Solomon. He had never felt so happy. He looked into Naama's striking green eyes and took her arm to lead her out of the palace.

As they walked through the palace gardens, Solomon told Naama everything that had happened to him. Then he picked up a branch to make her believe what he was telling her. He stretched out his arm and golden beams of light began to surround the branch. Then a red rose appeared right at the top of the branch. Solomon handed the rose to Naama. Naama took the rose in amazement and Solomon watched her wide green eyes with a smile. Solomon slowed his steps and stopped. Naama stopped with him. Naama was still looking at the rose Solomon had given her. with his hand, Solomon, moved the brown hair from Naama's face. As he put one hand on her cheek, Naama lowered the rose and looked up. She looked straight into Solomon's blue eyes. Solomon could feel his heart beating fast.

“Naama, there's one more thing I have to tell you.” Solomon said. “After we get married, we need to go east. Because there is a mine there. A mine that the Kingdom of Destiny needs. We will build a kingdom for ourselves there.”

“I will go anywhere with you.” Naama said as she hugged Solomon's arm tightly.

“Then tomorrow morning, Naama, will you marry me?”

“Yes!” said Naama. She threw herself into Solomon's arms with excitement.

Solomon was so excited he couldn't sleep. He sat on his balcony until sunrise. He stared at the stars shining in the sky, lost in thought. When he realized it was time, he went into his room. He opened his closet. When he couldn't find a suitable outfit for the

wedding, he panicked for a moment. But it was only a momentary panic. Smiling, he ran his hand over himself. His dress began to change shape. It shone. He looked at his jacket covered with gold ornaments in the mirror. He straightened his collar and went to the throne room.

Inside, he slowly made his way towards Naama, who was waiting for him in her ornate wedding dress. He took her hands.

"No matter what happens, no matter where you are, I will love you, Naama. My love. My queen." Solomon said with a smile. A tear of happiness rolled down his cheek.

"I love you too, Solomon, my darling. I loved you when I thought I could never have you, I love you now and I always will, my King."

Solomon looked at the king with a big smile blooming on his face.

"My brother, as a king, and more importantly as a brother, I want you to always be happy, and I know you have never been as happy as you were when you held Naama's hand. You never will be. So, long story short, brother, do you take Naama to be your wife?"

"I cannot build a kingdom far away without my queen. Yes, yes, I do."

"Naama, Do you take Solomon to be your husband?"

"Yes."

"As king of Israel, in the presence of God, I pronounce you man and wife. Rings!" said the king and Tamar entered. Tamar walked in with the rings in her hand. When she came to them, she first handed Solomon the tray with the rings on it. Solomon took one of the rings and put it on Naama's thin ring finger. Naama put the ring on the hand with Solomon's star ring.

“Congratulations, brother.” Said the King as he hugged Solomon.

“Thank you for everything.”

“Solomon...” said Solomon's mother as she hugged Solomon. “I wish... I wish your father could have seen it.” Solomon's mother couldn't speak any more. She hugged Solomon tightly. Solomon's mother wiped away her tears and let Solomon go. Congratulations, my son.”

“Thank you, mother.”

“Brother, congratulations.” Said Tamar. Solomon hugged his sister tightly.

“Congratulations, brother. I hope you will come to my wedding.” Said Jerimoth as he hugged Solomon.

“I would never miss it.” Said Solomon and embraced his brother. Then he let go of his brother and hugged his wife around the waist. They all went together to the dining room. There were small changes on the table. It was decorated and full of food. At the head, where the king used to be, there were two chairs. Solomon and Naamah sat in the two front chairs. Solomon took his wine in his hand. He looked at Naama. Naama did the same. They raised their glasses and then passed them to each other. They each took a sip of wine. And they began to eat together.

“Solomon, your new kingdom... what was it for?”

“To get rid of the darkness I told at dinner. I saved only one part, but the whole world is in darkness. In the place where I will build the kingdom, there is a mine that I can use to fight the creatures there. When the time comes, I will go there with the army I have built, and together with the army of the Kingdom of Destiny, we will gradually declare war.”

"I have every confidence that you will fulfill your plans, Solomon."

"Thank you, brother."

After we finished eating, everyone got up from the table. Without letting go of Naama's hand, Solomon called to one of the soldiers.

"Tell those who are coming north with me to get ready. Tomorrow we will be moving." Solomon put his free hand on the king's shoulder as the soldier nodded and left the dining room. "Brother, thank you for everything."

"If you need anything, remember that Israel and its King are always there for you."

Solomon smiled and nodded in greeting. "My King." He said to Naama and they left the dining room together.

Solomon put his sword with its scabbard on the belt of his robe from the Kingdom of Destiny. He left his room with his wife Naama. As they walked through the corridors of the palace, a guard stopped in front of Solomon. He nodded in greeting.

"Sir, those who are coming with you are waiting outside the palace." He announced.

"And my brother?"

"The king is waiting for you outside the gate. Along with the other royals."

When Solomon arrived at the palace gates, the guards opened them wide without hesitation. The first thing Solomon saw was the crowd. He looked at the gathered crowd for a while and then nodded. Then he looked one by one at his family waiting just outside

the door. He stood in front of his brother in the front row. He hugged him tightly.

“Solomon, our best troops are at your disposal.”

“Thank you, brother.” Said Solomon as he hugged him once more. Then he hugged his mother.

“You've just arrived and... and you're leaving already. Can't you stay a little longer?”

“I'm sorry, Mother, but I have work to do, vows to fulfill. But I'll come to visit you.”

“You're just like your father. He would be proud of you.”

“Thank you, Mother.”

Solomon let go of his mother and hugged his brothers in turn.

Solomon made his way towards his people gathered for him. One of the guards brought two horses that he had saddled. Solomon helped his wife onto the horse and then mounted himself. He tapped the reins and set his horse in motion.

“Thank you for choosing to come with me. And don't worry, we will get the riches I promised you! Solomon, the son of David, never breaks his word. Now let us set off. we have a long way to go.” Said Solomon and set his horse in motion again. The people gathered on both sides and made way for their king. They did not move until Solomon and his wife Naamah came to the front.

As Solomon and his people rode out of the kingdom, the friends, relatives and associates of the people who had stayed behind waved to them as they left, and there were some who wept. On the way there were those who changed their minds and joined the community, or those who changed their minds and could not leave their homeland.

CHAPTER TWENTY FOUR

The sky was red, as far as you could see through the leaves of the trees. Ahead, stretching out from the treetops, stood a castle. Its walls were clearly visible. The green castle walls were not far away.

They crossed the bridge over the deep blue river that flowed from one side to the other through the trees. After a little more time in the forest, they came to a path that led to a path in front of the castle. Carefully climbing the path, they stopped for a moment. They looked at the castle. The gate of the castle with its weathered walls covered with green ivy stood right in front of them. There was an unlit torch on the wooden door.

"I think this is Lord Hugo's castle." Said Nathaniel. Merlin nodded. "Since we defeated them in battle, the castle is ours, right?" Nathaniel continued with a small smile as Rose rolled her eyes and looked at Nathaniel. "I'll come here after defeating Blacked with the army of the Kingdom of Destiny, and if we can find a way to bring the people from the library here, they might want to live here. Under the orders of the Headknight Cooper, of course."

“Merlin, will you show us where the boats are?” asked Rose.

“Of course. As I recall, the pier is that way.” Said Merlin, without taking his gaze from the castle. He kept riding his horse and set off again.

The path led to a wooden pier. They came to a pier with all kinds of ships. From small two-man boats to large warships, there were many ships. Nathaniel dismounted and walked along the pier. One by one he looked at the vessels available to them, then smiled and gestured to one. He mounted the ship with the carved dragon in front of it. The others followed him

When everyone was on board, Nathaniel went to the front of the ship. He put his hand to his forehead and looked out to the rippling sea.

“To the oars, my brave Vikings! We have a kingdom to conquer!” he said in a deep voice. When the ship did not move, he turned around. Everyone was looking at him. With a sigh, Nathaniel sat down at the front rowing oars. He started rowing like the others.

The oars were getting heavier and heavier. They had been rowing for hours. The only good news was that the kingdom was close. Hugo's castle looked like a small shack compared to the splendor of the Kingdom of Destiny. And it was more fun to row in that direction.

They continued on into the darkness of the night. They were halfway there. Against the black backdrop of the sky, a large shadow hovered in the sea. Nathaniel ignored it and thought he had seen it wrong. The others didn't see much. They were only interested in rowing. Scatt stood by the horses, trying to calm them down. Because every now and then they would get restless and beat their hooves on the wooden floor of the ship. And Scatt couldn't row.

As Nathaniel's tired arms kept pulling the oars in the same way, his eyes were on the shadow moving under the water. First it circled around the ship, then it disappeared for a short time.

When it reappeared, it moved with great speed towards the ship. It was moving fast under the water. Before Nathaniel realized whether the shadow under the water was real or just an illusion, it ended up at the bottom of the ship. When it hit the ship, though not violently, the ship shook slightly with a thud. Then the shadow at the bottom of the sea became thinner and thinner and disappeared into the water.

It had been a few hours since the sun had risen on their right. It wasn't until they were close to the kingdom's ramshackle dock that Nathaniel tried to determine if the shadow was real. Merlin's voice broke him out of his thoughts.

"Let's leave the raft here." He said and stepped onto the rotten dock. As he tied the ship's rope to one of the masts, Nathaniel got up from where he was standing and stepped onto the scaffolding. James stepped onto the dock right behind him and held out his hand to Rose. She held his hand with a small smile and he gently helped her up. Scatt was the last to dismount. One by one, Merlin led the horses out onto the pier. When everyone had their own horse, they came to the beach, holding the reins. For a moment they stood side by side, looking at the city before them.

"Here we are." Merlin said, pointing to the rows of beach houses opposite. The houses seemed to be spread all over the beach. In the distance, just beyond the houses, a wall rose. The magnificent city wall seemed endless, stretching out on either side. Even farther away from the wall, the palace could be seen, reflecting the sunlight around it from the very top. "The Kingdom of Destiny." Said Merlin.

The streets seemed deserted at first, but as they moved inland, it became crowded. People were coming in and out of everything from marketplaces to inns. A man burst out of the door of the inn, which had two small wing doors on either side. The innkeeper, who came out behind him in his dirty apron, shouted curses and told him not to come back, while the drunk man got up from the ground and staggered on his way. After watching him go, they continued on their way.

“What do we do now? Do we talk directly to the king? Can we do something like that?”

“I don't think so, but Merlin's brother might be able to help us. Do you know where we can find him, Merlin?”

“I have no idea.” Merlin said, looking around.

“I don't know about you, but I'm not gonna find anyone with a dry mouth. I say we go to the inn and have an ale.” Said Nathaniel and without waiting for an answer, he walked towards the double doors. He tied his horse to the post next to the inn, slowly opened both doors and went inside. The others followed him.

When Nathaniel first entered, he saw the big man sitting in front of the counter. Across from him, on the other side of the counter, the innkeeper was taking orders from a customer. As Nathaniel made his way inside, he saw that a few tables were occupied. But the inn was mostly empty. So Nathaniel sat down at one of the empty round tables. James came in behind Nathaniel and sat across from him. Nathaniel looked around suspiciously. As Rose, Scatt and Merlin each pulled a chair around the table, Nathaniel approached James, resting his elbows on the stained table.

“The bartenders, or innkeepers in this case, will know everything that goes on around here. I say we start looking here.”

With one hand, the innkeeper placed a tray over his shoulder and filled it with wooden mugs full of ale. He passed between the tables and quickly distributed the drinks to them. When he had finished the tray, he approached his new customers.

“What can I get you guys? Judging by the horses, you've come from a journey. Would you like a cold beer to wash away the fatigue of the journey?”

“Make that three!” said Nathaniel and felt the focused gaze on him. “What?”

"Actually, the reason we came here... We're looking for someone called..." said James, gesturing to Merlin.

"Arthur. Arthur Mattson."

"Arthur and Merlin, wow!" said Nathaniel, "or is your brother the king?"

"I wish! My parents loved the legend of Merlin the Wizard and King Arthur. That's why they named us after the story. You see, my brother is not a king, all I know is that he is a commander."

"I've never heard such a name in my life." Said the innkeeper through clenched teeth. "And who are you?"

"I am Nathaniel, son of the brave knight Will, bravest knight of the north. Perhaps you have heard of my reputation! This is James my bard, who writes songs inspired by my adventures! And this young fellow is Arthur's little brother..."

"So you are his brother!" said the innkeeper in surprise. All the stiffness was gone from his face. "Then allow me to call him here." He said, bowing. He straightened up again. "If you like, I'll give you something to drink while we wait for Arthur."

"Thanks, but we don't want anything." Rose said.

"I don't think we should break the innkeeper's heart, Rose." Said Nathaniel, "I'm sure there's a delicate little heart underneath that big, huge, bulky belly of him. Not like your father, you see."

"Told you," said Nathaniel as the innkeeper sighed in exasperation and walked away from the table. Nathaniel said. "Innkeepers always know everything."

"Merlin Vern Mattson," a voice of stranger said from behind Merlin. Those at the table turned to see the owner of it. woman with a hood half covering her face. Her red hair fell over her shoulders on either side of the hood. The part of her face that was visible showed her uneasiness.

“We don't have the ring if you're looking for it, Aragorn?” said Nathaniel.

“If you really are who you say you are, you are all in danger.” She said, ignoring Nathaniel.

“What are you talking about?” James asked, one hand on the sword at his waist.

“You don't understand!” she said. She pulled out a chair and sat down next to them, pulling down her hood. “Your brother was a commander. He was my commander. Until the king died. The new king has declared your brother and those who stood behind him rebel. If you follow me, I can lead you to him.”

“You expect us to trust someone we do not know?” Rose asked.

“If you don't trust me...” She said and slipped her hand under her cloak. Nathaniel stepped back and put his hand on the hilt of her waist as James unsheathed the sword he held by the hilt, just a little. She took a step back and slowly removed her hand from the cloak. She took out a piece of paper to show that she was not a threat and showed it to those at the table. Then she handed it to Merlin, who unfolded the worn paper. Inside was a picture of a man with a short beard and long wavy hair down to his shoulders. Underneath was a large gold reward with a few zeros.

“But... But...”

“And then there's this.” The woman gestured to the door before Merlin had finished. The door slammed open and out stepped the innkeeper and two guards in shining armor. As soon as the innkeeper entered, his eyes searched for Merlin and he immediately pointed.

“There he is! The rebel's little brother!”

“Sounds very trustworthy to me.” Nathaniel said and raised from his seat, knocking the chair back. James risen quickly and drew his sword with a clang. With his other hand he threw the chair in front of him aside. Nathaniel also unsheathed both swords.

“Follow me!” she said.

“This time we might run away” James said, looking at Nathaniel. Nathaniel nodded his head in agreement and they took off after the red-haired woman. Immediately after them, the guards started running.

They ran up the stairs to the top floor. There was a railing on one side and rows of rooms on the other. Without waiting, the woman kicked the door of the first room. The door burst open and she entered. She jumped over the bed, reached the window, opened it and jumped out. After everyone was inside, James locked the door. And he went with the others to the window. The woman had jumped onto the roof of the house next door to the inn. She gestured for them to come. The guards kicked the door, just as the red-headed woman had done, and one by one everyone jumped out of the window onto the other roof.

They went from roof to roof, some going up and some jumping down. On some rooftops, they moved on a thin flat area at the top. But the soldiers were not letting them go. On the contrary, the guards patrolling the market areas, near the stalls and markets, followed their friends as they jumped from rooftop to rooftop. Some went up to the roof of the first building they could find, others followed along the paths that ran alongside the houses.

They came to the end of the houses as the soldiers piled up more and more in pursuit of the rebels. They stopped in front of a single-towered building that resembled a huge church. The road was over. The pine tower next to the house was several buildings high. The woman put her hands on the wall of the bell tower. After running her hands over it for a while, she found the ledge she was looking for and pulled herself up. One by one she grabbed hold of the ledges and

climbed up. The people on the roof followed her before they had time to think what to do. Because the Guards kept coming.

The stones deliberately protruding from the flat wall of the building formed a single path. And everyone was taking turns. The red-haired woman, Nathaniel, Merlin, Rose and James. Scatt thought James was high enough, so he put his hand on the ledge and tried to climb up. Before falling down, he jumped himself while cursing. He couldn't get up with one arm. He looked at the Guards coming up behind him. He cursed again and looked at the tower from which everyone had come. And then the guards. Gasping for breath, he looked both ways and then turned sideways. He descended cautiously but quickly down the descending roof of the house he was on. At the far end of the roof he jumped down without stopping, knowing the guards were following him. He landed in the middle of the road, in the middle of the villagers, who were moving calmly, minding their own business. As the people of the kingdom backed away, trying to understand what had happened, Scatt sat up, aching with pain. Starting with slow, drunken steps, he pulled himself together. He picked up speed and began to run.

James looked down at the Guards. He was angry with himself when he saw Scatt jumping down. was about to put his foot on the ledge below to get down when one of the guards coming after them grabbed his ankle. James cursed and tried to pull himself up while shaking his foot. But the man's fingers were as firm as if they were glued to James's ankle.

With a whistle, an arrow flew through the air and quickly lodged in the guard's forehead. The guard's body stayed where it was for a moment, then slowly, one by one, his fingers left James' wrist and fell backwards. The guards screamed as their hands and feet slipped off the tower with the body falling on them. A few of them fell down while others pressed themselves against the wall as best they could. They waited, feeling the fallen ones on their backs.

James looked up at the red-haired girl standing at the top of the tower. He nodded his thanks and continued up the stairs. On the

way up, he looked down the path Scatt had come down. Scatt and the guards who had followed him had disappeared into the crowd.

When James, got to the top of the tower like the others, he looked over the edge at the guards climbing up, one by one, quickly.

“As soon as we get rid of the guards, we should search Scatt. He couldn't climb the tower, so he jumped down from the roof. Some of the guards were following him. We must find him!”

“Okay, first of all, calm down.” Said the red-haired woman “There is nothing easier than finding your friend. Now let us worry about ourselves.” She added and rang the bell.

As the ringing of the bell spread through the streets of the city, the blocks just below the bell began to move. They seemed to tremble. Soon several blocks of stone came down. The woman pointed to the rope ladder underneath. “Down,” she said, and as everyone else descended the ladder, the woman swung down slightly from the balcony on the other side of the bell. Pieces of wood, tied together with ropes on both sides, were piled up to the very top of the bell tower. The woman quickly drew a dagger from her belt and cut one of the ropes. As the pieces of wood fell rapidly down, the ropes tied around the edges stopped them before they reached the ground. At the top, the wooden staircase attached to the bell tower swayed as the woman left it there and entered through the opening beneath the bell.

As Scatt pushed his way through the crowd, he saw the guards following behind him. People were not much in the way of the guards. As soon as they saw them, they nervously made way for them. Scatt was running without knowing where he was going. One of the three guards running behind him had a bow slung over his shoulder. But he was waiting for him to get away from the city center to a secluded place to use it. He couldn't use a bow in the crowded streets of the city where people came from everywhere.

When Scatt came to the fork of the path, he chose the most crowded one and ran away. The more people, the more obstacles for the guards. Even though the people were retreating before the guards arrived.

Scatt kept bumping into people, apologizing for destroying their fruit stands. Most of the men shouted creative swearing at him as he ran away without looking back, but Scatt ignored them and tried to keep going.

He didn't hit as many people as he used to. Because the number of people on the roads was slowly decreasing. Scatt took the right of the two roads he came across. The guards standing guard at the crossroads looked at the running man for a moment, but did not pay much attention to him. Until they saw the others running after him. Both of the guards started running after Scatt. They didn't know why they were chasing a one-armed man, they were just running.

Scatt turned at the crossroads again, panting. But this time he slowed his pace. On three sides were adjoining buildings. There was no one near the old, damp houses. Nor, Scatt thought, did anyone live in them. He turned around and walked backwards with heavy steps. The guards who had cornered Scatt slowed to a crawl. "I am not afraid of you!" Scatt shouted as he put a trembling hand to the dagger at his waist. He hoped his voice would not tremble. "And I am innocent! Can any of you tell me my guilt?" He knew there would be no answer. "No? That's what I thought."

"Only five of you?" said a mocking voice from behind the guards. "I expected more." The guards turned to see a man wearing an old cloak on his back. He opened the edges of the cloak to reveal a sword at his waist.

"This must be one of the rebels! Seize him!" said one of the guards. Three of the guards took up their weapons and marched towards the rebel, while the others marched towards Scatt.

“Now you are down to three.” Said the rebel. The sword he drew from beneath his cloak filled the street with its metallic whistle. He pointed the unsheathed sword at the guards and placed his free hand on his back. When the guard in front raised his sword, the rebel took a step forward and swung the incoming blade to the side, spinning his own sword without waiting. He cut a deep gash in the first guard.

Before the first guard's bloodied body had even fallen to the ground, the second guard attacked from the side. Before the rebel could even straighten his sword, he saw the guard's sword hurtling towards him. He tried to dodge by leaping backwards, but the sword struck the rebel in the shoulder. There was a deep cut on the shoulder holding the sword. The rebel looked at his wound. “A small price for justice.” He said and went on the attack.

This time the third guard stepped forward. The rebel attacked the second guard first. As the swords clashed and trembled, the rebel clumsily turned around and blocked the second sword coming at him. As the swords clashed, he turned with his whole body without waiting. He twirled the sword as if it were part of his arm and swiftly struck the second guard in the neck as quickly as the first.

The guard's thin, light sword moved as if cutting the air. As soon as the guard's sword was free, he leapt forward. The third guard's sword, swung from the sky, clattered to the ground. As the guard straightened his position, he made his second attack. He swung his sword. The moment the rebel's own sword touched his opponent's, he drove the guard's sword down with an imaginary arc of his sword in the sky. The sword down, the guard turned his gaze from his weapon to the rebel, who punched him in the face with his free hand. As the guard was thrown backwards, the rebel shook his hand, wincing with the pain he felt. Then he looked down at the fallen guard. Frowning, he looked back at the man he had tried to save.

The two guards stood with their swords at Scatt's neck.

“One more step and...”

“What will you do? Or will you kill that man I don't know? What a serious threat.” Said the rebel with his initial sarcasm. He cleared his throat and looked at the sword in his hand. After a moment of silence and stillness, he threw his sword with all his might at the man on Scatt's right. Before he could move much, the guard fell to the ground with a groan, his voice barely audible. The second guard collapsed like the first before he could make a move. The only difference was the dagger stabbed into him as he fell on his face.

“Good move.” Said the Rebel as he drew his sword from the guard's body. Scatt drew his dagger with alarmed eyes.

“Thank you for saving me.” Scatt said, panting.

“I saw you jump down from the bell tower and the guards were following you. It would have been much easier if you had gone with whoever took you to the tower.”

“I tried, but I couldn't climb the tower.”

“It's easy to climb it. You just need two hand that's all, my friend.” The rebel paused for a moment and looked at both sides of Scatt. “Ohh...”

“Yeah.” Scatt said, shaking his head as if he annoyed.

“My apologizes.” Said rebel and pulled his hood up. Underneath the hood, his black hair was hidden in a bun. Looking at Scatt with his light blue eyes, he held out his hand.

“My name is...”

“You're Arthur! Merlin's brother!” Scatt said with wide-open eyes.

“Do you know my brother? But... How you know him?”

“He brought us here. Me and my friends...”

“And where is he?” Arthur asked. There was a frightening coldness in his voice. He grabbed Scatt's shoulder. “Or have the guards caught him?”

As Scatt said Arthur's last sentence, he saw something in Arthur's eyes that he hadn't seen even when he was fighting the guards. Anger and fear.

“Last time I checked, Merlin was climbing in the bell tower with the red-haired woman.” Scatt said quickly and fearfully.

Arthur took a deep breath. He stepped back, letting Scatt go. He pulled his hood back down.

“Good, let's go.” Arthur said and looked up at the sky. “It's almost dark.”

At the bottom of the passage that opened under the bell were steps that curved downwards. The two men who had opened the passage stood at the foot of the stairs and helped everyone in, then closed the entrance behind them and started down the stairs. The stairs were dimly lit by torches placed at regular intervals. Everyone descended the stairs one by one.

On the ground, at the bottom of the stairs, they moved quickly through the tunnel of stones. The red-haired woman was at the front of the line, and the guards she passed along the corridor all saluted her.

At the end of the corridor they entered a wooden door with a metal strip. They came to a large area. It was as crowded as a marketplace. But there was no disorder of people rushing in different directions to go about their business. The whole crowd moved in a certain order. Most of them wore the same armor as the guards. They were spread out in teams across the field. Some were eating their meals, some were practicing one-on-one drills, some were in the middle of a circle of people, ringing their swords for the last time.

Those around them were cheering both sides on, some shouting and making bets.

“Here it is” said the red-haired woman. “Our headquarters.” Sighing, she gestured to the gathered crowd. “This part is a bit too loud, so we mostly hook upstairs.” She said and gestured to the stone steps at the far end of the building, which curved upwards like the staircase they had come down. “Follow me.”

These stone steps were not as long as the other one. At the end, they connected to a wooden attic door. The red-haired woman opened the door above and pulled herself up. One by one, she helped her followers up.

Everyone looked around. The stairs led them to an inn. It smelled just as bad as the first inn they had been to, but it was much bigger. Just beyond the door they had come out of was a fireplace. Above the fireplace was a stuffed boar's head. On the opposite side of the fireplace was a bench. The innkeeper, his beard braided halfway down his belly, came out from behind the counter and saw the people using the door on the floor. With quick steps, he walked across the creaking floor towards them.

“Alesia, I'm glad you came! And you brought a guest with you! Just like Arthur.” She said and gestured to Arthur sitting at one of the tables. When Arthur saw that he was being pointed at, he immediately understood why and after taking another sip from his wooden pint, he raised his large beer pint and bowed to Alesia. Then his gaze shifted to Merlin standing behind Alesia. He immediately put the pint on the table and jumped up. He took quick steps towards his little brother. He hugged his brother whom he had not seen for a long time. Then he looked at the strangers behind him.

“I think you must be... Nathaniel, James and Rose.” Arthur said. His gaze searched Nathaniel and James' hands and he saw the gauntlet in Nathaniel's hand. He knelt in front of Nathaniel. “Headknight Cooper. I am Arthur Mattson, at your service.”

“Thank you, Arthur. I would be honored to have you serve me. And we really need your help.”

Arthur motioned everyone to one of the large tables in the inn. He then went to the innkeeper and asked him to get everyone something to drink. The innkeeper bowed as if on command and quickly poured the drinks and brought them to the table.

“Your friend Scatt told me why you came here, but I have some bad news. In the past few months the king has died. Prince Hendry, the king's brother, was supposed to sit on the throne, but the king's stubborn son Richard claimed the throne for himself and had his uncle imprisoned.”

“And because you and your men stood up to him, he was declared you as rebel.” Nathaniel speculated.

“Close. When his father was dying, he gave me a parchment that said his brother was next in line for the throne. In his own handwriting and with his own mark. And before I could reveal it, Richard spread the word throughout the kingdom that I was a traitor. From the inns to the blacksmiths. In short, everyone. A group of soldiers and trusted friends decided to stand behind me.”

“We don't even know where Blacked will strike first, let alone an army.”

“By Blacked, you mean the one who made the deal with Valefar? The one who took the Book?” Arthur asked, looking at Scatt, who had told him everything. Scatt nodded in agreement.

“Actually, we know. The power unleashed with the book is only a small part of the power that is hidden. This spell is supposed to take the Book to the pillars so that the power - at least most of it - can be unlocked. But don't worry. There is a small troop of soldiers around the pillars. For centuries those pillars have been protected. They are protected again, and he will not be able to breach them alone.”

“Not alone, if he knows how to get to where we came from. He has unleashed the power Solomon distributed to his army. If he can gather all the other rebels. Then it won't take a small force to stop him.” James said, not taking his eyes off the cup in his hand.

“But... “But the soldiers in this kingdom must have grown stronger.”

“If that had changed, there would have been chaos here. Because not everyone with the blood of the old guard is still a guard. And they may not be loyal to the kingdom. And that would lead to great chaos. You'd have criminals who think they're superior. But there's no change in this city. So I don't think it's happening.”

“Damn it!” shouted Nathaniel, banging his pint on the table. “We're fucked!”

“I'm sorry, but we haven't gotten to the worst part yet.” Arthur said and took a big gulp of his ale. “King Richard has sent his armies to tear down the walls. Because he wants more land. But he doesn't know that all he gets is destruction. He beheads those who try to warn him. And if the armies tear down the wall, then we are dead.”

“Yes, that wall.” Nathaniel said, nodding slowly, “That wall must not come down, and as Headknight I can tell you that it is very important.”

James sighed . “We don't know what you are talking about.” He said as ignoring Nathaniel and then he put his empty pint to the side and became serious. “What is behind the wall?”

“Ah, my friends, behind the wall there is nothing but darkness. Thousands of creatures like Valefar. Some worse than that.”

CHAPTER TWENTY FIVE

Blacked closed the book without waiting for the surrounding darkness to pass. The magic had spread, reaching everyone who bore the blood of guards and rebels. Blacked walked forward with a small smile. He looked at Nathaniel, slumped on the ground. Then to James.

“I could kill you here, but it would be no fun. I will take care of you after I build my kingdom.” Blacked said in his thick, dirty voice. As the palace slowly lit up, Blacked left the throne room. He walked through the corridors and came to the outer door of the palace. He looked at the book he was holding. With one hand he began to turn the book over in his lap while the other ran over it. Dark mist surrounded the book. When it covered it completely The book quickly disappeared with the fog. Blacked smiled and put both his hands on it. And pushed. The doors opened with a great creak.

When Blacked stepped outside, he stopped for a moment. Disturbed by the sunlight shining directly into his eyes, he squinted

his eyes. He stepped onto the sand. On one side was the sea, on the other mountains and forests.

Blacked looked around for a while and then started walking without leaving the wall of the palace. He walked on the sand shining in the sun. He kept the palace wall to his left.

When he reached the back of the palace, he looked around again. And he kept walking. He walked where the beach and the forest began to merge. As he continued walking, the grass, bushes and trees became denser. After a while, he came to the place where the sand ended and the brown soil began.

He lifted his head up. The sun was setting and the moon was rising on the other side. Blacked didn't care that it was getting dark. He kept walking.

At midnight, with the moon shining brightly overhead, he came to a river. He looked in the direction the river flowed. Then the other side. He looked for a bridge. But when he could not see a bridge, he sighed and entered the river. Slowly he waded into the deepening river. The water was up to his waist at most. He crossed half wet.

Across the river, among the outstretched branches of trees, a castle was visible. No matter how tall the trees were, they could not hide the top of the castle, which rose with stone pillars. Without waiting, Blacked started walking towards the castle.

In the darkness of the night, the howls of wolves faded away. Blacked knew he was being watched. Behind him, to the sides and in front of him. He could feel creatures moving all around him. But he didn't care. He knew they could do nothing.

When he was close to the castle, he slowed his steps. One by one he made his way through the trees. When he came to the path in front of the castle, he stopped. He went behind a tree and looked around. Then he started moving. He stepped onto the path and started walking.

When the first rays of the sun began to fall on the path, Blacked stepped into the forest. He continued walking along the path. As he kept walking, he saw people in armor. They were walking on the path with torches in their hands. They were coming towards him. Blacked did not want to deal with the soldiers. He changed his direction a little more and walked away from the path they were on. After walking deeper into the forest for a while, when he was sure that the soldiers had passed, he walked back to the path.

He stopped when he saw that the path split into two different paths. One of the paths led to the castle. It led to the entrance of the castle, which stood right next to it. There were armored soldiers standing guard in front of the entrance. The other path continued straight ahead. Blacked took the straight road.

With the sun shining brightly overhead, Blacked reached a place where the forest met the coast again. He walked forward and saw the jetty where the path continued. The wooden pier stretched out to sea, with ships of different sizes and types lining both sides. Where the pier met the land, two soldiers stood guard.

Jack opened both sides of his jacket. He closed them back, remembering that he had left the knives at the palace. He stepped out of his position and moved with great strides towards the pier. The guards who saw him drew their swords as they saw Blacked coming towards them.

As Blacked ran, he noticed the sword coming at him from above. He jumped back. When the sword landed in front of him, he quickly stepped forward and stepped on it. At that moment the second guard swung his sword at Blacked. Blacked quickly ducked and jumped on the second guard. He and the sentry hit the ground together. The sentry looked to both sides for the sword he had dropped. It was lying on the scaffolding. Blacked beat him to it and jumped to the sword's side. He grabbed the hilt and before he could get up, the guard with the sword raised his sword and brought it down swiftly on Blacked. Blacked rolled to the side and escaped.

“Why am I even bothering with this?” he said in a terrible voice and held out his free hand to one of the guards. The thin mist that surrounded him shot out like a spear and stabbed the guard. The guard fell to his knees as blood began to ooze from the center of his chest. “I wanted some action, but it went on too long.” Blacked said and put the sword on the shoulder of the guard on his knees. He swung the sword quickly. As body and head fell to different sides, Blacked walked towards the guard who was trying to stand up.

Seeing Blacked coming towards him, the guard backed away in fear.

“Please... Please don't!”

“Kneel in front of me!” said Blacked. The guard stood for a moment. When he saw Blacked's black eyes, he got down on one knee without resistance.

“Please don't kill me!”

“Soon the whole Kingdom of Destiny will kneel before me, just like you. And just like you...” Blacked plunged the sword into the man. “They will die!” Blacked whispered. He drew the sword with all his might. Blacked kicked the man in the chest as blood poured from the wound. As the man fell off the pier into the shallow water, Blacked walked along the pier. All the way to the end. Never stopping.

He looked across with a smile. Across the sea. He saw the city walls stretching out. And just beyond that, the palace stretching into the sky. The walls covered most of the city, but not the palace. It didn't look like the last time Blacked had seen it. It was beautiful, though.

One by one, Blacked looked at the rafts and ships on the wharf. He chose the raft that was tied up on the left side of the pier, untied the rope and climbed aboard. The oars were right at his feet. He placed the oars on both sides and started rowing.

He rowed along the blue sea. He reached the opposite side under the sky that turned orange with the setting sun. When he was close enough, he jumped off the raft. The water was almost up to his knees. He left the raft where it was and went to the beach.

After a short beach walk, he entered the kingdom. Small wooden houses were scattered around. There were not many people outside. Those who were outside were slowly going home.

By the time the day was completely over and the night began, Blacked had made it to the center of the city. The houses looked bigger and newer. And this part of the city was more organized than the other parts. The houses were all lined up in a certain order and sequence. Blacked passed between the houses and continued on his way.

Gradually he began to see men with torches in the darkness. He was approaching the outer walls of the palace. He walked as far away from the guards as possible. The guards who saw him watched him carefully for a while and then went on their way.

Blacked saw the palace from afar. But his business was not with the palace. He changed his path before he got any closer to the palace.

The houses started to get disorganized again. And they became fewer. They were getting farther and farther apart, farther and farther apart. Gradually he came to the houses with trees between them. Where the houses ended completely, the forest began. He continued to walk through the forest without giving break.

At some point, at a certain border, the forest ended completely. It was a straight line, as if it had been deliberately made. And where the forest ended, the sands began. The sand was not beach sand. A desert began right there.

When Blacked saw the sand through the trees, he frowned and tried to understand what was happening. His eyes widened as he saw the dunes stretching on as if they would never end. He quickened

his pace and passed through the trees. Finally, when he reached the point where the desert began, he stopped. As far as his eyes could see, it was covered with sand. The hills rose and fell. A few hundred meters ahead he saw towering white pillars. And dozens of soldiers positioned around it. He turned back, cursing silently. He knew he could not cope with that many soldiers.

He went back to the city. He wandered the streets of the kingdom. He looked for a suitable place. And he set his sights on the first inn he saw. He opened the double doors and went inside. The innkeeper didn't seem to have many customers. All but one table was empty. At that one full table, two people were sitting and talking. Quietly and calmly. There was nothing to drink or eat in front of them.

Blacked went to the innkeeper who was wiping the counter. When the innkeeper saw Blacked, he greeted him with a fake smile.

"I need a room." Blacked said. Using the voice he had before he put the ring.

"Of course." Said the innkeeper. "How long will you stay?"

"Just one night."

"That's two silver coins." Said the innkeeper and reached for one of the drawers on the other side of the counter. He rummaged through them and pulled out a key. He handed it to Blacked.

Blacked reached into his pocket. He had no money in his pocket. He didn't need to. He quickly turned his hand in his pocket. The black mist moved quickly and met in the void. It took shape and turned into two metal coins. Blacked smiled and handed the money from his pocket to the innkeeper.

"Upstairs, second room on the right. Would you like something to eat?"

"No." Blacked said and took the key and went upstairs. He found his room and went inside. He closed the door behind him and locked it. He took off his black coat and threw it on the bed. He pulled up the sleeves of his sweater. He stretched his hands forward at chest level. One facing down and one facing up and they were in the same line. From both hands, around both hands, the black mist flowed heavily into the center. It continued to flow without stopping. Finally it took shape. And the shadows returned to where they came from. Between Blacked's hands was Solomon's book.

Blacked turned the pages of the book. All the pages were empty except for the last few. Blacked flipped through the full pages and when he found what he was looking for, he put the book down. He picked up the candles that had been placed to light the room, hanging on the stand. He held the string on one of the candles with two fingers and it suddenly caught fire. He did the same with the other candles he found. He put his finger on the floor. And he started to move it. The places where his finger passed began to be scratched with an ash-colored paint. Blacked drew a big star on the ground. He placed the lit candles at the corners of the star. When he had placed all five candles, he moved to the center and picked up the book. He began to read the words on the open page. He got faster and faster. His voice rose with each word. Suddenly he interrupted. And as he spoke, all the candles went out.

When Blacked opened his eyes, he was no longer in the inn with its wooden walls. He smiled as he felt the cold winds of the night on his body. He spread his arms wide and looked around. He took a deep breath.

"So this is Solomon's world." He said in his wheezing voice. "The second world I will rule!" He put one hand on the book again and covered it with his black mist. When the book disappeared, he started walking. He knew everything Blacked knew. He had his thoughts. He also knew where he had to go.

After walking for a long time, he came to a highway. He walked along the desolate road, dry on both sides.

Blacked was walking in silence when, near sunrise, he was startled by a sound coming from behind him. He looked at the source of the sound and saw a truck. He raised his hand in the air and made the truck driver notice him. The truck driver stopped right in front of him.

Blacked smiled at the man. And extended his hand towards him. The mist quickly flew out of his hand and stabbed him. Just as quickly, it returned to where it belonged. Blacked opened the driver's seat, grabbed the body by the collar and threw it down. He got into the truck and started driving.

After a long journey, he saw a city ahead. Just down the road. There were buildings of different heights. As he got closer to the city, he saw cars driving on the road. The road was not so deserted anymore. Cars drove past him, running on the guard. Blacked ignored the cars and drove towards the city.

When he reached a certain place, he stopped the truck and got out. He stepped onto the sidewalk and started walking. Even though it was early in the day, the city streets were crowded. People of all ages were trying to get somewhere. Some on bicycles, some in their cars, some on foot.

After a while he stopped in front of one of the tall buildings. He looked up and looked at the building. At the top was a broken, upside-down sword. It was the symbol of the company. Blacked entered through the revolving door. As the guard looked curiously at the pale-skinned, dark-eyed Blacked, Blacked nodded to the man. He kept walking. He took the elevator to one of the top floors of the building. When he got off the elevator, he walked forward and entered the first door he came across.

Inside, there was a man sitting behind a desk, his face scarred from head to toe. He was fiddling with the papers in front of him when the door opened and he looked up. When he saw that it was Blacked entering the room, he jumped to his feet.

“For God's sake, Blacked! You've been gone for days! For finding you, I sent men to... palace!” the man stopped. He looked at her with wide-open eyes. He had noticed her eyes. “Blacked... Jack you... Your eyes... my God! Your eyes! They're jet black!”

Blacked sighed and motioned for the man to sit down. As the man slowly sat back in his seat, Blacked approached him. He held his hands at the level of his chest and waited for the fog to flow between his fingers. Man watched in amazement as the book formed.

“You... Damn it, Jack, will you talk to me? What the fuck happened? You... What the hell have you become?” the man shouted. He didn't know what to do. Then his eyes went to the book in Blacked's hand.

“Is that Solomon's book? Did the book... Did the book do this to you? The power the book holds...”

“Calm down, Leo!” Blacked said in his dirty voice.

“I have good news for you. The powers in the book were given to those from whom they were taken. Those who bear the blood of the rebels and the guards. They just need time for everyone to understand. Now let's get down to business.” Said Blacked and sat down in one of the chairs in front of Leo. “We have the book. But the power that you, the rebels, have and the power that the book contains are completely different levels. Do you understand? The power you have is nothing compared to the power hidden in the book.

“But as I said at the beginning, I have good news for you. I know how to use the magic hidden in the book! But for that I need an army. There's only one place where I can unleash the power, and that's guarded by the Kingdom of Destiny's guards. To deal with those guards, I need my own army. You. But we can't go to war with the same nasty metals you're using, they are nothing but piece of shit. We need some metals from my world. Like... Like the weapons in the sorcerer's palace.

“When I get the power, I'll be able to shape the Kingdom of Destiny the way I want. And, you know... I will let you be a soldiers in the kingdom of mine if you are volunteering. You can be soldiers in the kingdom I will rule, Blacked frowned and looked at himself. He looked at his own body. “Actually, I'm getting bored with this body and we can run the kingdom together when I run it.”

“The Kingdom of Destiny?” Leo said in surprise. None of what he was hearing made any sense. He was trying to understand what Blacked was saying. “Your world? Blacked, are you out of your mind? What are you talking about?”

“Oh, mortal Leo. You are confusing me with someone else. The body may belong to Blacked, yes. But I am not him. No, no, no. I am Valefar, Lord of Darkness!”

CHAPTER TWENTY SIX

As sweet as it felt to sleep with the light wind whistling in through the window, the pounding on the door spoiled everything. Someone was banging her fists down incessantly. Rose's shouting was added to the sound that woke Nathaniel. "Nathaniel! It's almost noon! Come on, get up!"

"I'm awake, I'm awake." Nathaniel managed to grumble as he clambered out of the low bed. Rising, he went to the door and opened it. Rose was nowhere in sight. She must have come downstairs after waking him. Nathaniel went back into the room and looked at his messy hair in the mirror. He ran his fingers through his hair, awkwardly trying to give himself a little pull. He buttoned the few open collar buttons on his shirt and pulled his cloak over his back. He strapped his swords to his belt and confidently left the room.

Arthur saw Nathaniel coming down the stairs and started to speak.

"Now that Master Cooper is here, we can begin. Tomorrow there is a banquet in the kingdom to which all kings, lords, feudal

leaders and princes are invited. Richard's plan is to join with the other kingdoms and tear down the wall. Everyone will expand their borders and no one will have to fight each other.”

“Then we must prevent this meeting.” Nathaniel said, glaring at the innkeeper's variously laid table.

“Yes, but we can do more. We can save the true king and end this war.” Said Arthur, his voice growing louder with excitement.

“And how would we do that?”

“Kill the king with poison? I'm sure we could make some variation.”

“No matter how bad Richard as a king, Merlin, we can't kill him. Besides, those poisons tarnish gold in minutes. And the King's guests eat with gold pitchers and goblets. Poison attracts a lot of attention. But in any case, it's important how we stretch it inside.

“The guards of the kingdom must know me. There is already talk everywhere of dozens of gold coins to be paid to anyone who leads me to the king.” Arthur said and sighed, looking at Nathaniel, Rose and James in turn. “But they don't recognize you. You can go in freely. At least I can get you in. I'm sure Richard hasn't seen all the kings and lords. And since you are not recognized...”

“And we will be in disguise!” Nathaniel finished the sentence.

“Yes. So, who wants to go to the banquet?”

“How about sending two of us?” said James. “We can both go as different kings,” said James, looking at Nathaniel.

“Or one of you can go as king and one as guard. And that way, when the kings are meeting, the guard can go to the dungeon and get the king out.”

“Yes, that makes more sense.”

"I'm not sending you two alone." Rose said as she sat with her arms crossed.

"All right, then you'll go as the king's wife."

"Agreed."

"I think I'd better stay here and look at some books that might be useful to us." Said Scatt while he chopping the bread in his hand "There must be somewhere around here where I can find something about the Book of Solomon."

"Good, everyone..."

Someone fell through the double-winged door of the inn that suddenly opened. Or rather, he threw himself inside quickly. Everyone in the inn stood up with the man who entered. Some of them were looking at the fallen man with their hands on the sword at their waist. The man was gasping for breath. "Guards!" he shouted as he put his hands on the ground and tried to get up. "The guards are coming! Hurry!"

"Hurry!" Arthur said in rush and went behind the innkeeper's counter. The others were right behind him, following him. The innkeeper ran his hand along the edge of the shelf where he had stacked the beer kegs, and very quickly there was a click and the shelf moved forward a few inches. The innkeeper pulled the shelf towards him. The shelf opened into a completely empty room. There was no light, but it was no dirtier than the rest of the inn. Arthur and the others went inside.

One of the guards who had entered the inn sat in the chair Nathaniel had just left. His friends took the others' seats. They called the innkeeper and asked for a beer. When they finished, they asked for another. And another...

From behind the barrels, they opened the cellar door on the floor and went downstairs. As before, the soldiers continued their work in different groups, keeping their order. After standing where

they were for a while, Arthur ordered Alesia to find armor for Nathaniel. Alesia went off to fulfill the order and took Nathaniel with her. Arthur took James and Rose and walked quickly in a different direction. He brought them into a dark room. Only the light from the torches outside the room came in, illuminating part of the entrance. In one swift movement, Arthur went outside, grabbed one of the torches hanging on the wall and went back into the room. When he shone the light inside, the wooden nobles came into view. There were many hangers in the room, overflowing with different clothes. On either side were dressing cabinets with matte curtains. At the far end, opposite the door, was a large mirror.

“Now we have to find something suitable for you.” Said Arthur. “And James, we need to shave your beard.”

Alesia walked past the soldiers. When they saw her, they stopped their work for a moment and saluted her. Then they immediately picked up where they had left off. After walking for a while, Alesia led Nathaniel into a room that reminded him of the place where he had received his swords. It was full of swords and different pieces of armor.

“Here you can choose the armor you want. The soldiers can engrave the coat of arms of the kingdom we need on it.” Alesia said and left Nathaniel there to try on the armor. Nathaniel walked through the armor and looked at the chain mail. Then he looked at the torso, the armbands, and the helmets that he would put around the chainmail. He tried them all on in turn.

James found himself a black lord's suit. He showed the cloth with gold trim on it to Arthur and when he got his approval, he looked at it once more in the mirror with a smile on his face. Then Arthur handed him a razor blade to smooth his beard. James stared at the blade for a moment and then carefully began to trim his beard.

Rose showed the red dress she had chosen to Alesia, who had joined them later. When Alesia said she liked the dress, they left the wardrobe area for makeup and hairstyling.

At Arthur's choice, a metal crest was attached to the chest of the dress James had chosen. It was emblazoned with Lord Hugo's dragon, which wriggled and gurgled. Arthur took a few steps back after putting on the crest and looked at James. He squinted at him for a moment and then nodded his head in approval. Then he gave an order to one of the guards waiting outside the room to have the same coat of arms engraved on the armor of Headknight Nathaniel. The soldier hurried away to carry out the order.

Once the outfits were chosen, Arthur gathered Nathaniel, Rose and James together and one by one began to tell them what they needed to know. That the kingdoms were at peace, that the closest kingdoms to the center of the Kingdom of Destiny were the Desert kingdoms, that they were to portray Lord Hugo and Lady Isabella... As he was saying everything he could think of in the limited time he had, a guard came up to them. He bowed first and then began to speak.

"Sir, the carriage is ready." The guard said and Arthur stood up slowly and looked around. There was no sun in the torch-lit shelter. There were no windows. "Sir, the sun came up a few hours ago, the carriage is ready to leave."

"Very well," Arthur said, taking a deep breath and looking around the table. "I won't be able to help you after this, so be careful." One by one, everyone got up from the table and Arthur accompanied them to upstairs to the inn. Although Arthur and his soldiers never used it, a carriage stood just outside the double-winged entrance door of the inn. The carriage, decorated with ornaments, carved wood and embroidery, stood right in front of the door. The black and white horses in front of it were neighing and kicking up dust with their hooves.

As they emerged from the inn, the man standing beside the carriage immediately opened the door, letting James and Rose get in, and gesturing Nathaniel to the side of the reins. Nathaniel took his place in clanking armor. Just as the door on the side James and Rose got in was about to close, Arthur handed James an envelope.

“Your invitation, Lord Hugo.” Arthur said with a strained expression. “Good luck.” As Arthur closed the carriage door and stepped back, the man standing beside the carriage leaped onto it. He took the reins in his hand and swung them quickly. The neighing horses began to move slowly.

The carriage jerked forward. Outside, in front of the carriage, Nathaniel crossed his arms and watched the man swinging the reins. Inside, Rose and James sat opposite each other. James was running his hand over his shaved face as he looked at Rose, who was sitting across from him. Rose, who looked like a real princess in her red dress, was smiling at James' beardless form. They both came to their senses when the shaking in the carriage stopped with the sound of the horseshoes, which rapidly diminished and suddenly stopped. They were able to free their eyes from their gaze. They both turned their heads out of the carriage window. And the door opened. It was opened by one of the guards of the Kingdom of Destiny.

“May I see your coat of arms, sir?”

“Of course.” James said and handed the guard the metal coin, slightly larger than the gold coin with the swirling dragon on it, which he wore on the breast of his ornate black coat.

“And your invitation.” man said and handed the guard the stamped parchment Arthur had given him. Carefully and slowly, the guard looked over the paper and the writing on it. When he had finished squinting, he nodded. “Welcome to the Kingdom of Destiny, Lord Hugo and Lady Isabella.” The guard raised his hand and signaled to the guards in front of the door. The guards standing in front of the rusted bars that resembled the door of a large cage stepped aside, while those tasked with opening the door moved to the side. The rusty bars rose with a low creak, scattering dust. The horses moved again at the snap of the reins.

When the carriage stopped again, the man driving the horses immediately jumped down and opened the door of the carriage behind. Bending down, he stepped back. James got out of the carriage

with a broad smile on his face. Straightening his back, he looked at the palace in front of him. He stood in front of the two magnificent gates of the palace, surrounded by a huge green field. Then he turned and held out his hand to Rose, who was trying to get out of the carriage.

“My lady.” James said and helped Rose out of the carriage. Rose got out of the carriage slowly, careful of the skirt of her dress. She took James's arm. Nathaniel took James's other side, his double sword lying on either side of his waist. He crossed his arms and waited silently.

James raised one eyebrow and looked at Rose, who was walking right next to him, as they walked slowly towards the wide door of the palace. He was about to open his mouth when he heard the voice of the guard by the door.

“No weapons are allowed in the palace. The king has his orders. You must leave your weapons to enter.” James nodded and looked at Nathaniel standing to his left. The helmet on his face showed no features, no expression, no emotion of any kind. He could only be seen turning his head towards James. James nodded and Nathaniel put his hands on his belt. He unstrapped the weapons and handed them to the guards outside the door. James reached into the back of his jacket and pulled out a small knife. He placed it on top of Nathaniel's swords.

Some of the guards opened the gates while other guards went inside with them to guide the guests of the palace. Behind the creaking doors, there was a wide corridor. A few meters further on it split off in many different directions. Along the corridor, they saw a variety of shining armor at their sides. Most of them carried axes almost as long as the man's height. At intervals, various pictures were sewn on large banners hanging from the ceiling. Most were of black creatures with fangs and fangs and different body shapes and of brave knights swinging their swords at the creatures. Swords and axes hung in some gaps in the walls. Many of them were crossed in pairs.

Although to the guards it seemed like a normal sight, Rose, James, and Nathaniel stared at the decorations with fascination.

The guards led them to a large door with two wings. Slowly they opened both doors. Inside was more ornate than the corridor of the palace. It was wider and higher. Large windows on the right side of the room let in beams of light, giving the place a magical atmosphere. In the center of the room, a carpet stretched from the double doors to the opposite wall, just in front of the throne. On the throne sat King Richard the Younger.

“Welcome, I am King Richard, the new ruler of the Kingdom of Destiny!”

“Thank you for inviting us to your court, King Richard.” Said James and took a step forward. He bowed and did the introduction. “I am Lord Hugo. Lord of the island at the east. And my beautiful wife, Isabella.” As soon as James introduced her, Rose grabbed both sides of her skirts and curtsied awkwardly.

“Lord Hugo, Lady Isabella. You have just returned from your journey. You must be tired. My guards will escort you to your room. The meeting will be tomorrow evening. We expect all the kings to arrive. If there is anything you need, just let me know.”

“Thank you, King Richard.” James said, bowing slightly, and with the guards behind him they began to walk through the ornate corridors again. After a while and a few flights down the corridor, the guards led them to a row of rooms. They were shown which room they would be staying in and returned to their posts.

Most of the furniture in the room was made of wood that looked as if it had just been polished. A bright red blanket was draped over the bed. On the floor was a widely spread taupe-colored fur coat. There was a candle on each of the single-drawer nightstands on either side of the bed. Next to the candle on the left side was a large bottle. On either side of the ornate bottle were small goblets. On the other side of the room were two chairs. The chairs were right next to the

red curtains on either side of the window that opened to the deep blue sky.

James looked around the room for a few seconds, then took a few steps to the opposite side of the room. He put his hands on the corner of the window and looked out for a while.

"It's a great view here." He said and turned around and sat on one of the chairs. Rose took a few steps and sat on the bed.

Nathaniel waited outside the room until the guards were out of sight. As soon as the guards were out of sight, he opened the door and walked in.

"The guards have gone. I think it's time for a tour of the palace." Said Nathaniel. Looking at James and Rose in turn.

"Be careful. Try to be as inconspicuous as possible." Said James.

Nathaniel bowed slightly in a mocking curtsy. "Yes, my lord." He said and left the room.

Nathaniel walked past knightly armor in different poses. In every corridor he met someone else. It wasn't just knights. Paintings accompanied them. Most of them were paintings depicting different battles. On one wall there were kings from beginning to end. Some of them stood tall over the mutilated bodies of horrible creatures, while others looked as if they had been painted in the garden section of the palace with its most colorful flowers. As Nathaniel made his way to the end, he suddenly stopped. He looked at the painting of four men. One was very ashen compared to the others. Another had no expression on his face. One had a crown on his head. The fourth was Solomon with a shiny ring. The moment Nathaniel recognized him, he stood still for a moment. His heart began to race as he remembered what he had seen. His eyes widened. Forcing himself to look away from the painting. Blinking, he shook his head from side to side. "No, it won't happen. I won't let it." He said quietly and decided to occupy himself with his task as he breathed in and out deeply.

“Ian.” Rose called out. James slowly turned his gaze from the window to Rose. He looked at her with a small smile. “How do you know Blacked? He’s a descendant of the rebels. And if you know him, give me two possibilities. Either you are a descendant of the rebels like him. If that’s the case, it makes sense for the guards to capture you, but it doesn’t make sense for you to be facing Blacked. If you’re on different sides, you’re one of the good guys and you recognize Blacked because you’re on different sides. Which makes sense. He doesn’t seem to like you very much. So it doesn’t make sense for the Guardians to take you prisoner. Do you see my point?”

“Yes, but there’s a lot you don’t know,” James said and slowly got up and sat down next to Rose. He looked into her eyes with an even wider, wrenching smile. “Blacked is not descended from the rebels. No, he is not. He is a descendant of the Headknight. With the magic given to him, he can move various objects. But he has to mark them before he can move them. The items need to be sealed with the Headknight’s item.”

James continued with a sigh.

“As for the guards capturing me, they took me prisoner because I killed someone with a magical weapon, a sword, that I found after a long search. “

“Who did you kill?” Rose asked, averting her eyes.

James looked away and stared at the blank wall for a moment. He put his elbows on his knees, crossed his arms and stood there for a moment. “The first Headknight who joined the rebels.” “I killed Jack’s father,” James said.

Nathaniel turned left down the corridor and saw the two guards walking. He took a quick step back and put his back against the wall. He poked his head around the corner and looked at the

guards. The guards were walking towards the end of the corridor, talking. Nathaniel waited until they turned right at the end of the corridor. Then he continued on his way. When he reached the end of the corridor, he looked both ways. And he decided to go in the opposite direction of the guards.

As he passed through the corridor, he started to smell delicious scent. He followed the smell and found himself in the kitchen, next to the cooks in white aprons. Most of the cooks were short and chubby. Each was at a different pot. Nathaniel saw the source of the smells. It was coming from the big bones of meat on the tray. He took a step inside to take one of the meats, but was stopped by the sound of footsteps coming from across the hall. He changed his direction and disappeared into the corridors of the palace.

“I grew up with magic all my life, Rose. My father used to tell me stories. He said they really happened. And the Professor told me all the stories too. Sometimes my father would go out of town to do research. And when he was out of town, the professor took care of me. The documents we found are most likely my father's research when he was out of town.

“One day, when I came back from school, I saw that the door of the house was open. As soon as I got inside, I closed the door and walked with quick steps to my father's office. I was just happy that my father and I were going on vacation soon, but the office... when I entered the office, books were scattered around. Documents, files, small sculptures... It was a big mess. And in the middle of the mess... was my father's body. He was bleeding. Seeing him... seeing him like that...” James put his hands over his face and sniffled.

“When I run to my father, I saw three marks on him. Three knife marks. They weren't ordinary knives. The marks were from Blacked knives. When the professor explained everything to me, I made a promise: I would find whoever killed my father and avenge

them, but not in the normal way. Like they took my father's life. With magic." James said and couldn't hold back his tears any longer.

"Seeing his dead body... what I felt when I saw him..." James snorted. "I swore I would avenge him with a magical weapon, and if I didn't die in the process, I swore I would finish the research that led to my father's murder. Solomon's book." Rose wrapped her thin arms around him as James sniffled and wiped away his tears. As James was slowly recovering, there was a knock on the door of the room.

Rose took her arms away from James and hurried to the door. James wiped his eyes as she opened the door. It was Nathaniel. "I found out where the dungeons are!" he shouted cheerfully. After a stern look from Rose, he realized his mistake, lowered his voice and repeated the sentence. "I found out where the dungeons are, the only problem is there are guards at the gate. You need to make a scene at the dinner tomorrow. You have to distract the guards somehow. Can you gather them all in the dining room? Maybe... Maybe you can take the king prisoner. Or... I don't know. Find something. As soon as the guards are out of the sight of the dungeon, I'll go in and rescue the king."

"And how do you plan to find the king?" James gave a final sniff before turning to Nathaniel.

"Leave that to me." Nathaniel said confidently, raising his eyebrows. "Now..." Nathaniel said and paused for a moment. He gestured to the bottle next to the bed. Then he looked at Rose. "You can't drink on duty. Let me help you." Nathaniel said with a little smile and took a few steps to the bottle. He picked it up and left the room again. "I'm going. It's a bit conspicuous for a Guardian to be in the same room as a Lord and Lady."

"Be careful." James said, averting his gaze. And Nathaniel left the room.

Nathaniel closed the door to the room behind him and walked towards the gate that led to the palace garden. When he

reached the gate and noticed the guards looking at him suspiciously, he showed them the bottle he was holding in his hand. After taking a sip, he offered it to them. When the guards politely declined, Nathaniel shrugged, continued drinking and went out into the garden. As he walked through the garden, he reached for his belt. The metal flask on his belt. When he shook it, he saw that it was empty and poured the contents of the bottle into it. When he had filled his canteen sufficiently, he drank what was left in the bottle.

When Nathaniel opened his eyes, at first he could see nothing but two shadows standing in front of him. The sun was blinding him. As he slowly tried to sit up, his surroundings became clearer and clearer. Shadows were belongs James and Rose. Nathaniel looked around for a while, trying to understand what was happening. Without waiting, James took the bottle from Nathaniel's hand and reached out his other hand to help him up. Nathaniel yawned and stretched as he stood up and picked up his helmet from the floor.

"Nate, you need to be more careful! You're on a mission!" Rose scolded with a frown. Nathaniel looked at Rose for a moment as if he didn't understand, then turned to James.

"I'm going to look for a way into the dungeon, maybe the guards are moving around. Or maybe there's a back door. I don't know. You guys... You play your part." Said Nathaniel and stumbled on his first step towards the palace. James caught him just as he was about to fall. "Thank you, Hugo." Said Nathaniel and he broke free of James' hands and started walking. His first steps were unsteady, but he soon recovered.

"I think we can sit with the kings." James said.

"Good idea, my lord." Rose said sarcastically. They wandered around the lush garden of the palace for a while longer, seeing the various flowers, plants and trees. They examined the white statues in certain parts of the garden. After a few hours, they decided

to return to the palace. They went to the room where the kings and lords came one by one, the room reserved for the guests of the palace. When they entered, only certain chairs around the long table were occupied. Together they greeted the kings and queens, the lords and ladies, each and every one of the nobles and took their places at the table.

In the evening, all the guests had come to the king's dining room. The chairs on either side of the long table were almost full. Only two chairs were empty. And at that moment two men entered through the creaking double doors. Their clothes were very similar. They were both wearing clothes made of animal skins. Compared to the kings and lords sitting at the table, they stood out from everyone else in the room. They were both middle-aged. One of them, the larger one, was always sulking. The other was more cheerful. The crown of the cheerful one was larger and more ostentatious. It was studded with diamonds that didn't match the clothes he was wearing. The other had a thin crown on his head. A crown of gold with curves resembling a crown of thorns. As the man with the big crown sat down at the table, he looked at James, who was standing right across from him. "Hello, you..." he squinted and waited for a while, looking James's coat of arms then said, "You must be Lord Hugo." He said and extended his hand. James shook his hand and the man said, "I am King Augustine. My uncle could not come here because of his illness, so he sent my sullen cousin Prince Alden in his place. We represent two different kingdoms of the desert kingdoms."

"King Augustine, Prince Alden." James greeted, ignoring the anger in Alden's gaze.

Augustine stepped toward James to speak and was about to open his mouth when the king began to tap his golden goblet with his golden fork. Augustine changed his mind and sat back. The other kings and lords, like Augustin, put aside their speeches, their stories and their policies and listened intently to the king.

"Kings and queens, ladies and lords, feudal lords and princes, all of you welcome! I have summoned you to my kingdom

today for a great purpose. I have summoned you to do what should have been done centuries ago for the good of all kingdoms! To break down the wall and declare war. I want to unite all armies, great and small, and tear down the walls!"

The people at the table began to whisper among themselves. The king ignored the whispering and continued his speech.

"If we stand together, we can take back the lands that used to belong to our ancestors! We can expand our kingdoms, strengthen and enrich them! And all the while we can destroy the greatest threat in our world, those damned creatures! All I need is your army! Together we can tear down the wall and triumph over the creatures! Humans can rule the world again! We can rule the world!"

"But it would mean a great loss! Our soldi... We'll have to bury a lot of dead for a land. If we succeed! If we fail, all mankind will be wiped off the face of the earth." Said a king with a chubby beard. He looked around in alarm. Sweat poured down his forehead and he straightened the crown on his white hair.

"Don't worry, as I said, if we are united, we can defeat them. They are a bunch of mindless creatures. We can defeat them. Most of my armies are on their way. They are going to war. And with or without you, I will make my kingdom greater. King Miles? What do you say? You are the closest kingdom to the wall, and your kingdom's territory will increase as a whole."

"I agree with you, King Richard." Said King Miles in his polite accent.

"And what about you, King Raymond of Rowan?"

"A little land is never a bad thing. Besides, those creatures have been in this world longer than they should." Said Reymond, thick voiced, wearing a king's suit that resembled armor. His long brown beard almost touched the table.

“And what about you, Alden, Prince of the Desert. What would your father say about this?”

“My father stands with you, King Richard.” Alden said, frowning.

“And what about you, King Augustin? Aren't you tired of the deserts?”

“No.” Augustine replied with a small smile. He turned his head to both sides and looked at the kings. For a few seconds there was dead silence. Now everyone took their gaze away from King Richard and looked at Augustine with great astonishment.

“Excuse me? But your kingdom is located in arid lands! Wouldn't you like to have green lands? Beautiful land surrounded by trees and plants. With the peaceful sounds of deep blue streams and waterfalls?”

“As you all know, I built my kingdom myself and I don't have much of a problem with its location. Of course, if it were built on greenery we could live much more comfortably, but greenery means nothing if there are no people to live on it. I'm sorry, King Richard, but I cannot risk the lives of my men just because you say we will succeed. Unless, of course, you're determined to keep going. If I see you start to win, I will join you.”

Richar tried to hide his anger and sat back down, crossing his arms twice. “I ask you to reconsider your ideas by the end of the meal and you will soon see how right I am.”

A few servants came in with golden trays and began to distribute the food. Some were tasked with placing the food on the table, others with distributing soup to all the guests. When all the plates were placed, King Richard gestured with his hand. “Here you are. Enjoy your meal.” He said without taking his threatening gaze from Augustine.

"You have sent most of your army, haven't you? Isn't that too risky?" One of the kings asked.

Before Richard could take his first sip, he put the spoon back in the bowl. And he thought for a moment. "I don't think there's any threat to fear, of course," He pointed to Augustine and his cousin Alden. "Unless the nearby kingdoms declare war on me," he said, smiling. And he took the spoon back. Something caught James's attention. Half the spoon was shining, and the other half was black. As Richard brought the spoon to his mouth, James grabbed the second spoon, which he didn't even know what he was going to use it for, that was next to his own plate and threw it at Richard. Richard blushed furiously as James' spoon hit his and clinked on the floor, and the soup spilled on him made him even angrier. His chair tipped back as he sat up quickly. "Stop!" James shouted "Don't eat! They're poisonous!"

The kings, who had already swallowed several spoonfuls of soup, spat out whatever was in their mouths. The guards slowed down. King Richard was looking curiously at James. One of the staff began to take a step backwards. Seeing the pace quicken, James picked up one of the knives and threw it quickly. As the maid's dress was nailed to the wall, the Guards went to her. The woman had already torn where the knife had stabbed her, but she could not escape the guards.

"Your spoon, King Richard, got black. Poison made from a plant found on the island where I come from has the same effect on gold."

Richard angrily went to the servant. Guards held her tightly with both arms.

"Give me a name! Who do you serve?" Richard shouted, leaving her speechless. She was trembling with fear. "I said, who do you work for? The rebels?"

“Alden, actually.” Corrected James. “Everyone turned their gaze to James in great surprise. “As you can see, only two spoons are blackened, yours and King Augustine's. I don't know what he will gain if he kills you, but there is great competition between him and Augustine. He probably wants to rule the whole desert. Maybe he'll fight his way to the kingdom of destiny. After all, you have sent most of your men.”

Snorting angrily, Alden jumped across the table, knife in hand. James sat up and pulled his chair back as far as he could. But he couldn't get away fast enough. The big man, Alden, collapsed on top of him. James groaned in pain as his back hit the floor. He threw a clumsy punch at Alden, who was standing over him. The punch did nothing but turn Alden's head to the side and make him angrier. Alden, now even more enraged, held a dinner knife to James's throat.

“You bastard...” he was cut off by the cool sensation on his neck. Rose held another knife to Alden's neck.

“You have one chance to back off.” Rose said through clenched teeth.

Alden stayed where he was for a while. And by the time he had time to think, the guards had already arrived. They grabbed him by both arms before he could move. As they lifted him off James, Alden began shouting swears to Lord Hugo, King Richard, the Kingdom of Destiny, Solomon the Sorcerer... As the guards dragged him away, Alden kept coming up with new swear words.

“Ia... Hugo are you all right?” Rose said as she exhaled deeply, having corrected her mistake at the last moment.

“Don't worry m'lady, I'm fine.” Said James trying to smile. Rose held out her hand to help James up. James stood up and looked into Rose's eyes. “I'm fine, thanks to you.”

Nathaniel wandered around the palace. He was looking for other ways to get into the cell. Anything. So far, he hadn't found it. And then he heard voices coming from the side corridor. He turned his head in the direction of the sound. Two guards were dragging a man away by his arms. The man was struggling to break free of the guards, swearing that he would destroy the palace, that he would kill the king. Nathaniel laughed and leaned against the wall, choosing not to be seen by the guards. He followed the guards, keeping enough distance between them. He stood to the side and watched them until each corridor turned, and as they turned, he moved to the corner of the wall where he could see the corridor they were in.

As he had expected, the guards were on their way to the dungeon. When the guards in front of the huge iron gate, surprised to see Prince Alden being dragged away, they did their duty and opened the gate. They allowed the guards to let in Alden, who was shouting obscenities. Soon the guards left and started walking towards Nathaniel. Nathaniel quickly turned back the way he had come. He moved quickly through the same corridors.

The guards outside the door to the dining hall allowed Lord Hugo's guard to enter. When Nathaniel entered, he saw all the kings standing. Some were shouting, others were sighing.

"How can such a thing happen, King Richard! You want me to follow a man who doesn't even know what is going on in his own kingdom!" shouted a king in long robes, banging his hand on the table.

"I agree with Lord Hank, this is unacceptable!"

"I came here out of respect for your father, but you have nothing of him!"

"Lords and kings, queens and ladies of the realm, please forgive me. This should not have happened, and I apologize. Please... Please give me one more day. I believe that during this time those who don't want to join our union will change their minds. We will talk

about it at breakfast in the morning tomorrow and I assure you that I will make up for all the unpleasantness that happened today. I just ask you to give me one more day. I will personally control tomorrow's foods."

The protesting voices of the kings grew fainter and fainter and finally the kings fell silent. No one objected. Then James saw Nathaniel coming in. "Excuse me, King Richard." James said, and he nodded and curtsied and joined Nathaniel waiting at the entrance to the room. Together they walked out of the room. They were just far enough away that the guards outside the door could not hear them.

"There are guards outside the dungeon." Nathaniel said without taking his eyes off the guards at the door. "We can get in by killing them, but the castle is full of guards. If we are discovered, there will be no escape." He stopped whispering briefly and looked around again "Another way is to become a criminal. They brought a big man to the dungeon today. We too can commit a crime to be sent to these dungeons. It's nothing we haven't done before. But that would make our job harder. After all, we'd have to escape from the cells."

"I have the king's trust." Said James, puffing out his chest and smiling. Like Nathaniel, he whispered, "Maybe in a few days I can find a way into the dungeon. Or Augustine could help us. I'm sure he'd be glad to see the real king on the throne."

"Augustine? Who is he?"

"One of the kings."

"Damn it, James, what happened while I was gone?" Nathaniel whispered and realized his mistake too late. He looked around to make sure no one had heard him. The guards were holding their old positions. They hadn't heard. As Nathaniel let out a deep sigh, the doors to the room opened. King Richard came out.

"I'll tell you everything later." James whispered and patted Nathaniel on the shoulder. "But you must go now."

"As you wish, Lord Hugo!" Nathaniel said loudly and pounded his fist against his chest.

"Lord Hugo, may I have a word with you?" said King Richard as he took a few steps towards them. For a while he kept an eye on Nathaniel, who was moving quickly down the corridor. But Nathaniel quickly turned at the first parting and disappeared from sight.

"Of course, King Richard."

"I want to thank you, Lord Hugo. You saved my life. If there's anything you need from me, don't hesitate to ask. I am in your debt." Said King Richard.

"The Kingdom of Destiny is no ordinary kingdom, and you know that, sir. This is where it all began. This is where Solomon started it all. And you... You are the ruler of this great kingdom. I mean, I would be honored to serve the King of Destiny."

"Thank you, Lord Hugo. I must leave now to make up for the canceled dinner, but I will see you again as soon as I can."

"Of course, you are a busy king." Said James. Richard smiled back and walked quickly away from James. James entered the room and took Rose's arm. Wishing Augustine well, they left the room and went to their own rooms. James looked out onto the balcony for a while. He breathed in and out deeply with the gentle breeze. For a while he watched the stars, the moon and the small fires that some people lit, illuminating the darkness of the night. Then, as he had done the day before, he fell asleep on the sofa and left the bed to Rose.

Early in the next morning there was a knock at Lord Hugo's door. James opened the door to find King Richard standing there. "King Richard, you need something?" he asked, raising one eyebrow.

“Would you care to join me in the garden, Lord Hugo? There are a few things I would like to discuss with you.”

“Of course.” James said and closed the door quietly behind him and walked with the king through the corridors of the palace. All the guards they met along the corridor greeted the king. As long as they were inside the palace, the king said nothing. When he went outside, he did not speak for a while and enjoyed the fresh air. James accompanied him without breaking the silence.

“Lord Hugo, what are your views on the attack on the wall?”

“My army is but a handful of soldiers compared to yours or any other King's army, Sir, but if my men want to fight, to claim new lands, I am with you, not to mention the honor of fighting on your side.”

“If your soldiers refuse, I think we can tempt them with some gold. If so, I am willing to pay a high price.”

“I like that offer, King Richard. And thank you very much for your generous offer. I am sure my soldiers will not be able to say no.”

“That is good news. We need to gather as many men as we can. I'll be expecting you for breakfast in an hour, Lord Hugo. I will try to make you forget yesterday's unfortunate dinner, and I assure you, Lord Hugo, you will never face such trouble in this kingdom again.”

“I,” James said, his gaze far away. “I'm just the lord of a castle. There's no problem for me, but I can't say the same for Kings. Especially King Augustine.”

“I suppose you are right, Lord Hugo. But I am sure King Augustine will see the good in my cause and support me.”

“I hope so, King Richard. I hope so.”

All the kings, lords, and other guests were lined up around the table, waiting hungrily. Some were talking about yesterday's events; others were enthusiastically telling tales of heroic deeds. The latter was mostly done by the older, fatter kings.

At King Richard's insistence, James sat right next to the King and looked at all the kings and lords. One by one he looked at their faces and listened to their stories. And at that moment, new servants were coming in and serving the table. James' eyes fell on one of them. He did not recognize the servant at first. Then he realized who the man was. He was the owner of the first inn they entered into the kingdom. The king must have hired the innkeepers for a day. James sighed and tried to cover his face with his hand on the table. He turned his head to Rose, who was sitting next to him and pointed to the innkeeper. Rose looked where James was pointing for a while. When she saw the innkeeper, her eyes widened, and she bowed her head.

At that moment King Richard stood up. And the whole hall instantly fell silent. They turned their gaze to the king.

"I apologize to you all for the unfortunate incident yesterday. Especially to King Augustine. I assure you that nothing like this will ever happen again. As King of the Kingdom of Destiny, I say it will never happen again!"

"You don't need to apologize to me." Said Augustine, "I apologize to you for what my Idiot cousin did. And I understand if you do not want to return him to my uncle. And the death penalty."

"We will talk to your uncle and decide on that punishment. Finally, I would like to thank Lord Hugo for saving my life and that of my guest. Please stand up, Lord Hugo. What you did was a great heroic act."

"Actually, I'm fine."

"I insist." The King kept insisting,

“Shit!” James said quietly, turning to Rose sitting next to him. And he stood up.

“Lord Hugo, I would like to say that you...”

“My Lords who is as hungry as wolves?” James interrupted the king. As the lords and kings at the table laughed, James continued, “Just like the other guests. With all due respect to King Richard, sir, everyone saw what I did, and I never thought in my life that I would have your friendship but now I am sitting right next to you and I thank you for everything. Now if you'll excuse me, I'd like to get back to breakfast.” Said James. He spoke rapidly, without breathing.

“Of course, please enjoy your meal.” Said King Richard. Without waiting for King Richard, James quickly sat down and took his seat, exhaling deeply. Without taking his eyes off the innkeeper, he began to eat.

“Did you changed your mind, King Augustine?” asked King Richard. He sat down and folded his hands on the table.

“As I said before, it won't do me much good to have more beautiful land without people to live on it. But don't worry. As soon as I get back to my kingdom, I will ask my people what they think about this. If they want to get out of the deserts and are willing to die trying, I can support you.”

“I think I will stand behind the King of Destiny.” Said one of the Kings. And everyone took turns expressing their opinion. There was no one who would not join. Some agreed to fight. Others wanted more time. As they ate, they continued their usual conversation. Some tried to convince the unconvinced people, while others continued with their unfinished stories. Rose and James were eating their breakfast, relieved that the innkeeper had left the room.

One by one, the kings finished their breakfast. Some ate a few pieces graciously and finished their breakfast, while others ate as if they were never full. But finally, when all the plates were empty, they too had to stop. When all the guests had finished their breakfast,

the servants slowly began to clear away the dirt from the table. The kings continued their conversation, ignoring the hands that were being passed over their heads.

King Richard asked James about the Barghests on the island and James tried to tell the king as much as he knew, as much as he had heard from Merlin.

“Yes, those damned creatures stare at you at night. It's like they want you to attack. They want to strike back. The best thing is to pass them quietly and carefully. Stay as far away from them as possible. They don't avoid you, though. And... and sometimes you have to attack.”

“Have you, Lord Hugo, ever attacked one of the Barghests?”

“Yes.” James said in a calm voice. “I had to cut down a few of them. Otherwise, someone else would have attacked them and the Barghests would have come after her. I had to draw them to me. Then, of course, I don't want to admit it, but I ran away. They were coming from all sides of the forest. They just jumped in front of me!” said James. He said the last sentence aloud. The more James saw the wonder in King Richard's eyes, the more he enjoyed telling stories. Now he understood better why the kings at the table made up stories. With a small smile, he continued. “But to escape from them...”

“Rebels!” the innkeeper shouted, pointing at James. Everyone was petrified. Everyone was looking at the innkeeper. James, who had lost his focus on hiding himself from the innkeeper because of his stories, cursed silently. “I wasn't sure at first, but he shaved his beard! I wasn't sure until I saw the woman with him, but now, I'm sure! This man and the woman with him are rebels!”

“Damn it!” James said again hoarsely and stood up, throwing his chair back. “King Richard, what the hell is this? I'm coming here at your invitation! I'm coming here to ally with you! I just saved your life! But I can't believe there is still such nonsense in your palace! As Lord Hugo of Radland, I cannot accept such slander!”

I want that damned innkeeper executed!” James shouted angrily and realized his mistake as he uttered the words. Inhaling and exhaling rapidly, he looked at King Richard and then at the innkeeper. He looked. “You’re not going to do anything! You’re letting him slander me!” James was getting more and more agitated. Not a sound came from anyone.

“Lord Hugo,” King Richard said. Calmly. “How do you know this servant is the innkeeper?”

James paused briefly. He was not the only one to realize his mistake.

“Look at him! That dirty apron, that big belly and that stubble! It can’t belong to a servant!”

“Please take your seat, Lord Hugo. I know what the innkeeper says is slander, or rather I want to believe it is, but I must be sure. The liar will be executed.”

James threw himself helplessly into the chair and took a deep breath. “Spare the innkeeper. After all, he must have mistaken me for someone else. If he apologizes to me and admits his mistake, I can forgive him.”

King Richard turned his gaze to the innkeeper. Sweat began to pour down the innkeeper’s forehead.

“That is for me to decide, Lord Hugo.” King Richard said. James nodded his head in agreement. “Now tell me, innkeeper, when did you see this man?”

“Three or four days ago. They were looking for the rebel’s he... they were searching Arthur. In fact, Arthur’s brother was with them. So, I called the guards, the two guards who came to my inn when I was off duty.”

“And do you know their names?”

“Yes, my king. Hendrix and rufus.”

The king motioned to one of the guards in the back. "Bring me Rufus and Hendrix." He spoke. The guard ran off to do his duty.

No one made a sound. They were silently waiting for the guards to arrive. Everyone was curiously looking at the door. They wait for a long time. It was longer for James and Rose. And finally, the expected happened. Three guards came in. James put his hands on the table and prepared to get up.

The two newly arrived guards bowed to the King with their fists on their chests and bowed their heads. "My King, you wanted to see us." He said without lifting his gaze from the floor.

"Have you chased any rebels in the last three or four days, soldier?"

The question seemed very strange to the guard.

"Well... Yes, sir, they even escaped over the rooftops."

"And have you seen that man and that woman before?" King Richard asked, gesturing with one hand towards James and Rose.

The guard raised his helmeted head and looked where King Richard was pointing angrily. If it wasn't for his helmet, all the kings would have seen his eyes widen in surprise.

"Sir... the man shaved his beard. And the woman... Yes, it's definitely them!"

James cursed. He and Rose threw back their chairs and stood up. They ran towards the exit. But as they reached the door, the guards drew their swords and pointed them at them. Rose and James raised their hands in the air as the other guards came up behind and grabbed them.

"Lord Hugo..."

“That's just the name of an asshole Ruler!” said James with real anger. “I am Ian James Fate! I'm one of the fighters who put an end to Hugo's tyranny!”

“Take these damned rebels away! And tomorrow, gather all the people in the town square! This bastard man will be executed! I'll do it with my own hands! Now take these rebels away!” Richard shouted in anger. His hands were shaking with rage. As the guards forced James and Rose out of the room, the King turned back to the table. He was breathing angrily.

“Are you sure they are rebels, King Richard? Because usually Kings don't allow rebels to sit with them at important dinners. And also, don't think that rebels gonna prevent the assassin who try to take the life of the king's himself” Said Augustine and stood up. And he left the room with heavy steps. King Richard angrily threw down the few plates and goblets left on the table with a loud shout. He put his hands on the table. He took deep breaths and closed his eyes.

“I'm sorry.” Richard said, trying to calm down and pulled out his chair and sat down. “Where were we?”

Nathaniel was about to turn left when he saw four guards and his back pressed against the wall next to the hollow armor. The guards had grabbed two of them, but Nathaniel couldn't see who they were. When the guards continued straight ahead, Nate poked his head out from the side of the wall. He saw James and Rose. Sighing, he put his hand over his face. Then he took his hand away from his face and turned around. He wished he had his gauntlet with him. He closed his eyes tightly and breathed in and out slowly. He didn't know if James and Rose had been caught on purpose, but he knew where they were going. At least where they were being taken. And he knew the other corridors that led to it. He took a quick deep breath and started to run.

His armor clanged as he ran. He turned quickly through the corridors. He had to stop abruptly when he suddenly saw the armored man in front of him. The metal fingers of the armor gripped the handle of a huge axe. He was standing straight in front of Nathaniel.

“Well, uh...”

Nathaniel narrowed his eyes and looked at the empty armor. “Damn it!” he said and kept running past the ornately placed armor.

Running, he made it to the front of the dungeon before the guards. He was out of breath, but he had arrived. He poked his head over the edge as usual. He watched James and Rose for a while. Finally, his eyes met with James’ James shook his head from side to side with a grimace. Nathaniel caught the look immediately. “Don't do anything stupid.” He knew exactly what he meant. And he stepped back. First a few heavy steps, then more. As he turned and started to run, he was sure he wasn't going to listen to James.

They led James and Rose into one of the dark cells. There was nothing to illuminate it except the low sunlight coming in through a few barred windows. Candles hung on parts of the wall, but they were not lit. There were not many people inside the dungeon. But James knew one of them. Alden was trying to grab James through the bars with his arms outstretched. And cursing as he did so. The guards put James and Rose in a dungeon away from Alden. They closed the door hard and left the dungeon.

“That's great! Now what do we do?”

James reached into his jacket sleeve and produced a gold dinner knife from the table. He inserted it into the keyhole of the cell and began to turn it.

“Now I've been thinking.” James said after fiddling with the lock for a while, “I wish I had attacked the guards with this knife, because the damn lock won't open!” James said angrily and heard the

creaky door of the dungeon open. He quickly tucked the knife into his jacket. They were expecting a guard to enter, but it was Augustine.

"I am grateful to you gentlemen." He said to the guards. "It will be quick. Just few words with my idiot cousin." The guards nodded again and let King Augustine in. They closed and locked the doors behind him.

"I have nothing to say to you! Don't expect me to apologize!"

"I didn't come here for you, cousin. I came to see the man who saved my life." Augustine said and walked past his cousin's cell without even looking at him, going through it one by one, looking for James. When he found him, he entered the empty cell next to him and sat on the floor with a sigh.

"I don't care who you are. A lord or a rebel. You saved my life, and I am grateful. I owe you my life. I don't know how to thank you."

"I don't think you can get me out of here until tomorrow." James said, trying to smile.

"I think I supposed to have to declare war to save you."

"And I know you are not gonna do something stupid like this."

"I'm sorry, but you're right. Again, thank you. I have to go now." Said Augustine and stood up. "Soon the kings will sit at the table again. I need to protect my army from this war. I can't lead my armies into a losing battle with great ambition. I hope you can find a way out of here. Thank you for what you have done."

"Augustine." James nodded.

"My friend in the guise of Lord Hugo." The King bowed and rose from the dust-covered floor. He left the dimly lit dungeon.

Nathaniel was trying to figure out how to get out of the palace. The palace was full of guards. He couldn't kill them all and he had to get out of the palace. He had to alert the rebels and bring reinforcements. As he moved quickly down the corridor, he stopped. He looked at the knight's armor standing tall in front of the corridor. Then the shiny shield he held in his hand. After a moment's thought, he pulled the shield away. Smiling, he looked at the triangular shield. He looked at his reflection in the shiny shield. Then he turned the shield over and slipped his hand into the shield's belt. He tightened it until he felt the tension in his arm. With his back to the wall, he took careful steps forward. He was heading towards the exit of the palace.

As soon as he saw the soldiers in shining armor coming his way, he immediately changed direction. He entered another corridor. And the next time he saw a new guard, he entered another corridor. He finally made it to the hall with the exit door, albeit with a long way to go. He was about to take a few steps back to avoid being seen by the guards when a voice behind him shouted, "Hey you!" Nathaniel looked over his shoulder and saw the guards coming fast behind him. "Stay where you are, rebel! You are under arrest by order of the king!" the guard shouted. Nathaniel cursed and looked at the guards behind him and the guards standing in front of the door. And he started to run towards the door.

The guards thrust their axes, the tip of which resembled the tip of a spear, at Nathaniel as he came towards them. The guards behind them were coming, their swords unsheathed. Nathaniel slowed his steps. And he stood in front of the axes pointed at him.

"I suppose I have no choice but to surrender, do I?" he said, smiling from under his helmet. As the men behind him slowed their steps and the men in front breathed a deep sigh of relief, Nathaniel did not wait for an answer, but struck the long-handled axes pointed at him with his shield and pushed them aside. Stepping forward, he ducked under one of the men and struck the guard in the face with the metal shield. He quickly ducked and dodged the sword that swept

over him and hit the guard holding the sword in the stomach with the pointed end of the shield. He struck with all his strength at the part, which was covered by a chain, not covered by the metal armor. As shards of chain flew everywhere, Nathaniel stood up without waiting and pushed open one of the doors. He stepped out with great happiness and excitement. But he expected there to be guards outside. At least he didn't expect twelve guards to be standing in the doorway pointing their weapons at him. All twelve guards were pointing their axes at Nathaniel. Four guards came through the door he opened. Two with axes and two with swords.

"Put the shield down!" shouted one of the guards. Nathaniel thought for a while. He looked around him. Sixteen soldiers surrounded him. With a sigh, he loosened the shield's belt and stretched out his hand, reaching for the ground. He let the shield slip from his arm. As the shield clattered and shook on the ground, two guards with swords came up behind Nathaniel. One of them put his sword to his neck while the other struck the back of Nathaniel's knee, causing him to fall to the ground. Then they tied his hands tightly.

The sunlight filtered through the metal bars and illuminated the dungeon, gradually turning it red. For a long time, all that could be heard inside was the low clang of metal echoing and James's voice shouting curses. James had not immediately given up on the golden knife. But his faith didn't last long either. Eventually he saw that the knife was useless and stepped aside.

The dungeon door creaked open again and three armored men came in. One of them had his hands tied. He was being dragged by his arms and dragged towards the cell where James and Rose were. When they reached the front of the cell, they dragged Nathaniel and threw him into the cell. When Nathaniel's hands were untied, he found a place to sit in the cell and took his helmet off his head, threw it to the side.

"Do you know how hard it is to breathe in this thing? And more importantly," Nathaniel continued, changing his tone completely, "we lost. Twice."

“You sound like a dead man!”

“Could it be because we are gonna rotten in here?” shouted Nathaniel.

“They're going to execute us. Do you know what that means?” said James calmly.

“We'll be hanged or they'll put an axe around our necks and chop our heads off.”

James sighed.

“Yes, that too, but more importantly it will be public. Arthur and the others might come to our rescue. If we don't survive, we're still not lost. There are still people on our side. Even if it's just one person, it means the fight is continuing.”

“If I'm going to die,” Nathaniel sighed as he pulled his canteen from his belt, “I want to have my last drink with my friends.”

Nathaniel took a sip from the flask and handed it to James. James nodded his thanks, took a sip and handed it to Rose. Rose took a drink and handed it to Nathaniel. The flask spun in each of their hands in turn. They got used to spending the night drinking in small sips and chatting. But the flask was small for three people, and it was soon empty. Throughout the night they tried to chat and somehow cheer themselves up. But they couldn't manage more than bitter smiles. Finally, at sunrise, the dungeon door creaked open.

“Here we go,” Nathaniel sighed. He lifted his flask and turned it upside down. Closing one eye, he looked into the flask. When he was sure the flask was empty, he put the lid on and fastened it to his belt. The metal clanking of the guards' armor could be heard throughout the corridor and was getting closer. The three of them looked at each other. They kept looking at each other anxiously until the guards arrived. Finally, the guards came to the door. They unlocked it and tied those inside tightly. They led the three of them

out of the dungeon. As they walked past Alden, Alden was smiling and watching James on his way to execution.

When they left the palace, a group of guards surrounded the prisoners and started walking with them. At first there weren't many people around, but those being led to execution attracted the attention of everyone walking down the street and they started to follow them. The following group was getting more and more crowded. After walking through the streets of the city for a while, they came to the city square.

There were three logs like a stamp standing on the wide floor high above the ground. And they immediately proceeded in a single file up the steps leading to that height. Two guards led Rose up the steps and stopped her in front of a log, ignoring the murmur of the crowd that was slowly starting to gather. James and Nathaniel continued. James was the second to stop. He, like Rose, was standing in front of a stump. And Nathaniel stood in front of the third log.

Rose knelt in front of the log and laid her head on it. Then James did the same. Nathaniel, who was struggling, was brought to his knees by the guards behind him, who hit him on the back of the knee. Then they pressed his shoulders and laid his head on the log.

The crowd gathered to watch the execution of the rebels grew louder and louder. Their whispers among themselves turned to shouts. Until King Richard arrived. The moment the king ascended the steps, silence fell. It was the silence of death. The people were afraid of their king.

"These rebels you see have entered my palace! They called themselves lords and tried to get close to me! They followed Arthur, the head of rebellions! They followed his orders! But they were not good enough. They just act like little mice. Just like the other rebels." The King shouted, spewing all his anger. He walked behind the prisoners and came to Jaems. "They made me trust them! They tricked me by making deals with other kings! But it didn't work. What they did was exposed!

"I'll show you myself the end of the rebels, how you will end up if you join them! Bring the sword!" Shouting angrily, the King looked at the guards coming up the stairs on the other side. One of them was holding a long, thin wooden box with runic engravings. When they arrived in front of the king, they each got down on one knee and bowed to the king, then one of them handed him the wooden box. The king unlocked the locks on both sides of the box. His eyes shone with anger as he threw back the lid. After opening the cover on both sides, he smiled and ran his hand over the sword. He touched his finger to the leather on the hilt. Then he brought it up and felt the coldness of the metal. He gripped the hilt firmly and lifted it into the air. He held it so that all the onlookers could see it clearly. The whole crowd was looking at the sword with the runes on it. No one made a sound. Not even a peep. "I will behead the rebels with the Sword of Destiny!" King Richard said as he looked at his people with a terrible smile.

"It was brought by Headguard Hadrick for like two years ago or less. This is the sword of Solomon. Also, the sword of Arthur, the legend I had named after." Arthur whispered from under the hood covering his face.

"Excalibur." Said Scat, the sword's second name. He was cloaked like Arthur.

"We must save them!" said Merlin. He put one hand to the quiver strapped to his leg.

"There are too many of them." Arthur whispered and put one hand in front of Merlin. "If we attack, we probably won't make it out alive. Even if we do, we'll have killed soldiers who could have protected the pillars. In both ways. I'm sorry, Merlin, but we can't."

"Fine, but they couldn't save Hendry! How do we lead the army into battle?"

“By reinstating me in exchange for throwing the scroll into the fire. The one given by king himself. We can also tell the king about the book and the power it will bring and make him accept the war. That's my second plan.”

King Richard bowed next to James. “You and I could be friends if you were really a Lord! And if the saving my life part wasn't a fucking trick!”

“You probably won't believe it, but I really did save you from death.” James said quietly.

“I've had enough of your lies!” shouted King Richard and straightened his posture. He raised the sword slowly and brought it down with all his might.

CHAPTER TWENTY SEVEN

As the sun set, Solomon stopped his horse and turned it around. He took a deep breath. "Let's stay here tonight. We are setting up the camp here." He said and dismounted. Seeing the new king dismount, all the horsemen dismounted too. One of them was the head of the guard. He was shouting the order of the guard to his soldiers. The others were already pitching their tents.

They traveled for a long time. They walked through wide plains and climbed mountains. They passed through dense forests with trees like pillars. Sometimes they would stop, hunt in case they needed food for the night, then either stay there for the day or continue for a few hours.

On one of the days when the sun no longer made them sweat, as they passed by the sea, Solomon noticed a stranded ship. It was a ship he had seen before. Solomon ground his teeth together in great anger. He tugged at the reins of his horse and it reared up and neighed. When his front hooves touched the ground again, Solomon rode up to the head of the guard.

“Your Highness?” The guard saluted.

“Commander, do you see that ship over there? That ship belongs to the one who killed my father and most of our guards who opened with him.”

“I hope you won't order us to move on, sir, especially when we may avenge the king's death.”

“Prepare a troop. I'll order the people to move on. Then we will go to avenge ourselves.”

“Yes, Sir!” the guard said enthusiastically. And Solomon rode his horse to Naama's side this time.

“My queen, continue ride on with our people. I and a group of our soldiers have a job to do.”

“What are you talking about, Solomon?” asked Naama. Fearfully and curiously.

“We need to have a chat with the owner of that ship.”

“With your swords?”

Solomon sighed.

“Most likely.”

“All right, you can go. But remember! If you die, I will kill you!”

“Don't worry, my Queen. Don't worry.”

Solomon rode his horse to the guards waiting behind. He rode up to their commander, who stood at the front.

“Sire, our soldiers are all ready. They will attack at your command!”

“Good.” Solomon looked at his army for a moment. “Attack!” he said calmly.

The sound of hooves pounding on the floor woke many of those sleeping in the cabin. They ran upstairs and tried to find out where the sound was coming from. Behind them, creaking the wooden floor of the ship, the big marauder pushed his men in different directions to make way for himself. He recognized the crest on the guards as soon as he saw it. He looked at the soldiers charging at them on their horses. Then he looked at his own men. The newly awakened men could barely stand. Some of them still had bottles of liquor in their hands. "Untie the ship!" the big raider said through gritted teeth, then repeated it loudly. "Untie the ropes of this damned ship! We must leave before this army gets here!"

Understanding what their leader had said, a few of the sober men went to untie the ship's ropes. But when they got to the knot, they were shot with arrows and knocked overboard. Whoever went was shot and collapsed. In the end, no one had the courage to untie the rope. The big marauder cursed and picked up his axe. Without going near the rope, he threw his axe. The axe spun and cut the rope into two pieces. A smile spread across his face as the ship slowly left the shore with the waves.

"Sir, if the ship keeps moving away, we won't be able to catch up with them!" the guard shouted as he spurred his horse.

"Don't worry, soldier. The ship will not sail!" Solomon said and his ring glowed. The same glow appeared on the sea the ship was on. The shining part of the sea calmed down and stopped its waves. And when the waters were recalled by the sea, the ship ran aground.

"Arm yourselves!" shouted the raider. Some of his soldiers did so clumsily, but those who came to their senses did as the big man told them.

Solomon was the first one on board. He moved forward without taking his eyes off the big looter. One by one, he swung his sword through the looters in torn and dirty clothes that came his way. The big looter squinted his eyes and looked at the man coming at him. His eyes widened when he realized who it was.

“You... You were dead.”

“Solomon, son of David, not so easy to kill.” Solomon said, frowning angrily, looking at his bloody sword. “But the same is not true for those who killed my father.” Solomon swung his sword over his head.

Solomon entered the ship's cabin. There was a chest full of gold and jewelry. None of it caught Solomon's attention. Just as he was about to leave, he saw something shining on the table. He approached the table and picked up the crown that lay on it. It was his father's crown. He turned it around and put it on his own head. Then he left the cabin. His soldiers were in the sea, cleaning their clothes covered in blood. Solomon came to the head guard.

“There is a chest inside. Send two of your men to get it.” Said Solomon, the guard noticed the crown on Solomon's head and never took his eyes off him.

“What would you order us to do with the ship?”

“Burn it down.” Solomon said. bowing his head soldier went off. Solomon went to his horse.

The soldiers cleaned their clothes as best they could and mounted their horses. Two guards loaded the treasure chest onto the back of one of the horses. Others searched all the ship and took what is useful and valuable. Then with the order of Solomon, they see a fire. It was growing and rising to the blue sky with dancing mist on it.

All the guards put spurs to their horses as Solomon rode off.

When Solomon and his soldiers joined the others, they saw that no one was outside except a few guards in the darkness of the night. Solomon's tent was larger and more ornate than the others', so Solomon found it easily. Solomon entered his tent as the leader of the guard shouted out the new guard posts to his soldiers. Naama, who had been waiting by candlelight, was excited to see Solomon coming through the door and hugged him tightly.

As the days passed, the weather grew colder. And the first snowflake fell from the sky. And then more snowflakes followed. The children were excitedly looking at the snowflakes falling from the sky. They enjoyed the smoke created by exhaling their breath and smiled. The adults were looking at the tents in the distance. Even though the tents were far away, they could be seen through the slowly falling snowflakes.

As the weeks passed, the snow fell more and more often. Shivering from the cold, they continued to ride their horses. The thick clothes they were wearing did not always work. Some days they could not leave their tents because of the blizzards. They waited until the weather calmed down. Then they continued their journey.

Solomon stopped his horse as the horses' feet were digging in the snow. The others behind them stopped in turn. Solomon got off his horse. Of course, not everyone could see him dismount. The blowing wind and falling snow obscured the sight of half of Solomon's people. Solomon pushed through the snow. He closed his eyes and exhaled deeply.

He saw a glow behind the snowflakes. Everyone could see it. All the people. The glow grew stronger. When the snowfall slowed, they saw the light coming from Solomon's ring.

"This is it!" Solomon said happily. "The land of our kingdom! This is our new home!" and the light from Solomon's ring spread everywhere.

CHAPTER TWENTY EIGHT

Screams rose from the crowd gathered to watch the execution. Adults covered children's eyes, trying to blind them to what was about to happen. But all that soon ended. The silence of death enveloped the area. No one spoke. They were looking at the king with curiosity. Because there was no blood. Or a head rolling on the ground. The sword remained in James' neck. At first the king was petrified like a statue. Then he realized he couldn't control his arms. He was forced to take a few steps backwards. As if someone was pushing him on the shoulders. Immediately, like a bolt of lightning, the king felt the pain from the sword radiating from his wrist to his entire body. And he threw the sword down with a scream. As the sword clattered to the ground, the ropes binding the hands of Rose, Nathaniel and James suddenly loosened and fell to the ground. Everyone presents watched in amazement. James straightened up, putting one foot on the ground first. And he stood up. Then he turned around. Richard looked into James's eyes with fear. James's eyes were golden. It was as if golden flames were burning inside him.

“You have declared war on the wrong blood.” Said a deep voice. It echoed and spoke with Jaems' mouth. He reached for the sword. The sword came into his hand as quickly as if James had a magnet in his hand. James gripped the hilt with both hands and took his position. “Solomon's blood accepts the call of battle!”

“Ian James Fate, open your eyes!” James felt the powerful voice with every fiber of his being. It felt impossible to resist and he opened his eyes. King Richard was not standing before him. Or the execution table. Only a man with a long black beard and blue eyes stood before him. From his dress and the throne, he was sitting on, it was clear that he was a king. On his finger was a ring. James raised his hand and looked at the ring he wore in the palace.

“You... You are Solomon! Where am I?” James asked and looked around, realizing for the first-time what kind of place he was in. He was surrounded by thrones. Only one of the thrones was empty, the others were occupied by people whose faces he had never seen in his life.

“You are in the presence of the Kings of Destiny, the true heirs of Magic, James.”

“But... I don't understand.”

“You have a destiny to fulfill, and I couldn't let you die here. You need to know who you are. You were lied to for your own good. And you never knew who you were. Until now.”

James didn't know what to say. He felt his heart beating fast. His throat tightened.

“The Professor you know was never my bloodline. Your father has the same blood as me, James.”

“So... you're saying...” James couldn't swallow with excitement.

“Yes, James, you have the same blood as me. You are my legacy. And I think I've done all I can to help you in this situation. It's time to take back control, James.”

“What control?”

James moved towards the King, who was looking at him with fear. His own face was expressionless. He put his sword directly to the King's neck. “Please don't kill me!” the King said in fear. Nathaniel and Rose, who could not see the sword against the King's neck, were busy with attacking the two guards behind them.

Merlin turned to his brother as soon as he saw James standing up. Arthur quickly unsheathed the sword hidden under his cloak. “For King Hendry!” he shouted as the people around him began to flee in fear, and he began to run, pushing people in front of him. As he ran, people running in different directions in the chaos began to take up their weapons. Some grabbed the wooden handles of their double axes and attacked with shouts, others with arrows in their bows. Merlin was one of those who attached an arrow to his bow. All but a few of the guards went on the defensive. The others went to help the king. They became the archers' priority.

“Please, don't kill me!” repeated the King with a sword to his neck. James, his eyes shining, lowered his sword and grabbed the King by the collar, slamming him hard on the execution table. He put the sword to his neck. He closed his eyes and squeezed them shut. When he opened them again, he looked around with his dark blue eyes.

Guards and rebels were at war. The people of the Kingdom of Destiny were running this way and that in fear. Alone in the middle of the street, James saw a child crying. And the villagers who stumbled into the fighting. And he saw both sides of the same army trying to kill each other.

“Stop!” James shouted and lifted King Richard up again and grabbed his hands behind his back. He put his sword to his neck. “All of you! Stop fighting! If the guards keep fighting you will have nothing but your King's head! And Arthur, pull your men back!” All the peasants had managed to flee the battlefield. And this, combined with the standing battle, created the silence of death.

It was James who broke the silence. He was holding the king's arm tightly.

“There is a battle coming our way now! And we need everyone to survive it! All of you! Arthur, come here and show the scroll to every guard here!”

Without thinking, Arthur did as he was told. He walked over to James. He put his hand inside his cloak and pulled out the parchment. Then, under the curious gaze of the guards, he came to James. He stood on the execution log. Ignoring the King, who looked at him angrily, he opened the scroll and began to read aloud.

“I am King Theodore of the Kingdom of Destiny. This scroll is my last command before I die. My brother Hendry will sit on the throne of the Kingdom of Destiny. My son Richard is too young and ambitious for the throne. Until my brother Hendry says that my son Richard is ready to rule the Kingdom, he is the new King of the Kingdom of Destiny.”

Arthur read the parchment and then turned it so the guards could see it. “The King's own signature and his own seal. Now let us end this war and put the true King on the throne!” said Arthur. The guards returned their drawn arrows to their quivers and their raised swords to their scabbards. Arthur signaled two of his men to come to him. When they came, he pointed them to King Richard and James handed the king to them.

“The time has come to bring the true king out of the dungeon and place him on his rightful throne! You go ahead! I'll catch up with you.” Said Arthur. He grabbed James by the arm and pulled him aside

as his soldiers walked away. Rose and Nathaniel came up on either side.

“Ian...”

“It seems the professor lied.” James explained briefly.

“James, pay attention. You are Solomon's heir! And what you did in there, will be really useful in the battle!”

“What thing?”

“Your use of the sword and your magic!”

“I have no idea how to use them.”

“Well, the things you do...”

“Headknight, I'm interrupting, but James, you need to go and learn how to actually use the sword. And by sword, I don't mean a few moves. You need to learn the magic that comes with the sword.”

“And how am I supposed to do that?”

“I have no fucking idea. But maybe the ones who made it have some ideas about it. Blacksmiths, the Excas. I think it's worth a try.”

“The Excas? Who are they?” Artur took a deep breath, looked around and finally his eyes fell on Merlin.

“Merlin, take James to the Excas!” Arthur turned back to James. “Our time is limited. The more you learn before the battle begins, the better. Now go! Merlin will tell you what you need to know on the way.” Said Arthur. As soon as James and Merlin found a horse, they set off.

The people who had fled from the town square in great haste soon seemed to have returned to their old routines. Some had opened their inns; others were filling their stalls with a variety of fruit. James and Merlin rode their horses swiftly past the people. They were doing

their best not to bump into anyone. People were also moving to the sides to avoid being crushed under the horses.

After a while, the people began to dwindle. And then there were fewer buildings. More trees and bushes took their place. Soon they came to a path through the forest, covered with earth and grass. As they slowed their horses, Merlin gestured where they should go. A huge burning mountain surrounded by green trees.

As they rode along the path leading to the burning mountain, the sunlight through the trees began to fade and turn red. It was getting dark. Merlin and James continued on their way, not caring much about it. As they spurred their horses on, James's horse neighed as it jumped over a log that had collapsed in the middle of the path. James continued to ride, petting the horse's neck with his hand.

The middle-aged man with a long gray beard looked around once more. He could see nothing but a few criminals behind the bars. He turned to the barred window that showed a small square of blue sky. He exhaled a deep breath and lay down on his hard to bed, half a meter off the ground. There was no pillow and nothing to cover him with. He just lay there and stared at the ceiling. When he got bored of the cobweb-covered ceiling, he turned to the wall right next to the bed. And closed his eyes.

The echoing sound of the dungeon door had roused Hendry from his light sleep. Curious to see if they were bringing in a new prisoner or executing someone else, he decided to look. Men were coming towards him through the door. He could not see their faces clearly.

"King Hendry?" the man in front called out as he approached with quick steps. They've come to hang someone, Hendry thought, and he forced himself to stand up. "King Hendry?" the guard repeated and stopped in front of the door. "There you are, sir." Said Arthur and opened the cell door.

“Guard Arthur. Have you come to take me to execution?” Hendry asked with an exasperated sigh.

“Actually,” Arthur interrupted and the two guards behind him led the bound Richard into another cell. Arthur handed the parchment to Hendry. “I’ve come to put you on the throne, Your Majesty. And we are in a terrible situation.”

“I can imagine that, Arthur Why don't you tell me all about it over dinner?” said King Hendry and quickly left his cell. Arthur and his two guards followed him.

When the new king emerged from the dungeon, he breathed a sigh of relief and slowed his pace. He gestured for a passing servant to come.

“Tell the cooks to bring whatever food is ready for the royal dining room.” Said Hendry and the servant bowed to the king and left with quick steps. The king went to the dining room with his three soldiers behind him.

As soon as the king took his place in the dining room, the table was filled with several kinds of food. Without waiting, the king began to eat. But he did not eat like a king. He did not use forks and knives. He picked up a large piece of meat and held it firmly in his hand. Without waiting, he ate it in big bites. As he chewed, he said, “You can tell me now, Arthur. What happened in my absence.” He said. Arthur took a few steps forward.

“Sir, a quick recap is that I and a few guardsmen were declared rebels. While the kingdom was searching for us, your nephew Richard sent an army to the walls. He wants more land.” Hendry spat out his wine with surprise and anger. He opened his mouth to say something when Arthur, without waiting for an answer, offered his own opinion. “If I may, Sire, I would like to send a messenger, a messenger who will find them and bring them back before the army gets there. He will keep his horse running and catch up with them.”

After a few coughs, the King nodded and looked at Arthur.

“Arthur, you really deserve your job. But we need to do something about this nephew of mine, Richard. If he takes the throne after my death, he could make the same mistakes again.”

“Sire, I swore an oath to protect the Kingdom of Destiny, or die protecting it. I will do anything for the sake of the kingdom.”

“That's what I was hoping to hear.” The king said happily and went back to his meal. “Sire,” Arthur said, as he stuck a large piece of bread in his mouth. Said Arthur. “Actually... There is something else you should know.”

The king rolled his eyes and sighed.

“What other trouble could my idiot nephew have caused?”

“I wish it was something your nephew did, sir, but it's nothing to do with him. A... A Headknight has arrived in the kingdom. A real one who is one of Solomon's chosen bloods. And he said the Book of Solomon has been found. Soon there will be a great battle.”

“Damn it!” shouted Hendry as he stormed from his seat. “Arthur, go and tell all the soldiers to prepare. Now! And meet me in the throne room while the army prepares. We need to work out the details of the battle.”

“Yes, Sire.” Said Arthur and nodded, heading for the door.

“And Arthur,” Arthur turned and looked at his king. “Thank you for being loyal to my brother to the end.” Hendry said in a calm voice.

“I am willing to do anything for the kingdom, Sire, now if you will excuse me. We have a battle to win.” Said Arthur and nodded and left the room.

Nathaniel and Rose were in the armory, as were most of the guards. The only difference was that the guards knew what weapon they were going to get before they entered, so they were done quickly. They went in, equipped themselves and left. Nathaniel and Rose were looking at the weapons one by one.

“You know Rose, I have no intention of changing my double swords.” Nathaniel said and put down the huge, double-edged, inlaid axe in his hand. Then, as he looked around at the guards preparing around him, his eyes fell on the guard passing by, the elaborate, shiny metal armor causing Nathaniel's eyes to widen and a smile to spread across his face. “But I want that too.” He said excitedly and moved quickly to the armor.

Nathaniel had gotten what he wanted. It was a metal armor bearing the crest of the Kingdom of Destiny. The only difference from the other guards was that instead of an armband, he wore the gauntlet of the Headknight. He held his featherless helmet under his arm. “I almost forgot.” He said and put his helmet on the table. He took the flask from the waist of his old belt and put it on his new belt. And he put on a big dagger. He took the helmet in his hand again. “I'll be right back, I've got a quick errand to run,” he said as he walked past Rose, who was putting on her gauntlets. He said and disappeared among the other guards leaving the armory.

Nathaniel moved quickly through the corridors of the palace. He had learned well enough where to go. Soon he reached the kitchen. He took a deep breath as good smells wafted into his nostrils. Then he concentrated and stepped in front of the first cook he came across.

“Can you show me the best drink in the palace?” he asked with a smile. The cook was about to protest until Nathaniel lifted his gauntlet. Seeing the glowing eye, the cook did not protest just obeyed the order and quickly showed the Headknight where the drink he was looking for was located. Nathaniel filled his flask with the expensive palace wine, tucked it into his belt and left the kitchen.

Merlin and James had finally reached the foot of the mountain. They dismounted and tied their horses to one of the thick branches of a tree. After walking around the mountain on foot for a while, they saw steps carved out of the stone. The steps led upwards, wrapping around the mountain. One by one, Merlin and James began to climb the cracked stone steps.

After a few hours, they reached the end of the steps. The end of the steps led to a hollow. An entrance carved into the mountain. The arch around the entrance was decorated with runic letters and various ornaments. There was no lock and no door to close. They went straight inside.

It was dark inside. At least for a while. They had taken a few steps inside when one by one the torches on the pillars caught fire and illuminated the surroundings. As the interior of the mountain was illuminated, the architectural structures inside became clearer. Carved and shaped columns were arranged in a certain order and sequence in a huge area. There were arches connecting them all. In front of the walls stood statues much larger than a human being. They were usually cloaked men holding long-handled hammers.

They kept walking, their eyes wide open. They marveled at their surroundings, as if they were becoming more and more fascinated with each step.

“Solomon's blood is back in the Exca's mine.” Said a mysterious voice. As the voice echoed through the void, it seemed to come from everywhere and nowhere. Unable to understand where the voice was coming from, James turned his head in all directions but could not see the source of the voice.

“Keep walking!” the Voice said. “Follow the light!” All the torches went out except for two rows of pillars. James and Merlin stood where they were for a brief moment, exchanging glances, then

started walking at the same time. They walked in silence between the two columns, which were lined up in rows, their torches lit.

The light led them under an arched doorway. There was no need for torches on the other side of the arch. Behind the arched passage was a stone path. The end of the path led to a huge door with two wings. Both sides were covered in boiling and flowing lava.

“All right.” James said and took a deep breath and started walking. Merlin followed close behind. They walked on, looking around at the lava bubbling up and bursting in little bubbles. As the lava continued to boil, they finally made it to the door.

The metal, double-leafed door glowed red. Red like a sword from a forge. But as soon as they were in front of it, the doors opened by themselves and invited James and Merlin inside. James and Merlin accepted the invitation after a brief moment of surprise. When James and Merlin entered the room, the doors closed behind them with a great creak.

A man was standing inside the room the doors closed. He looked like a human-sized version of the statues he had seen at the entrance. He was cloaked, holding a long-handled metal hammer. Half of his face was shrouded in darkness. The part of his mouth that was visible had a wound that reached up to his chin. The man put the handle of the hammer on the ground and spread his arms wide. The hammer stood straight.

“Welcome, blood of Solomon. heir of magic. Savior of destiny.”

“Who are you?”

“Who am I? A blacksmith to some, a friend to others, a leader to my kind... But who I am is not important, Ian James Fate. the question is where are you?”

James frowned and looked briefly at the man who knew his name with curiosity, then looked around. Different runes began to

appear on the walls. Runes that looked familiar. With the thin channels of lava flowing, the places where the writings were carved were filled with lava and shimmered. After all the runes were filled with lava, James saw lava flowing from two different points. They flowed from the lava bed and formed a star on the ground behind the cloaked man.

“This is where Solomon's sword was made.” Said James, looking at the sword at his waist with wide-open eyes.

“This is where it all began. This is where light first had hope against darkness. This is where the sword hanging on your belt was forged! And I am the blacksmith who forged this sword.

“You made this sword. Do you know how to use it?”

“I am not a warrior. I don't know how to use a sword. I know how to make them.”

“Great! We came for nothing then!”

“I told you I don't know how to use a sword, but I can show you the way to someone who does.” “You are the only one who can find your teacher,” the man said, stepping aside and pointing with his hand to the big star on the ground. He said, “History.”

James took a deep breath. He turned to Merlin. It was clear from his face that he understood nothing. He just followed the man's lead. He stepped over the two-foot bed of lava, first jumped over one of the triangles at the corners of the star, then over the second lava channel and into the pentagram in the center of the star.

He looked at the symbols on the walls. And he remembered where he had seen it. He reached for the hilt of his sword. Without haste, he unsheathed his sword. Slowly, the sword rose with a metallic whistle as it slowly unsheathed. When the sword was completely unsheathed, James gripped the hilt with both hands and reached forward. He looked at the runes on his sword. They were the same as on the wall. He turned the sword over and rested the tip on

the floor. When he realized that the fingers gripping the hilt were turning white, he took a deep breath and calmed himself. He relaxed his hands and closed his eyes. He relaxed more and more. He tried to shake off all his thoughts. All except his sword. Though James couldn't see it, the symbols on the sword glowed, one by one, from the one closest to the hilt to the one at the end. Again.

“Open your eyes, last of my blood, heir to magic and blah blah blah.”

James heard a tone that did not belong to Solomon. After “Blah, blah, blah,” he opened his eyes in disbelief. Standing before him was a man with short, dark hair. His green eyes stared directly into James' blue ones. He was wearing heavy and ornate armor. On his head was a thin golden crown. The man stroked his long goatee.

“Welcome, Ian James Fate. I was the heir of the magic long time before you born. I am of the same lineage as you. King Arthur. owner of the sword of destiny, the sword in your hand, otherwise known in my time as Excalibur.”

James looked around. There was no sign of the thrones he had seen the previous time. They were just standing on a great white marble floor. There was nothing else. Just the floor. There was no ceiling, no sky. It was neither black nor white. There was just nothing.

James realized he was still holding his sword. And when he looked up, he saw King Arthur.

“You must teach me how to use magic.” James managed to get the knot out of his throat.

“Jimmy Jimmy Jimmy, I am not a wizard, I am a warrior.” Arthur said with exaggerated hand gestures. “Just like you. You and I are different from others. We can't use magic without a sword like the others can. Not to mention the old man. I mean, boy, I'm going to try

to teach you how to use the sword, and when you do, you'll be able to cast a few spells. Shall we begin?"

James looked at him for a moment, not knowing what to say. Then he just nodded his head up and down in agreement.

King Arthur took a few steps backwards and clenched his fists in front of him. Yellow beams of light stretched out from between his fingers and hands to form a sword of light. When the shape was complete, the light suddenly went out. In the mold of light stood a sword. It was exactly the same as James' sword. James also took his position, putting one foot forward.

"Become one with the sword. Connect with the magic that flows through your veins, boy."

"And how do I do that?" James asked, frowning.

"Honestly, have no fuckin idea. I've learned how to do it when faced with death, and the only way I can think of is to put you in the same situation. And I have to tell you, any wounds you receive here will carry over to the other side." King Arthur crossed his sword. "All the pain you feel will be real. If you are wounded here, you will have the same wound on the other side. So try not to lose your arm. You may need it in a great battle. If you are ready, let us begin." Said King Arthur, his tone showing how confident he was in his plan.

James nodded again. King Arthur began to take sideways steps. James joined him. He did not let him out of his sight. As they circled around a small, imaginary circle, King Arthur began to spin his sword. Step by step he was getting closer to James. James waited for the right moment. With a quick step he stepped forward and swung his sword at King Arthur. He planned to slice the king in half through the stomach.

But it didn't go as he planned. Just as the sword did not touch James in execution, it did not touch King Arthur. It seemed to hit an invisible barrier at the base of his abdomen. James tried again. And again. The result was the same.

“You only use a sword made of simple metal. You do not use magic. And this sword alone cannot harm our blood.” Said King Arthur. He leapt backwards and swung his sword at James' face. At the last moment he turned his sword so that James's face was spared from being sliced in two. The broad side of the sword struck James in the face and he staggered to the ground. When he landed, King Arthur began to twist his sword again.

James brought his hand to his face, which ached with pain. That's when he realized he didn't have his sword in his hand. He turned his head straight to the right. The sword was lying on the ground. With a sudden sensation he looked up. He saw the King coming towards him with heavy steps.

As King Arthur brought his sword down from the sky on James' head, James jumped up and dodged King Arthur's sword. He picked up his sword from the ground and stood up, without looking back, he spun around with all his might, sword in hand. James stopped as the metallic sound of swords clinking filled the endless void. He had managed to parry the King's move.

“Nice move.” King Arthur said mockingly. “It could be If we weren't trying to use magic.”

James angrily attacked again. He drew his sword back and swung again. Again and again. And with each swing the clang of steel sounded like thunder all around him. They circled around each other, keeping up the sound and the thrusts. relentlessly. They took turns. From different directions and angles. All with the same result. It reaches the ringing that spreads around.

“Rule the sword!” King Arthur shouted. James leapt backwards and away from the battlefield. There was a short silence. James looked down at his hands, panting. His knuckles were white from gripping the sword so tightly. His arms ached with pain. James looked at his opponent with a sigh.

“I can't!”

“Then Solomon the sorcerer entrusted the book to the wrong person! Centuries of preparation for nothing! It was all just an old man's bull shit!”

James began to swell with rage. Anger made him forget everything. The pain on his cheek. What he'd been through. What he knew... All he knew now was anger. He felt the hot blood coursing through his veins, spreading throughout his body.

James took a deep breath. He raised his sword and gripped it with both hands. He looked at his reflection in the sword for a second and turned his chest to the side and attacked. He swung his sword with all his strength and fury. And there was a deafening clang. Then he struck again and again. The result was the same. He retreated again. He decided to take his sword in one hand and hold it upside down.

James swung his sword diagonally. The King joined in and held his sword in the same way and raised it high above the ground. As the swords clashed, James' sword went up with his hand. King Arthur took a quick step towards James and grabbed James' raised hand with his free hand. With a swift thrust he straightened his sword and thrust it into James' stomach.

James staggered as King Arthur drew back. His sword fell from his hand. He brought his free hand to the wound in his stomach. He pressed his hands over the wound where his warm blood was flowing. He could feel his breath constricting. Groaning in pain, he fell to his knees, then rolled onto his side. His eyes began to fail him. Every drop of blood that flowed from his stomach seemed to diminish his sight.

The king bent down and put his hand over the wound. Soon he withdrew his hand. And when he took his hand away, the wound began to close rapidly. At last it was as if nothing had happened except the blood.

James opened his eyes as if waking from a nightmare and tried to take a deep breath. He sat up with a cough. He looked at the wound that had killed him a few seconds ago. It was gone.

"I think you now understand the seriousness of the situation." Said the King and took up his position again. "Attack! Show me you are my blood!"

Seeing the King's grip tighten on his sword, James coughed once more and took his stance. He took a deep breath and charged.

The king frowned at first. He loosened his fingers that held his sword tightly. The sword almost slipped through his fingers. But James clung to the sword with white knuckles. He swung his sword. The king made no effort to meet it. It was as if he was wearing transparent armor. The sword did not want to touch him. The king lowered his head in frustration and shook it from side to side. He threw his shoulders back and kicked James in the chest with all his might. James was flew off his feet and thrown back.

"Rule the bloody sword!" King Arthur shouted angrily.

James got desperately to his feet.

"I can't." James said quietly. Slowly the sword slipped from his fingers and clinked on the floor. Then he collapsed on his kneecaps. His face was staring at the ground.

"Look at me! I said look at me! Solomon trusted only you with the book! I didn't find the book or Rehoboam or any of us with the same blood! You found it, Ian, Ian James Fate! the last bearer of the blood! And if you don't accept this mission, all the work that's been done so far will be for nothing! And all that will come after! If you don't take this mission, thousands of men will have died in vain, especially your beloved father! He didn't die to protect you, James! He died to protect the Book! Now stand up and fulfill your damn destiny! Fulfill your promise to your father!"

Hope began to replace anger. James felt the power radiating from his chest to every part of his body. His body seemed to be regenerating. His strength was restored. He quickly grabbed the sword at his side and stood up. He could feel the fatigue in him. But he also felt the strength that stood against him. The two were intertwined. James took his time. He gripped the sword calmly. He advanced with careful steps. As his blue eyes turned yellow, he charged.

He swung the sword at the King's neck. The King dodged the attack and took a step towards James. James stepped back, keeping the distance between them. And then he lunged forward again and swung the sword sideways. King Arthur grabbed the sharp edge of James's sword, dropped his own sword and held out his empty hand towards James. As if an invisible wall had rushed forward and slammed into James, he was knocked off his feet again and fell back to his original position.

“Your friends...”

“Is it the time I let them down now?” asked a breathless James, carefully trying to get to his feet.

“No, they came to get you.” Arthur said and held out his right hand to James. James stood up with support. “James, I believe in you, you will win this battle. protector of Destiny, don't you dare lose because this battle will decide not only yours but the destiny of all mankind.” King Arthur said and put his hand on James' forehead. James closed his eyes. He disappeared like a gust of wind. Now King Arthur was alone. He put his hand down which he had put on James' forehead and raised his other hand. Blood oozed from the gaping wound in his hand. With a smile the wound shimmered and closed.

James opened his eyes. Nathaniel was standing right in front of him.

“James? You're finally awake! The armies are gathering! I hope you've learned something.” Said Nathaniel and tugged James by the arm. “We have to go!”

James took a deep breath, nodded and looked at his sword one last time before sheathing it. He followed Nathaniel over the lava channels and over to the side where Merlin and Exca were.

“You cannot send Solomon's blood into battle without armor.” Exca said and walked slowly, pointing to one of the chests against the wall. James stood where he was for a while and then went to the chest Exca pointed to and opened it. A large star was engraved on the chest of the armor. There were different runic letters all over the armor. As James took the pieces one by one and put them on, he said, “Unfortunately, that is no more than ordinary armor.” Exca said. “If I had the metal your sword was forged from. I could make you invincible.”

“Thanks for everything.” James said as he put on his armor. He said.

James put the armor on completely and turned to Nathaniel with open arms. Nathaniel nodded that he liked the armor.

As the red double doors creak open slowly, “Destiny is in your hands. All of you! And for the good of all worlds, you must succeed!” Exca said from behind them.

“We will kick the Rebel's ass!” said Nathaniel confidently. He turned to James. James looked at Nathaniel with hesitant eyes for a while, but finally nodded. And they walked out of there together.

Without waiting, they crossed the stone path between the lava. Then through the large area where the pillars were lined up. Finally, they descended the steps that had taken them several hours. As soon as they came down, they went to the horses with quick steps.

They rode their horses quickly through the forest. The sun was shining high overhead. They rode swiftly under the shadows of

the trees. As they neared the kingdom, the first houses of the kingdom slowly coming into view, Nathaniel pulled back the reins with all his might and his horse came to a halt. Merlin and James also stopped their horses a few paces away and then turned their horses toward Nathaniel.

“Is something wrong?” James asked with a frown.

“Scatt.” Nathaniel said with a sigh. “I didn’t believe it at first. The war... Well... A war with swords seemed... unreal to me, but...” As Nathaniel spoke rapidly, James held out a hand towards him.

“Nathaniel, calm down, please. I don’t know what you mean, take a deep breath.” Nathaniel tried to calm down, trying to do as he was told. “Now tell me from the beginning.”

“All right.” Said Nathaniel. He took a deep breath, trying to calm down again. “When I took the scroll, Solomon gave me several visions in sequence. You were killing someone, one showed me the formation and hiding of the pyramids where the scroll was hidden. And in the last one... Scatt.

“I didn’t believe it at first because in the vision everyone had swords and shields. They were riding horses. But now I know we’re heading for that battle. And if Scatt... If Scatt comes to the battle... he will die.”

“Are you... Are you sure?” James asked after a moment of silence. His face had gone white. “We have to get him off the battlefield.”

“Yes, you’re right. And we will.” Said Nathaniel, and without waiting, he tapped the reins and spurred his horse into a trot. His horse ran with all its might and Merlin and James followed close behind Nathaniel.

They changed direction before they came into the kingdom. And soon the grass and trees gave way to sand. Just like in Solomon’s

palace. Only this was a desert, not a beach. The sun, beating directly on the face, burned.

Soon the soldiers appeared, stretching along with the mountain. Rows and rows of soldiers in the same armor, armed with different weapons, stretched out as if there was no end to them. They were standing still, waiting for orders from their commanders. A few meters ahead of the line of soldiers, Arthur was standing on his horse, watching them intently. Merlin, James and Nathaniel slowed their horses as they approached them.

As they drew closer to the army, Nathaniel rode straight up to Arthur. He made sure that no one could hear what he had to say.

“Arthur, we must send Scatt back to the palace. Otherwise he will die.” Nathaniel said. Arthur raised one eyebrow and looked at Nathaniel.

“We are fighting soldiers with magic power. We are all likely to die. But I think I know a way to send Scatt back to the palace.” Arthur said and raised his hand for Merlin to see, who was standing next to the lined up soldiers, and motioned for him to come to him. Without hesitation, Merlin rode up to his brother. When Merlin was beside Arthur, Arthur reached into his belt and pulled out a bound piece of paper. “Merlin, you must hurry your horse and deliver this letter to the king. You must get there no matter what. You have no idea how important this is. Do you understand?” Merlin nodded solemnly. “And with you...” Arthur squinted and looked to both sides of the army. “Get Scatt! Quickly! We have no time to lose!” Arthur said and handed the letter to Merlin.

“Convince Scatt to stay at the palace.” Said Nathaniel.

“Yes, Headknight.” Said Merlin and put spurs to his horse and rode off. As Merlin and Scatt spurred away, Arthur watched his brother go like he just frozen.

“I don't want Merlin in the war either, he's only seventeen.” Arthur said. Nathaniel nodded and took his place at the front of the army.

James rode up beside Rose. When he was right beside her, he nodded and reached for his belt. He took out a blue rose.

“Rose... I didn't want to lost the chance to tell that I... I have feelings for you. And I wanted to tell you in case in war... If we can't make it. I wish we were in better place better circumstances. But here we are. In a rough battle.” He gave the blue rose to Rose. “I believe it really looks good on you. And if we survive... I will make better speech you can be sure of that.” Ian said and tried to smile. Little smile for giving little hope. Rose smiled too. With same little smile he looked at James.

“Thank you Ian.” He smell the rose with blushed face under the helmet. “And yes you should make a better speech next time.”

“Deal.” Said James smilingly. And when he turned his face to the army it fade away. He realized what is coming.

The army of the Kingdom of Destiny was lined up a few meters in front of a white building. Arthur took one last look at his army. Once he was sure his army was in formation, he turned his horse and looked across. The other army was in position on the sand dunes.

“All right, listen!” Arthur said as he turned his horse. “There is going to be a great battle here today. And we will win it, a legendary battle that will be talked about for centuries! One battle that will close the gates of darkness! All we have to do is get that book! And that's a child's play for the soldiers of Destiny! And our army has something they don't! The Excalibur! The sword of Solomon and the heir of Solomon are on our side! With its help we'll show those bastards!” Arthur glared at the opposing army. “Let's go and win this fucking battle!” he shouted as he rode off, and the whole army joined him. They shouted with great enthusiasm as they rode. They galloped

their horses. Their voices drowned out the sound of swords drawn eagerly from their scabbards. The helmeted James, Rose and Nathaniel kept pace with the other soldiers.

Seeing the charging soldiers of the Kingdom of Destiny, the kin of the rebels also took up arms and attacked. Some of the armor had filaments on their chests and some of the men on their shoulders. A sword that looked like two claws drawn on a black background. Both armies attacked with all their might.

“Here we go.” Blacked said. His face was pale, as if disturbed and frightened. He handed Leonard the bag containing the book. Leonard held out his hand as he slung the bag over his shoulder. Blacked took his hand and shook it. Both of them suddenly threw their heads back. First Blacked's veins swelled, became prominent and darkened. Then the veins in Leonard's hand became dark and prominent. It spread up his arm and all over his body. The mist that had surrounded Blacked's arm curled up and spread up Leonard's arm and then around his body, and after they both moaned silently in pain, their hands separated. If the men who had seen what had happened in the first place had not been wearing their helmets, their faces would have betrayed all the fear they felt.

Leonard smiled and stretched his hand forward.

“Charge.” He said calmly, confident that they would win. As soon as the rebel army heard the order, they charged. Some ran on horseback, others on foot. Both armies were charging towards each other.

The ranks of the two armies intertwined as both sides of the front riders broke ranks. The sound of swords rang out. Horses neighing, people screaming in pain. Horses' feet kicked the ground, kicking up sand and creating a cloud of dust. James swung his sword, Excalibur, and pulled with all his might on the reins of his horse as it tried to advance. As the horse reared, he used his sword to separate

the head from the body of one of the men who had passed him. He dodged an attack from the other side at the last moment. James and the other warrior both turned their horses and clashed swords on the battlefield. They continued without stopping. James spurred his horse and rode up beside the man and at the last moment he leaned back, his back arched. As the enemy's sword passed right in front of his eyes, he straightened up and swung his sword. With the impact of the sword, the man's sword and the hand holding it were severed from him. The man screamed as James put him out of his misery.

Nathaniel had started riding at the front, but had fallen behind the guards who had passed him. James had passed him too. With great excitement mixed with fear he plunged into the chaos of the battlefield. He charged across the square, where the sand, horses and soldiers were all painted red. Nathaniel saw the sword thrust coming at him at the last moment and met it with his sword. He took a deep breath. He brought his own sword and his opponent's sword down in an imaginary arc. And he attacked the man's leg. The man let out a cry of pain and rage and swung his sword again. Nathaniel threw one leg over the other side of the horse and saw the sword coming at the last moment. But he was still unable to block the attack completely. Sitting sideways on the horse, he quickly pulled on the reins, supported them and kicked the man with both feet. The man lost his balance and fell to the ground screaming and was soon silenced by the horseshoes passing over him. Nathaniel put his feet back where they should be and put his hand to the cut on his shoulder. It was split. Blood was flowing. And all the pain had just happened. Nathaniel gritted his teeth and kept fighting.

Rose slowed her horse and did not engage in close combat. She stood with the archers who had stayed behind. Until the battle heated up. Soldiers on both sides were close together. For a long time the arrows rained down on the clashing swords, then the archers on both sides drew their swords and charged onto the battlefield. They all dived into the intertwined armies. Rose joined them.

The battle was getting fiercer. The soldiers became more ruthless. It was getting more bloody. Everyone on the battlefield was used to seeing the arm, leg or head of the person wearing the same armor separated from the body. Some saw it on the ground, others saw it being cut off next to them. Armor and weapons were painted red. More often it was the blood of the soldiers of the Kingdom of Destiny. Because they were losing.

James was thrown back by a mace blow to the shoulder. He barely held onto his horse. For a moment he felt his arm being torn off. In pain, he straightened his position on his horse and continued to fight. He swung, trying to use the sword's magic. It wasn't working. At least not his magic. He could still cut. As James swung his sword, killing one of the Maces, another's mace exploded in his chest. He fell off his horse and landed on the ground. As he lay on the red sand and a few human fragments, he felt his chest heaving. He could hardly breathe, and with each breath he felt a great pain radiating from his chest.

Before he even realized that his breastplate had been torn, he saw horses coming towards him. They were coming from both sides. The horses didn't care as they trampled people. James rolled to the side, freeing himself from the horse of one of the men of the Kingdom of Destiny. And when he could catch his breath, he tried to sit up. He managed to see his sword in the dust. Just as he was about to take a step, he stopped and a horse rode quickly past him. Without waiting for the second one, he threw himself on the sword. As his chest tightened and hurt, he stood up with his sword. With all the anger and pain he felt, he swung his sword from side to side. He brought it down from above and cut both horses that passed by. Both of their riders fell to the ground. Then he struck the third rider. The rider fell to the ground. James went to one of the fallen men. As the man tried to sit up, he raised his sword and plunged it into the man's throat. He turned around for the others and was knocked off his feet by a blow to the center of his face, his helmet. He could feel the heat on his face. The pain of the broken bones, the bent helmet, the blood spreading all over his face... First the blood splattered in his eye,

blurring the surroundings, and then his blackened eyes made him completely blind.

Nathaniel couldn't understand what had happened. As he swung his sword and blocked the attack, his horse whinnied in pain and collapsed. Taking Nathaniel with it. At the last moment Nathaniel pulled his foot out from under the horse and staggered to his feet. He unsheathed his second sword. He jumped back, dodged the man's attack and twirled the sword in one hand. The man stepped forward and lunged again. Nathaniel deflected the thrust with the sword he held straight. He did a half-reverse half-turn and plunged the reverse sword into the man's neck. He pulled back and his armor turned red. He looked around and saw that the cavalry of both armies was few and far between and dwindling.

The soldiers, the soldiers of the Kingdom of Destiny, were retreating and fighting on. The rebels were coming at them with all their might and they were finding it hard to fight back. They were losing far more than they were killing, and the battle was getting tense. It was only delaying the end. They were losing.

The big man raised his mace. He took one last look at the man lying on the ground, the man whose face he had smashed a few seconds before, and raised his mace. He quickly brought it down on the man with all his might. For a brief moment he and his companion froze like statues. As the sphere of the mace cut diagonally straight across and fell to two different sides, they saw the man holding the sword angrily in front of them. The one who had just wrapped the big man around the ground. James, who had been lying on the ground, was now standing. He took his position while looking angrily at the big man in front of him. The gleaming sword in his hand was glaring at the men in front of him. With a huff, James pulled his crooked helmet off his head and threw it down next to the other shattered armor on the battlefield. He looked at both men with golden eyes.

Without waiting any longer, the first man raised his axe and brought it down with all his might. James jumped to the side, grabbed the axe handle and brought his sword down on the man's hands. As

the man screamed, James let go of the axe handle and let it fall to the ground with the hand. He grasped the hilt of the sword with his second hand and plunged it into the one-armed man. He removed the sword from the body and moved to the second man.

“This is the last time I save you, Ian James Fate. I can't do it again. I'm sorry. Even for me, there are rules.” Said Solomon as he sat on his throne. He stood up and walked over to James.

“I am trying to my best!” Said James with his head bowed. He was sitting on the floor, on his knees. “And I promise no matter what happens I will do it.” He added. While Solomon was walking through him his hear rose.

“I hope you're telling the truth, James. I chose you because I knew you could do it. The destiny is in our side son. You just need to lead the way through it.” Solomon said and put his hand on James' forehead.

James was awakened from the silence by the sound of shouting and clanging, horses neighing and horseshoes shaking the ground. And when he came to, he saw the man writhing at his feet. And gripping the sword of Solomon. After a moment's hesitation, he brought the sword full circle over his head and killed the man.

As James watched the man giving breathe his last, he saw Leonard. He was moving forward, swinging his sword. Killing people. In one hand he held the Book of Solomon. James pulled the sword from the chest of the corpse on the ground. He had Leonard in his sights. As he made his way towards him, he clashed his sword with everyone in his path. Leonard's eyes hadn't missed James. Especially Valefar's. Gritting his teeth, he cut the neck of the guard next to him and fixed his eyes on James. They approached, challenging each other.

When he was swept off his legs, Nathaniel groaned in pain. he fell to the ground. He could feel the blood running under his

armor. And that He didn't have their swords. The lack of weapons was not a problem. Because there were dead soldiers everywhere. On both sides. But mostly from the Kingdom of Destiny. The weapons of the retreating army were everywhere. Nathaniel rushed forward and grabbed the shield at his side. A sword was coming down on him. He had barely lifted the shield when the man collapsed on top of him. Nathaniel threw him off and grabbed the hilt of one of the swords on the ground. He stood up, supported by the outstretched hand.

“Did you drink before the war, Nate?” Rose shouted. And she turned and swung her sword. Nathaniel turned his back to Rose and swung his sword at the man in front of him. He turned his head slightly to the side.

“Not in this battle, I'm afraid!” he shouted and swung his sword again.

Arthur looked at his soldiers. For a moment the battlefield was completely silent for him. His retreating soldiers, slain, fighting on, their armor covered in blood. He wiped the blood from his face, knowing they could not win. And he remembered where he was. The silence was broken again, replaced by screams and ringing. He shouted angrily and kept swinging his sword. He swung his sword at the soldiers in front of him. Their necks, their arms, their knees... Anywhere he could cut with ease. He kept going, even though his face was covered in blood again.

Arthur lifted his aching arm with the last sips of his strength and swung his sword. And he heard a groan from very close by. He turned back to where the sound had come from and saw the soldier with an arrow through his helmet. He was a rebel soldier. The hand holding the rebel's sword remained in the air for a brief moment. His body collapsed at Arthur's feet. Arthur turned in the direction from which the arrow had come and saw Merlin in the red hood riding fast. Merlin was riding furiously.

“You drove me away from the battle!” he shouted as he came up to his brother. He took another arrow from the quiver on his leg

and quickly placed it on the bow. He drew it, and after a moment's hesitation, he released the bowstring. Another rebel fell to the ground.

"No regrets!" Arthur said as he swung his sword. When he had killed the man, he turned back. "And it wasn't just you! Scatt had to be taken away too! I hope you didn't bring him with you!"

"I tried!" Merlin said, reaching for his quiver and when he realized he had no arrows left, he struck the nearest man with his bow. "But he wouldn't listen to me! He wanted to join the battle, even after I told him!" He hung his bow beside his horse and unsheathed his sword.

"What are you talking about? What did you tell him?"

Blacked raised his knives and killed those who tried to attack him with great ease. Quickly and easily. Until one of the blades cracked and shattered into pieces. And it didn't happen to just one knife. One after the other, they all shattered in the same way. And Blacked had to draw his sword. He was good enough with that too. He ducked and waited for the sword to pass over him. He straightened up and with a quick turn killed the soldier.

When he jumped over the bodies and looked ahead, Blacked saw victory. One by one, the soldiers of the Kingdom of Destiny were falling to the ground, pulling back the defensive line as their army advanced with great speed. This brought a smile to Blacked's face. They were winning.

He was now facing the man standing between him and James Leonard. He was just getting into a position to make a move when a sword came out of the man's chest. Leonard pulled the sword from the body of his own soldier. Holding the bloody sword in his hand as the man slumped to the ground in pain, the glittering black-eyed Leonard cocked his head to either side, snapped his fingers and spun his sword around a full revolution. The book in his hand slowly flew up three man high.

“Let us begin, Blood of Solomon!” he said in a frightening voice.

James went on the offensive. He swung Excalibur, gripping it tightly by the hilt. It met Leonard's sword. Leonard didn't wait for a second move and punched James in the face. As James staggered back, Leonard stepped forward and swung his sword. James parried the attack but not well enough. He fell back from the blow. With his gloved hand he touched the gash on his cheek. He rised on his feet And he attacked again. He spun on his axis and swung his sword with him. Blacked was prepared for that too.

The swords clashed again. Leonard leapt to the side and quickly drove his sword into James's leg. As James fell to the ground in pain, Leonard wrenched the sword out of James's leg with great fury. He lifted the sword and dabbed at the blood with his fingertip.

“I will kill you slowly, and since Solomon is not here, someone with the same blood can take his punishment.”

James spat on the ground and stood up. In all his fury, he attacked without a moment's hesitation. Leonard stepped aside and grabbed James's sword hand by the wrist. He put his sword hand on James's shoulder and drove his knee into James's arm. James couldn't heard the sound of crunching bones. His ears was full with his own scream. Leonard kicked him in the stomach. James was knocked off his feet and hit the ground hard. He grabbed his arm, which hurt like hell. Leonard came over and kicked him in the face. Then he bent down and grabbed James by the hair and lifted him to his knees.

“Open your wet eyes, James! And look at your defeat! Look all the distraction! The corpses! You are all loosing.”

James stared with eyes he could barely open. His whole body ached with pain as he focused on what Leonard was saying. The armies of the Kingdom of Destiny had fallen back to the white pillars. They were losing. The ground was littered with corpses. Most of them carried the blood-stained banners of the Kingdom of Destiny.

Screams rose from the living. Horses neighing in pain. They were losing.

Leonard let go of James's hair. He turned around. And started walking. James wiped as much blood as he could from his nose. He gave up when he realized he was covered in blood. He tried to sit up, supporting himself with one hand. He straightened up, feeling the hot blood flowing from the wound on his leg and the pain of the wound. He was trying to keep his arm steady as it ached with every movement. Pressing her teeth tightly together, he was able to stand upright in front of Leonard again. Trying to ignore the pain that wracked his whole body, he bent down and grasped the sword in his good hand. He turned back to Leonard. He was inhaling deeply.

“Ah... you people don't know what it's like to give up, do you?” Leonard asked with a mocking smile.

James twirled his sword awkwardly.

“As you wish, chosen one.” Leonard said and closed his eyes and spread his arms wide. Matte steam surrounded him. He lowered one hand and grabbed the spear lodged in the belly of one of the corpses on the ground and pulled it out. The mist around his hand flowed into the spear and surrounded it too. He opened his fingers and the spear started to fly. Leonard raised his hand and the spear spun on its axis.

“Oh, I've missed doing this.” Leonard said. When he stopped his hand, the tip of the spear pointed at James. Leonard smiled as James straightened his stance and held his sword in front of him. Leonard brought his hand forward and the spear shot out like an arrow. And at the same moment James swung his sword with all his might.

The ground shook as the spear bounced off Excalibur and plunged into the sand. At least for a few meters. The matte mist that wrapped the spear like a rope, like the roots of a spreading tree, scattered in different directions without leaving the ground. One of

them had rushed towards James. James, unable to see through the blackened sand, collapsed in great pain. As the dull fog spread around in the dust cloud, the neighing of a horse was heard. And the sound of someone moaning in pain. Someone falling off a horse. But James couldn't pay attention to the sounds. It was too hard for him to think. He could no longer think when his whole body was covered in blood, when he was losing.

As the dust cloud slowly dissipated, James barely opened his eyes to see the other spear floating in the air. He tried to raise his sword, but his strength was not enough. He could only lift it and put it to his chest.

"You escaped the first one, but you won't escape the second one." Leonard said and smiled again.

James had no strength left to resist. For the last time, he turned his head back, trying to sit up. The rebels were very close to the pillars. The guards of the Kingdom of Destiny were doing their best, but it wasn't enough. One by one they were being knocked down and stretched. They were losing. James turned to face his enemy. James didn't even have the strength to keep his eyes open. Slowly closing his eyes, he saw the spear hurtling out.

CHAPTER TWENTYNINE

“And that is the story of how this kingdom was built in such a short time.” Said the old man with the scruffy beard and held a glass of ale over his head. As the ale flowed from his long beard, the sound of the horns spread throughout the kingdom. It was also heard in the inn, despite all the commotion in the inn. The armored soldier in front of the big man startled himself awake.

“Damn it! I am late! Thanks for the story!” he said and started running. He quickly pushed open the small double doors of the inn and ran. He kept running through the crowded streets. He was running towards the ostentatious palace. he kept running, even Tho he bumped a man. shouting apologizes while the other shouting swears. At last he slowed his pace. he was out of breath. Soldiers were scattered in columns along the front facing the balcony of King Solomon's throne room. The young soldier quickly took up his position at the back of the third line of troops. He put his hands on his knees and breathed in and out deeply.

“Where have you been?” said the soldier next to him. To change the subject, the newcomer pointed to the young man walking towards the palace gate. He was wearing a long robe with gold ornaments. Silver armor glittered on top of it.

He stood up to change the subject. He was still panting. “There! He’s here!” he said. The man entered the palace without waiting. As he made his way inside, the guards moved back to stay out of his way.

As the man in the gold-trimmed suit approached the two giant brass doors, the men standing on either side of the doors quickly opened them. The man entered. old Solomon, who was stroking his white beard while examining the armor laid out on a table next to the throne. Young one got next to him.

“It makes no sense to me to bring your own men into a war to save the other world. There is no reason for the war! The Kingdom of Destiny is safe. So are we.”

“Rehoboam, my son, you know how this kingdom was founded, don’t you?”

“Yes, but what does that have to do with it?”

“Son, it has everything to do with this. My father gave up his power and chose me because he knew I would make the right decision. I will not disappoint him, and my promises for Orin... I have to do this, there are more people we can save. It’s not craving more land but to save more life that drowned by the dark.”

“Father, you know our enemies better than I do! It would be suicide to fight them like this!”

Solomon lifted one of the suits of armor and handed it to the man standing beside the table. Solomon turned to his son as the man in the long robe put the armor over Solomon’s head and tightened the straps.

“What do you suggest, my son?”

“Can't you at least strengthen our people a little? Use your magic. Otherwise, our army will be destroyed. While the armies of other kingdoms kill our enemies, we will only be a decoy, a distraction. And we will perish.”

Solomon frowned as he put on the sleeves of his armor.

“Sometimes a few must die for the many to live, Rehoboam.”

“So, you would lead us to our deaths on purpose?”
Rehoboam said angrily.

“No, my son. Just as you say, I will strengthen all the warriors with my magic. They will be stronger, faster and more agile.”

Solomon put on the last piece of armor. “Now go and make sure the army is ready.” He said.

When the army returned to their world, victorious in their first battle, the soldiers, their armor stained with blood, were now talking about how they would eat in celebration. Except for one part. They were interested in something else entirely.

“This power that Solomon gave us... It is far, far less than his power.”

“Yes. So?”

“Why didn't he give us more power? At least we deserve more than what he gave to the Orin's soldier! Because he thinks we can't control more! But he carries more power than any of us!”

“You're right. He keeps all the power for himself.”

“We all deserve that power! And we know Solomon won't give it to us. We have to do something!”

“Like what?”

“Like depose Solomon from his throne.”

CHAPTER THIRTY

“James!” Scatt shouted and without hesitation threw himself in front of the spear. Surrounded by mist, the spear struck Scatt in the chest. Scatt, knocked off his feet by the spear, collapsed next to James. Fragments of mist from the tip of the spear that pierced his armor surrounded Scatt's whole body. Scatt's chest was still. James realized that Scatt wasn't breathing as blood poured out of him in many places.

“Scatt...” James managed to say as tears fell from his eyes. The drops turned to anger. Anger into power. James forced himself to stand up once more. He straightened up, not for himself for the sacrifice of a friend. feeling the heat spreading from his chest to his whole body. Staggering, he picked up his sword. He looked up at Leonard. Groaning in pain, he grabbed the hilt of the sword with his broken arm. He sniffled and raised his sword. He took his position. His blue eyes turned golden with a gleam. Valefar, who had seen golden eyes before, took a step backwards as James charged, shouting angrily.

James swung the sword to the right. Leonard met the attack with his sword. James made a reverse turn and swung his sword from the other side. Again, the swords trembled. James, in all his fury, brought the third strike down from above. With a great crack, Leonard's sword split in two.

James was breathing rapidly as Leonard staggered backwards. He continued to charge towards Leonard, rage in his eyes.

“You wanted Solomon's blood, you filthy creature!” James said, “I will show you his true heir!”

Leonard threw down his broken sword, picked up one of the axes lying on the ground and swung it. Excalibur, bearing the bright runes, split the axe in two at the handle. James took two nimble steps behind Leonard. He made an invisible arc with his sword and drove it into the man's calf. Leonard screamed and fell to his knees. James moved heavily in front of him. “This is for Scatt!” he said as a tear fell from his eye and he plunged Excalibur into Leonard's chest. A golden circle formed just beyond the hilt as the sword plunged. As if drawn with invisible chalk, runes appeared inside the circle. Then different shapes formed. When the whole shape was formed, the runic letters began to glow one by one. Then the rest of the shape glowed. A blindingly bright light rose for a moment. Leonard let out a scream as everything went white for a moment. James, whose eyes began to turn blue as the light faded, pulled the sword from the dead body. And Leonard's body collapsed to the ground.

James, who had lost all his strength, felt the blood flowing down his leg and knelt in pain. Then he felt the pain of his broken arm. With the spell gone, all his wounds had returned. He forced himself to turn his head as he heard the sound of approaching hooves. Blacked was galloping his horse. James saw the book lying next to Leonard. As he tried to stand up, to straighten up, Blacked slowed his horse, jumped down and picked up the book. Then he got back on his horse.

“For the second time.” Said Blacked with a smile, “You're losing again. I would have killed you here, I would have done it with great pleasure, but no. I want you to see the destruction of the Kingdom of Destiny with your own eyes. And your newfound friends will die too... Just like...” He gestured to Scatt lying on the ground. “Like your one-armed friend over there.” Blacked said and spurred his horse and rode towards the white pillars. James sat up. He tried to walk. He ignored the pain in his leg for a while. And he fell to the ground. He put his hands on the ground and looked up. He saw Scatt. Scatt's dead body.

“One last time...” he said to himself. “One last mission.” And he forced himself to stand up. In one swift movement he took off the belt of his armor and wrapped it around the wound in his leg. He took a deep breath and suddenly tightened the belt. Gritting his teeth, he tried not to scream. While trying to cope with the pain by clenching his teeth, he used his sword as a walking stick and began to advance slowly. He had fallen behind the armies.

As James tried to go as fast as he could, he finally made it to the battle area, to the armies. He had no strength left to fight, but he kept moving towards the pillars. When he saw the sword raised in the air towards him, he did not have the strength to meet it. But before James could do anything, he saw the same man being killed. As the sword was drawn back from the soldier's chest, James did not at first recognize who had killed the man. But he soon realized that the bloodied face belonged to Arthur. Without waiting for James to thank him, Arthur continued the battle. Another soldier attacked James from his right. This time the rebel was knocked down by an arrow. Rose hadn't even seen James when she shot the arrow.

Nathaniel crossed his swords over the shoulders of the man kneeling before him. And he opened them like a pair of scissors. With a sickening sound, he saw blood splatter on his armor. But it made little difference. It was just a new red on top of the red. He saw James as the corpse lay on the ground in front of him. He realized he was barely walking and without thinking, he ran towards him. He swung

his sword in both directions. He continued without mercy or focusing on anyone. When he came to James, he sheathed one of his swords and supported James.

“Oh, God! James, what happened to you? I have to get you out of here.” Nathaniel said hurriedly.

“No.” Said James in a whisper “To the pillars. We're going to the pillars,” James said barely. “The pillars... We have to protect them.”

Nathaniel hugged James with one hand and used his sword with the other to ward off their attackers. With quick steps, after killing and wounding several soldiers, they made it to the last line of the Kingdom of Destiny and walked through the white pillars, Last line was protecting them from the rebels' soldiers.

They had not even reached the pillars when they saw the horse that was rearing up right next to the pillar. The horse and its rider collapsed with the spears. But soon the rider got up and killed the soldiers of the kingdom of Destiny around him, one by one. As he stepped onto the ground between the white pillars, he smiled at James, who was looking at him from a distance with his bloody face and saluted with his hand. In the other hand he held the book.

“We lost.” Nathaniel said with sorrow.

“Is your flask full?” James asked, not taking his eyes off Blacked a few meters away.

“Always.” Said Nathaniel. He handed his flask to James. James uncapped the flask, took a small sip and grimaced. He forced himself to pour the rest on his sword. As he did so, he twisted his sword so that it would work on both sides. Nathaniel watched James with one eyebrow raised. When James finished, he handed the flask to Nathaniel and looked around. He closed his eyes. As he took a deep breath, the runic inscriptions on the sword glowed one by one. And the metal part of the sword suddenly caught fire. The blue flame enveloped the metal part of the sword from top to bottom.

“Cheers.” Said James and handed the sword to Nathaniel. Nathaniel took the sword. He looked at James uncertainly.

“We have no choice but to destroy the book.” Said James and Nathaniel threw the sword with all his might without a second hesitation. The sword spun. When the book which was standing on the middle pillar was stuck by the sword, It burst into flames. was impaled on the pillar behind it, along with the sword itself. Blacked stepped back in fear as the blue fire enveloped the book. Blacked looked angrily at James as the book slowly burned to ash, and that was the moment the last line was broken.

The rebels took the offense. They were moving fast. Nathaniel let go of James and drew his second sword. He took two steps in front of James and tried to protect him. At first he was able to kill the soldiers, one at a time, to fend them off, but there were more and more of them. More and more soldiers were coming every moment. And finally, many soldiers surrounded Nathaniel. Too many for him to face. As Nathaniel continued to fight, the soldier behind him raised his sword. Nathaniel couldn't see him. But before he could make his move, the soldier was knocked down by a feathered arrow. And then the next one. And the next...

There was the sound of horns. It was coming from the direction of the arrow, and for a moment it caught everyone's attention. First a man appeared with the bugles. Immediately after him, a shadow rose and grew larger. Augustine, standing in the center of the shadow that grew on both sides, slung his trumpet over his shoulder. And with the order to charge, an entire army rushed to the battlefield.

As the book burned and shriveled into ashes, Blacked cursed angrily and looked at the coming army. Then he turned back to James. He glared angrily and stormed off cursing. Without looking back, he disappeared into the armies. James took a deep breath and smiled bitterly. Coming down from the mountain, Augustine and his army were putting the Rebels to the sword.

When Nathaniel saw the army, he shouted with joy, raised his sword and charged, a smile blooming on his bloody face.

Augustine swung his axe, knocking the men down. Splitting helmets, chopping off heads. He didn't try to kill everyone he came across. He was just making a path for himself as he rode. He rode his horse next to James.

When he got close to James, he dismounted. He screamed and kept swinging his axe at the men around him. When he got to James, he reached out his hand and helped him up.

“I don't... I don't know how to thank you... You saved me.”

“And for that I had to declare war.” Augustine said. sarcastically got angry. It was easy to see that he was smiling from under his helmet.

Most of the rebels had died on the battlefield and the few that remained had fled. The battle was won by the army of the Kingdom of Destiny and Augustine, King of the Desert. The place where the battle had taken place, around the white pillars, was covered in blood and corpses. It was full of shattered body parts and many pieces of armor. The battle had been won. But at a great loss.

As the sun was about to set, the able-bodied soldiers began to help the wounded. Swords were sheathed. The soldiers were moving calmly. No one was happy to have won the battle. Too many soldiers had died in the battle. Too many lost for cheers and joys.

Nathaniel took a deep breath, relieved that he had won the battle. Then he went to the wounded and looked around. His eyes searched for James. Finally, he saw James crouching on the ground. He went over and helped him up and put his arm around his neck to support him.

“Nathaniel, I need to tell you something. Scatt...”

"It's a good thing we kept him away from the war." Said Nathaniel, shaking his head with a small smile. That was all he can do with his bloody face. "You can't change fate, Cooper," Nathaniel said in a deep voice. "They make a big deal out of seeing visions of the future, you know?"

"Nate..." James choked for a moment, unable to speak. Finally, he bowed his head in silence. "Scatt's returned to the war," he said quietly, tears running down his cheek. He said quietly.

"No! This can't be!" said Nathaniel and shook his head from side to side, "Please tell me this is a joke." He said making fake smile, but James remained silent. "No, no, no! It can't be!" Nathaniel cursed and shouted and then fell silent. His knees buckled and he fell to the ground, tears streaming from his eyes.

"I... I could have... stopped him... if... if I had told him the truth..."

"He went back to war anyway." Said Merlin. He and Arthur had come to him, supporting each other. "I... I tried to tell him... I tried to tell him at the palace, and I told him he was going to die, and he... he said with his peaceful smile... 'If I die, maybe I can see my love, Emily.'" Merlin finished his sentence and lowered his head.

"That shouldn't have happened." Nathaniel said quietly. "It shouldn't have happened."

CHAPTER THIRTY ONE

Rehoboam was galloping his horse swiftly through the streets of the kingdom. When he arrived at the palace's garden, he dismounted his horse and one of the nearest guards took hold of the reins, leading the prince's horse to the stable while the others opened the door for Rehoboam. This time, Rehoboam was dashing through the corridors of the palace.

“Father!” he exclaimed anxiously as he entered the throne room. “A portion of the army... They have rebelled believing that you are the one who has kept all the magical power to yourself! What should I do? Shall I have them killed before the rebellion grows even stronger?”

Elder Solomon, watching outside through the window, turned to his son. He brought his hand to his beard and began stroking it. “Dark magic has had a worse effect than I anticipated. Their desires may seem simple, but their demands will be endless. No matter how much power they possess, they will always crave more! However, we still haven't been able to cleanse the other realm. That's

why, even with a slight chance, they might regain their senses. We will give them some time. Gather the people in the palace garden. Ensure their safety. And I want a wall from the soldiers. Let our loyal ones protect our people.”

“As you command,” Rehoboam said, then swiftly exited the throne room. Solomon took a deep breath and made his way towards his throne.

CHAPTER THIRTY TWO

A few days later, Rehoboam hurried back into the throne room.

“Father! We have done as you said, but the rebels have attacked again. More than that! some of our loyal soldiers have defected to his side, and more of our men are defecting as we speak! Can I give the order to fight now?”

“I will not give the order to kill my own army, son. At least not now. I ask you to be patient a little longer, get everyone inside the palace, lock the gates.”

Rehoboam turned angrily toward the door when the double doors of the throne room swung open. A guard in armor entered, panting.

“Forgive me, my lord, but the rebellion has spread to our own men. Some of them have attacked our people!”

“Unarmed folk?” asked Solomon.

“Yes, sir.” Said the guard.

“Then it’s the time! Bring me my Headknights. Because we have rebels to kill! Rehoboam, bring your mother and brothers here!”

“Yes, father!” said Rehoboam and quickly left to find the rest of his family. He ran through the corridors filled with the rush of battle. Just like the other guards. And like the servants in the palace, he was running somewhere.

After a while, Solomon's four children and his wife entered the throne room. Then the Headknights in their metal armor. As soon as the guards entered, they fell to their knees. Before Solomon could say anything, Rehoboam gestured to the knights.

“Wouldn't we be better off with guards on the battlefield, Father?”

“I will take back the power I gave from everyone. If it does not stop the rebels, it will slow them down.”

“And what does that have to do with the knights? You can do the spell without them!”

“Because we are fighting the battle which we are losing and I need the knights to win the real battle, the battle bigger than kingdoms, the battle between darkness and light. I will take the dark magic back from everyone. I understand how dangerous it is, but I cannot risk the great war. I will give the Headknights a power they will pass down from generation to generation, my own power.”

Solomon said and clasped his hands together. When he spread them apart diagonally, a book appeared in a bright light. At that moment a guard entered. He saluted the king.

“Sire, the Kingdom of Destiny has heard of the rebellion and is coming to help us!”

Solomon frowned.

“Send word to them quickly! Don't let them come! Because we have already lost the war!”

“Yes, sir!” said the guard and left the throne room.

Solomon opened the book and ran his hand over the writing. Transparent waves came shrinking from the whole kingdom towards the book Solomon held in his hand. Solomon continued to turn the pages of the book as he saw the writing disappear as if the first page had been erased. One by one the pages were erased. Except for a few pages at the end.

“Is that All?”

“Yes, but the Book is slowly dying. And I don't know how long this seal will hold its power.” Said Solomon and turned the pages of the book with widened eyes. He tore out one of the blank pages. And put it on the table at the foot of the wall. He started writing with a quill. When he was done, he rolled it up. He chose one of the fancy boxes and put it inside. He handed it to one of the guards.

“Take this and get as far away as you can. When you get to the right place...” Solomon closed his hand and when he opened it again there was a silver coin and three gold coins. “Use these. You will know when you need to use them.”

“Yes, sir.”

Solomon turned to Rehoboam. He took him by the shoulders and pulled him into a tight hug.

“My son... I want you... I want you to get as far away as you can. Go far away. Cross the seas. And start a new life with those who don't know who you are. Tell your sons what happened to you, what I told you. And they will tell their sons.”

“I can't turn my back and leave while you fight here!”

“Rehoboam, I am not asking you as a father, I am commanding you as a king!” Solomon said and hugged his father

again. Then Rehoboam left the throne room even though he wanted to protest he couldn't. His tears were his response.

This time Solomon hugged his second child tightly.

"Melenek, what I want you to do is to return to my brother's kingdom. Take your mother, the villagers, people in palace, everyone and go back to the kingdom of Israel."

"No, I am staying with you!" Naama protested. Solomon approached his wife with heavy steps. He put his hand on Naama's cheek.

"I am sorry, my queen, but we must part for a while."

Naama could only say "But..." As if her throat was in knots. Tears began to roll down her cheeks.

"My queen, please don't cry. Don't worry, we will meet again soon. Until then, don't forget. No matter what happens to me, no matter where I am, I will always love you."

Naama hugged Solomon tightly.

"You will come back. You will use your magic and come back."

"Of course!" said Solomon, trying hard not to cry. He swallowed. "Like I said, I will be with you as soon as I can, my Queen." Solomon hugged his wife tightly, as if it was the last time he would ever hold her. He turned to his son Melenek.

"I know you will protect your mother no matter what, son." Solomon said and hugged his son once more. Then he hugged his daughter and said, "Go with Melenek." He gestured for his fourth child to stay. Then he raised his hand with the ring. First the ring shone. Then the star above his throne. And the wall behind the throne began to tremble. Pebbles and dust fell from the ceiling and the wall opened to two sides. Behind it was a small room. Solomon entered

the room. He put the book on the pillar in the center of the room and left. The wall closed again.

Solomon pointed to the sword at the waist of his last son. Without thinking, the son took it out and handed it to his father. Solomon ran his hand over the sword. The sword glowed for a few seconds. And he gave it back to his son. As he hugged his son, he said, "Go away, my son, like your brother Rehoboam. Hide the sword. Make sure no one finds it. For this sword is the key to all power."

As the last son left the room, three men entered.

"Solomon." Said the foremost among them, "So you're trying to turn us away from the war?"

"Rodrin! Windsor and Azderson! Why are you here? I told you not to come! We cannot win this war!"

"We're not here to win, my friend. We're here to die fighting beside a great King."

"Now," said Solomon. "We are all gonna die." Solomon took his ring off his finger. Leaning down, he whispered into the ring. As the ring glittered, he placed it in the palm of one of the knights. "Take this ring. You will use it to power certain items. And each of you is only allowed one. Use it wisely. And when you are done, the ring will go back where it belongs. What you do now is to leave the palace with your most trusted men. After everyone in the palace has left, no one will be able to come back here without the key, and no one will remember what happened here in the throne room, except for their duties! Now go!" said Solomon. They left the palace after kneeling to their king for the last time.

"You gave your magic power with the ring."

"Yes, Rodrin. But don't worry. I have enough magic to fight." Solomon looked at his friends as he tightened the cuffs of his

armor a little tighter. “My guards will remember this day as a day we won.”

“And will we win, you maj... Solomon?” asked Windsor.

Solomon looked into Windsor's eyes with a desperate smile. “Let us go and find out, my friends.”

CHAPTER THIRTY THREE

At night, all the people gathered in the palace garden. Thunder rumbled and lightning flashed, illuminating the surroundings for a moment. Many people had tears in their eyes as sadness enveloped the kingdom. Some were swollen with weeping, while others wept silently. But still, everyone who could was there, in the palace gardens.

Arthur walked slowly to Hendry, who was standing in front of the double doors of the palace. One of the guards in knight's armor also approached. He had cleaned the blood off the armor, albeit clumsily. He held out the golden crown. Arthur took it carefully and placed it on Hendry's head. The king nodded to Arthur. Arthur responded in kind, stepping aside and kneeling. After Arthur, Rose, Nathaniel, Merlin and James, who were waiting closest to the King, fell to their knees. Then all the people.

As soon as the coronation was over, the funerals began. Everyone was digging the graves of their relatives and burying them. Scatt's grave was dug by Nathaniel, Rose, Arthur and Merlin. As

much as James wanted to help, he couldn't do much with his broken arm.

They were watching Scatt's grave in the morning as the rain poured down. Nathaniel, James, Rose, Arthur, Merlin. One of Augustine's soldiers stood silently with them a few paces behind. Nathaniel stepped forward. He bowed in front of the graveyard. He took a deep breath, sniffled and turned around.

"Scatt was my friend. And I couldn't save him, even though I knew everything beforehand... He fought valiantly. You saved us all, my one-armed friend..." said Nathaniel, managing to smile a little. Then he took out his flask and raised it. "For Scatt!" he took a sip from it and poured what he left in the flask on the tomb. He walked away from the cemetery. No one spoke after Nathaniel, no one could say anything. Merlin and Arthur left too. Then Rose and James. Augustine's helmeted soldier was last. His head bowed; he watched the others disappear into the rain.

"Vexilious!" said a voice behind him. A voice he had not heard for a long time. Augustine's soldier took off his helmet. Removing his helmet, Vex wiped a tear from his cheek and turned around. He saluted with a hand on his chest.

"King Solomon, we meet again in the rain as I saw you the first time, sir."

Although not clearly visible, King Solomon was sparsely visible among the raindrops.

"You have completed the task I gave you, Vex, and I thank you for that, for caring and protecting my heir. But you broke the deal I made for the immortality I gave you."

"If I never fought a battle, I would become immortal, and I was supposed to keep that power until your heir appeared. I did what you ordered to me, sir."

“Yes, and I thank you for what you've done, Vex, but you're a mortal now.”

“Thank you very much, sir. Thank you very much.” Vex said and looked at Solomon's silhouette disappearing into the rain. He watched the cemetery for a few more minutes and then left. He mounted his horse and rode slowly through the rain. He rode away calmly. He disappeared into the raindrops.

NOT THE END

The torches suddenly caught fire one by one. The illumination continued until the very top of the tower. On the top floor the ground trembled, pebbles and dust scattered. The armored figure on which the reflection of the flames danced on him, slowly stood up. Its huge wings suddenly opened and filled the room.

“The seal is broken!” He said full of fear. “The Lord of Darkness has awoken!”

M. V. BALDUR